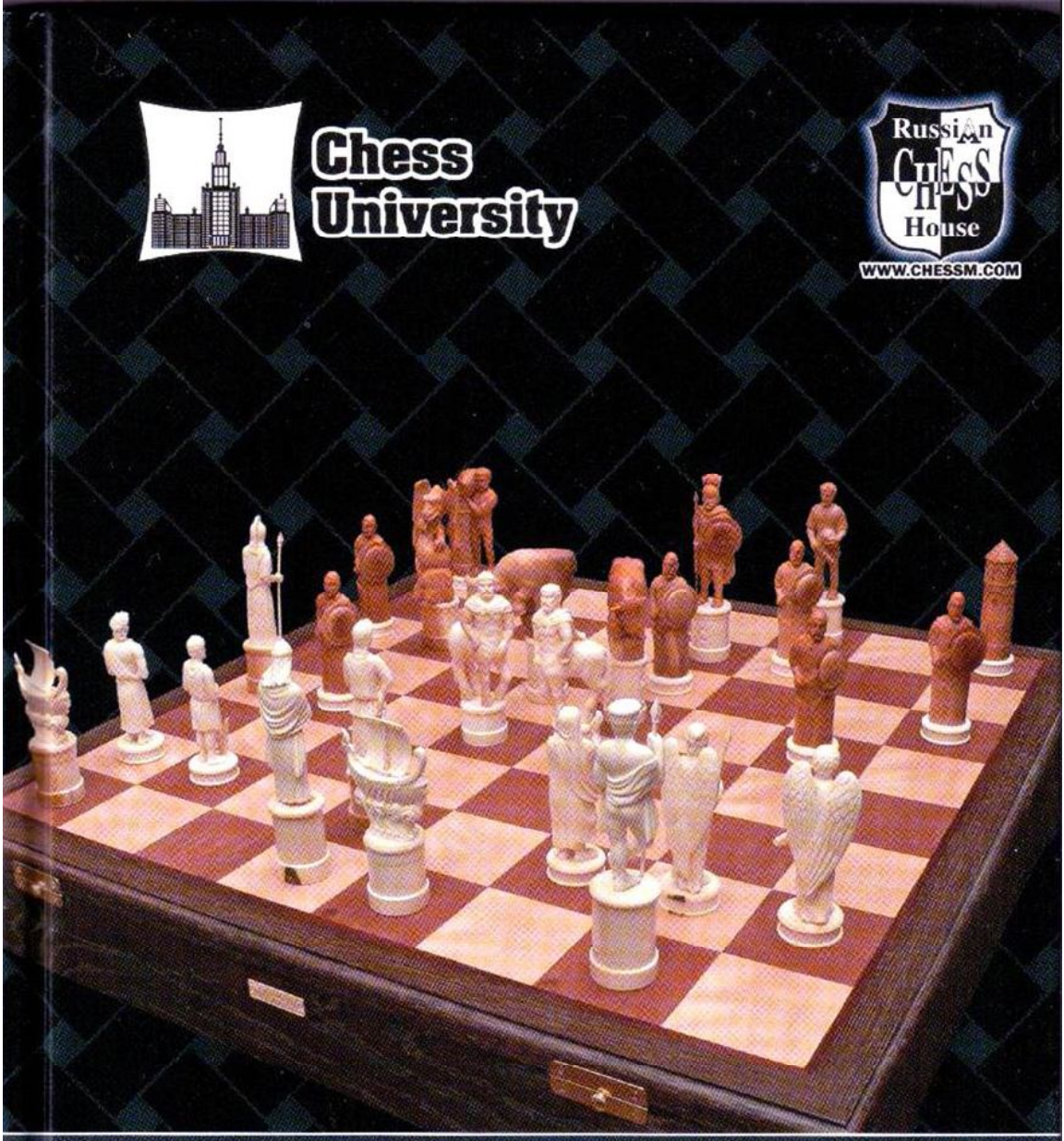
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Alexander Beliavsky, Adrian Mikhalchishin & Oleg Stetsko

Isolani Strategy

Strengths and Weaknesses of the Isolated Queen's Pawn





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Alexander Beliavsky
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& Oleg Stetsko

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Introduction

Anyone who fears an isolated pawn should not play chess
Siegbert Tarrasch

Aaron Nimzowitsch, one of the outstanding chess researchers, considered that the problem of the isolated pawn was one of the cardinal problems of positional play. We are talking about a central d4-pawn for White or a d5-pawn for Black, the isolation of which is characterised by the absence of the pawns of this colour on the c- and e-files.

From the dialectical point of view, the specific nature of the isolated pawn is the assessment of its inherent contradictions – strengths and weaknesses, or in other words, dynamics and statics. In the opening stage of the game this is an assessment of the advantage of the first move, although for the modern state of theory the creation of dynamically balanced positions is more typical.

From the dynamic point of view, the advantage of the isolated pawn, let's say a pawn on d4, is that it is an outpost, controlling the central c5- and e5-squares, on which a knight can be established, supporting an attack on the king, and the presence of the open e- and c-files assists the rapid activation of the rooks. From the static point of view, the defects of the isolated pawn are that it needs defending, especially when it is not supported by the bishop, and above all that it can be blockaded by a piece, usually a knight, occupying an important outpost (in our case this is d5), which is not easy to eliminate. The benefits of controlling this outpost become especially apparent when the material is reduced, since the weakness of the squares e4 and c4 is felt.

The first to begin studying the topic of the isolated pawn was the first world champion Wilhelm Steinitz, who encountered this problem in his match for the world title with Johann Zukertort. Here is this historic 9th game of their match, in which the method of playing against

the isolated d4-pawn was convincingly demonstrated.

ZUKERTORT – STEINITZ
New Orleans 1886
Queen's Gambit Accepted D26

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.e3 c5 6.♗xc4 cxd4 7.exd4 ♗e7 8.0-0 0-0.



A typical position with an isolated d4-pawn, characteristic of the Queen's Gambit Accepted.

9.♕e2 ♘bd7 10.♗b3 ♘b6 11.♗f4. Nowadays the development of the bishop at g5 is preferred.

11...♘bd5 12.♗g3 ♕a5 13.♖ac1 ♗d7 14.♘e5 ♖fd8! 15.♕f3 ♗e8! Note the manoeuvre ♖f8-d8 followed by playing the bishop to c8 – this is an important positional idea, which is still practised today. Such a regrouping of the pieces is useful both for attack, and for defence.

16.♖fe1 ♖ac8 17.♗h4.



17...♘xc3! Today the positional ideas of fighting against the isolated d4-pawn are known to many players, but when they were employed by Steinitz they were a revelation. After Black has securely defended his kingside, he switches to an attack in the centre and creates a so-called isolated pawn pair d4-c3. The d4-pawn is defended, but there is now a new weakness – the c3-pawn, which needs defending.

18.bxc3 ♕c7. One of the elements of modern technique is the fixing of the isolated pawn pair, which in the given position could have been achieved by 18...b5!?, but Steinitz carries a different plan against the weaknesses. He aims to simplify the position, reckoning that the hanging pawns (if White plays c3-c4) will remain a target.

19.♕d3 ♘d5! (nowadays a typical exchanging manoeuvre) **20.♗xe7 ♕xe7 21.♗xd5.** White falls in with Black's plans, and commits a serious positional mistake.

21.♗g3 would have retained roughly equal chances.

21...♖xd5 22.c4. White plays too actively – the advance of the e-pawn merely weakens his pawn centre.

22...♖dd8 23.♖e3. This attack on the securely defended king is not realistic. White should have supported his d4-pawn with 23.♖ed1, intending ♕d3-b3 with the idea of c4-c5 and ♘e5-c4-d6, or, in some cases, d4-d5.

23...♕d6 24.♖d1. 24.♖h3 ♕xd4 25.♕xh7+ ♔f8 is not dangerous for Black.

24...f6 25.♖h3 h6 26.♘g4 ♕f4! Black has repelled White's attack and he now launches a counterattack, which gains in strength because the rook at h3 coordinates poorly with the remaining pieces.

27.♘e3 ♗a4! The need to defend the d4-pawn forces the white rook to abandon the first rank.

28.♖f3 ♕d6 29.♖d2 ♗c6 30.♖g3. Nothing is given by 30.♖xf6 gxf6 31.♕g6+ ♔f8 32.♕xf6+ ♔e8 33.♘f5 exf5, but 30.d5 ♕e5 31.♖g3 exd5 32.♕g6 came into consideration, although even here after 32...♖c7 Black has the advantage.

30...f5 31.♖g6 ♗e4 32.♕b3 ♔h7 33.c5 ♖xc5 34.♖xe6 ♖c1+ 35.♘d1 ♕f4 36.♕b2 ♖b1 37.♕c3 ♖c8 38.♖xe4 ♕xe4. White resigned.

A convincing win, wouldn't you agree? Johann Zukertort clearly failed to cope with the problem of the isolated d4-pawn, which he **deliberately** (we must emphasise this) went in for in the opening, hoping to benefit from his advantage in space, which was greatly valued in the romantic 19th century. It was no accident that one of the faithful followers of Steinitz's teachings, Siegbert Tarrasch, vigorously stood up for the isolated pawn: 'I think that the player whose queen's pawn is isolated has a clear advantage. The point is that this pawn may serve as the starting-point for a very strong attack.' Tarrasch's belief in the virtues of the isolated pawn was so great, that he was also prepared to have one with Black, by playing in the Queen's Gambit 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 e5! (Tarrasch's evaluation), thereby agreeing to the isolation of his d5-pawn after 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘f3 followed by the exchange on d4. Nowadays the Tarrasch Defence to the Queen's Gambit is regarded as a sound opening, where Black achieves a position of dynamic balance.

In modern practice the appearance of an isolated pawn is the result of an opening variation being chosen, in which the possessor of the pawn hopes in return to exploit his advantage in time or space. It is well known that the advantage of

the first move affects the possibility of exploiting the dynamic and static features of an isolated pawn when there are still a large number of pieces on the board. Therefore we think it is logical to consider separately positions from the opening obtained with isolated d4- and d5-pawns. In isolated pawn positions with reduced material and stable in character, the strategy of the play, irrespective of the colour, has its general rules, both in the middlegame, and in the endgame.

PART I

THE ISOLATED D4-PAWN

The study of modern chess takes account of the interconnection of the opening with the middlegame, since the pawn structure arising after the opening largely determines the further development of the game. As regards our theme, Tarrasch remarked: 'If for an isolated pawn one can obtain an advantage in time or position, such an operation is advantageous and becomes an important feature for the creation of an attack. But if the opponent has a lead in development, the isolating of the pawn is unfavourable.'

Modern opening theory includes a quite extensive range of openings, where White goes in for an isolated d4-pawn, with the hope of exploiting its dynamic features. Here are a number of typical positions, arising in the popular openings.

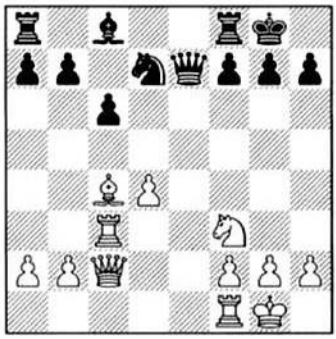
Queen's Gambit, Orthodox Defence

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♗g5 ♗e7 5.♘f3 0-0 6.e3 ♘bd7 7.♗d3 dxc4 8.♗xc4 c5 9.0-0 cxd4 10.exd4.



Queen's Gambit, Capablanca Variation

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♗g5 ♗e7 5.♘f3 0-0 6.e3 ♘bd7 7.♖c1 c6 8.♗d3 dxc4 9.♗xc4 ♘d5 10.♗xe7 ♕xe7 11.0-0 ♘xc3 12.♖xc3 e5 13.♕c2 cxd4 14.cxd4.



Queen's Gambit, Tarrasch Defence Deferred

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♘f3 c5 5.cxd5 ♘xd5 6.e3 ♘c6 7..♗d3 cxd4 8.exd4.



Queen's Gambit Accepted

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.c3 c6 5..♗xc4 c5 6.0-0 ♘c6 7.♕c2 cxd4 8.♖d1 ♗e7 9.exd4.



Queen's Gambit Accepted

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘c3 c5 4.c3 cxd4 5.cxd4 ♘f6 6.♗xc4.



Nimzo-Indian Defence

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 0-0 5.♗d3 d5 6.♘f3 c5 7. 0-0 ♘c6 8.a3 cxd4 9.cxd4 dxc4 10.♗xc4 ♗c7.



Caro-Kann Defence, Panov Attack

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 e6 5.♘c3 ♘f6 6.♘f3 ♗e7 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 .



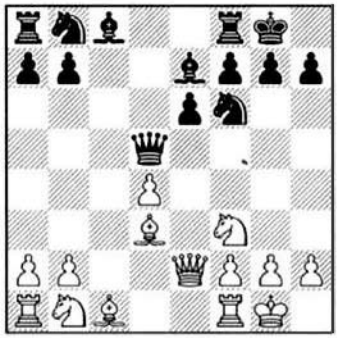
Sicilian Defence, Alapin Variation

1.e4 c5 2.c3 d5 3.exd5 ♕xd5 4.d4 e6 5.♘f3 ♘f6 6.♗d3 ♗e7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♕e2 cxd4 9.exd4.



Caro-Kann Defence, Panov Attack

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.♘f3 ♗g4 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♕b3 ♗xf3 9.gxf3 ♘b6 10.♗e3 e6.



Petroff Defence

1.e4 e5 2.♘f3 ♘f6 3.♘xe5 d6 4.♘f3 ♘xe4 5.d4 d5 6.♗d3 ♗e7 7.0-0 ♘c6 8.♖e1 ♗g4 9.c4 ♘f6 10.♘c3 0-0 11.cxd5 ♘xd5.



Giuoco Piano

1.e4 e5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.♗c4 ♗c5 4.c3 ♘f6 5.d4 exd4 6.cxd4 ♗b4+ 7.♝d2 ♗xd2+ 8.♘bxd2 d5 9.exd5 ♘xd5.



By agreeing, on emerging from the opening, to a position with an isolated pawn, White hopes to exploit its dynamic features. What do they comprise?

1) The d4-pawn ensures control of the c5- and e5-points. Of particular importance is the e5-outpost, from which a knight, supported by active bishops (in particular the light-square bishop) assists the mounting of a kingside attack.

2) A dynamic feature of the d4-pawn is the potential energy of its advance, comprising the d4-d5 breakthrough, which leads to the opening of the position and is especially apparent when White has a lead in development.

3) If Black is behind in development, an attack on the piece blockading the d4-pawn may lead to a favourable change in the pawn structure by means of exchanges on d5.

Chapter 1

Attack on the kingside

1.1. Attack with the f-pawn

The feature of this attack is making use of the rook on f1. From here it supports the f2-f4-f5 advance, and after the exchange on f5 coordination is established between the knight on e5, the light-square bishop on the a2-g8 diagonal, and the rook on f1. After this the f7-pawn will need constant defence.

The first player to carry out this theme most effectively world champion Mikhail Botvinnik.

BOTVINNIK – VIDMAR
Nottingham 1936
Queen's Gambit D60

1.c4 e6 2.♘f3 d5 3.d4 ♘f6 4.♗g5 ♗e7 5.♘c3 0-0 6.e3 ♘bd7 7.♗d3 c5 8.0-0 cxd4 9.exd4 dxc4 10.♗xc4 ♘b6 11.♗b3 ♗d7 12.♕d3.

A typical switching of the queen to the kingside, which we will also encounter in later examples.

12...♘bd5 (nowadays Black would almost automatically prefer 12...♘fd5, aiming for simplification) **13.♘e5 ♗c6 14.♖ad1 ♘b4 15.♕h3 ♗d5 16.♘xd5 ♘bxd5?**

A mistake, allowing White to begin the pawn attack f2-f4-f5. 16...♘fxd5 was correct, when after 17.♗c1 ♖c8 White has only a slight advantage.



17.f4! ♖c8.

Black is unable to prevent the opening of the f-file. If 17...g6, then 18.♗h6 ♖e8 19.♗a4, winning the exchange. If 17...♘e4 there follows 18.♘x17! ♔x17 (18...♖x17 19.♕xc6) 19.♖de1! with a decisive attack.

18.f5 exf5?

Apparently the decisive mistake. 18...♕d6 was more tenacious, although after 19.fxe6 fxe6 20.♘c4 ♕c6 21.♖fe1 here too White has a great advantage.

19.♖xf5 ♕d6.

If 19...♖c7, then 20.♖df1 ♘b6 21.♕h4 ♘bd5 22.♘xf7 ♖xf7 23.♗xd5 ♘xd5 24.♖xf7 ♔xg5 25.♕xg5 with a mating attack.



20.♘xf7! ♖xf7 21.♗xf6 ♔xf6 (21...♘xf6 22.♖xf6 ♗xf6 9.♕xc8+) **22.♖xd5 ♕c6 23.♖d6 ♕e8 24.♖d7.**

Black resigned.

SPASSKY – NIKOLAEVSKY

Kharkov 1963

Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗xc4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.a4 cxd4 8.exd4 ♘c6 9.♘c3 ♗e7 10.♗e3.

The experts have different opinions about this modest development of the bishop. Thus Tarrasch and Nimzowitsch recommended that the d4-pawn should first be defended, reckoning that the attack on the king would follow of its own accord.

10...0-0 11.♕e2 ♘b4 12.♘e5 b6?!

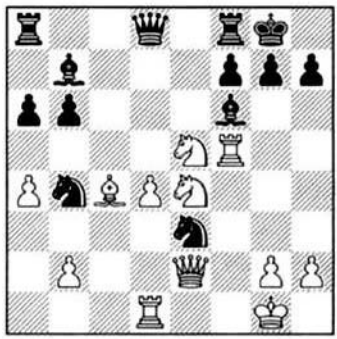
12...♘bd5 was more logical.



13.f4! ♘fd5 14.♖ad1 ♗f6.

14...g6, preventing the advance of the pawn to f5, came into consideration.

15.♘e4 ♗b7 16.f5 exf5 17.♖xf5 ♘xe3.



18.♘xf6+!

Black had only reckoned on 18.♕xe3 ♗xe5 19.♖xe5 ♗d5.

18...gxf6 19.♕xe3 fxe5 20.♕xe5 h6 21.♖f6 ♔h7.

He also loses after both 21...♘d5 22.♕g3+ ♔h7 23.♗d3+ and 21...♗d5 22.♖xh6 f6 23.♕g3+ ♔f7 24.♖h7+.

22.♖df1 ♗d5 23.♕f5+ ♔g8 24.♕g4+ ♔h7 25.♖xh6+.

Black resigned.

LERNER – KHARITONOV

51st USSR Championship, Lvov 1984

Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 a6 4.e3 ♘f6 5.♗xc4 e6 6.a4 c5 7.0-0 cxd5 8.exd5 ♘c6 9.♘c3 ♗e7 10.♗e3 0-0 11.♕e2 b6 12.♖ad1 ♘b4 13.♘e5 ♗b7.



14.f4! In contrast to the similar situation in the previous game, Black has completed his development and he has secure control of the d5-square, but here too the attack with the f-pawn gives White the better chances.

14...♘bd5 15.f5 ♕d6.

Since 15...exf5 is unfavourable for Black, he tries to maintain his e6-point.

16.♗g5! ♘xc3.

White steps up the pressure on Black's position, and Black tries to weaken it by exchanging. However, it is not easy for him to find a satisfactory plan of defence, since in some variations the weakness of the a6-pawn is felt. If 16...♖fe8 White could have continued 17.♖d3, when 17...♘b4 is not dangerous in view of 18.♖g3 ♕xd4+ 19.♔h1 with a strong attack.

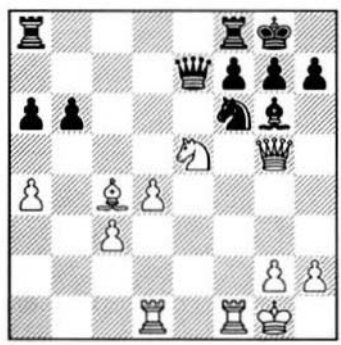
17.bxc3 ♘e4 18.♗xe7 ♕xe7 19.♕g4! ♘f6.

White's pressure increases (19...♘xc3? 20.f6) and Black is forced to make positional concessions.

20.♕h3 exf5 21.♕xf5 ♗e4.

It is not possible to neutralise White's pressure on the kingside by 21...♗d5?, since this loses a piece: 22.♗xd5 ♘xd5 23.♘c6 ♕d6 24.♕xd5 ♕xd5 25.♘e7+.

22.♕g5 ♗g6.



23.♖f3! A typical inclusion of the rook in the attack on the king. Nothing is given by 23.♘xg6 hxg6 24.♕xg6 ♕e3+ 25.♔h1 ♕xc3 26.♖xf6 ♕xc4 with equality.

23...♕c7 24.♖h3 ♖fe8 25.♗b3 (intending 26.♘xg6) **25...♖xe5 26.♕xe5 ♕d7 27.♖e3 ♖e8 28.♕f4 ♖c8 29.♖de1 b5 30.axb5 axb5 31.h3 ♕c6 32.♕f3 ♕b6 33.♖e5 b4 34.♕e3 h6 35.c4 ♔h7 36.c5 ♕c6.** Black resigned.

NEVEROV – MAKSIMENKO
Kherson 1989
Nimzo-Indian Defence E41

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 c5 5.♗d3 cxd4 6.exd4 d5 7.♘f3 dxc4 8.♗xc4 ♘bd7 9.0-0 ♘b6 10.♗b3 ♗d7 11.♗g5 ♗e7 12.♘e5 ♗c6.



13.f4! 0-0 14.f5 exf5?! 14...♗d5! was necessary, covering White's important attacking diagonal a2-g8.

15.♖xf5 ♘fd5. 15...♗d7!? with the idea of ♗e6 was more tenacious.

16.♗xe7 ♕xe7 17.♕d3



17...♖ad8?

A routine move, allowing White to develop an irresistible attack. 17...g6!? with the idea of 18.♕g3 ♘xe3 19.bxe3 ♗d5 was necessary.

18.♖af1 f6 19.♖h5 g5. No better is 19...g6 20.♘xg6! hxg6 21.♕xg6+ ♕g7 22.♕e4 with a decisive pin on d5.

20.♘g4 ♖d7 21.h4 gxh4 22.♘e3 ♖fd8 23.♖ff5. Black resigned.

1.2. Piece attack on the kingside

This attack involves coordinating the heavy pieces, and switching them to the kingside with the aim of provoking a weakening of the king's pawn screen. One of the standard procedures is moving a rook along the 3rd rank to h3 or g3.

FURMAN – KERES
22nd USSR Championship,
Moscow 1955
Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 c5 5.♗xc4 e6 6.0-0 a6 7.♕e2 ♘bd7 8.a4 cxd4 9.exd4 ♘b6 10.♗b3 ♗e7 11.♘c3 0-0 12.♖d1 ♘bd5 13.♘e5 ♗d7 14.♗g5 ♗c6.



15.♖d3! Although Black has completed his development and is controlling the d5 blockading square, White retains attacking resources and he switches his rook to the kingside.

15...♕d6. If 15...♘b4 there would have followed 16.♖g3!, when 16...♕xd4 is dangerous because of 17.♘xf7! ♔xf7 (17...♖xf7 18.♕xc6 ♘d5 19.♖d1) 18.♕xc6+ ♔e8 19.♖d1 with a strongattack for White, for example: 19...♕b6 20.♗e3 ♕c7 21.♖xg7.

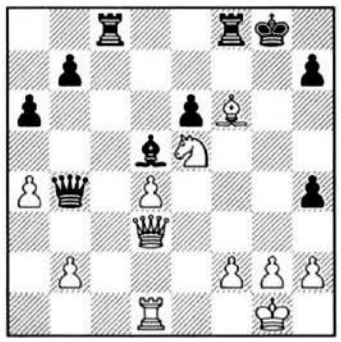
16.♖ad1 ♖fd8 17.♖h3 g6. If 17...♗e8, then 18.♘xd5 exd5 (18...♘xd5 19.♗xd5 exd5 20.♘c4) 19.♗c2 h6 20.♗xf6 ♗xf6 21.♕d3 g6 22.♘g4 h5 23.♖xh5 gxh5 24.♕h7+ ♔f8 25.♘h6 ♕e6 26.♔f1 with the idea of ♖e1.

18.♗c1. The bishop returns to its initial position, in order to vacate the diagonal for the queen, but this manoeuvre loses White two tempi compared with 18.♕d3!? followed by ♕g3 and ♕h4.

18...♖ac8 19.♕d2 ♘h5. Black should have included his bishop in the defence: 19...♗f8 20.♕g5 ♗g7 (if 20...♕b4, then 21.♗xd5 ♘xd5 22.♘xf7! ♔xf7 23.♖xh7+ ♗g7 24.♕e5 ♖g8 25.♗h6) 21.♕h4 ♘e7 (weaker is 21...♘h5 22.♘e4 ♕e7 23.♘g5! f6 24.♘xc6 ♖xc6 25.♘e4 with advantage to White) 21.g4 ♔f8 22.♗g5 ♘eg8 with chances of a defence.

20.♖xh5 gxh5 21.♘e4 ♕b4 22.♕d3 h4 (preventing 23.♕g3) **23.♘g5 ♗xg5 24.♗xg5 f6 25.♗xd5 ♗xd5.** If 25...♖xd5?, then 26.♗xf6 ♗xa4 27.♕h3! ♖xe5 28.♗xe5 ♗xd1 29.♕xe6+ ♔f8 30.♗d6+, winning.

26.♗xf6 ♖f8.



The game would appear to be decided. After 27.♘g4! White's attack should have brought him a material advantage, since Black has nothing better than to return the exchange: 27...♖xf6 28.♘xf6+ ♔g7 29.♘xd5 exd5 30.♕f5, transposing into an endgame which is hopeless for Black. However, White relaxed and after **27.♗xh4? ♕xb2 28.♘d7 ♖c3 29.♕f1 ♖fc8** Black seized the initiative.

POLUGAEVSKY – LUTIKOV
Sverdlovsk 1958
Queen's Gambit D40

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 c5 4.e3 ♗e7 5.♘c3 0-0 6.♗d3 d5 7. 0-0 dxc4 8.♗xc4 ♘bd7 9.♕e2 a6 10.a4 cxd4 11.exd4 ♘b6 12.♗b3 ♗d7 13.♘e5 ♗e8?! (13...♗c6 or the immediate 13...♘bd5 was more active) **14.♖d1 ♘bd5.**



15.♖d3! The bishop on e8 disrupts the coordination of the black pieces, and this facilitates the switching of the white rook to the kingside.

15...♖c8 (after 15...♘b4 all the same there follows 16.♖g3, since 16...♕xd4 is not possible because of 17.♗h6) **16.♖g3 ♔h8 17.♗g5 ♘b4 18.♖d1 ♖c7.** Preparing 19...♘fd5, which was impossible immediately on account of 19.♘xd5 ♘xd5 20.♗xd5 ♗xg5 21.♗xb7. After 18...♘g8 19.♗xe7 ♕xe7 20.d5! exd5 21.♗xd5 White has a strong attack.

19.♖h3 (preventing 19...♘fd5 in view of 20.♕h5) **19...g6?** But such a weakening of the position should be made only if absolutely necessary. It was more logical to play 19...♗c6 20.♕e3 (20.♗xe6 fxe6 21.♘g6+ ♔g8 22.♕xe6+ ♖f7 is inadequate) 20...♘g8 21.♗f4, although White's attack is still strong.

20.♕f3 ♖g8. After weakening his kingside, Black essentially has no defence. If 20...♘fd5 there follows 21.♘xg6+ fxg6 22.♕xf8+ ♗xf8 23.♗xd8, while after 20...♘h5 White has the decisive 21.♗h6 ♖g8 22.♕xf7!

21.♘e4 ♘h5. The capture 21...♘xe4 leads to mate – 22.♖xh7+ ♔xh7 23.♕h3+ ♔g7 24.♕h6#.

(See diagram)

22.♕xf7! The decisive stroke, since after 22...♗xf7 23.♘xf7+



♔g7 24.♘xd8 ♖xd8 25.g4! ♘f6 26.♗h6+ ♔h8 27.♘g5 Black loses material.

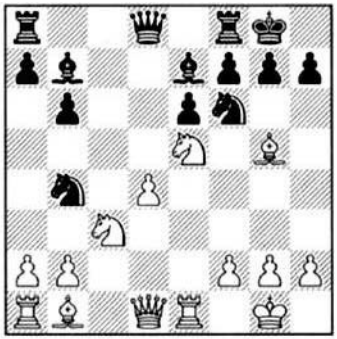
22...♗c6 23.♕xc6 ♖g7 24.d5 ♗d7 25.♗xe7 ♖xe7 26.♕d6 ♕e8 27.♘f6 ♘xf6 28.♕xf6+ ♖g7 29.d6. Black resigned.

KEENE – MILES

Hastings 1975/76

Queen's Gambit D42

1.♘f3 ♘f6 2.c4 c5 3.♘c3 ♘c6 4.c3 e6 5.d4 d5 6.cxd5 ♘xd5 7.♗d3 cxd4 8.exd4 ♗e7 9.0-0 0-0 10.♖e1 ♘f6 11.♗g5 ♘b4 12.♗b1 b6 13.♘e5 ♗b7.



14.♖e3 g6. 14...♘g4 15.♗xe7 ♘xe3 does not work because of 16.♗xh7+!

15.♖g3 ♖c8. It was essential to play 15...♘c6! 16.♗h6 ♕xd4 17.♕xd4 ♘xd4 18.♗xf8 ♔xf8, hindering White's attack at the cost of a slight loss of material.

16.♗h6 ♖e8 17.a3 ♘c6.



18.♘xg6! hxg6 19.♗xg6 fxg6. Black loses after both 19...♗d6 20.♗xf7+ ♔xf7 21.♖g7+ ♔f8 22.♕f3, and 19...♗f8 20.♗c2+ ♔h8 21.♗xf8 ♖xf8 22.♕d2 ♘g8 23.♖h3+ ♔g7 24.♖h7+! ♔f6 25.d5.

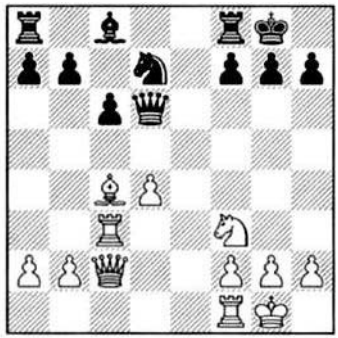
20.♕b1 ♘e5 21.dxe5 ♘e4 22.♘xe4 ♔h7 23.♘f6+ ♗xf6 24.♕xg6+ ♔h8 25.♗g7+ ♗xg7 26.♕xg7#.

We will consider some examples of attack with the pawn structure where an isolated d4-pawn is impeded by a pawn on c6. A characteristic feature is the active use by White of the open e-file for his rook. If Black

delays his development, White can also begin a direct piece attack.

FARAGO – VELIKOV
Albena 1983
Queen's Gambit D68

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♘f3 e6 5.♗g5 ♗e7 6.e3 ♘bd7 7.♖c1 0-0 8.♗d3 dxc4 9.♗xc4 ♘d5 10.♗xe7 ♕xe7 11.0-0 ♘xc3 12.♖xc3 e5 13.♕c2 exd4 14.exd4 ♕d6.



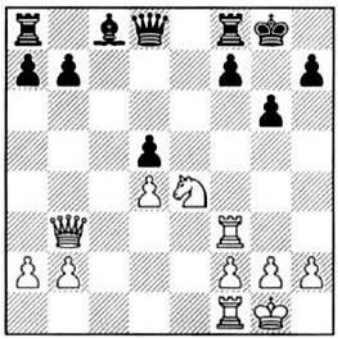
White's pieces are well mobilised, and the rook at c3 is already on its way to the kingside. Black is behind in development, but the main defect of his position is that his knight is unable to block the a2-g8 diagonal of the bishop. Exploiting the fact that the king is inadequately defended, White builds up an irresistible attack.

15.♘g5! (attacking the h7- and f7-pawns) **15...♘f6.** 15...g6? leads to disaster on the f7-square: 16.♘xf7! ♖xf7 17.♖f3 ♘f6 18.♕b3 ♕e7 19.♗xf7+ ♕xf7 20.♖xf6.

After 15...♕g6 16.♕xg6 hxg6 17.♖c1 the invasion of the rook at c7 is decisive.

16.♖f3 g6 17.♕b3 ♘d5. If 17...♕c7 White wins by 18.♘xf7! ♖xf7 19.♗xf7+ ♕xf7 20.♖xf6.

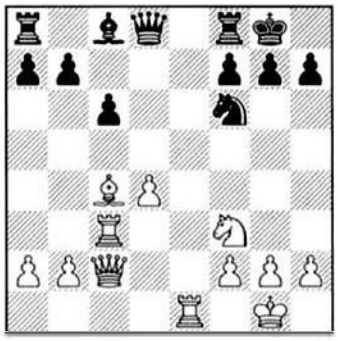
18.♘e4 ♕d8 19.♗xd5 cxd5.



20.♘f6+! ♔g7 21.♕e3! (the decisive queen invasion) **21...h5 22.♕e5 ♔h6 23.♘xh5 ♗g4 24.♕g7+ ♔g5** (24...♔xh5 25.♕h7+ ♔g5 26.h4#) **25.♖g3.** Black resigned.

LPUTIAN – BALASHOV
Yerevan 1986
Queen's Gambit D68

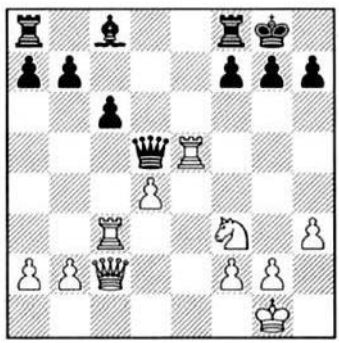
1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 d5 4.♘c3 ♗e7 5.♗g5 0-0 6.e3 ♘bd7 7.♖c1 c6 8.♗d3 dxc4 9.♗xc4 ♘d5 10.♗xe7 ♕xe7 11.0-0 ♘xc3 12.♖xc3 e5 13.♕c2 exd4 14.exd4 ♘f6 15.♖e1 ♕d8.



The pawn structure of both sides is identical to the previous example, but here Black succeeds in blocking the bishop's diagonal. However, an important virtue of White's position is his control of the e-file, and he exploits the outpost at e5 to switch his rook to the kingside.

16.h3! White prevents the development of the bishop at g4 and threatens after 17.♖ce3 to invade with his rook at c7, placing Black in a critical position. His reply is forced.

16...♘d5 17.♗xd5! ♕xd5 (17...exd5 18.♖c7) **18.♖e5.**



With the exchange of his knight, Black's king has been left without protection and it comes under attack by the heavy pieces.

18...♕d6 (18...♕xa2?? 19.♖a3 and the queen is lost) **19.♘g5 g6** (if 19...♕g6, then 20.♕b3 is possible) **20.♖f3 f6.** 20...♕xd4?! is dangerous because of 21.♖e4 ♕d5 22.♘xf7

24.♕c3+ ♔h6 25.♕e3+ ♔g7 26.♖xf7+ ♕xf7 27.♖e7, winning the queen, while if 20...♗f5 there follows 21.♖xf5 gxf5 22.♖g3 ♔h8 23.♕xf5 ♕g6 24.♕f4 f5 25.♘xh7.

21.♕b3+ ♔g7 22.♖e8! a5. After 22...♖xc8 the king succumbs to a mating attack: 23.♕f7+ ♔h6 24.♕xh7+ ♔xg5 25.h4+ ♔g4 26.♕xg6+ ♔xh4 27.g3+.

23.♖xc8. Black resigned.

KARPOV – YUSUPOV

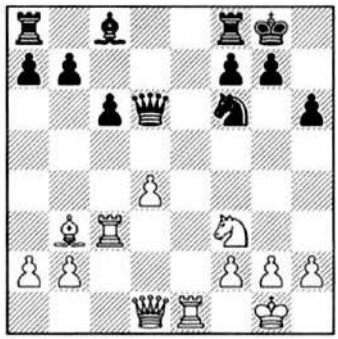
Candidates match, 8th Game, London 1989

Queen's Gambit D56

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 d5 4.♘c3 ♗e7 5.♗g5 0-0 6.e3 h6 7.♗h4 ♘e4 8.♗xe7 ♕xe7 9.♖c1 c6 10.♗d3 ♘xc3 11.♖xc3 dxc3 12.♗xc4 ♘d7 13.0-0 e5 14.♗b3 exd4 15.exd4 ♘f6 16.♖e1 ♕d6.

(See diagram)

The pawn structure in the diagram is similar to the previous examples, but here the e5 outpost is

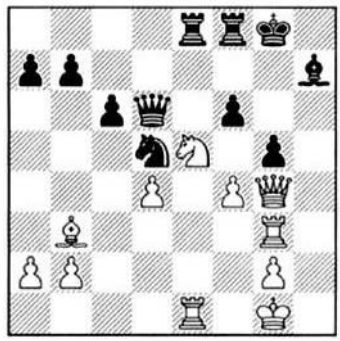


accessible to the knight. Therefore White's move seems obvious.

17.♘e5! ♘d5?! Black's reply seems equally obvious, since the knight occupies the strategically important d5-point and blocks the important diagonal of the bishop at b3. But the knight moves away from the castled position, which White immediately exploits. Black should have aimed for the exchange of bishops: 17...♗e6 18.♗xe6 fxe6, although after 19.♖g3! he would still have had to work hard to defend his position.

18.♖g3 ♗f5. 18...♗e6 19.♕d2 ♔h8 was more cautious, but not 19...♗f5 20.♗xd5! exd5 21.♕f4 ♗e4 22.f3 ♗h7 23.♕g4 g5 24.f4 f6 25.fxg5 hxg5 26.h4 with an attack.

19.♕h5 ♗h7 20.♕g4! (White's attack develops rapidly) **20...g5** (2 **hxg5 23.f4 ♖ae8?** This move leads to loss of material. 23...♔h8 was better, at least maintaining material equality in an inferior rook endgame: 24.fxg5 fxe5 25.g6 ♕xg6 26.♕xg6 ♗xg6 27.♖xg6 cxd4 28.♖c4 ♖f7 29.♗xd5 cxd5 30.♖h4+ ♖h7 31.♖xd4 ♖d8.



24.fxg5! fxe5. If 24...♝f5, then 25.gxf5+! ♗xg4 26.♖xg4+ ♔h8 27.♘f7+ ♖xf7 28.♖xc8+ ♖f8 29.f7 ♘f6 30.♖xf8 ♕xf8 31.♖g8+.

25.g6 ♗xg6 26.dxe5 ♕e6 27.♗xd5! cxd5 28.♕xg6+ ♕xg6 29.♖xg6+ ♔h7 30.♖d6, and White won the double rook endgame.

In the last two examples White's spatial advantage was determined by his control of the e-file. Now we will consider one more example with the use of the e5 outpost by a rook.

VAGANIAN – HÜBNER
Tilburg 1983
Queen's Gambit Accepted D20

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘c3 e5 4.e3 exd4 5.exd4 ♘f6 6.♗xc4 ♗e7 7.♘f3 0-0 8.0-0 ♘bd7 9.♖e1 ♘b6 10.♗b3 c6 11.♝g5 ♗g4.



12.♕d3! White is much more active, mainly due to his pressure on the e-file. By removing his queen from the pin by the bishop, he provokes its exchange by the threat of ♘f3-e5.

12...♗xf3 13.♕xf3 ♘fd5 14.♗xe7. Not 14.♖xe7 ♘xe7 15.♖e1 ♘bc8 16.♕c2 ♖c8 17.♗xf7+ ♔xf7 18.♕e6+ ♔f8 19.♖e3 ♘d6 20.♖f3+ ♘ef5!, and White is weak on the back rank.

14...♘xe7.



15.♖e5! The rook joins the attack, combining control of the e-file with control of the d5-point.

15...♘g6 16.♖e4 ♘d7 17.♖d1 ♕a5 18.♖e3! (vacating a square for the knight) **18...♖ad8 19.♘e4 ♕c7 20.h4! h6.** 20...♘xh4 is not possible on account of 21.♕h5 ♘g6 22.♖h3 h6 23.♕xg6.

21.♕g4 ♔h8 22.h5 ♘f4 23.♖g3 g5 24.hxg6 fxg6 25.♖e1 ♖de8 26.♖ge3. Combining an attack on the king with pressure on the e-file.

26...♘b6 27.♘c5 ♕c8? An oversight in a difficult position; 27...♖xe3 was necessary.

28.♕xf4. Black resigned.

In an attack on the kingside, begun with the switching of the queen, its enhanced mobility expands White's possibilities. The most usual route for the queen to the kingside is via d3-h3.

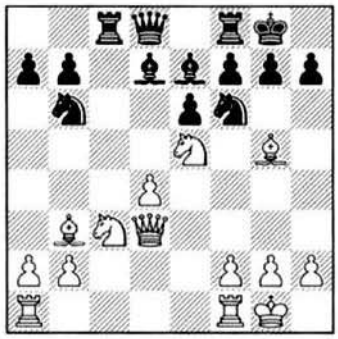
BRONSTEIN – BERGER
Amsterdam 1964
Queen's Gambit D60

1.c4 e6 2.♘c3 d5 3.d4 ♘f6 4.♗g5 ♗e7 5.e3 ♘bd7 6.♘f3 0-0 7.♗d3 dxc4 8.♗xc4 c5 9.0-0 cxd4 10.exd4 ♘b6 11.♗b3 ♗d7 12.♘e5 ♖c8.

(See diagram)

13.♕d3. White is intending to switch his queen to the kingside.

13...♘bd5? This moveonce again indicates the lack of understanding in those years of how to play dynamically against an isolated pawn. Modern-



day defensive technique is based on striving for exchanges, and therefore correct was 13...♘fd5! 14.♗x♗c2 g6 15.♗h6 ♘b4=) 14...♕xe7 (14...♘xe7 15.♗c2 g6) 15.♘xd5 exd5 16.♖ac1 ♕d6 17.f4, although even here White's initiative is quite serious.

14.♖fe1 ♗c6 15.♕h3 a6. Black is unable to relieve the pressure on the kingside. If 15...h6 there follows 16.♗xh6! gxh6 17.♕xh6 ♘h7 18.♗c2 ♘g5 19.h4, while after 15...g6 White has the decisive 16.♗h6! ♖e8 17.♘xf7.

16.♖ad1 b5 17.♗c2.



17...♕d6. There is no defence. If 17...h6 there follows 18.♗xh6! gxh6 19.♕xh6 with a decisive attack. In the event of 17...b4 18.♘xd5! ♗xd5 19.♕d3 g6 20.♗h6 ♖e8 21..

exchange.

18.♘xc6 ♖xc6 19.♗xf6 ♘xf6 20.♘e4! Black resigned.

KAVALEK – PRITCHETT

Olympiad, Haifa 1976

Queen's Gambit D42

1.♘f3 c5 2.c4 ♘f6 3.♘c3 e6 4.e3 ♘c6 5.d4 d5 6.cd ♘xd5 7.♗d3 cxd5 8.exd5 ♗e7 9.0-0 0-0 10.♖e1 ♘cb4 11.♗b1 ♘f6 12.a3 ♘bd5 13.♘e5 ♗d7.



14.♕d3! White switches his queen to h3 for an attack on the h7-pawn with the active support of his bishops.

14...♗c6 15.♕h3! ♕d6 16.♗g5! (threatening 17.♘xd5 and 18.♗xf6) **16...g6** (16...h6? 17.♗xh6!).



17.♗a2! The bishop takes control of the important d5-point, allowing the queen's rook to come into play.

17...♖fd8 18.♖ad1 ♗e8 19.♖d3! White is threatening to double heavy pieces on the h-file after ♕h4 and ♖h3.

19...♘xc3 20.bxc3 ♘d5 (20...♕xa3? 21.♗xe6! fxe6 22.♕xe6+ ♔g7 23.♘e4. regaining the piece) **21.♗xd5 ♗xg5** (21...exd5 22.♘xf7! ♗xf7 23.♗xe7) **22.♗xb7 ♖ab8 23.♕f3 ♕c7 24.♗c6 f6 25.♗xe8 fxe5 26.♕g4 ♕c4** (26...♖xe8 was more tenacious) **27.♗xg6 hxg6 28.♖g3 ♗f4 29.♕xg6+.** Black resigned.

DLUGY – OLL
Moscow 1989
Caro-Kann Defence B14

1.c4 c6 2.e4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.d4 in a critical position (the threat ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.cxd5 ♘xd5 is 18.♘g4). If 17...♕d8, then **7.♘f3 e6 8.♗d3 ♗b4 9.♗d2 0-0 10.0-0 ♘f6 11.a3 ♗e7 12.♗e3 b6 13.♖e1 ♗b7 14.♗c2 ♘a5?!** Withpleasant threat of 21.♘xf7!) 20...

the faulty idea of playing the knight to c4. 14...♕d6 15.♕d3 ♖fd8 should have been considered.



15.♘e5! The logical reaction to the decentralisation of the knight, preparing the switching of the queen to the kingside.

15...♖c8 16.♕d3! ♕c7.



17.♗g5. By playing 17.♗f4! White could have placed Black

♕d6 21.♗a4 ♘c6 22.♘b5 ♕d5 23.♘xf7! ♔xf7 24.♗b3 with a decisive attack.

17...g6 18.♕h3! ♘d5 19.♗h6 ♘xc3 20.♗xf8 ♗xf8 21.bxc3 ♕xc3 22.♗d3.



22...♕xd4. It was better to capture this pawn with the knight – 22...♘b3!? 23.♖adl ♘xd4, for example: 24.♗xg6 hxg6!? (or 24...♕xh3 25.♗xf7+ ♔g7 26.gxh3 ♗c5) 25.♕xc3 ♖xc3 26.♖xd4 ♗d5 with compensation for the exchange. 22...♖c7!?, defending the f7-pawn, also came into consideration.

23.♘xf7! ♔xf7 24.♖ad1 ♕f6 25.♕xh7+ ♗g7 26.♗xg6+ ♔e7 27.♗f5 ♖c6 28.♖e3 ♕h6 29.♕g8 ♗f8 30.♗e4 ♖c4 31.♗g6. Black resigned.

VELIMIROVIC – RUKAVINA

Novi Sad 1975

Caro-Kann Defence B14

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♘f3 ♗e7 7. cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♗d3 ♘c6 9.0-0 0-0 10.♖e1 ♕d6 11.♕c2 g6.



12.♘e4. The black king's position has been compromised by the move g6, creating the grounds for an attack.

12...♕c7 13.a3! It is important to take control of the b4-square, restricting the mobility of the black knights.

13...♗d7.



14.♕d2! A brilliant solution! The queen heads for h6, from where with the support of the minor pieces

it will exert strong pressure on the king.

14...♖fe8 15.♕h6 ♗f8 16.♕h4 ♘ce7. If 16...♗g7 there follows 17.♗c4!♘ce7 18.♘e5 ♗xe5 19.dxe5 ♕xe5 20.♗xd5 ♘xd5 21.♗g5, attacking the weak dark squares.

17.♘eg5 h6 18.♘h3 ♔h7. If 18...h5 there follows 19.g4! hxg4 20.♘hg5 ♗g7 21.♘e5, winning the f7-pawn with a continuing attack.

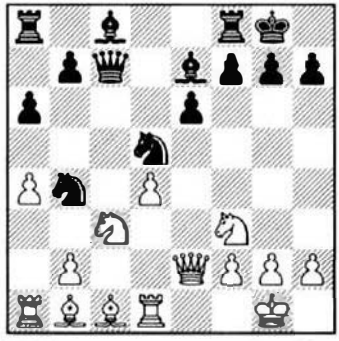
19.♘e5 ♘f5? (20...f6 would have enabled the position to be held) **20.♗xf5 exf5 21.♘g5+ ♔g8 22.♘gxf7**, and White won.

LOBRON – DJURIC

Adelaide 1986

Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 ♘f6 2.♘f3 d5 3.c4 dxc4 4.e3 e6 5.♗xc4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.a4 ♘c6 8.♕e2 cxd4 9.♖d1 ♗c7 10.exd4 0-0 11.♘c3 ♘d5 12.♗d3 ♘cb4 13.♗b1 ♕c7. It is sounder to develop the bishop at d7 or fianchetto it after 13...b6 (with the idea of 14.♕e4 f5).



14.♘e5! Black's kingside is inadequately defended, and this allows White to begin an attack on the king, since the acceptance of the pawn sacrifice 14...♘xc3? 15.bxc3 ♕xc3 allows the rook to be included with decisive effect – 16.♖a3! ♕c7 17.♗xh7+ ♔xh7 18.♕h5+ ♔g8 19.♖h3.

14...f6. After 14...♗d7 15.♖a3! ♘f6 16.♘e4 ♘bd5 17.♖h3 White also succeeds in switching his rook to the kingside with a dangerous attack.

15.♕h5 f5. White's activity on the kingside has borne fruit – Black has weakened his pawn structure. Now White exploits the delay in the development of the c8-bishop and attacks the blockading knight, with the intention of seizing the c-file.

16.♘xd5 ♘xd5.



17.♗a2! Black's position is held together by the strong knight on d5, and therefore it is impor-

tant for White to take it under control, by threatening in the event of 17...♗d7?! to transform the position by the exchange 18.♗xd5! exd5 19.♗f4 ♗d6 20.♖ac1 ♕d8 21.♕f3, with a serious positional advantage.

17...♕c2 18.♕f3 ♕xa4 19.♗xd5! ♕xa1 20.♗b3 a5. 20...♕a5 was more tenacious, after which White would have carried out a favourable breakthrough in the centre: 21.d5! ♕b6 (21...♖d8 22.dxe6! ♖xd1+ 23.♕xd1 ♕xc5 24.♕d8+!) 22.♗f4 ♗f6 23.♘c4 ♕b5 24.♘d6 ♕b6 25.dxe6, obtaining a great advantage.

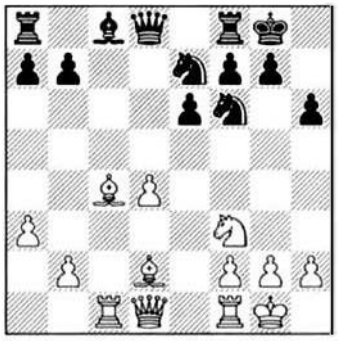
21.♗f4 ♕xb2 22.♘c4 ♕xb3 23.♕xb3, and White soon won.

In the preceding examples we have seen that Black most often opposed White's attack with the (usually forced) barrier g7-g6, which is not easy to breach. It is more difficult to defend after the position has been weakened by h7-h6, which makes the bishop sacrifice a possible motif.

DREEV – DOLMATOV
New York 1989
Keres Defence E00

1.d4 e6 2.c4 ♗b4+ 3.♘d2 d5 4.e3 ♘f6 5.♘f3 0-0 6.♗d3 c5 7.a3 ♗xd2+ 8.♗xd2 cxd4 9.exd4 dxc4 10.♗xc4 h6. In preventing the pin on his knight, Black weakens his king's defences. 10...♘d5 11.0-0 ♘c6 came into consideration.

11.0-0 ♘c6 12.♖c1 ♘e7.



13.♘e5!? This centralisation of the knight is tactically based. It is risky for Black to accept the sacrifice of the d4-pawn in view of his lag in development: 13...♕xd4?! 14.♗b4 ♕xc5 15.♗xe7 ♖e8 16.♖c1 ♕ 5 (16...♕g5 17.h4! ♕xh4 18.♗b5 leads to the loss of the exchange) 17.♗d3! (after 17.♕d6?! b5 18.♗d3 ♕d5 White has no compensation for the pawn) 17...♕h5 18.♗xf6 ♕xd1 19.♖exd1 gxf6 20.♖c7 with a permanent advantage for White in the endgame.

13...♘ed5 14.♕b3! White switches his queen to the kingside.

14...b6 15.♖fe1 ♗b7 16.♕g3 (with the threat of ♗xh6) **16...♘h5 17.♕f3 ♘hf6 18.♕g3 ♔h8 19.♕h3 ♖c8.**



20.♗d3. White rejects the tempting 20.♗xh6 gxh6 21.♕xh6+ ♘h7 (not 21...♔g8? because of 22.♕g5+ ♔h8 23.♗xd5! ♘xd5 24.♖xc8 ♕xc8 25.h3! followed by ♖e4) 22.♗d3 f5 23.♘g6+ ♔g8 24.♘xf8 ♘xf8, and Black parries the attack, since his knight at d5 occupies a dominating position.

20...♖xc1 21.♖xc1 ♘h7. 21...♔g8 was better. The decentralisation of the knight allows White to intensify the pressure.

22.♕h5 ♕e8 23.♕h4 f5?! It was better to defend without weakening the pawn structure, for example, 23...♔g8.

24.♕g3 ♖f6 25.h4 ♘f8 26.♗c2. White is completely dominant, and Black has a problem finding useful moves.

26...♔g8 27.♗f3. By playing 27.♕b3 followed by 28.♗f3, White would have placed Black in a critical position.

27...♕d8 28.♘c6?! This exchange of the strong knight is strategically unjustified. The position should have been strengthened by 28.h5, since Black cannot play 28...♘d7? because of 29.♗xd5! ♗xd5 30.♘xd7 ♕xd7 31.♖c7, while 28...f4 loses a pawn after 29.♕h4 and ♘g6.

28...♗xc6 29.♖xc6 f4, and Black managed to defend.

RADJABOV – SVIDLER
Linares 2006
Slav Defence D16

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.a4 e6 6.e3 c5 7.♗xc4 ♘c6 8.0-0 cxd4 9.exd4 ♗e7 10.♗g5 0-0 11.♖e1.



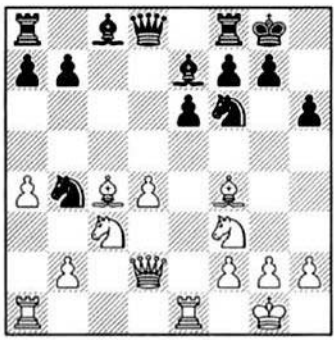
11...h6. The white pieces are actively developed and therefore it looks quite logical to put the question to the bishop on g5. However, the appearance of the pawn at h6 creates motifs for an attack.

12.♗f4. If 12.♗h4 Black exchanges the dark-square bishops – 12...♘h5 13.♗xe7 ♘xe7 14.♕d2

♘f6, when he succeeds in establishing a blockade at d5.

12...♘b4. Now the threat of an attack on the h6-pawn becomes very real. Apparently Black should have continued harassing the dark-square bishop: 12...♘d5!? 13.♗xd5 (13.♘xd5 exd5 14.♗d3 ♗d6=) 13...cxd5 14.♕b3 ♗b4 15.♖e3 ♗e6, obtaining a solid enough position.

13.♕d2!



13...♗d7. It is already not easy to defend. If 13...♘bd5 White can also sacrifice his bishop with 14.♗xh6!? gxh6 15.♕xh6, creating dangerous threats to the king. 15...♘g4 can be met by either 16.♕h5 ♘gf6 (16...♘df6 17.♕g5+ ♔h8 18.h3 ♖g8 19.♕d2) 17.♕g5+ ♔h8 18.♘xd5 exd5 19.♕h4+ ♔g7 20.♖e5, or 16.♕h3 ♘gf6 (16...♘df6 17.♕g3 ♔h8 18.♕h4+ ♔g7 19.♕g5+ leads to a position from the previous variation) 17.♖e5 ♘f4 18.♖g5+ ♘g6 19.♗d3 and then 20.♗xg6.

14.♗xh6! ♖c8 15.♗b3 gxh6 16.♕xh6 ♘h7. 16...♘g4 17.♕h5 ♘f6 18.♕g5+ ♔h8 19.♕h6+ ♘h7, was more tenacious, when if 20.♖e5 Black defends with 20...♖g8. But White can open up the position by 19.d5!?, for example: 19...♘h7 (or 19...♖g8 20.♕h6+ ♘h7 21.♘e5 ♕f8 22.♕xf8 ♘xf8 23.♘xd7 ♘xd7 24.dxe6) 20.♕h5 ♘xd5 21.♘xd5 exd5 22.♗xd5, with a continuing attack.

17.♖e5 f5 18.♖xe6 ♗xc6 19.♗xc6+ ♔h8.



20.♗xc8. 20.♘e5! ♖f6 21.♘g6+ ♖xg6 22.♕xg6 was stronger, also picking up the f5-pawn.

20...♖f6 21.♕h5 ♕xc8 22.♖e1 ♗f8 23.♘e5 ♔g8 24.♕d1 ♘g5. 24...a5 was more tenacious: 25.♕b3+ ♔h8 26.h4, and then as in the game.

25.♕b3+. 25.♕e1! ♗h6 26.f4 ♘h7 27.♘d5! was stronger.

25...♔g7 26.h4 ♘f7 27.♘e2 ♘xe5 28.dxe5 ♖c6 29.♘f4 ♗e7 30.♕g3+ ♔h7 31.♕f3 ♕e8 32.g3 ♕f7 33.e6 ♕f6 34.♕h5+ ♔g8 35.♕e8+ ♕f8 36.♕g6+ ♕g7

37.♕xf5 ♖c5 38.♕e4 ♘c6 39.♘d5 ♕xb2 40.♕f5 ♖c1 41.♘xe7+. Black resigned.

NAVARA – SVIDLER
Olympiad, Turin 2006
Slav Defence D16

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.a4 e6 6.♗e3 c5 7.♗xc4 ♘c6 8.0-0 cxd4 9.exd4 ♗e7 10.♗g5 0-0 11.♖e1 ♗d7. In contrast to the previous game, Black does not hurry to drive away the bishop from g5, and he completes his development, intending to play his light-square bishop to c6. If he attempts to fianchetto it – 11...b6 he has to reckon with the opening of the position: 12.♗xf6!? ♗xf6 13.d5 exd5 14.♞xd5 ♗b7 15.♘e4 ♗e7 (15...♗xb2? is dangerous because of 16.♘fg5 with the threat of 17.♘xf7 ♖xf7 18.♘d6) 16.♖c1 ♜c8 17.♖e3 with a serious initiative for White.

12.♕e2. Making way for the rook, the queen defends the bishop on c4.

12...h6. Black puts the question to the bishop in more favourable circumstances, since he succeeds in securing control of the d5-point.

13.♗f4. If 13..♗h4 Black simplifies the position by 13...♘h5!? 14.♗xe7 ♘xe7 15.♘e5 ♘f6, retaining control of d5.

13...♘b4 14.♘e5 ♞c6 15.♖ad1. 15.♘xf7?! ♖xf7 16.♗xe6 ♘bd5 17.♗e5 ♘xc3 18.bxc3 ♗d5 19.♞xf7+ ♞xf7 is not dangerous for Black, since in the middlegame the two minor pieces may prove more mobile than the rook.

15...♘bd5 16.♗c1. It stands to reason that White did not play ♘e5 in order to exchange 16.♘xc6 bxc6, when Black stands no worse.

16....♗b4 17.♖d3 ♘e7. A prophylactic knight retreat, with the aim of preventing 18.♖g3 in view of 18...♘f5.

18.♗d2 ♖c8?! Black could have maintained the balance by 18...a5, supporting his bishop, which makes the breakthrough in the centre ineffective.





19.d5! The breakthrough in the centre is one of the main dynamic resources with an isolated pawn (it is examined in more detail in Chapter 2). By opening the position, White exploits the fact that the bishop at b4 is unprotected.

19...exd5 20.♘xd5 ♗xd5? Black begins with the wrong piece, which leads to the forced break-up of the pawns covering his king. Correct was 20...♘exd5 21.♗xb4 ♖e8! (weaker is 21...♘f4 22.♗xf7+ ♔h7 23.♕e3! with advantage to White – Svidler) 22.♕d2 ♕c7 23.♗xd5! ♖xe5 24.♖xe5 ♕xe5 25.♗c3 ♕f5 26.♗xe6 ♖xe6 27.f3 with a positional advantage for White, since his bishop is stronger than the knight (Navara).

21.♗xb4 ♖e8 22.♕d2 ♕b6. In the event of 22...♕c7 23.♗xd5 ♘exd5 24.♖xd5 ♘xd5 25.♕xd5 ♖cd8 26.♕e4! f6 White forces the transition into an endgame: 27.♕c4+ ♕xc4 28.♘xc4 ♖xe1+ 29.♗xe1 ♖d4 30.b3 ♖d3 31.♘d2, where his minor pieces are stronger than the rook.

23.♗xe7 ♗xc4 24.♖d6? 24.♖dc3! ♖xc7 25.♘xc4 would have decided the game more quickly.

24...♕c7 25.♗xf6 gxf6 26.♖d7 ♖cd8? 26...♕b8 27.♘g4 ♖xe1+ 28.♕xe1 ♕f4 29.♘e3 ♗e6 was stronger, when Black consolidates his forces.

27.♖d1 ♖xd7 28.♘xd7 ♔g7 29.♕c3. White could have won a pawn – 29.♘xf6 ♔xf6 30.♕xh6+ ♔e7 31.♕h4+ ♔f8 32.♖e1, but this would have meant going into a queen endgame: 32...♕a5 33.♕xc4 ♖e1+ 34.♖xe1 ♕xe1+ 35.♕f1 ♕b4.

29...♕f4? This leads to the loss of the f6-pawn, which could have been defended by 29...♕c6, although even here after 30.h3 it is not easy to defend against the threat of ♕g3+ and ♖d6.

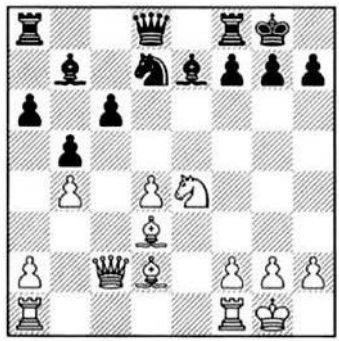
30.g3 ♕g4 31.♕xf6+ ♔g8 32.♕d6 ♖c6 33.♕f8+ ♔h7 34.♕xf7+ ♔h8 35.♕f8+ ♔h7 36.♖c1 ♕d4 37.♕c5 ♖e4 38.♕f5+ ♔g7 39.♘f6 ♖e2 40.♖xc4. Black resigned.

BRUZON – DOMINGUEZ

Cuba 2005

Queen's Gambit D47

1.d4 d5 2.e4 c6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♘f3 ♘bd7 6.♗d3 dxc4 7.♗xc4 b5 8.♗d3 ♗d6 9.0-0 0-0 10.♘g5 a6 11.♗d2 ♗b7 12.♘ce4 ♘xe4 13.♘xe4 ♗e7 14.b4 e5 15.♕c2 exd4 16.exd4.



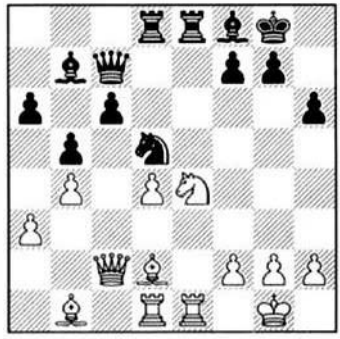
White's spatial advantage on the queenside is obvious, but it is not easy to convert it into a win. In the given situation he must widen the attacking front, in other words, follow Nimzowitsch's rule about the need to create new weaknesses. Clearly, White will try to do this on the kingside.

16...h6?! Without particular need, Black weakens his castled position, creating a target for White to attack – the h6-pawn. At the same time, there was nothing wrong with developing the rook by 16...♖e8, for example: 17.a3 ♘f8 18.♘e5 ♗xc5 19.dxe5 ♕h4 (or 19...♘g6 20.♖ad1 ♕h4) 20.♖ad1 ♖ad8, not weakening the king's defences.

17.a3 (17.♖ae1 was also good) **17...♘b6 18.♖ad1 ♘d5 19.♖fe1 ♕e7 20.♕c1.** Threatening the bishop sacrifice on h6. White would not have achieved anything significant by 20.♘c5, for example: 20...♖fe8 21.♖c1 ♗xc5 22.♕xc5 ♖xe1+ 23.♖xe1 ♖d8 24.♗e4, although here too he retains the advantage.



20...♖fe8 21.♗b1 ♗f8 22.♕c2 ♖ad8.



23.h4! A far-sighted move. In view of the threats along the b1-h7 diagonal, Black cannot get by without the g7-g6 barrier, and White prepares to undermine it. For example, if 23...a5 there can follow 24.♘d6! ♖xe1+ 25.♖xe1 g6 (25...♘f6 26.♘e8!) 26.♘xb7 ♕xb7 27.h5.

23...♖e6 24.♘g3 ♖xe1+ (24...♘f6 25.♘h5) **25.♖xe1 g6 26.h5.** Now the appearance of a weak pawn at g6 is unavoidable.

26...♖d6 27.hxg6 fxg6 28.♘e4 ♖e6 29.♘c5 ♖xe1+ 30.♗xe1 ♗xc5. The g6-pawn cannot be saved: 30...♘e7 31.♕b3+ ♘d5 (31...♔h8 32.♕f7) 32.♗xg6.

31.♕xg6+ ♕g7 32.♕xg7+ ♔xg7 33.dxc5, and White converted his extra pawn in the endgame.

In a number of positions with an isolated d4-pawn one possibility that has to be reckoned with is an

attack on an inadequately defended king along the a2-g8 diagonal.

KRAMNIK – KASPAROV
World Championship Match,
10th Game, London 2000
Nimzo-Indian Defence E54

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3 ♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 0-0 5.♗d3 d5 6.♘f3 c5 7. 0-0 cxd4 8.exd4 dxc4 9.♗xc4 b6. This same position can be reached in the Caro-Kann Defence under index B14.

10.♗g5 ♗b7 11.♖e1 ♘bd7 12.♖c1 ♖c8 13.♕b3 ♗e7 14.♗xf6 ♘xf6. This allows the bishop sacrifice on c6, which could have been avoided by 14...♗xf6.



15.♗xe6 fxe6? The acceptance of the bishop sacrifice places Black on the verge of defeat. After 15...♖c7! 16.♗c4!? (in the event of 16.♘g5 ♕xd4! 17.♘xf7 ♗c5 the initiative may pass to Black) 16...♗xf3 17.gxf3 ♖d7 in such a sharp middlegame an extra doubled pawn does not have any serious significance (variations by Kramnik).

16.♕xe6+ ♔h8 17.♕xc7 ♗xf3 18.gxf3. After the transition into an endgame – 18.♕xd8 ♖cxd8 19.gxf3 ♖xd4 Black's chances of saving the game are improved.

18...♕xd4 19.♘b5.



19...♕xb2? Apparently both players were familiar with the game Hazai – Danielsen, Valby 1994, which continued 19...♕f4 20.♖xe8 ♖xc8 21.♘d6 ♕xf3? 22.♘xc8 ♕g4+ 23.♔f1 ♕h3+ 24.♔e2 ♕xc8 25.♔d2, and White won. Instead of 21...♕xf3?, which led to a hopeless ending, in Kramnik's opinion the only defence was 21...♖a8, but here too after 22.♘f7+ 22...♔g8 23.♘d8 ♕g5+ 24.♔h1 ♕h5 25.♕e6+ ♔h8 26.♘f7+ ♔g8 27.♘c5+ ♔h8 28.f4 White has the advantage.

In capturing the pawn, Kasparov overestimates Black's defensive

resources, whereas, as shown by Kramnik and backed up by computer analysis, Black would have done better to play his queen to d3 or d2. Here are the main variations:

a) 19...♕d3!? 20.♖xc8 (or 20.♘d6♖a8 21.♘f7+♔g8 22.♘e5 ♕f5 23.♖c7!? ♘h5! 24.♕h4!? ♘f4 25.♕g4 ♕f6, with the tactical basis 26.♘d7 ♕d6 27.♘xf8 ♕xc7 28.♘e6 ♖e8!) 20...♖xc8 21.♘d6 ♖a8 22.♕e6 h6 23.♔g2;

b) 19...♕d2!? 20.♖xc8 ♖xc8 21.♘d6 ♖b8! 22.♘e8 ♖b7! 23.♕f8+ (23.♕c5 ♘g8) 23...♘g8 24.♖e4 ♖d7 25.♖g4 ♕xb2.

20.♖xc8 ♖xc8 21.♘d6 ♖b8? Black sets a clever trap – 22.♕xa7? ♖f8 23.♕e7 ♖a8 and the absence of the a7-pawn enables him to hold the position after24.♘f7+♔g8 25.♕e6 ♕xa2! But 21...♖a8 also fails to save him 22.♘f7+ ♔g8 23.♕e6 h6 (or 23...h5 24.♘g5+ ♔h8 25.♕f5 ♕xa2 26.♕g6) 24.♘xh6+ ♔h7 25.♘f7! ♖e8 26.♕f5+! g6 27.♕h3+ ♔g8 28.♖xe8+ ♘xe8 29.♕e6 ♘g7 30.♕d5 (Kramnik). 30.♕xg6! is also possible, since after 30...♕xa2 the advance of the h-pawn is decisive: 31.♘h6+ ♔h8 32.♘g4 ♔g8 33.h4 ♕e6 34.♕g5 ♔f8 35.h5.

22.♘f7+ ♔g8 23.♕e6! ♖f8. Opening an escape square for the king by 23...h5 also does not save Black, since White sets up on attack on the g7-pawn by coordinating his queen and rook: 24.♘g5+ ♔h8 25.♕f5 ♕c3 (25...♕xa2 26.♖e6 ♔g8 27.♕g6) 26.♖e6 ♕c7 (26...♔g8 27.♖c7) 27.♕g6 ♖f8 28.♖xf6 gxf6 29.♕h6+ ♔g8 30.♕xf8+. If 23...h6 a similar mechanism goes into operation: 24.♘xh6+ ♔h7 25.♕f5+! ♔h8 26.♘f7+ ♔g8 27.♘g5 ♕xa2 28.♖e7 (threatening ♕g6) 28...♖e8 29.♖xe8+ ♘xe8 30.♔g2 with the irresistible threat of ♕d7 (30.♕d7 ♕b1+ 31.♔g2 ♕g6).

24.♘d8+ ♔h8 25.♕e7. Black resigned.

SARGISSIAN – NAJER

Kallithea 2008

Slav Defence D16

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 dxc4 5.a4 e6 6.e3 c5 7.♗xc4 cxd4 8.exd4 ♘c6 9.0-0 ♗e7 10.♖e1 0-0 11.♗g5 ♗d7 12.♕d2 ♘b4. Black is aiming to set up a blockade on d5, but White's initiative proves more real. 12...♖c8 13.♖ad1 ♘b4 14.♘e5 ♘bd5 15.♗xf6 ♘xf6 16.d5 ♗b4 17.dxe6 ♗xe6 18.♕c2 ♕b6 19.♗xe6 fxe6 looks sounder, with an inferior, but defensible position, Shirov – Svidler, Foros 2008.

13.♘e5 ♗c6?! Creating the motif for an attack. 13...♖c8 was more circumspect.



14.♘xf7! This combination is based on the coordination of the knight at c5 and the bishop on the a2-g8 diagonal, supported by the rook.

14...♖xf7. If 14...♔xf7? 15. ♖xe6 ♘bd5 White decides matters with 16.♖xe7+! ♔xc7 17.♕c2+ ♔f7 18.♗xf6!

15.♗xe6 ♘bd5 16.♖e5 ♘c7?! Black forces the exchange of the bishop, after which his king remains under attack. He should have considered 16...♘xc3!? 17.bxc3 ♗e8 (17...♗d5? 18.♗xf6!) 18.♖ac1 ♗d6 19.♖f5 ♔h8, evacuating the king.

17.♗xf7+ ♔xf7.



18.d5!? The alternative was 18. ♖ac1!? .♗d6 19.♖f5, building up the threats.

18...♘cxd5 19.♘xd5 ♘xd5 20.♖d1 ♘f6 21.♕c2 ♕g8. 21... ♕c7 22.♖de1 ♗d8 was more tenacious.

22.b4 h6 23.b5 hxg5 24.bxc6 bxc6 25.♖de1 ♖e8 26.♕xc6 ♔f8 27.♕b7 ♕f7 28.♕xa7. The game is decided. Black is powerless against the advance of the a-pawn.

28...g4 29.a5 ♘g8 30.a6 ♕b3 31.♕c7 ♕b8 32.♕xb8 ♖xb8 33.a7 ♖a8 34.♖a5 ♗d8 35.♖b1 ♗c7 36.♖b7. Black resigned.

Chapter 2

The d4-d5 breakthrough

The dynamic strength of the isolated pawn is founded on its 'lust to expand', as remarked on by Aaron Nimzowitsch. Indeed, the advance of the d4-pawn across the d5 blockading point is one of the methods often used by White to gain an advantage. The basic idea of the d4-d5 breakthrough is to seize space in the centre after the exchange of a number of pieces. An important accompanying factor in the opening of the position is a lead in development, which shows itself to particular effect if Black has not yet castled. The first to demonstrate this was again Wilhelm Steinitz.

STEINITZ – BARDELEBEN
Hastings 1895
Giuoco Piano C54

1.e4 e5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.♗c4 ♗c5 4.c3 ♘f6 5.d4 exd4 6.cxd4 ♗b4+ 7.♘c3 d5 8.exd5 ♘xd5 9.0-0 ♗e6 10.♗g5 ♗e7. It looks safer to play 10...♕d7!? 11.♗xd5 ♗xd5 12.♖c1+ ♔f8! (Kasparov).



In this position the blockade at d5 of the isolated pawn is ineffective, since the blockading piece is not supported by a pawn. This factor, and Black's delay in castling, allow White to break the blockade.

11.♗xd5! ♗xd5 12.♘xd5 ♕xd5 13.♗xe7 ♘xe7 14.♖e1! The concluding move of the exchanging operation – the king is forced to remain in the centre.

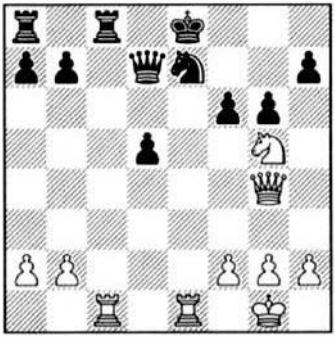
14...f6 15.♕e2 ♕d7 16.♖ac1 c6. Later analysis established that Black could have defended with 16...♔f7!



17.d5! The decisive breakthrough! By sacrificing a pawn, White includes his knight in the attack.

17...cxd5 18.♘d4 (with the threat of 19.♘f5) **18...♔f7 19.♘e6! ♖hc8.** Black has to defend against the invasion of the rook. He loses quickly after 19...♘c6 20.♘c5 ♕c8 21.♕h5+.

20.♕g4! g6 21.♘g5+! ♚e8.



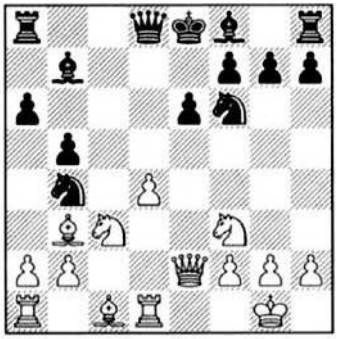
22.♖xe7+!! The culmination of White's attack, based on geometric motifs: 22...♚xe7 (22...♕xe7 23.♖xc8+) 23.♖c1+ ♚d6 24.♕b4+ ♔c7 (24...♖c5 25.♖e6+) 25.♘c6 ♔b8 26.♕f4 ♖c7 27.♘xc7.

22...♔f8 23.♖f7+! The same geometric motif.

23...♔g8 24.♖g7+! ♔h8 (24...♔f8 25.♘xh7+) **25.♖xh7+!** and here, according to contemporary reports, Karl Bardeleben left the tournament hall, tacitly admitting his defeat. It was left to Steinitz to demonstrate to the delighted spectators the following mating finish: 25.♖xh7+! ♔g8 26.♖g7+ ♔h8 27.♕h4+ ♔xg7 28.♕h7+ ♔f8 29.♕h8+ ♔e7 30.♕g7+ ♔e8 31.♕g8+ ♔e7 32.♕f7+ ♔d8 33.♕f8+ ♕c8 34.♘f7+ ♔d7 35.♕d6#.

SPASSKY – AVTONOMOV
Leningrad 1949
Queen's Gambit Accepted D28

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘13 ♘f6 4. e3 c5 5.♗xc4 e6 5. 6.0-0 a6 7.♕e2 b5 8.♗b3 ♘c6 9.♘c3 cxd4 10.♖d1 ♗b7 11.exd4 ♘b4.



White has a big lead in development, and in addition the black king has not castled, which creates the motifs for exploiting the opposition of queen and king.

12.d5! Exploiting the fact that the d4-pawn is not blockaded, White opens the position with this breakthrough in the centre.

12...♘bxd5 13.♗g5! The bishop pin is an important motif, which we will encounter on numerous occasions.

13...♗e7 14.♗xf6 gxf6 15.♘xd5 ♝xd5 16.♗xd5 exd5 17.♘d4. As a result of the opening of the centre, White has transfomed his lead in development into a strong attack. Black is unable to cover his numerous weaknesses.



17...♔f8 (or 17...♕d7 18.♖e1 ♖a7 19.♖ac1 ♔f8 20.♕h5 with the threat of ♘f5) **18.♘f5 h5 19.♖xd5! ♕xd5 20.♕xe7+ ♔g8 21.♕xf6.** Black resigned.

EINGORN – GELFAND
Tallinn 1989
Queen's Gambit D24

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 d5 4.♘c3 dxc4 5.♗g5 a6 6.a4 ♘c6 7.e3 ♘a5 8.♘e5 c5 9.♗xc4 ♗e7 10.0-0 cxd4 11.exd4 ♘xc4 12.♘xc4 a5.



Not only has Black not castled, but his queenside is also weak. And since White's pieces are excellently mobilised, the best way of converting his lead in development is by opening the position.

13.d5! exd5. In the event of 13...♘xd5 14.♗xe7 ♔xe7 15.♕g4 White has a strong initiative for the pawn.

14.♝xf6 ♗xf6 15.♘xd5 ♗e6. After the natural 15...0-0 there could have followed 16.♘cb6 ♖a6 17.♘xc8 ♕xc8 18.♕b3. The centralised knight and the vulnerable pawns on a5 and b7 give White the advantage.

16.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 17.♘d6+ ♔f8.



18.♘xb7?! The capture of this pawn allows Black to exchange the queens, whereas 18.♕d2! h5 (18...♖d8 19.♖a3) 19.f4! would have continued White's attack.

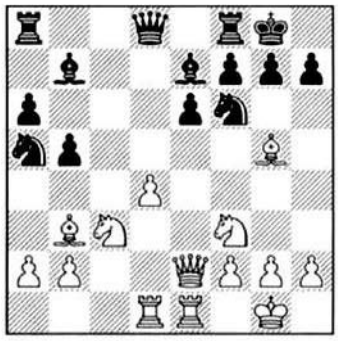
18...♕e7! 19.♕d6 ♕xd6 20.♘xd6 ♔e7 21.♘b5 ♖hd8 22.♘c7. The situation is not changed by 22.♖fd1 ♖ab8 23.♘d4 ♔f6 24.♘xe6 ♖xd1+ 25.♖xd1 ♔xe6 with equal chances.

22...♖ab8 23.♘xe6 fxe6 24.♖ab1 ♖d2 25.b3 ♖d3 26.♖fe1 ♖bxb3 27.♖xb3 ♖xb3 28.f4 ♖b4. Draw.

In the following example Black castled, but he underestimated White's lead in development.

BOLESLAVSKY – KOTOV
Candidates Tournament, Zurich 1953
Queen's Gambit Accepted D28

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗xc4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.♕e2 cxd4 8.exd4 ♗e7 9.♘c3 b5 10.♗b3 ♗b7 11.♗g5 0-0 12.♖fe1 ♘c6 13.♖ad1 ♘a5.



White has a clear lead in development, and his rooks (in contrast to Black's) are mobilised on the central files. This creates the motif for exploiting the opposition of queen and rook in the event of the position being opened, which is aggravated by the fact that the bishop at e7 is inadequately defended. Therefore on the last move 13...♘d5, blocking the d4-pawn, would have been more circumspect.

14.d5! A decisive breakthrough. Since 14...♘xd5 15.♗xd5 ♗xd5 16.♖xd5! exd5 17.♗xe7 leads to the loss of a piece, Black has to agree to the loss of a pawn.

14...♘xb3 15.dxe6 ♕b6 16.axb3 fxe6 17.♘d4! (it is important for White to strengthen his control of the e6-square) **17...♗d6.** In the event of 18...♗c5 19.♕xe6+

♔h8 20.♕xb6 ♗xb6 21.♖c7 the rook would have invaded.

18.♕xc6+.



As a result of the breakthrough in the centre White is a pawn up and his pieces are completely dominant.

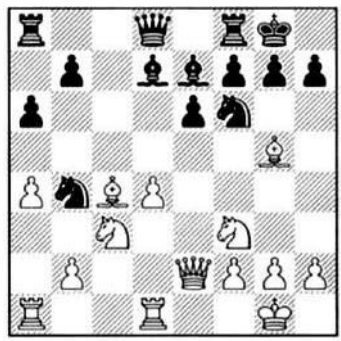
18...♔h8 19.♘f3 (19.♗f4 ♗c5 20.♕xb6 ♗xb6 21.♖c7 was more consistent) **19...♖ad8 20.♗f4! ♗xf3 21.♖xd6 ♖xd6 22.♕xd6 ♕xd6 23.♗xd6 ♖e8 24.♖xe8+ ♘xe8 25.♗e5!** An instructive manoeuvre, with which White restricts the black knight – after its exchange the endgame with knight against bishop and an extra pawn is easily won. Avoiding the exchange of the knight also does not save Black.

25...♗c6 26.b4!, and after fixing the pawns on light squares, White won the a6-pawn and the game.

A delay in the development of the pieces may become the theme of an opening conception, based on the d4-d5 breakthrough.

BOTVINNIK – PETROSIAN
World Championship Match,
10th Game, Moscow 1963
Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗xc4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.a4 ♘c6 8.♕e2 cxd4 9.♖d1 ♗e7 10.exd4 0-0 11.♘c3 ♘b4 12.♗g5 ♗d7. In Reshevsky – Petrosian, Olympiad, Siegen 1970, Black preferred 12...♘fd5, and after 13.♘xd5 ♘xd5 14.♗xc7 ♘xc7 15.♕c4 ♘d5 16.♘e5 ♘f6 17.♕f4 ♘d5 18.♕e4 ♘f6 19.♕f4 ♘d5 peace was concluded. 13.♗xc7 ♘xc7 14.♘e5 leads to sharper play.

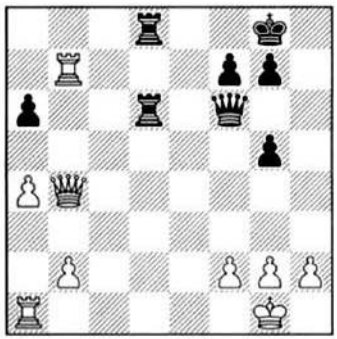


13.d5. In his comments on the game Botvinnik remarks that this move and the subsequent continuation were prepared for the game, and yet he hesitated before going in for it, since he foresaw that it would be very difficult to convert the extra pawn.

13...exd5 14.♘xd5 ♘bxd5. Black simplifies the position as

much as possible. Weaker was 14... ♘fxd5 15.♗xc7 ♘xc7 16.♘e5 with a spatial advantage for White.

15.♗xd5 ♘xd5 16.♖xd5 ♗xg5 17.♘xg5 h6 18.♕d2 hxg5 19.♖xd7 ♕f6 (19...♕b6 would not have saved the pawn in view of 20.a5 ♕b3 21.♖a3) **20.♖xb7 ♖ad8 21.♕a5 ♖d6 22.♕b4 ♖fd8.**



Botvinnik's doubts were confirmed – the active placing of Black's pieces fully compensates for the lost pawn.

23.♖f1 ♖d4 (23...♖d1 24.♖b8) **24.♕b3 ♖d3 25.♕c2 ♖d2 26.♕c7 ♕f4.** Petrosian is not looking for adventures in the ending with queen against two rooks (26...♖xf2 27.♕xd8+ ♕xd8 28.♖xf2) and he prefers to take play into a double rook endgame.

27.♕xf4 gxf4 28.h4 ♖c8 29.♖b4 f3! With a temporary pawn sacrifice Black breaks up White's pawns.

30.gxf4 ♖cc2 31.b3 ♖b2 32.♔g2 (32.♖b6 a5=) **32...♖d3 33.♖b8+ ♔h7 34.♖b7 f6 35.♖e1 ♖dxb3 36.♖xb3 ♖xb3 37.♖c6 ♖b4 38.♖xa6 ♖xh4 39.♔g3 g5 40.♔g2 ♔g6 41.♖a8 ♖f4 42.a5 ♖a4 43.a6 ♔f5.** Draw.

Although further games confirmed Botvinnik's doubts about the early 13.d5 breakthrough, few players were happy to play for a draw a pawn down. In his notes to the game, Botvinnik himself thought it was sounder to blockade the d4-pawn by ♘f6-d5. However, removing the knight from the king-side allows White to transfer his queen there, which creates definite problems with the defence of the king.

PETROSIAN – SPASSKY

Moscow 1971

Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗xc4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.a4 ♘c6 8.♕e2 cxd4 9.♖d1 ♗e7 10.exd4 0-0 11.♘c3 ♘d5. A passing of the baton by world champions: the ninth champion invites the tenth to demonstrate the virtues of the blockade, adopted by him in the 16th game of his match with Botvinnik.

12.♕e4. Apparently Botvinnik's attacking procedure 12.♗d3 ♘b4 13.♗b1 ♗d7 14.♕e4 did not seem convincing to Petrosian.

12...♘cb4 13.♘e5.



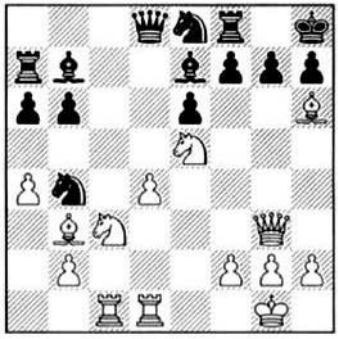
13...♖a7. Black prepares the fianchetto of his bishop, since if 13...b6 White exchanges the blockading knight with 14.♘xd5! exd5 (14...♘xd5? 15.♘c6) 15.♕f3, when Black's queenside is substantially weakened. This topic is examined in Chapter 3.

14.♗b3 ♘f6 15.♕h4 b6 16.♕g3.



16...♗b7?! The white pieces are very actively placed and the d4-d5 breakthrough is in the air. But Black underestimates the threat of 17.♗h6, which forces him to weaken his control of the key d5-point. 16...♔h8!? was more circumspect, when 17.d5?! does not now work in view of 17...exd5 18.♘xd5 ♘fxd5 19.♗xd5 ♘xd5!, since 20.♘c6? is parried by 20...♘c3!, after which it is White who has to seek a way to save the game.

17.♗h6 ♘e8 18.♖ac1 ♔h8.



19.d5! Now is the time! The knight retreat to e8 has disrupted the coordination of the black pieces, and the breakthrough in the centre converts the opposition of the d1-rook and the d8-queen into a spatial advantage.

19...exd5. If 19...gxh6 the simplest is 20.dxe6 ♘d6 21.exf7, since nothing is given by 20.♘xf7+ ♖xf7 21.de ♖g7 22.♖xd8 ♖xg3 23.♖xe8+ ♖g8 24.♖xe7 ♗xg2!, when White has to reconcile himself to a draw by 25.♖xa7 ♗h3+. 19...♘xd5 20.♘xd5 exd5 21.♗e3! ♖a8 22.♘c6 is also bad for Black.

20.♗e3! ♖a8. Not 20...a5 in view of 21.♘xd5! ♘xd5 22.♗xd5 ♗xd5 23.♘c6. If 20...♗c5, then 21.a5 ♘f6 22.♘a4 is strong.

21.♘c4! ♘d6 (21....♗c5?! 22.♘a5!) **22.♝xb6.** 22.♘xb6 is less good because of 22...♘f5! 23.♕h3 ♘xe3 24.♕xe3 ♗g5 25.f4 ♖e8!

22...♕b8. Weaker is 22...♕d7?! 23.♘e3! ♕e6 24.♗c5 a5 25.♝xb4 axb4 26.♘cxd5.



23.♘a5. 23.♘e3! was stronger.

23...♘f5 (23...♖c8!? 24.♕f4) **24.♕xb8 ♖axb8 25.♘xb7 ♖xb7 26.a5 ♗g5 27.♖b1 d4 28.♘d5 ♘c6 29.♗a4 ♖c8 30.f4 ♘ce7 31.♖bc1 ♖cb8 32.fxg5 ♘xd5 33.♝c6 ♖xb6 34.axb6 ♘de3 35.b7 ♘xd1 36.♖xd1 g6 37.g4 ♘g7 38.♖xd4 ♘e6 39.♖d7.** Black resigned.

We will now consider a more modern example of the blockade of the central pawn.

MILOV – GULIYEV
Corsica 2005
Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♝xc4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.a4 ♘c6 8.♕e2 ♗e7 9.♖d1 cxd4 10.exd4 0-0 11.♘c3 ♘b4 12.♘e5 ♘fd5. Black blockades the isolated d4-pawn, which allows White to switch his queen to the kingside.



13.♗b3. A prophylactic bishop retreat. The attempt to attack on the queenside with 13.♖a3 is parried by 13...f6 14.♘f3 ♝d7 15.♗d2 ♖c8 16.a5 ♔h8 17.♖b3 ♖e8 with a sound position for Black (he is threatening both 18...♕xa5, and 18...♕c7), Milov – Xu Jun, Olympiad, Istanbul 2000.

13....♗d7 14.♕g4!? After 14.♕f3 both 14....♗c6 and 14...♗e8 15.♕h3 ♖c8 are good.

14...♘f6. Black has to reckon with the threat of ♗h6. For example, in the event of the placid 14...♝c6 15.♗h6

♗f6 16.♘e4 ♖c8 White takes play into a favourable endgame: 17.♘xf6+ ♕xf6 18.♗g5 ♕f5 19.♕xf5 exf5 20.♗d2, obtaining not only effectively an extra passed d4-pawn, but also the better position, which is not easy for Black to defend. For example: 20...♖ce8 21.♖ac1 ♖c7 22.♖c4 a5 23.♖c5 ♖a8 24.♗xb4 ♘xb4 25.f4, or 20...a5 21.♗xb4 axb4 22.♘xc6 bxc6 23.a5.

15.♕g3 ♔h8?! This radical way of parrying the threatened ♗h6 does not prevent d4-d5. 15...♖e8!? 16.♗h6 ♗f8 was possible, when the breakthrough 17.d5 exd5 18.♘xd5 ♘bxd5 19.♗xd5 is parried by 19...♖xe5!



16.d5! By opening the position, White exploits the fact that the f7-pawn is inadequately defended.

16...exd5 17.♘xd5 ♘fxd5. Or 17...♘bxd5 18.♗xd5 ♗c6 (18...♗f5 19.♗b3 ♕e8 20.♗e3) 19.♗b3 ♕e8 20.♗e3 with a positional advantage for White.

18.♗xd5 ♗c6? Black overlooks the queen and rook 'X-ray'. Correct was 18...♗f5 19.♗b3 ♕c8 20.♕f4 ♗e6 (after 20...♗c2 21.♗xf7! a pawn is lost) 21.♗xe6 fxe6 22.♕e4, when although he has an isolated e6-pawn, his position is defensible.



19.♗h6! gxh6 20.♗xc6 ♕b8 21.♗xb7 ♕xb7 22.♖d7 ♕b6 23.♖xe7 ♕f6 24.♘xf7+. The simplest, although the diagonal 'X-ray' 24.♕c3! ♘d5 25.♘xf7+! is also good.

24...♖xf7 25.♖xf7 ♕xf7 26.♕c3+ ♕g7 27.♕xb4 a5 28.♕b6 ♕c5 29.♖d1 ♖b8 30.♕xh6 ♕xb2 31.♕e3 ♕b3 32.♖d8+ ♔g7 33.♕e5+. Black resigned.

GAVRIKOV – HULAK
Moscow 1990
Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.e3 ♘f6 4.♗xc4 e6 5.♘f3 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.a4 ♘c6 8.♕e2 cxd4 9.♖d1 ♗e7 10.exd4 0-0 11.♘c3 ♘b4 12.♘e5.



12...b6?! This move allows White to switch his queen to the kingside with gain of tempo. Here Botvinnik considers the soundest continuation to be 12...♗d7, when the 13.d5 breakthrough proves unsuccessful in view of the simplifying manoeuvre 13...♘fxd5 14.♘xd5 ♘xd5 15.♗xd5 exd5 16.♖xd5 ♗g4! (after 12..♗g5 .♝d7 this manoeuvre does not work) 17.♕c4 ♕xd5 18.♕xd5 ♖ad8. In the event of 13.♝g5 ♖c8 Black completes his queenside development. For example, the game Bareev – Ivanchuk, Linares 1994, continued 14.♖e1 ♗e8 (after 14...♗c6 14.♘xc6 bxc6 15.a5! it is more difficult to defend) 15.♖ad1 ♘fd5 16.♘xd5 ♘xd5 17.♗xd5 ♗xg5 18.♗xb7 ♝xa4 19.♗xc8 ♗xd1 20.♕xa6 ♕xc8! 21.♕xc8 ♖xc8 22.♖xd1 ♖b8 23.♖b1, and here the balance would have been maintained by 23...♖b4! 24.♘f3 ♗f6 25.♝f1 g5! 26.h3 h5 27.g4 hxg4 28.hxg4 ♚f8 29.♔e2 ♗xd4 (Bareev).

13.♕f3 ♖a7 14.♕g3 ♖c7?! Since the opposition of queen and rook creates the threat of ♗h6, it is usually parried by prophylaxis – 14...♔h8.

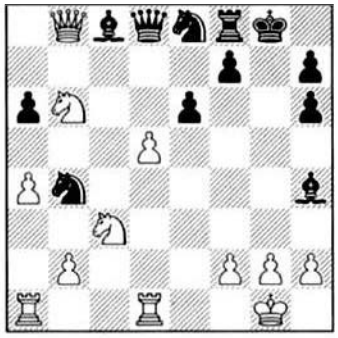
15.♗h6 ♘e8. White also gains the advantage after 15...♘h5 16.♕g4 f6 17.♗xe6+♔h8 18.♗xc8 fxe6 19.♕xh5 ♕xc8 20.♗e3 (if 20.d5, then 20...♝c5! is good) 20...♘□2 21♘d5.



16.d5! The retreat of Black's knight has weakened his control of d5, which White immediately exploits.

16...♖xc4. Consideration should have been given to 16...♗h4 17.dxe6 ♕xd1+ (17...♝xe6 18.♖xd8 ♗xg3 19.hxg3 ♗xc4 20.♗e3 leads to an advantage for White) 18.♖xd1 ♗xg3 19.exf7+ ♔h8 (19...♖xf7 20.hxg3 favours White) 20.♖d8 (20.hxg3 gxh6 21.♖d8 ♖e7=) 20...♗xf2+ 21.♔h1 ♖e7, when Black holds the position.

17.♘xc4 ♗h4 18.♕b8 gxh6 19.♘xb6.



19...♕c7 (19...♕d6 leads to a similar variation) **20.♕xc7 ♘xc7 21.♖d4 ♘c2 22.♖g4+ ♔g5 23.♖c1 f5.** White is also better after 23... ♘d4 24.d6 ♘d5 25.♘cxd5 ♘e2+ 26.♔f1 ♘xc1 27.♘e7+ ♔h8 28.♘bxc8.

24.♖xg5+ hxg5 25.♖xc2 ♗b7 26.d6, and White converted his extra pawn.

But more often the d4-d5 breakthrough is carried out in a situation where, in parrying a piece attack on his king, Black disrupts the harmony among his pieces.

PETROSIAN – BALASHOV
Moscow 1974
Nimzo-Indian Defence E57

1.c4 ♘f6 2.♘c3 e6 3.d4 ♗b4 4.e3 c5 5.♗d3 d5 6.♘f3 0-0 7.0-0 dxc4 8.♗xc4 ♘c6 9.♗d3 cxd4 10.exd4 ♗e7 11.♖e1 b6 12.a3 ♗b7 13.♗c2 ♖c8 14.♕d3 ♖e8?. It is surprising that this move periodically occurs even in grandmaster games. It is essential to restrict the ♕d3 + ♗c2 battery with 14...g6.



15.d5! exd5 16.♗g5! This standard attacking mechanism, based on the d4-d5 breakthrough, is worth remembering. 17.♗xf6 is threatened, and Black cannot play 16...g6 because of 17.♖xc7! ♕xc7 18.♘xd5.

16...♘e4 17.♘xe4 dxe4 18.♕xe4 g6 19.♕h4 ♕c7. The game Portisch – Karpov, Milan 1975, continued 19...♖c7 20.♗b3! h5, and here with 20.♗b3! White could have placed Black in a critical position.

20.♗b3!



Black has no defence. 21.♗xf7+ is threatened. If 20...♗f8 there follows 21.♗f4! and then 22.♘g5, while after 20...♗d6 there is the unpleasant 21.♗f6.

20...h5 21.♕e4 ♔g7 22.♗xf7! ♔xf7 23.♗h6! ♕d6. The game S.Garcia – Pomar, Salamanca 1975, went 23...♗d6 24.♘g5+ ♔f6 25.♘h7+!, and Black resigned.

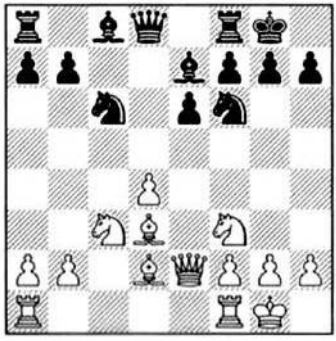
24.♕c4+ ♔f6 25.♖ad1 ♘d4 26.♕xd4+ ♕xd4 27.♖xd4. Black resigned.

KAMSKY – KARPOV

FIDE World Championship Match, 2nd Game, Elista 1996

Caro-Kann Defence B14

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♘f3 ♗b4 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♗d2 ♘c6 9.♗d3 ♗e7 10.0-0 0-0 11.♕e2 ♘f6. The win of a pawn by 11...♘db4 12.♗e4 ♘xd4 13.♘xd4 ♕xd4 14.♖fd1 would have allowed White too serious an initiative.



12.♘e4. White prevents the standard development of the light-square bishop on the long diagonal (12...b6? 13 ♘xf6+ ♗xf6 14 ♕e4) by tactical means, since the win of the d4-pawn is risky: 12...♘xd4?! 13.♘xd4 ♕xd4 14.♗c3 ♕d8 (14...♕b6? is not possible because of 15.♘xf6+ ♗xf6 16.♕e4) 15.♘xf6+ ♗xf6 16.♖fd1 ♗d7 17.♗xf6 ♕xf6 18.♗xh7+ ♔xh7 19.♖xd7 with advantage to White.

12...♗d7. Black's striving to complete his development as quickly as possible leads to difficulties. In the 4th game of the match Karpov played the stronger 12...♕b6.

13.♖ad1 ♖c8 14.♖fe1. The alternative is 14.♘xf6+!? ♗xf6 15.♕e4 g6 16.♗h6♖e8 17.♘e5.

14...♘d5 15.♘c3! A deep penetration into the position. White aims to exchange the blockading knight on d5, exploiting the lack of harmony created by the bishop development at d7.

15...♘f6. Black should have begun with the useful move 15...♘cb4 16.♗b1, and only then 16...♘f6, strengthening his control of the d5-square.

16.a3 ♕c7 (16...♕b6 is more active) **17.♗g5 ♕a5?** This move, removing the defence of the bishop on d7, allows White to carry out a breakthrough in the centre, which could have been prevented by 17...♖fe8.



18.d5! exd5. Weaker is 18...♘xd5? 19.♘xd5 ♗xg5 (19...exd5 20.♗xe7 ♖fe8 21.♗b4! leads to the loss of a piece) 20.♗xh7+! ♔xh7 21.♘xg5+ ♔h6, and now by 22.♕e4!, with the threat of a mating attack after 23.♕h7+, White wins the queen: 22...♔xg5 23.♕f4+ ♔g6 24.♕g4+ ♔h7 25.♕h5+ ♔g8 26.♘c7+ ♘xc7 27.♕xa5.

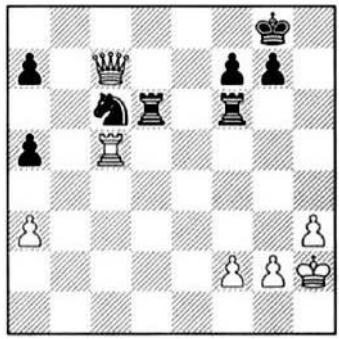
19.♗xf6 ♗xf6 20.♗xh7+! ♔xh7 21.♖xd5 ♗xc3. Understandably, Black is not satisfied with 21...♕c7 22.♕d3+ ♔g8 23.♖xd7, where he has no compensation for the pawn, and he decides to give up queen for rook and bishop in the hope of creating a fortress.

22.♖xa5 ♗xa5 23.b4! This important intermediate move, defending the rook (keeping 24.♕d3+ in reserve) ensures White a material advantage.

23...♔g8 24.ba ♗g4? Black misses an opportunity to exchange a pair of rooks – 24...♖fe8 25.♕d3 ♗g4 26.h3 ♗xf3 27.♖xe8+ ♖xe8 28.♕xf3 ♘xa5, which would have given chances of setting up a fortress along the 6th rank after the coordinating of the remaining pieces.

25.a6! (depriving the knight of its support) **25...bxa6 26.♕e4 ♗xf3 27.♕xf3 ♖fe8 28.♖a1!** It is important to retain the rook, since with the queen alone it is far more difficult (if at all possible) to breach Black's defences.

28...♖e6 29.h3 ♖d8 30.♕3 ♖dd6 31.♖b1 ♖d7 32.♕c4 a5 33.♖b5 ♖d1+ 34.♔h2 ♖d2 35.♖f5 ♖d4 36.♕c3 ♖dd6 (36...g6 37.♖xa5) **37.♖c5 ♖f6 38.♖c4 ♖fe6 39.♖c5 ♖f6 40.♕e3 ♖fe6 41.♕g3 ♖g6 42.♕b3 ♖gf6 43.♕b7 ♖fe6 44.♕c7 ♖f6.**



45.f4! After the preceding manoeuvres, which had the aim of reaching the adjournment, Kamsky shows his hand: he plans a pawn attack on the king (45...♖fe6 46.f5 ♖f6 47.g4 g5 48.h4).

45...g6 46.f5 gxf5 47.♖xf5 ♖de6 48.♖h5 ♖h6 49.♕g3+ ♔f8 (49...♖hg6 50.♕c3 ♖h6 51.♖f5) **50.♖d5 ♖hg6 51.♕f2 ♖gf6 52.♕b2 ♔e7 53.♖h5 ♖h6 54.♖b5 ♖hf6 55.♕c3 ♔f8 56.♖h5 ♖h6 57.♖f5 ♖hg6.** White has managed to disrupt the coordination of the rook pair.

58.♕f3! ♖g7 (58...♖c7 59.♕f4 ♔e8 60.h4) **59.♕f4 ♔g8 60.♕c7 ♔f8 61.♕c8+ ♔e7 62.♖d5 ♔f6 63.♕h8 ♖e4 64.♖h5 ♘e7 65.♖h7.** Black resigned.

Often the d4-d5 breakthrough is an effective measure during an attack on the king.

KAVALEK – LARSEN
6th Match Game, Solingen 1970
Caro-Kann Defence B14

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♘f3 ♗e7 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♗d3 0-0 9.0-0 ♘c6 10.♖e1 ♘f6 11.♗g5 b6 12.a3 ♗b7.



White has good chances of an attack on the king: the presence of the pawn at a3 prevents the standard knight manoeuvre to b4, making it difficult for Black to control the d5-square.

13.♗c2 ♖e8. Black does not have time for 13...♘d5 in view of 14.♕d3 g6 15.♗h6.

14.♕d3 g6 15.h4! ♖c8 16.♖ad1 a6. The blockading 16...♘d5? does not succeed: 17.♘xd5 ♕xd5 (or 17...exd5 18.♗a4! ♗xg5 19.hxg5 ♖xc1+ 20.♖xc1 ♘e7 21.♘e5 with the unpleasant threat of 22.♕f3!) 18.♗b3! ♕a5, as after 19.d5! exd5 (19...♖cd8 dxe6! ♖xd3 20.exf7+) 20.♗xd5 ♖cd8 21.♕b3 the f7-pawn cannot be defended.

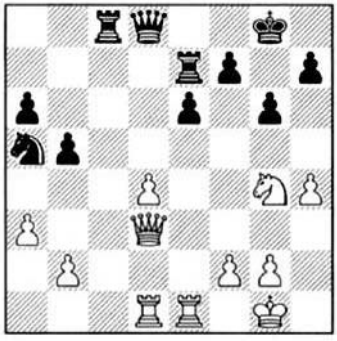


17.♗b3 ♘a5. By countering the threat of d4-d5, Black weakens his control of the e5-square.

18.♗a2 b5 19.♘e5 ♘d5 20.♗xd5. An advantageous transformation of one type of advantage into another.

20...♗xd5 21.♗xe7 ♖xe7 (or 21...♕xe7?! 22.♘xg6 hxg6 23.♘xd5 ♕xh4 24.♘c3, renewing the threat of d4-d5) **22.♘xd5 ♕xd5.** 22...exd5 23.h5 ♘c4 was safer, with chances of neutralising White's initiative.

23.♘g4! ♕d8? If 23...♕d6 there would also have followed 24.d5, but the most tenacious was 23...♔g7 24.♕d2 ♕h5 25.♕f4 ♕f5 26.♕h6+ ♔h8!



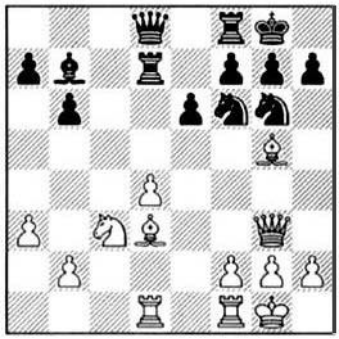
24.d5! exd5 25.♕d4 ♖xe1+ 26.♖xe1 ♕f8 27.♘f6+ ♔h8 28.♖e8 ♖xe8 29.♘xe8+ f6 30.♘xf6 ♘b3 31.♕e5 d4 32.g4 d3 33.g5 d2 34.♕d5 ♕c8 35.♕xb3 ♕c1+ (35...♕c4 36.♕f3) **36.♔g2 ♕c6+ 37.♘d5 ♔g8 38.f3.** Black resigned.

KASPAROV – PSAKHIS

6th Match Game, Murcia 1990

Nimzo-Indian Defence E42

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 c5 5.♘e2 d5 6.a3 ♗xc3+ 7.♘xc3 cxd4 8.exd4 dxc4 9.♗xc4 ♘c6 10.♗e3 0-0 11.0-0 b6 12.♕f3 ♗b7 13.♗d3 ♖c8 14.♖ad1 ♖c7 15.♕h3 ♘e7 16.♗g5! ♘g6 17.♕g3 ♖d7.



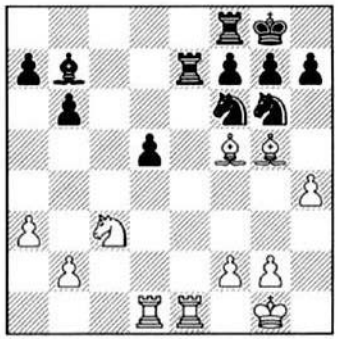
The first impression is that Black is securely blocking the isolated d4-pawn, but the pin on the f6-knight allows White to carry out a breakthrough in the centre and realise the potential of his bishop pair.

18.d5! exd5. If 18...♗xd5, then 19.♗b5! ♖c7 (19...♖d6 20.♗xf6 gxf6 21.♘e4! leads to the loss of the exchange) 20.♘xd5 exd5 21.♗xf6 gxf6 22.♕b3 ♘e7 23.♖d4, attacking the broken kingside.

19.♗f5 ♖e7 20.h4! (with the threat of 21.♗xf6 gxf6 22.h5) **20...♕c7** (in the hope of weakening the pressure of the white pieces by exchanging queens) **21.♕xc7 ♖xc7 22.♖fe1!** The white rooks dominate on the important central files.

22...♖e7. The desire to exchange the active rook is natural. In the event

of 22...h6 23.♗xf6 gxf6 24.h5 ♘f4 (24...♘e7? 25.♘b5) 25.g3 ♘xh5 26.♘xd5 ♗xd5 27.♖xd5 the white rooks are still dominant.



23.♘b5! By attacking the queenside weaknesses. White does not allow Black the slightest respite. If 23...a6 there follows 24.♘d6 ♗c6 25.♘c8.

23...♖fe8 24.♖xe7 ♘xe7 25.♗h3 ♗c8 26.♗xc8 ♖xc8. More tenacious was 26...♘xc8 27.♗xf6 gxf6 28.♖xd5, although here too White's position is technically won.

27.♘xa7 ♖c2 28.b4 ♔f8 29.♗e3 ♘f5 30.♗xb6 ♘g4 31.♗c5+ ♔e8 32.♘b5 ♖a2 33.♘c3 ♖xa3 34.♘xd5 f6 35.b5 ♖b3 36.b6. Black resigned.

However, despite its obvious virtues, the d4-d5 breakthrough does not always achieve its goal. We will consider a few examples.

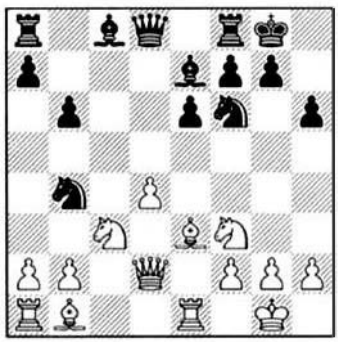
KARPOV – BELIAVSKY
Linares 1995
Caro-Kann Defence B14

1.c4 c6 2.e4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.d4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♘f3 ♗e7 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♗d3 0-0 9.0-0 ♘c6 10.♖e1 ♘f6 11.♗g5 (this position may also be reached via the Tarrasch Defence Deferred to the Queen's Gambit under index D42) **11...h6.** The main reply is considered to be 11...♘b4, aiming for the maximum control of d5. The move in the game is aimed at 12.♗h4 ♘h5 with the exchange of bishops.

12.♗e3. Now Black has to reckon with the threat of the bishop sacrifice on h6.

12...♘b4 13.♗b1 b6? Careless. 13...♖c8, preparing ♗f8, was essential.

14.♕d2.



14...♖e8. Forced. If 14...♗b7 White can sacrifice his bishop: 15.♗xh6 ♗xf3 16.♗xg7 ♘g4

(Black loses after 16...♔xg7? 17.♕g5+ ♔h8 18.♕h6+ ♔g8 19.♖e5) 17.gxf3 ♗g5 18.♕e2 ♗f4 19.fxg4 ♕h4 20.♕f3 ♕xh2+ 21.♔f1 ♔xg7 22.♗e4 etc.

15.a3! ♘**c6.** The only move. If 15...♘bd5? White changes the pawn structure by the exchange 16.♘xd5 e□d5 (16...♘xd5 loses to 17.♗xh6 gxh6 18.♕xh6 f5 19.♕g6+ ♔h8 20.♗xf5! exf5 21.♘g5), after which there can follow 17.♗xh6 gxh6 18.♕xh6 ♘e4 (or 18...♗g4 19.♖e5 ♘e4 20.♗xe4 dxe4 21.♘g5) 19.♖xe4 dxe4 20.♗xe4, gaining a big material advantage.



16.♕**d3.** White continues to build up the threats. For the moment the 16.d5 breakthrough is premature and it proves effective only after the capture with the pawn: 16...e□d5? 17.♗xh6 gxh6 18.♕xh6 ♗f8 19.♖x□8 ♕x□8 20♕xf6 or 16...♘xd5 17.♘xd5 ♕xd5 18.♕c2 ♝f6 19.♕h7+ ♔f8 20.♝e4 ♕d7 21.♖cd1! ♕c7 22.♖ac1 ♝b7 23.♘d4 etc. (Karpov). But after 16...♘a5, with the threat of ♘c4, nothing significant is apparent. The bishop sacrifice 17.♗xh6 is parried by 17...♘b3 18.♕g5 ♗f8 19.♖a2 e□d5, while in the event of 17♗a2 Black simplifies the position – 17...exd5 18.♘xd5 ♘xd5 19.♗xd5 ♗b7 etc.

16...♗**b7 17.**♘**e4** ♔**f8! 18.**♝**d2.** After 18.♘xf6 ♗xf6 19.♕h7 Black can capture the d4-pawn. But now it is indirectly defended, since in the event of 18...♘xe4 19.♕xe4 ♗f6 20.♕h7 ♘xd4? 21.♗b4+ White wins.

18...a5 19.♗**f4** ♘**d5 20.**♗**g3** ♗**a6 21.**♕**d2** ♖**c8 22.**♗**a2** ♔**g8 23.**♖**ac1** ♘**f6 24.**♘**c3** ♝**f8.**



25.d5. This pawn breakthrough leads to simplification, after which the worst is over for Black. 25.♗h4!? looks more promising, since Black is practically forced to weaken his kingside: 25...g5 26.♗g3, and now

in the event of 26...♗g7 27.♖cd1 White is still threatening d4-d5. But Black can decide on a pawn sacrifice – 26...g4 27.♘e5 ♕□d4 28♕c2 ♘xe5 (not 28...♕c5? 29.♘e4, or 28...♗g7 29.♘c2! ♗xc2 30.♘xc6) 29.♗xc5 ♕d8 30.♖cd1 ♕e7, intending ♗g7.

25...exd5 26.♖xe8 ♕xe8 27.♘xd5 ♘xd5 28.♗xd5 ♘e7! 29.♗a2 ♖xc1+ 30.♕xc1 ♗b7! 31.♘e5 ♗d5 32.♗b1 ♘c6 33.♕d2 ♕e6 34.♘d3 ♕f5 35.♕d1 ♘d4 36.♘f4 ♗b3! 37.♗xf5 ♗xd1, and on the 70th move the game ended in a draw.

KASPAROV – KARPOV
World Championship Match,
11th Game, Moscow 1985
Nimzo-Indian Defence E21

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.♘f3 0-0 5.♗g5 c5 6.e3 cxd4 7.exd4 h6 8.♗h4 d5 9.♖c1 dxc4 10.♗xc4 ♘c6 11.0-0 ♗e7 12.♖e1 b6.



The white pieces are mobilised for the breakthrough in the centre, but if 13.d5 Black can defuse the situation: 13...♘xd5 14.♗xd5 exd5 15.♕xd5 ♕xd5 16.♘xd5 ♗xh4 17.♘xh4, and here 17...♗b7 is possible, not fearing 18.♖xc6 in view of 18...♖fe8. Therefore Kasparov decided to defer d4-d5 until a more propitious moment.

13.a3 ♗b7 14.♗g3. A noteworthy moment: exchanges usually make it easier to defend against an attack. Therefore White has to reckon with the possible 14...♘h5! with the exchange of the dark-square bishops. But now if 14...♘h5 there follows 15.d5!

14...♖c8 15.♗a2 ♗d6!



16.d5. It is hard to resist the temptation to make this breakthrough. But, as the further development of events shows, here too this move leads to a simplification of the position with possibilities of a defence. As an alternative Kasparov considers

setting up an attack: 16.♗h4!? ♗c7 17.♕d3 ♘h5 18.♗b1 g6 19.♗g3 ♘xg3 20.hxg3 ♕d7, when it is now good to play 21.d5! exd5 22.♘xd5 with a dangerous initiative for White. Therefore more determined defensive measures are demanded of Black, for which Kasparov suggests 16...g5! 17.♗g3 ♗xg3 18.hxg3 with the possible continuation 18...g4 19.♘c5 ♕xd4! 20.♘xf7 ♕xd1 21.♖cxd1 ♚xf7 22.♗xc6+ ♚g6 23.♗xc8 ♗xc8, although here too after 24.♖d6 White retains a serious initiative (24...♘a5 25.♘d5 ♗b7 26.♘f4+ ♔f7 27.♖c1). 16.♗e5!? ♗xe5 17.dxe5 ♘d7 18.♗b1 also comes into consideration, retaining chances of an attack.

16...♘xd5 17.♘xd5 ♗xg3 18.hxg3 cxd5 19.♗xd5 ♕f6 20.♕a4 ♖fd8 21.♖cd1 ♖d7?! As a result of the exchanges, Black has successfully completed his development. Here 21...♖c7! (Kasparov) would have retained equality.

22.♕g4!

22...♖cd8?! An oversight which loses, but it was not easy to find the correct solution. For example, 22...♖c7? was bad because of 23.♖xc7 ♕xc7 24.♗xf7+! ♕xf7 25.♖d7, while if 22...♖dc7 or 22...♖dd8 there follows 23.b4! with pressure. The strongest move was 22...♖d6!, neutralising White's initiative: 23.♖c4 ♖f8! 24.♖f4 ♕d8 25.♕h5 ♘e5! (Kasparov).

23.♕xd7! ♖xd7 24.♖e8+ ♚h7 25.♗e4+. Black resigned.

KASPAROV – ANAND
Wijk aan Zee 1999
Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.♘f3 d5 2.d4 e6 3.c4 dxc4 4.e3 c5 5.♗xc4 a6 6.0-0 ♘f6 7.♗b3 ♘c6 8.♘c3 cxd4 9.exd4 ♗e7 10.♖c1 0-0 (this position can also be reached from the Panov Attack in the Caro-Kann Defence) **11.♗f4 ♘a5** (if 11...b5, then 12.d5! exd5 13.♘xd5 is good).

12.♗c2 b5.





13.d5!? exd5 14.♕d3 ♘c6. This move allows White to make use of tactical motifs to set up the queen + bishop battery on the b1-h7 diagonal. In Illescas – Anand, Leon 1997, Black radically solved this problem with 14...g6 and succeeded in parrying White's attack: 15.♖xe7!? ♕xe7 16.♗g5 ♕d6 17.♕d4 ♘h5 18.♘xd5 ♘c6 19.♕d2 f6 20.♗b3 ♔h8 21.♗e3 ♗g4 22.♘b6?! ♕xd2 23.♘xd2 ♖ad8, with the clearly better endgame. But also in the middlegame after 22.♘d4!? ♘e5 Black's chances are preferable. However, White could have avoided these problems by playing 15.♘d4.

15.♗c7! ♕d7 (not 16...♕xc7? 17.♘xd5!).



16.♘e5! ♘xe5 **17.♗xe5.** If 17.♖xe5, then 17...♗b7! is good, with excellent play after 18.♗b6, for example: 18...♖fe8 19.♗d4 ♘e4!? (19...g6!?) 20.f3 ♖ad8 (weaker is 20...♗f6?! 21.♖xe8+ ♖xe8 22.♗e5, threatening to capture the knight) 21.♖d1 ♘f6, or 18...b4 19.♘e4 ♘xe4 20.♖xe4 f5 21.♖ee1 ♖ac8. But weaker is 18...♗d6 19.♗d4, when Black is forced to weaken his king's position by 19...g6, since after 19...♘e4 White gains an advantage by 20.♖xd5! ♗xd5 21.♘xd5 f5 22.♘b6.

17...g6 18.♗xf6. In Ponomariov – Galkin, Moscow 2005, White played 18.♕f3, which Black parried by 18...♕g4! 19.♘xd5 (19.♕xg4 ♗xg4 20.♗xf6 ♗xf6 21.♘xd5 ♗xb2 leads to a better endgame for Black) 19...♘xd5 20.♕xd5 ♗e6 (if 20...♗f5, then 21.♗□3! with the threat of 22.♕e5 is possible) 21.♕e4 ♕xe4 22.♗xc4 ♖a7 with an equal position.

18...♗xf6 19.♘xd5 ♗g7 20.a4 bxa4 21.♗xa4 ♕d8 22.♗c6. Draw.

Chapter 3

Attack on the queenside

In a certain type of position an isolated d4-pawn may provide the basis for an attack on the queenside. Against modern defensive technique it is not always possible to attack the king, especially if Black succeeds in setting up a blockade on d5. In order not to lose the initiative, the piece activity, which accompanies the isolated pawn, should be used to attack the blockade point, in order to unblock the d4-pawn or stabilise the pawn structure by exchanging on d5. A precondition for such strategy is the presence of pawn weaknesses on Black's queenside.

3.1. Exchange on d5

An effective method in the organisation of an attack on the queenside, if it is inadequately defended, may be an exchanging operation on the d5 blockading square. In this case Black often has to agree to the stabilisation of the pawn structure (a knight on d5 is replaced by a pawn) or to a less effective blockade of the pawn (a knight is replaced by another piece), allowing White to develop his initiative.

The importance of an energetic attack on the blockade point was observed several times by Capablanca. We will examine some examples from his games.

CAPABLANCA – LASKER
World Championship Match,
11th Game, Havana 1921
Queen's Gambit D64

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 e6 3.c4 ♘f6 4.♗g5 ♘bd7 5.e3 ♗e7 6.♘c3 0-0 7.♖c1 ♖e8 8.♕c2 c6 9.♗d3 dxc4 10.♗xc4 ♘d5 11.♗xe7 ♖xe7 12. 0-0 ♘f8 13.♖fd1 ♗d7 14.e4 ♘b6 15.♗f1 ♖c8 16.b4 ♗e8 17.♕b3 ♖ec7 18.a4 ♘g6 19.a5 ♘d7 20.e5 b6 21.♘e4 ♖b8 22.♕c3 ♘f4 23.♘d6 ♘d5 24.♕a3 f6 25.♘xe8 ♕xe8 26.exf6 gxf6 27.b5 ♖bc8 28.bxc6 ♖xc6 29.♖xc6 ♖xc6 30.axb6 axb6 31.♖e1 ♕c8 32.♘d2 ♘f8 33.♘e4 ♕d8 34.h4 ♖c7.



In this position the knight at d5 is the keystone of Black's defence, preventing his pawn weaknesses at b6, e6 and f6 from being approached. From this it follows that the knight has to be exchanged.

35.♕b3! White begins an attack on the d5-knight, exploiting the 'X-ray' of the queen and king on the a2-g8 diagonal.

35...♖g7. Black tries to provoke the move g3, to prevent White from switching his queen to the kingside along the 3rd rank.

36.g3 ♖a7 37.♗c4 ♖a5 38.♘c3! After the exchange of the knight, Black's defences collapse.

38...♘xc3 39.♕xc3 ♔f7 40.♕e3 ♕d6 41.♕e4 ♖a4 42.♕b7+ ♔g6.

(See diagram)

43.♕c8?! As was shown by Kasparov, there was a practically forced win by 43.h5+! ♔h6 44.♕f7 ♕d8 45.♗d3! ♖xd4 46.♖xe6 ♖xd3 47.♖xf6+ ♔g5 48.♕g7+ ♘g6 49.♖xg6+.



43...♕b4? By playing 43... ♖a7! 44.♗xe6 ♘xe6 45.♖xe6 ♕xd4 Black would have gained real saving chances. Indeed, White can win the b6-pawn, by diverting its defenders with an attack on the king: 46.♕g8+! ♖g7 47.♕e8+ ♔h6 48.♕f8 ♔g6 49.♖d6! ♕e5! 50.♖xb6 ♕e1+ 51.♔g2 ♕e4+ 52.♔h2 ♕f3. but with heavy pieces on the board and the pawns on one wing there is no direct win.

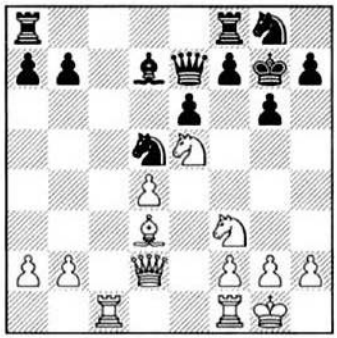
44.♖c1 ♕e7 45.♗d3+ ♔h6 46.♖c7 ♖a1+ 47.♔g2 ♕d6 48.♕xf8+. Black resigned.

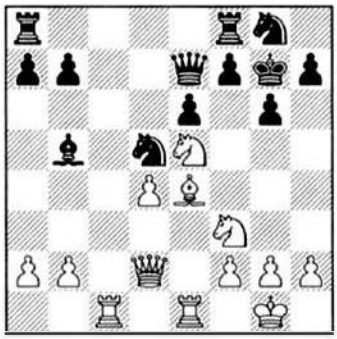
CAPABLANCA – ALEKHINE

St. Petersburg 1913

Queen's Gambit D30

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.e3 ♘f6 4.♘f3 e6 5.♘bd2 ♘bd7 6.♗d3 ♗e7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♕c2 dxc4 9.♘xc4 c5 10.♘ce5 cxd4 11.exd4 ♘b6 12.♘g5 g6 13.♘gf3 ♔g7 14.♗g5 ♘bd5 15.♖ac1 ♗d7 16.♕d2 ♘g8 17.♗xe7 ♕xe7.





18.♗e4! Capablanca: 'This move I've been considering for a very long time. It looks very simple and inoffensive, yet it is the foundation of the whole attack against Black's position. The fact is that the bishop is doing very little, while the black knight at d5 is the key to Black's defence, hence the necessity of exchanging the almost useless bishop for a most valuable knight.'

18...♗b5?! This move leads to a difficult position. Black should have tried to retain piece control of d5, which could have been achieved by 18...♘gf6, and if 19.♗xd5 ♘xd5 20.♘g4, then 20...♖fc8 21.♕h6+ ♔g8, and White has merely a slight advantage.

19.♖fe1.

(See diagram)

19...♕d6. With the appearance of the rook on e1, Black has to reckon with its opposition with the queen, and 19...♘gf6?! 20.♗xd5 ♘xd5 is now inadequate because of 21.♖c5 with the threat of 22.♖xd5! exd5 23.♘g4 ♕d6 24.♕h6+ ♔g8 25.♘g5. Also inadequate is 19...♘df6 20.♗c2 (in the event of 20.♕a5 ♘xc4 21.♖xe4 ♘f6 Black maintains his d5-point: 22.♖c7 b6! 23.♖xe7 bxa5 and 24...♘d5, or 22.♖cc1 ♕c8 23.♖c7 b6 24.♕a3 ♘d5) 20...♘d5 21.♗b3 ♘gf6 22.♖c5.

20.♗xd5! exd5 21.♕a5! Exploiting the fact that the bishop is undefended, White invades the queenside along the c-file and decides the game.

21...a6 22.♕c7 ♕xc7 23.♖xc7 h6 24.♖xb7 ♖ac8 25.b3 ♖c2 26.a4 ♗e2 27.♘h4 h5 28.♘hxg6 ♖e8 29.♖xf7+ ♔h6 30.f4 a5 31.♘h4 ♖xe5 32.fxe5 ♔g5 33.g3 ♔g4 34.♖g7+ ♔h3 35.♘g2. Black resigned.

An exchanging operation on the blockading d5-square may also be effective when Black is behind with his queenside development.

BOTVINNIK – ALEKHINE
AVRO Tournament,
Netherlands 1938
Queen's Gambit D41

1.♘f3 d5 2.d4 ♘f6 3.c4 e6 4.♘c3 c5 5.cxd5 ♘xd5 6.e3 ♘c6 7.♗c4 cxd4 8.exd4 ♗e7 9.0-0 0-0 10.♖e1 b6? The fianchetto of the bishop should have been prepared by exchanging knights first – 10... ♘xc3 11.bxc3 and now 11...b6.



11.♘xd5! With his last move Black weakened the light squares on his queenside, and by exchanging the knight White changes the pawn structure (after which the fianchetto of the bishop loses its point) and attacks the weaknesses on the queenside, by seizing the important c-file.

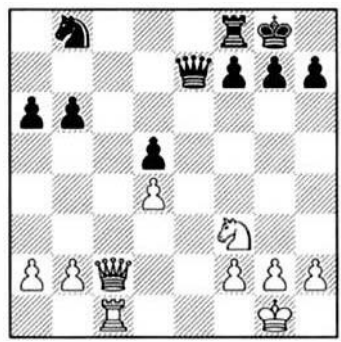
11...exd5 12.♗b5 ♗d7?! This leads to the exchange of the light-square bishops, after which the weakness of the c6-square is aggravated. But also after 12...♗b7 13.♕a4 ♖c8 14.♗f4 a6 15.♗xc6 ♖xc6 16.♘e5 ♖c8 17.♕d7! ♗a8 18.♖ac1, as occurred in Neikirkh – Sliwa, Sofia 1957, Black would have had to concede the c-file.

13.♕a4 ♘b8. After 13...♖c8 14.♗f4 with the threat of 15.♖ac1 White has a big advantage.

14.♗f4 ♗xb5 15.♕xb5 a6 16.♕a4 (with the threat of 17.♗xb8 ♖xb8 18.♕xa6) **16...♗d6** (trying by exchanges to ease his position) **17.♗xd6 ♕xd6 18.♖ac1 ♖a7 19. ♕c2!** The c-file is more important than the e-file, since the c7-square can be defended by the king, whereas the c7-square remains vulnerable (Botvinnik).

19...♖e7. If 19...f6, then 20.♕f5 with the threat of exchanging queens on e6.

20.♖xe7 ♛xe7.



21.♕c7! ♕xc7 22.♖xc7. Control of the c-file and Black's pawn weaknesses guarantee White a big advantage.

22...f6! 23.♔f1 (not 23.♖b7?! ♖c8! 24.♔f1 b5, when Black has

improved his position) **23...♖f7 24.♖c8+ ♖f8 25.♖c3!** Because of the differenee in the placing of the pieces, Black is on the verge of zugzwang (Botvinnik). White won on the 51st move.

RASHKOVSKY – KUPREICHIK
Minsk 1985
Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 e6 3.c4 dxc4 4.e3 ♘f6 5.♗xc4 a6 6.a4 c5 7.0-0 ♘c6 8.♕c2 cxd4 9.♖d1 ♗e7 10.exd4 0-0 11.♘c3 ♘b4 12.♘e5 ♘fd5 13.♕e4 b6.



In contrast to the Petrosian – Spassky game, Moscow 1971, which was examined in Chapter 2, with his last move Black has left his rook at a8 unprotected, which allows White to make a favourable change to the pawn structure.

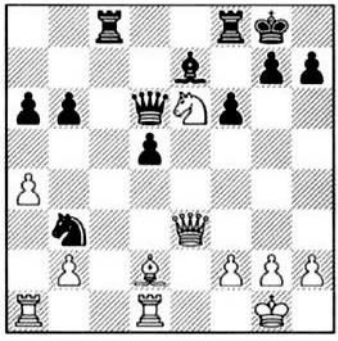
14.♘xd5! By changing the pawn structure in the centre, White hopes to exploit the weakness of the d5-pawn, which will need defending, as well as the weakening of Black's queenside, where the a6- and b6-pawns are potential targets.

14...exd5 (14...♘xd5? 15.♘c6) **15.♕f3 ♗e6 16.♗b3 ♖c8 17.♗d2 f6.** Black does not want to give up the c-file – 17...♘c6 18.♘xc6 ♖xc6 19.♖c1 – and he goes in for a weakening of the e6-square.

18.♘d3 (18.♘g4!? with the idea of ♘e3 also came into consideration) **18...♘c6?!** 18...♘xd3 19.♕xd3 a5 20.♖e1 ♗f7 was stronger, but by playing 21.♕b5! White switches to an attack on the queenside.

19.♘f4. Also good is 19.♗c3 ♕d6 20.♘f4 ♖fd8 21.♘xe6 ♕xe6, and here there is a choice between 22.♖e1 and 22.♗c2.

19...♘xd4 20.♕e3 ♘xb3 21.♘xe6 ♕d6.



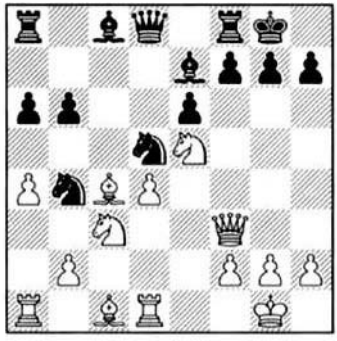
22.♘xg7! This is stronger than 22.♘xf8?! ♘xa1 23.♗b4! ♘c2! 24.♕xe7 ♕xe7 25.♗xe7 d4! But now, since 22...♘xa1? 23.♘f5 can-

not satisfy Black, he is forced to accept the break-up of his pawns.

22...♔xg7 23.♕xb3 ♖c4 24.♗e3 ♕b4 25.♕d3 d4? 26.♗d2 ♕c5 27.b3 ♖c3 28.♗xc3 dxc3 29.♖ac1 ♖c8 30.♕xa6 ♖c7 31.♕d3 f5 32.b4 ♕c4 33.♕xf5 ♕xb4 34.♕e5+ ♔g8 35.♖d4 ♕c5 36.♖g4+. Black resigned.

PINTER – KORCHNOI
Beer Sheva 1988
Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 ♘f6 3.c4 dxc4 4.e3 e6 5.♗xc4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.a4 cxd4 8.exd4 ♗e7 9.♘c3 0-0 10.♕e2 ♘c6 11.♖d1 ♘b4 12.♘e5 b6 13.♕f3 ♘fd5.



14.♘xd5! Compared with the previous game White has developed his queen at f3, and after the exchange on d5 he effectively has an extra tempo.

14...exd5 15.♗b3. The weakness of the d5-pawn and the vulnerability of the a6- and b6-pawns give White a stable advantage.

15...♗e6 16.♗d2 f6 17.♘g4. White transfers his knight to c3. The alternative was 17.♘d3.

17...♘c6 18.♗c3 ♕d7 19.h3 ♖ad8 20.♕e2 a5 21.♖e1 ♗f7 22.♕f3 ♔h8 23.♘e3 ♖fe8 24.♗c2 (switching the bishop to a more active position) **24...♗f8 25.♗d3 ♕d6.**



26.h4! A typical way of increasing the advantage: White seizes space on the kingside.

26...♘b4 27.♘f5 ♕c7 28.♗b5 ♘c6 29.♖xe8 ♗xe8 30.♖c1 ♘b4 31.♗d2 ♕f7. In the event of 31...♕b7? 32.♕g3! White breaks through on the e-file: 32...♗xb5 33.♖c7 ♕b8 34.axb5 ♖c8 35.♖xg7! ♕xg3 36.♖xg3 ♖c2 37.♗h6!, winning.

32.♗xb4 axb4 33.♘e3 ♔g8 34.b3 ♗xb5 35.axb5 ♕e6 36.♖c6 ♕e4 37.♕xe4 dxe4 38.♖xb6 (the passed b-pawn decides the outcome) **38...♖xd4 39.♖b8 ♔f7 40.b6 ♖d7 41.♖c8 ♗d6 42.♘c4 ♔e6 43.♔f1**

♗e5 44.♔c2 ♗d4 45.♖b8 ♔f5 46.b7. Black resigned.

ROZENTALIS–MIKHALCHISHIN
Trnava 1988
Sicilian Defence B22

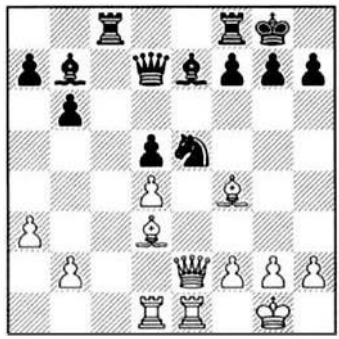
1.e4 c5 2.c3 d5 3.exd5 ♕xd5 4.d4 ♘f6 5.♘f3 ♘c6 6.♗e3 cxd4 7.cxd4 e6 8.♘c3 ♕d6 9.a3! ♗e7 10.♗d3 b6 11.0-0 ♗b7 12.♕e2 0-0 13.♖ad1 ♖ac8 14.♖fe1.



15...♘d5? A premature attempt to set up a blockade. Black should have played 15...♖fd8, increasing his control of the centre.

15.♘xd5! exd5. In the event of 15...♕xd5 White drives away the queen and carries out a breakthrough in the centre: 16.♗c4 ♕h5 17.d5! ♘a5 18.♗a2 ♗xd5 19.♗xd5 cxd5 20.♗xb6 axb6 21.♕xe7, winning a pawn. But now the bishop on b7 is running up against the d5-pawn, whereas White's pieces are excellently mobilised, which gives him the advantage.

16.♘e5! ♘xe5 17.♗f4 ♕d7.



18.dxe5! White transforms the position and sets his sights on the kingside; the f-pawn may be included in the attack.

18...♕e6 19.♕f3 ♖fe8 20.♕g3 d4 21.h4! h5 22.♗g5 ♗xg5. If 22...♖c5 there follows 23.f4!

23.♕xg5 ♕g4. Weakening the position by 23...g6 would be suicidal. But after the exchange of queens White wins a pawn, retaining an excellent position.

24.♕xg4 hxg4 25.♗f5! ♖c5 26.♖xd4 g6 27.♗xg4 ♖exe5 28.♖xe5 ♖xe5 29.♖d7 ♗d5 30.f4! Black resigned.

IVANCHUK – KARPOV
Linares 1991
Nimzo-Indian Defence E54

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 0-0 5.♗d3 d5 6.♘f3 c5 7. 0-0 cxd4 8.exd4 dxc4 9.♗xc4 b6 10.♗g5 ♗b7 11.♖c1 ♘c6 12.a3 ♗e7 13.♕d3 ♘d5.



14.♗xd5! exd5?! This restricts the light-square bishop. Better was 14...♗xg5 15.♘xg5 ♕xg5 16.♗f3 ♖fd8 17.♕e3! ♕xe3 18.fxe3 with a slight advantage for White (Ivanchuk). Here 16.f4 ♕g6 17.♗e4 f5 18.♗f3 ♖ad8 19.♘b5 also comes into consideration.

15.♗xe7 ♘xe7 16.♖fe1. As a result of the exchanging operation White has gained a small but enduring advantage, based on the defects of the d5-pawn, which is restricting Black's minor pieces.

16...♖c8.



17.h4! White seizes space on the kingside.

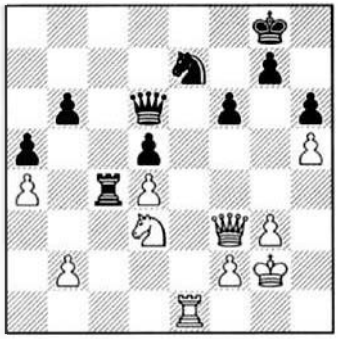
17...h6 (preventing 18.♘g5) **18.h5 ♖c7 19.♘b5.** It would have been useful to first include 19.♖c3 ♕c8 20.♖ee1 ♕f5, and here 21.♘b5!? is good.

19...♖xc1 20.♖xc1 ♗a6. Although the black bishop is inactive, it is fulfilling an important defensive function. 20...♘c6, preventing ♘e5, was better.

21.a4 ♗xb5? After the exchange of this bishop Black has problems defending the light squares on the queenside. Stronger was 21...♕b8! 22.♘c5 ♖c8 23.♖e1 ♗xb5 24.axb5 ♕d6 25.♕f3 ♕f6! 26.♕xf6 gxf6 27.♘g4 ♘f5 28.♘xf6+ ♔g7 29.♘xd5 ♘xd4, obtaining an equal endgame (Ivanchuk). Instead of 27.♘g4, also possible is 27.♘d7 ♘f5 28.♖a1!, retaining the better chances.

22.♕xb5 ♘f5 23.g3 ♘e7 24.♘e5 ♕d6 25.♕a6. 25.♔g2! was stronger, not allowing the counterplay which was now possible with 25...♕b4!? 26.♕d3! ♖c8 27.♖xc8+ ♘xc8 28.♕f3 ♕e1+ 29.♔g2 ♕e4, exchanging queens, although in the knight endgame after 30.♕xe4 dxe4 31.g4 Black still has problems.

25...♘f5 26.♕d3 ♘e7 27.♕f3 a5 28.♔g2 (28.b3! Anand) **28...f6 29.♘d3 ♖c8 30.♖e1 ♖c4.**



In this position White could have exploited his pressure on the e-file by 31.♕c3! ♔f7 32.b3 ♖c7 33.♘f4, increasing his advantage. The game went **31.♘f4? ♖xd4,** which led to equal chances.

SMYSLOV – RIBLI
Candidates Match, 7th Game,
London 1983
Queen's Gambit D42

1.d4 ♘f6 2.♘f3 e6 3.c4 d5 4.♘c3 c5 5.cxd5 ♘xd5 6.c3 ♘c6 7.♗d3 ♗e7 8.0-00-0 9.a3 cxd4 10.exd4 ♗f6 11.♗e4 ♘ce7 12.♘e5 g6 13.♗h6 ♗g7 14.♗xg7 ♔xg7 15.♖c1 b6.

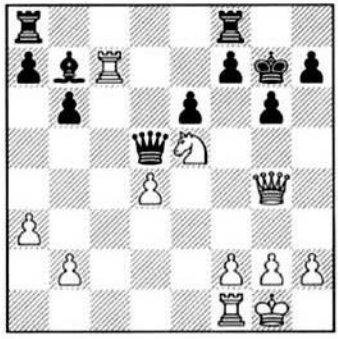


White is better developed, since Black has delayed the development of his bishop.

16.♘xd5! The aim of the exchanging operation on d5 is to make a favourable change to the pawn structure in order to exploit the c-file.

16...♘xd5 17.♗xd5! ♕xd5. After the pawn capture 17...exd5 Black's position becomes passive and the move 15...b6 loses its point. However, the price of retaining piece control over d5 is to allow the dangerous invasion of the rook.

18.♖c7! ♗b7 19.♕g4!



19...♖ad8. The white pieces coordinate excellently in the attack on the king, whereas Black's ♗b7 + ♕d5 battery is merely decorative. The attempt to evict the rook by 19...♖ac8 leads to the loss of a pawn: 20.♖d7 ♕e4 21.♕xe4 ♗xe4 22.f3 ♗d5 23.♖xa7 ♖c2 24.b4.

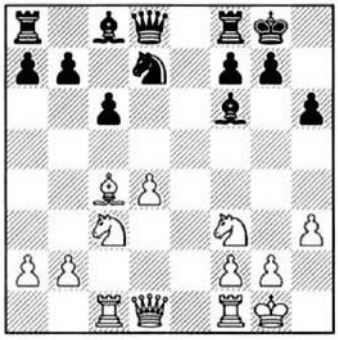
20.♖d1 a5 21.h4! ♖c8 (21...h5? 22.♕xg6+) **22.♖d7 ♕e4 23.♕g5**

♗c6 24.f3! ♕f5. In the event of 24...♕e2 25.♘g4! the weakness of the dark squares proves decisive: 25...♕xd1+ 26.♔h2 ♚g8 27.♕h6 followed by ♘f6+.

25.♖a7 ♗a4 26.♖e1 ♖c2 27.b4 ♗b3 28.bxa5 bxa5 29.♖e4 h6 30.♕e3 ♖b2 31.♖g4!, and in view of the threatened capture on g6 Black loses material. White won on the 43rd move.

KASPAROV – KARPOV
World Championship Match,
23rd Game, Moscow 1985
Queen's Gambit D55

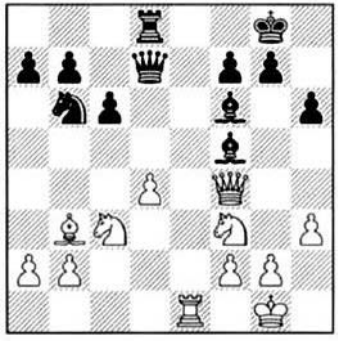
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗e7 4.♘f3 ♘f6 5.♗g5 h6 6.♗xf6 ♗xf6 7.e3 0-0 8.♖c1 c6 9.♗d3 ♘d7 10.0-0 dxc4 11.♗xc4 e5 12.h3 exd4 13.exd4.



This position with an isolated d4-pawn was the result of home preparation. In his choice of opening variation Kasparov was hoping to gain a slight advantage and to retain the initiative, thus retaining possibilities of playing for a win. If successful, such strategy could have decided the match ahead of schedule.

13...♘b6. A logical reply – Black takes control of the d5-point. If 13...♖e8, then 14.♕b3 is unpleasant.

14.♗b3 ♖e8 15.♖e1 ♗f5 16.♖xe8+ ♕xe8 17.♕d2 ♕d7 18.♖e1 ♖d8 19.♕f4.



19...♘d5. White has achieved his aim: he firmly holds the initiative, and this is essentially admitted by Karpov, an expert on this type of position, by allowing the consequences of the exchange on d5.

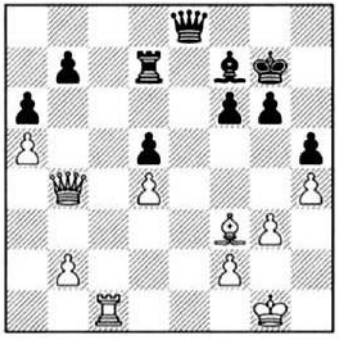
20.♘xd5! cxd5 21.♘e5 ♗xe5. A forced exchange: 21...♕c8 22.♖c1 or 21...♕e6 22.♘d3 favours White.

22.♖xe5 ♗e6. As a result of the exchanging operation White has a stable advantage thanks to his better bishop.

23.♕e3 ♔f8 24.♕d3 f6?! After this weakening move White's advantage increases. 24...♕c7 was sounder, intending 25.♖c1 ♕f4.

25.♖e1 ♗f7 26.♕c3 ♕d6 27.♖c1 ♗e8 28.♗d1 a6 29.♝f3 g6 30.h4 h5 31.g3. Kasparov comments that 31.♕c7 ♕xc7 32.♖xc7 ♗c6 33.♗e2 a5 34.♗d3 was also not bad, with the better endgame, but he prefers to complete his pawn squeeze on the queenside.

31...♗f7 32.a4 ♖d7 33.a5 ♔g7 34.♕b3 ♕e6 35.♕b4 ♕e8. Parrying the threat of 36.♖c8, since the exchange of queens after 35...♕e7 favours White.



In his commentary on this position, Kasparov writes: 'Here I decided on a plan with ♖c1-c5, ♕b4-c3, ♖c5-c8 and ♕c3-c5, forcing a transition into a won ending. However, unfortunately, I stopped keeping a careful watch on Black's actions'.

36.♔g2?! (36.♝g2 was more logical) **36...♕d8 37.♖c5 ♕e7 38.♕c3?!** White should have played 38.♕d2, and after 38...g5 39.♔g1 gxh4 40.gxh4 the opening of the game is in his favour.

38...g5! 39.♕e3 g4 40.♗d1 ♕e4+ 41.♔g1. Draw.

3.2. Attack on queenside weaknesses

Queenside weaknesses are usually characterised by the weakening of the dark squares after a7-a6, or the light squares after b7-b6, which may provide the motif for a piece attack.

KARPOV – GELLER
Moscow 1981
Queen's Gambit D58

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♝e7 4.♘f3 ♘f6 5.♗g5 h6 6.♗h4 0-0 7.e3 b6 8.♖c1 ♗b7 9.♗d3 ♘bd7 10.0-0 c5 11.♕e2 ♖c8 12.♗g3 cxd4 13.exd4 dxc4 14.♗xc4 ♝xf3 15.gxf3 ♘h5.



A serious defect of Black's position is the weakening of his queenside, which is aggravated by the absence of his light-square bishop.

16.♗a6! White immediately exploits the weakness of the light squares. To avoid losing the exchange, Black is forced to exchange the bishop on g3, repairing White's kingside pawn structure.

16...♘xg3 17.hxg3 ♖c7. If 17...♖a8 18.♖fd1 ♘f6, then 19.d5! ♘xd5 20.♘xd5 exd5 21.♗b7 is strong.

18.♖fd1! There was no point in playing 18.♘b5?! ♖xc1 19.♖xc1 ♘b8! 20.♘xa7 ♕xd4 with an equal game.

18...♘f6. If 18...♘b8 there follows 19.♗c4 with the unpleasant threat of d4-d5.

19.♘b5! ♖xc1 20.♖xc1 ♘d5. After 20...♕d5 21.a3 Black is condemned to passive defence.



21.♘xa7! Although the white pieces are stuck for time on the queenside, Black is unable to exploit this factor.

21...♘b4 22.a3! ♕a8 (22...♘xa6 23.♕xa6 ♕xd4 24.♘c6 was bad for Black) **23.♖c7! ♘d5 24.♖b7 ♗f6 25.♘c6 ♖c8 26.♘e5! ♗xe5 27.dxe5 ♖c1+ 28.♔g2 ♕d8 29.♗d3 ♖a1 30.♕e4 g6 31.♖xf7! ♔xf7 32.♕xg6+ ♔f8 33.♕xh6+.** Black resigned.

An attack on the queenside, based on an isolated pawn, may be carried out by obtaining a spatial advantage. Usually this is combined with threats to the king.

KORCHNOI – LJUBOJEVIC
Tilburg 1987
Nimzo-Indian Defence E56

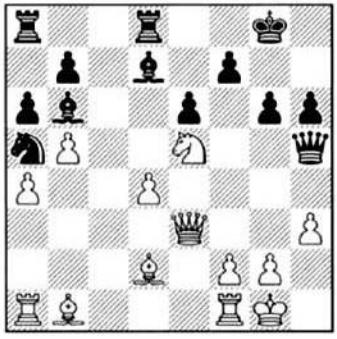
1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 0-0 5.♗d3 d5 6.♘f3 c5 7.0-0 ♘c6 8.a3 ♗a5 9.h3!? dxc4 10.♗xc4 ♗d7 11.♗d3 ♕e7 12.♘e4 ♘xe4 13.♗xe4 cxd4 14.exd4 h6.



15.b4! Exploiting the poor position of the bishop at a5, White seizes space on the queenside and drives back the black pieces to passive positions.

15...♗b6 16.b5 ♘a5 17.a4 ♖fd8 18.♗a3 ♕f6 19.♗b4 (threatening the b7-pawn) **19...♕f4.** The alternative was 19...♖ab8 20.♖e1 ♗e8 21.d5! exd5 22.♝c2 ♖dc8 23.♖a2 ♕f4! (weaker is 23...d4?! 24.♕d2 ♘c4 25.♕d3 g6 26.a5 ♗c7 27.♖xc8+ ♖xc8 28.♕xc4, obtaining two minor pieces for rook and pawn) 24.♗e7 with the better chances for White. But he can also simply strengthen his position – 20.♕d3 ♕f4 21.g3 ♕f6 22.♖ac1.

20.♗b1 a6 (in order to safeguard the knight at a5) **21.♕d3 g6 22.♗d2 ♕f5 23.♕e3! ♕h5 24.♘e5!** Threatening 25.♗xg6 fxg6 26.♘xd7 ♖xd7 27.♕xc6+ ♖f7 28.♕xb6.



24...axb5. 24...♗e8!? is also insufficient: 25.♘g4 ♗xd4 (the prophylactic move 25...♔h8!? does not help because of 26.♕a3!) 26.♗xa5! Possibly the best was 25...♔g7 26.♕xh6+ ♕xh6 27.♗xh6+ ♔h7 28.♗g5 with the initiative for White in the endgame.

25.♝xa5! ♗**xa5** (25...♖xa5 26.♗xg6!) **26.♕f4 ♗e8 27.♘g4 ♔f8.** 27...♔g7 does not bring any relief – 28.♕f6+ ♔h7 29.axb5 ♕g5 30.♗xg6+ ♕xg6 (30...fxg6 31.♕f8) 31.♖xa5!

28.♘f6 g5 29.♕e5 ♕h4 30.♘g4 ♗b6 31.♕h8+ ♔e7 32.♕f6+ ♔f8 33.♖d1 ♗c7 34.♖a3 (bringing up the last reserves into the attack) **34...h5 35.g3 ♕xh3 36.♘h6 h4 37.♗f5 ♝e5 38.♕xe5 exf5 39.♖e3.** Black resigned.

SASIKIRAN – MALAKHOV
Moscow 2006
Slav Defence D15

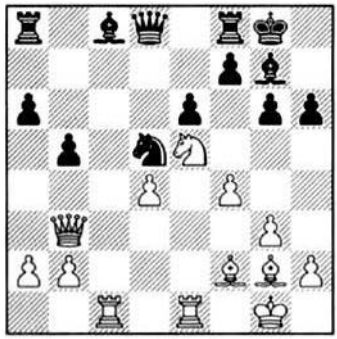
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 a6 5.g3 g6 6.♗g2 ♗g7 7.0-0 0-0 8.cxd5 cxd5 9.♘e5 e6 10.♗g5 h6 11.♗e3 ♘fd7 12.f4 ♘c6 13.♗f2 ♘e7 14.♖c1 ♘f5 15.e4 dxe4 16.♗xe4 ♘f6 17.♗g2 ♘e7 18.♕b3 ♘ed5.



White's control of the c-file gives him the advantage. He exploits it by combining threats against the seemingly securely defended kingside.

19.♖fe1! b5?! This creates combinative motifs in view of the rook at a8 being undefended. 19...♖c8!? 20.a4 ♖e7 was more circumspect, defending the f7- and e6-pawns.

20.♘xd5! ♘xd5.



21.♖c5. White prefers the domination of his pieces to the forced win of a pawn: 21.♘c6 ♕d6 22.♗xd5 exd5 23.♘e7+ ♔h7 24.♖c6!? (after the direct 24.♕xd5 ♕xd5 25.♘xd5 ♗b7 Black has compensation in the form of his active light-square bishop) 24...♕d8 25.♕xd5 ♗b7 (or 25...♕xd5 26.♘xd5 ♖d8 27.♘b6 ♖b8 28.d5 ♗b7 29.♖c7 ♗xd5 30.♘xd5 ♖xd5 31.♖xf7 ♔g8 32.♖a7 ♗xb2 33.♖xa6 ♔f7 34.♖a7+) 26.♕xd8 ♖axd8 27.♖c7 ♗f3 28.f5! ♖fe8 29.fxg6+ fxg6 30.d5 with the threat of 31.♘c6.

21...♕d6? After 21...♗b7?! Black suffers a catastrophe on the a2-g8 diagonal: 22.♘xg6! fxg6 23.♖xe6 ♖f5 24.♖e5! ♗xe5 25.♗xd5+ ♔g7 26.dxe5 with an obvious advantage to White. The only way of breaking White's attack was by exchanging his knight – 21...♗xe5 22.dxe5, but even here after22...♗b7 23.a4 b4 24.♖ecl a5 25.♕dl ♖c8 26.♕f1 White invades the weakened queenside.

22.♘xg6. 22.♘xl7! ♖xl7 23.♖xd5 cxd5 24.♗xd5 ♔h7 25.♗xf7 was even stronger (Sasikiran). Then 25...♗xd4? is not possible because of 26.♗xg6+! ♔xg6 27.♕g8+ ♗g7 28.♕e8+ ♔h7 29.♕c4+.

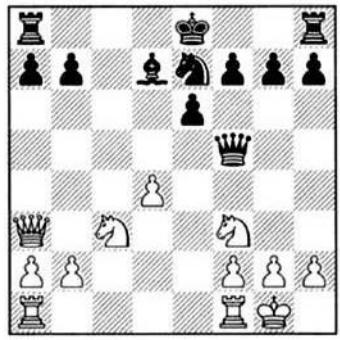
22...fxg6 23.♖xd5 cxd5 24.♕xd5+ ♕xd5 25.♗xd5+, and White gained a decisive material advantage.

Delay in castling may also provide the motif for a piece attack on the queenside. Usually such possibilities are the result of the opening.

PONOMARIOV – VAN WELY
World Cup, Khanty-Mansiysk 2005
Sicilian Defence B40

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 e6 3.c3 ♘f6 4.e5 ♘d5 5.♗c4 ♘b6 6.♗b3 d6 7.exd6 ♗xd6 8.0-0 ♘c6 9.d4 cxd4 10.cxd4 ♘d5 (10...♘e7!? is more flexible).





11.♗g5!? Black has blockaded the d4-pawn, but his delay in castling provides the motif for White to gain positional pluses by exchanges in the centre. 11.♘c3 looks more natural.

11...♗e7. The alternative was 11...f6 12.♗xd5 (12.♗d2 ♘cc7 13.♘c3 0-0) 12...fxg5 13.♗xc6+ (13.♗b3 g4) 13...bxc6 14.♘bd2 0-0 15.♘c4, where White's knights attack the numerous pawn weaknesses.

12.♗xd5 ♕xd5? Now Black is unable to castle. Correct was 12...♗xg5!? 13.♗xc6+ (13.♗e4 ♗f6 leads to the loss of the d4-pawn) 13...bxc6 14.♕a4 0-0 15.♘xg5 (after 15.♕xc6 ♖b8 Black has good counterplay) 15...♕xg5 16.♘c3 ♖b8 17.b3 a5 with counterplay, as the weakness of the c6- and d4-pawns balances out.

13.♘c3 ♕f5. With the king needing to be defended, 13...♕d8 looks more circumspect.

14.♗xe7 ♘xe7 15.♕a4+ ♗d7 16.♕a3.

16...♘d5. Black has been prevented from castling and it is already hard to offer him any good advice. If 16...♗c6 there also follows 17.♘e5, building up the pressure, for example: 17...♕f6 (17...♕f4 18.♖ad1) 18.♘xc6 bxc6 19.♘e4!? ♕xd4 20.♘d6+ ♔f8 21.♖fd1. In the event of 16...♘g6 17.♖fe1 ♗c6 there is the strong reply 18.d5! ♗xd5 19.♘b5.

17.♘e5 ♘xc3 18.bxc3 ♕g5 19.♖ab1 ♗c8 (19...♗c6 20.♘xc6 bxc6 21.♖b7 was also bad) **20.♖fe1 ♕e7 21.♕a4+ ♔f8 22.d5 h5 23.♖bd1.** The immediate 23.d6 was also possible: 23...♕d8 (23...♕xd6? 24.♕f4! with the threats of 25.♕f7# and 25.♘g6+) 24.d7.

23...exd5 (23...♖h6 24.d6) **24.♘g6+ fxg6 25.♖xe7 ♔xe7 26.♕d4 ♔f7 27.♕xd5+ ♔f6 28.♕d4+ ♔f7 29.♕c4+ ♗e6 30.♖d7+.** Black resigned.

AKOPIAN – KARJAKIN
Olympiad, Turin 2006
Sicilian Defence B50

1.e4 c5 2.♘f3 d6 3.c3 ♘f6 4.♗e2 ♗g4 5.0-0 e6 6.♖e1 ♗e7 7.d4 cxd4 8.cxd4 d5 9.exd5 ♘xd5.



Black has blockaded the d4-pawn, but his king has not yet castled and the b7-pawn is undefended, which allows White to develop an unpleasant initiative on the queenside.

10.♕b3! ♕b6. The pawn sacrifice 10...♘c6 11.♕xb7 ♘db4 looks dubious in view of 12.♗f4 a6 13.♗c7, when Black is forced to exchange queens.

11.♗b5+ ♘c6 12.♘e5 ♗f5. The knight retreat 12...♘f6!? leads after 13.♘c3 0-0 (13...♗f5 14.d5 exd5 15.♗e3 ♕c7 16.♗f4 also favours White) 14.♗xc6 bxc6 15.♕xb6 axb6 16.♗g5 ♗f5 17.♘xc6 to the loss of a pawn, in a worse version than the game.

13.♘c3 ♖d8. 13...♘c7 was weaker: 14.♗xc6+ (Black also has to reckon with 14.♘c4 ♕xd4 15.♗e3 ♕d8 16.♖ad1) 14...bxc6 15.♕xb6 axb6 16.♘xc6.

14.♗xc6+ bxc6 15.♕xb6 axb6 16.♘xc6 ♖d6 17.♘xe7 ♔xe7 18.♗d2.



The game has gone into an endgame with an extra pawn for White. However, as the course of the game shows, it is extremely difficult to convert this advantage, but an analysis of this endgame does not come within our objective. What is important is the method of converting the opening advantage.

18...♔d7 19.a4 ♖a8 20.♖ec1 ♘xc3! (with the exchange of knights, the role of the opposite-colour bishops increases) **21.♗xc3** (if 21.bxc3, then 21...♖d5! with the threat of ♖da5 is good) **21...♗e4 22.b4 ♖c6 23.a5 ♖ac8 24.♗d2 ♖xc1+ 25.♗xc1 b5.** 25...♖c4 26.♗d2 ♖c2 (26...♖xd4 is also

possible) 27...♗f4 ♖c4 also came into consideration.

26.f3 ♗d5 27.♗f4. 27.a6 would have set more problems to Black, but after 27...♗a8!? with the idea of ♖c8-c4 no clear plan for converting the extra pawn is apparent. It should be mentioned that 27...♚c6 is weaker: 28.♗f4 f6 29.a7 ♔b7 30.♗d6 ♚a8 31.♝c5.

27...♖c4 28.♖c1 ♖xc1+ 29.♗xc1 f6, and Black held the ending with opposite-colour bishops, gaining a draw.

Chapter 4

Defence based on the blockade at d5

'The main weakness created by an isolated pawn is not the pawn itself, but the square in front of it', wrote Richard Reti. Indeed, an isolated d4-pawn may be blockaded on d5 by a piece, the activity of which extends to the neighbouring squares. From our study of the attacking potential of an isolated pawn in the previous chapters it can be concluded that White's initiative was greatly aided by insufficiently effective use by Black of the blockading d5-square. The importance of exchanging pieces was also underestimated, although it is obvious that the static weakness of the isolated pawn increases as the material is reduced. At the same time, a study of positions from the standpoint of opposing the dynamics of the isolated pawn is important, since it aids the development of the positional skills, needed by every strong player.

This chapter examines plans for implementing the most expedient arrangement of the forces and specific positional methods of weakening White's attack. These, in particular, are control of the blockading d5-square, the knight manoeuvres ♘f6-d5 and ♘f6-h5 to exchange the dark-square bishops, the bishop manoeuvres ♗e7-g5 and ♗d6-f4 (with the white bishop on the c1-h6 diagonal) with the same aim, and also the knight exchange ♘d5xc3 to create an isolated pawn pair. As for the exchange of the light-square bishops, if the blockade of the isolated d4-pawn is maintained this is advantageous to Black, since it weakens White's control of the neighbouring e4- and c4-squares.

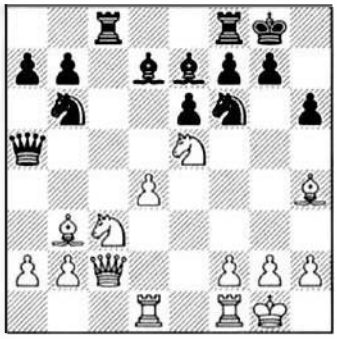
4.1. Reducing attacking potential by exchanging pieces

This important defensive method against the isolated d4-pawn was employed in the first famous game on this theme, Zukertort – Steinitz, with which we began our monograph. At the basis of Steinitz's defensive plan there was the leitmotif

of reducing the attacking material. It was echoed by Capablanca.

LASKER – CAPABLANCA
World Championship Match,
10th Game, Havana 1921
Queen's Gambit D61

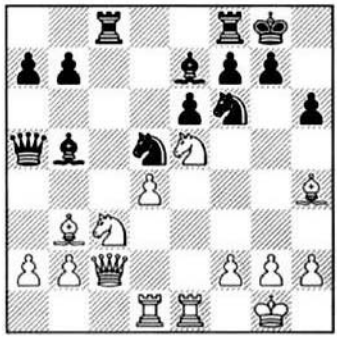
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♗g5 ♗e7 5.e3 0-0 6.♘f3 ♘bd7 7.♕c2 c5 8.♖d1 ♕a5 9.♗d3 h6 10.♗h4 cxd4 11.cxd4 dxc4 12.♗xc4 ♘b6 13.♗b3 ♝d7 14.0-0 ♖ac8 15.♘e5.



This was Capablanca's comment on the position: 'Black has obtained an excellent development. He must now find the way either to exchange the white bishop at h4 for his bishop at e7, or to post a piece at d5 so as to bring about some exchanges that will simplify the position to some extent. All this must be done while keeping immobile the white pawn at d4.'

15...♗b5?! 15...♗c6 was in the spirit of the position.

16.♖fe1 ♘bd5.



17.♝xd5? Lasker repeats Zukertort's mistake. In those times the magic of the blockading knight was so great, that even the strongest players in the world were prepared to give up for it their light-square bishop – one of the key pieces of White's attack. Such an exchange indicates a lack of experience in playing positions with an isolated pawn. Anyone who has studied White's potential in the preceding chapters would have no difficulty in finding the exchanging operation **17.♝xf6** ♗xf6 (not 17...♘xf6? on account of 18.♘g6! fxg6 19.♖xe6, regaining the piece with interest) 18.♗xd5 cxd5 19.♕f3, and Black's position is not easy to defend.

17...♘xd5 18.♝xe7 ♘xe7 19.♕b3 ♗c6 20.♘xc6 bxc6! With the exchange of three pairs of minor pieces, the weakness of the d4-pawn has become perceptible, and this gives Black the advantage. As for

Black's weak c6-pawn, it cannot be attacked.

21.♖e5 ♕b6 22.♕c2 ♖fd8 23.♘e2. Stronger was 23.♘a4!? ♕b8 24.♖c5, when after 24...♘f5 25.♖xc6 ♖xc6 26.♕xc6 ♘xd4 the ill-starred pawn is exchanged, although Black's position still remains preferable.

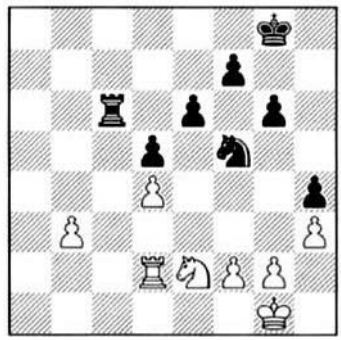
23...♖d5! By exchanging rooks, Black transforms one form of advantage into another. By agreeing to the elimination of the isolated pawn, Black gains control of the open c-file while retaining pressure on the d4-pawn.



24.♖xd5. It is risky to sit back behind the d4-pawn: 24.♖c3 c5!? (24...♘f5 25.♖b3 ♕d8 26.♖b4 ♕d7 is also possible) 25.♖c3 (25.dxc5 ♕xb2!) 25...♖cd8 26.♖b3 ♕c6 27.♖c1 ♕d6, and Black wins a pawn.

24...cxd5 25.♕d2 ♘f5 26.b3 h5 27.h3? This move allows Black to paralyse the kingside pawns. It was essential to exchange knights – 27.♘g3 ♘xg3 28.hxg3, although even here after 28...♕c7, by combining the threat of an invasion on the c-file with an attack on the queenside pawns, Black would have retained real winning chances.

27...h4! 28.♕d3 ♖c6 29.♔f1 g6 30.♕b1 ♕b4 31.♔g1 a5 32.♕b2 a4 33.♕d2 ♕xd2 34.♖xd2 axb3 35.axb3.



35...♖b6! 36.♖d3 (if 36.♖b2, then 36...♖b4, winning a pawn) **36...♖a6! 37.g4** (37.♘□3? ♖a1+) **37...hxg3 38.fxg3 ♖a2 39.♘c3 ♖c2 40.♘d1 ♘e7 41.♘c3 ♖c1+ 42.♔f2 ♘c6 43.♘d1 ♖b1! 44.♔e2.** The pawn is also not saved by 44.♔c1 ♘a5 45.♔d2 ♖xb3 46.♖xb3 ♘xb3+, although the chances of a draw in the knight endgame are somewhat better.

44...♖xb3! 45.♔e3 ♖b4!, and Black won on the 68th move.

In our time one of the great experts in the fight against an isolated

pawn has been Anatoly Karpov. The following example on the theme of exchanging operations is one of his masterpieces.

KORCHNOI – KARPOV
World Championship Match,
9th Game, Merano 1981
Queen's Gambit D53

1.c4 c6 2.♘c3 d5 3.d4 ♗c7 4.♘f3 ♘f6 5.♗g5 h6 6.♗h4 0-0 7.♖c1 dxc4 8.e3 c5 9.♗xe4 exd4 10.cxd4 ♘c6 11.0-0.



11...♘h5!? A standard idea, forcing the exchange of the dark-square bishops, which significantly reduces White's attacking potential. At the same time Black does not forget about his main objective – to retain control of the d5-square.

12.♗xe7 ♘xe7 13.♗b3?! White has not extracted anything from the opening, and it would have been better to get rid of the isolated pawn: 13.d5 exd5 14.♘xd5 ♘xd5 15.♗xd5 ♘f4 16.♗e4 ♕xd1 17.♖exd1 ♗e6 with a probable draw.

13...♘f6 14.♘e5 ♗d7 15.♕c2 ♖e8 16.♘c4. The exchange of minor pieces is advantageous to Black. 16.♖fe1 was more logical, preventing 16...♗c6? because of 17.♘xf7. Therefore Black should play 16...♖c7.

16...♘xc4 17.♕xe4.



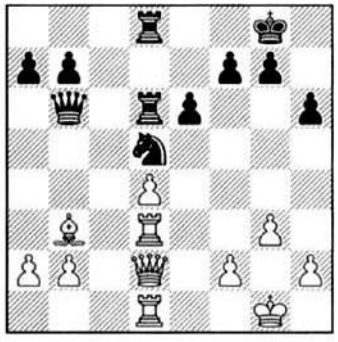
17...♗c6! An important subtlety. Black is not afraid that after a double exchange on c6 he will also have an isolated pawn. In this case his knight is capable both of securely defending his pawn, and attacking the enemy d4-pawn, whereas the functions of the white bishop are restricted (Karpov).

18.♘xc6 ♖xc6! 19.♖c3. Regarding White's avoidance of the exchange 19.♖xc6 bxc6, it can be remarked that the modern classics have learned the lessons from the games of their predecessors.

19...♕d6 20.g3. White shouldn't have been in a hurry to make this move. He could have used the g3-square for the participation of his heavy pieces in an attack on the black king, and therefore 20.h4 came into consideration.

20...♖d8 21.♖d1 ♖b6! (preparing 22...♕d7) **22.♕e1 ♕d7** (22...♖b4 23.♖c4) **23.♖cd3.** 23.♖c5 did not work: 23...♖d6 24.♖dc1 ♘c6 25.♗a4 ♘xd4! 26.♗xd7 ♘f3+ 27.♔f1 ♘xe1 with an extra pawn for Black.

23...♖d6 24.♕e4 ♕c6! 25.♕f4 ♘d5 26.♕d2 ♕b6! (with the threat of 27...♘b4).



27.♗xd5? Even in this situation White should have refrained from the exchange of the bishop and preferred 27.a3. In the heavy piece endgame it is extremely difficult to defend the isolated pawn. The attacking mechanism is the tripling of heavy pieces on the d-file with the threat of e6-e5, which forces f2-f4, seriously weakening the king's defences.

25...♖xd5 28.♖b3 ♕c6 29.♕c3 ♕d7 30.f4 b6! 31.♖b4 b5! (preventing ♖c4) **32.a4 bxa4 33.♕a3 a5 34.♖xa4 ♕b5! 35.♖d2.**



35...e5! The decisive thrust, revealing the exposed position of the white king.

36.fxe5 ♖xe5 37.♕a1 ♕e8! 38.dxe5 ♖xd2 39.♖xa5 ♕c6 40.♖a8+ ♔h7 41.♕b1+ g6 42.♕f1 ♕c5+ 43.♔h1 ♕d5+. White resigned.

It was easy for Karpov to play this game, since he already had experience of conducting a frontal attack against an isolated pawn in a game with Spassky at the Montreal Tournament of 1979. But there is also another, dynamic way of handling the position arising after White's 11th move.

Damljanovic – Beliavsky
Belgrade 1993
Queen's Gambit D53

1.♘f3 d5 2.c4 e6 3.d4 ♘f6 4.♘c3 ♗e7 5.♗g5 h6 6.♗h4 0-0 7.♖c1 dxc4 8.e3 c5 9.♗xc4 cxd4 10.cxd4 Nc6 11.0-0.



11...♕b6!? Exploiting the fact that the b2-pawn is temporarily undefended, Black sets up pressure on the d4-pawn without forgetting about control of the d5 blockading square.

12.♕d2 ♖d8 13.♘a4?! This allows Black to exchange the queens, which practically neutralises the dynamic potential of the isolated pawn. Of course, 13.♖fd1 was in the spirit of the position. For example, the game Yusupov – Beliavsky, Belgrade 1991, continued 12.♕d2♖d8 13.♖fd1 ♗d7 14.♕e2 ♘h5!? (after 14...♗e8 15.d5 exd5 16.♗xd5 ♚f8 17.♗b3 White has a spatial advantage) 15.d5 ♘f4 16.♕e1 exd5 17.♗xe7 ♘xe7 18.♕xe7 ♘g6! 19.♘xd5 ♘xe7 20.♘xb6 axb6 21.♘e5 ♗e8 22.♗b3 ♘c6! 23.♘xc6 (23.♘c4 ♘d4=) 23... bxc6 24.f4. Draw.

13...♕b4! 14.♕xb4 ♘xb4 15.♘c3 ♗d7 16.♖fd1 ♖ac8 17.♗b3 ♗c6 18.♘e5.



After the exchange of queens Black has regrouped his forces around the d5-point and obtained a favourable endgame. But what to do next? After the exchange ♘xc6 and then d4-d5 White may be able to neutralise the position. The problems are also not solved by 18...♗d5, after which White can exchange minor pieces: 19.♗xf6 ♗xf6 20.♗xd5 ♘xd5 21.♘xd5 exd5 22.f4.

18...g5! 19.♗g3 ♝e4! This move is linked with the previous one – Black plays his bishop to the kingside and prepares an attack on White's position in the centre after ♘c6.

20.h4. The exchanges 20.♘xe4 ♘xe4 21.♖xc8 ♖xc8 favour Black.

20...♗f5 21.hxg5 hxg5 22.a3 ♘bd5 23.♘xd5 ♘xd5 24.♗xd5. Sooner or later White had to capture on d5, to prevent the attack on his d4-pawn after ♘f6. But although the pawn structure in the centre is now stabilised, Black retains the better chances thanks to his bishop pair.

24...exd5 25.f3 f6 26.♘g4 ♗xg4! An old joke states that the advantage of the two bishops can always be transformed into the advantage of one. Now White has problems with his d4-pawn.

27.fxg4 ♔f7 28.♗c7 (parrying the threat of ♔e6 and ♖c4) **28...♖e8.** This is more accurate than 28...♖d7 29.♗g3 ♖c4 30.♔f2, which allows the king to be brought towards the centre.

29.♔f2 ♔e6 30.♔f3 (30.♔e3? ♔d7 31.♗g3 ♗xa3+) **30...♔d7 31.♗g3.**



31...b5! Preparing to occupy the most important square in the position – c4. For example: 32.♖h1 ♖c4 33.♖xc4 bxc4 34.♖h7 ♖c8 35.♗e1 ♚c6 and White has problems with his b2-pawn.

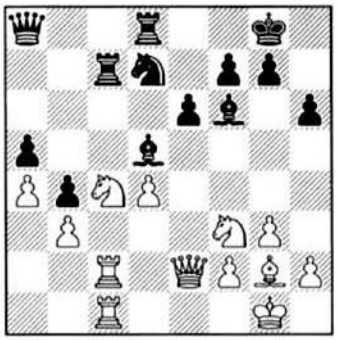
32.a4 bxa4 33.♖h1 ♖xc1 34.♖xc1 ♖c8! 35.♖xc8. If 35.♖a1 there follows 35...a3 36.bxa3 ♖c3+, but the bishop endgame with an extra pawn is also won easily.

35...♔xc8 36.♔e3 a3 37.bxa3 ♗xa3 38.♔d3 a5 39.♗e1 a4 40.♗c3 ♔d7 41.♔c2 ♔c6 42.♔d3 ♔b5. White resigned.

In modern chess the voluntary exchange of material occurs comparatively rarely, and the besieging of an isolated pawn often takes place in a complicated middlegame. However, the conversion of an advantage nevertheless usually takes place via exchanging operations.

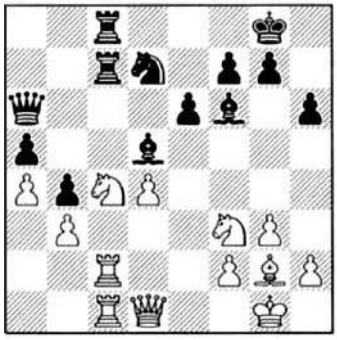
BRUZON – ANAND
Wijk aan Zee 2005
English Opening A13

1.♘f3 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♗g2 dxc4 5.♕a4+ c6 6.♕xc4 b5 7.♕c2 ♗b7 8.d4 ♘bd7 9.a4 c5 10.0-0 b4 11.♗g5 ♖c8 12.♘bd2 ♗e7 13.♖fc1 0-0 14.♕d3 h6 15.♗xf6 ♗xf6 16.e3 ♖c7 17.♕e2 ♕c8 18.♕b5 a6 19.♕f1 a5 20.b3 ♖d8 21.♕b5 ♝c6 22.♕e2 ♕b7 23.♘c4 ♕a8 24.♖a2 cxd4 25.exd4 ♗d5 26.♖ac2.



The advantage is with Black, whose bishops are trained on the pawn weaknesses at d4 and b3 on White's queenside. To intensify his attack Black provokes advantageous exchanges.

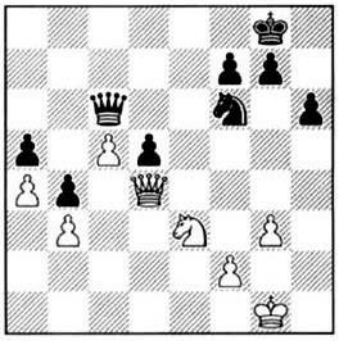
26...♖dc8 27.♕d1 ♕a6! Intensifying the pressure on the knight at c4. In the event of 27...♗xc4 28.♖xc4 ♖xc4 29.bxc4 ♕a7 30.c5 White has counterplay.



28.♘fe5. If 28.♕d3 matters are decided by the pin 28...♘b6 29.♗f1 ♘xc4 30.bxc4 ♗xf3! 31.♕xf3 ♗xd4, and Black wins the d4-pawn.

28...♗xe5 29.♗xd5 ♗xg3! A bird in the hand is worth more than two in the bush after 29...♗f4 30.gxf4 exd5 31.♘e3 ♕g6+ 32.♔f1 (variation by Anand).

30.hxg3 cxd5 31.♘e3 ♖xc2 32.♖xc2 ♘f6 33.♖c5 ♖xc5 34.dxc5 ♕c6 35.♕d4.



35...g6. As a result of the exchanging operation the game has gone into an endgame with an extra pawn for Black, although, in view of the possible activity of the white queen, it is not easy for him to win. For the moment Black forestalls the threat of 36.♘f5.

36.♕e5 ♘d7 37.♕d6? A time-trouble oversight. White transposes into a lost knight endgame, whereas he could have gone into a queen endgame: 37.♕e8+ ♔g7 38.♘g4 g5 (or 38...d4 39.♘e5 ♘xe5 40.♕xe5+ ♕f6 41.♕d5!) 39.♘e5 ♘xe5 40.♕xe5+ ♔g6 41.♕d4, where Black's passed d-pawn balances White's passed c-pawn.

37...♕xd6 38.cxd6 ♔f8 39. ♘xd5 ♘c5 40.♕f1 ♔e8 41.♘b6 ♘xb3 42.♔e2 ♘c5 43.f3 h5! It transpires that White cannot cope with the passed pawns on opposite wings.

44.♔e3 b3. White resigned.

4.2. Counterplay based on control of the blockading d5-point

In the preceding examples White underestimated the role of reduced material and he aided Black's exchanging strategy. However, modern technique usually does not allow the strategy of simplifying the position to be carried out so easily.

We will begin with a structure from the Queen's Gambit Accepted, which was examined in the preceding chapters.

GLIGORIC – SUETIN
Titovo Uzice 1966
Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗xc4 c5 6.0-0 a6 7.a4 ♘c6 8.♕e2 cxd4 9.♖d1 ♗e7 10.exd4 0-0 11.♘c3 ♘d5 12.♗d3 ♘cb4 13.♗b1 ♗d7. In recent times Black preferred to fianchetto his bishop by 13...b6, with the intention of parrying 14.♕e4 by 14...f5.

14.♘e5 (the 16th game of the Botvinnik – Petrosian match continued 14.♕e4) **14...♗c6.**



A dynamically balanced position has arisen. Black is securely controlling the d5 blockading point, but his king is inadequately defended. He also has to reckon with the weakening of his b6-point, which may be emphasised by a4-a5, when White has chances of an attack on the queenside.

15.♖a3! ♘f6. If 15...♖c8?! White builds up his threats to the king by 16.♘c4! with the threat of 17.♕h5.

16.♗g5 g6. Here 16...♖c8 was now possible, since the attack on the h7-pawn – 17.♗xf6 ♗xf6 18.♘a2 is parried by the mate threat 18...♕d5 (18...♘xa2? 19.♗xh7+), but Black prefers a radical way of defending the b1-h7 diagonal.

17.a5 (fixing the weakness of the b6-point).

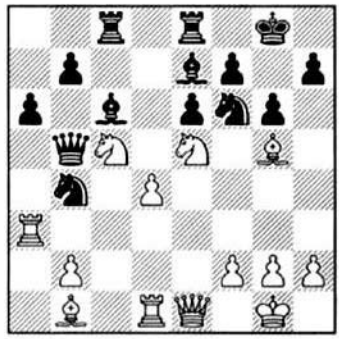


17...♖c8. In Gligoric – Ivkov, Novi Sad 1976, Black preferred the routine blockading move 17...♘bd5?!, underestimating White's possible initiative on the queenside. After 18.♘xc6! bxc6 19.♖a4! ♕c7 20.♗d3 ♕b7 21.♖c4 ♖fb8 22.♘a4 ♘d7 23.♗d2 ♗f6 24.♖dc1 ♖c8 25.♗e4 White gained a strategically winning position in view of the pawn weaknesses at a6 and c6.

18.♘a4?! This pawn sacrifice is unjustified. The idea looks more logical after 18.♖b3!? ♕xa5 19.♗e4, but here too after 19...♘bd5 (19...♘xe4?! 20.♗xe7 ♘xc3 21.bxc3 favours White) 20.♘xc6 bxc6 21.♗xd5 ♘xd5 22.♗xe7 ♘xe7 23.♖a3 White does not achieve anything significant. 18.♘xc6 ♘xc6 would have led to an equal game.

18...♕xa5 19.♘c5 ♕b5 20.♕e1. After 20.♕xb5 ♗xb5 21.♞xb7 ♘bd5 Black's advantage in the endgame is obvious.

20...♖fe8. 20...b6 21.♘xc6 ♕xc6 was simpler, with advantage to Black.



21.♘xf7? White has insufficient force for an attack on the king. 21.♖b3 a5 22.♗d3 ♕b6 23.♗c4 was in the spirit of the position, with the idea of 23...♗d5 24.♗xf6 ♗xf6 25.♘ed7 ♕d8 26.♗xd5 ♘xd5 27.♖xb7.

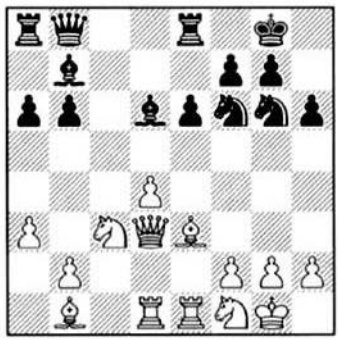
21...♔xf7 22.♕xe6+ ♔g7 23.♖h3 ♝d5 24.♕e3 ♘g4 25.♕d2 ♗d6 26.♗f4 ♗xf4 27.♕xf4 ♕e2 28.♖f1 ♗c4 29.♘d3 ♘xd3. White resigned.

MIKHALCHISHIN – PSAKHIS

49th USSR Championship, Frunze 1981

Nimzo-Indian Defence E48

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 c5 5.♗d3 ♘c6 6.♘ge2 cxd4 7.exd4 d5 8.0-0 dxc4 9.♗xc4 0-0 10.♗g5 h6 11.♗e3 b6 12.♕d3 ♝d6 13.a3 ♗b7 14.♖ad1 ♕b8 15.♘g3 a6 16.♗a2 ♘e7 17.♗b1 ♘g6 18.♖fe1 ♖e8 19.♘f1.



19...♘d5. Black firmly blockades the d5-square, and also controls the important b8-h2 diagonal, which enables him to exchange the dark-square bishops.

20.♗c1 ♕c7 21.♘e4.



21...♗f4! The exchange of the dark-square bishops is an important procedure in the battle against an isolated pawn.

22.g3 ♗xc1 23.♖xc1 ♕e7 24.♘e3 ♘xe3 25.♕xe3 ♖ad8. Black's plan includes playing his queen to d8 (after ♖d7) and his knight to d5 (♘g6-e7-d5) followed by f7-f5. This requires time, which allows White to forestall this plan. Therefore 25...♖ed8!? was more accurate, retaining the option of fighting for the c-file with the second rook, which could be exchanged.

26.♖ed1 ♖d7 27.♘d2! White exploits the weakness of the b6-pawn and, by playing his knight to c4, seizes the initiative.

27...♘f8 28.♘c4 b5 29.♘e5 ♖d6 30.♘d3?! White should have played 30.♖e5 with the idea of exploiting the c-file after ♕c3. Even so, with accurate play Black can hold the position: 30...f6 31.♘g6 (nothing is given by 31.♘d3 ♖ed8 32.♘b4 a5 33.♘c2 ♖d5) 31...♕f7 32.♘xf8 ♔xf8 33.♗a2 ♕d7 (33...♗d5 is premature: 34.♗xd5 exd5 35.♕f4, and White's chances are preferable) 34.♕c3 ♖c8 35.♖e1 and now 35...♖xc5 or 35...♖cc6.

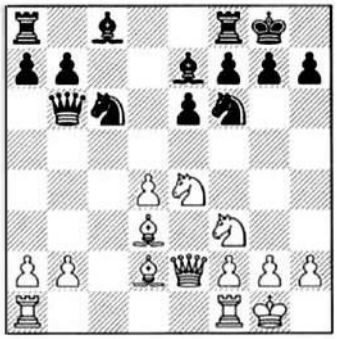
30...♖ed8 31.♘c5 ♗a8 32.♗e4 ♕a7 33.♕f3 ♗d5 34.♗xd5 ♖xd5 35.♘b3 ♘h7 36.♖c6?! More tenacious was 36.h4 ♘f6 37.♖c5 a5 38.♖xd5 ♖xd5 39.♖c1 ♖d8 (39...a4 40.♖c8+ ♔h7 41.♕d3+ g6 42.♘c5) 40.♕c6 a4 41.♘c5, complicating Black's task (41...♕b8 42.♘a6 ♕d6 43.♕xd6 ♖xd6 44.♘c7).

36...♘g5 37.♕c3 e5 38.♖c7 ♕a8 39.♖e1 exd4 40.♕d3 ♖5d7 41.♖xd7 ♖xd7. White resigned.

Now we will examine some modern examples of defence based on control of the d5-point.

KAMSKY – KARPOV
FIDE World Championship Match, 4th Game, Elista 1996
Caro-Kann Defence B14

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♘f3 ♗b4 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♗d2 ♘c6 9.♗d3 ♗e7 10.0-0 0-0 11.♕e2 ♘f6 12.♘e4 ♕b6!



An improvement compared with 12...♗d7, as occurred in the 2nd game of the same match. The attack by the queen on the d4- and b2-pawns resembles to some extent the game Damljanovic – Beliavsky, Belgrade 1993, which was examined earlier.

13.a3 (indirectly defending the b2-pawn – 13...♕xb2? 14.♖fb1) **13...♗d7 14.♖fd1 ♖ad8!?** A prophylactic defensive procedure typical of Karpov. He uses his queen's rook to control the d5-square and keeps his king's rook for the defence of his king. 14...♘xd4 15.♘xd4 ♕xd4 does not work because of 16.♗c3! ♕a4 17.b3! ♕c6 18.♘xf6+ ♗xf6 19.♗xf6 gxf6 20.♗xh7+, and White wins.

15.♘xf6+. The exchange of minor pieces plays into Black's hands, since it allows him to besiege the d-pawn. 15.b4!? followed by ♖ac1 is more in the spirit of the position.

15...♗xf6 16.♕e4 g6 17.♗e3 (with the threat of 18.♕f4 and 19.d5) **17...♘e7!** (parrying this threat – 18.♕f4 ♘d5) **18.♘e5.**



18...♘f5!? A concrete decision. Black begins an attack on the d4-pawn, leaving the control of the d5-square to his bishop, since its exchange will merely aggravate the problem of defending the pawn. Of course, 18... ♘d5 was by no means worse.

19.♘c4. It is not possible to exchange the d4-pawn – 19.d5? ♘xc3

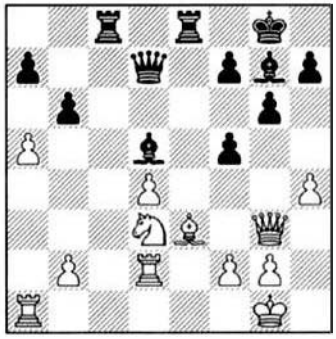
20.♘xd7 ♖xd7 21.♕xe3 ♕xe3 22.fxe3 ♖fd8 leads to its loss.

19...♕a6! (with the idea of 20...♗b5) **20.a4 ♗c6 21.♕f4 ♝d5.** Black has solved his main strategic objective – the blockade of the d4-pawn, and he stands better. Diverting from the general course by 21...♗xd4? hands the initiative to White: 22.♗xf5 ♗xe3 23.♘xe3 exf5 24.♘xf5!

22.♘e5 ♕b6 23.♗xf5 exf5 24.♖d2 ♗g7 25.h4 ♖fe8 26.♕g3 ♖c8. Karpov thinks that it would have been more accurate first to restrict White's possibilities with 26...h6, forestalling the threat of 27.h5 in view of 27...g5.

27.♘d7. White makes the knight manoeuvre ♘e5-d7-c5-d3-f4 rather than give up his d4-pawn after the 'short' 27.♘d3.

27...♕c6 28.♘c5 b6 29.♘d3 ♕d7 30.a5 (30.♘e5 ♕e6 31.a5 was more accurate).



30...♖e4! With the threat of ♖g4.

31.♘f4 b5 32.♖dd1 ♗c4 33.♖ac1. Objectively speaking, defending the isolated pawn from the rear is an unpromising business. Therefore White aims to activate his rook on the c-file, with the intention of defending the pawn from the side. However, he misses a chance to gain counterplay by 33.h5!?, which Black immediately nips in the bud.

33...h6 34.♖c3 b4 35.♖c2 ♖c6! (preparing the conditions for the exchange of rooks) **36.♖dc1 ♗b5 37.♔h2 ♔h7 38.♖xc6 ♗xc6 39.♖c4.** The only saving chance was 39.d5! (Karpov).

39...♗f8! A typical Karpov move! By playing his bishop to d6, Black aims to exploit the overloading on the b8-h2 diagonal. The pawn capture 39...♗xd4 40.♗xd4 ♖xd4 41.♕b3 ♖xc4 42.♕xc4 would have left White with some hopes.

40.♘d3 ♕e6 (40...♕d5! was stronger, with the threats ♕xc4, ♖g4 and ♗d6) **41.d5** (too late!) **41...♗xd5 42.♖xe4** (42.♘f4 ♗d6) **42...♗xe4 43.♝xa7.** White can simplify the position – 43.♘c5 ♕d5 44.♘xe4 fxe4 45.♕h3 ♕xa5 46.♕d7, but the endgame cannot be saved: 46...♕a2! 47.♕xa7 ♕xa7 48.♗xa7 b3.

43...♗d6 44.♘f4 (if 44.f4 Black wins by 44...♕d7! with the threat of 45...♗xd3) **44...♕e5 45.♘h3 ♕e7.** White resigned.

SVESHNIKOV – RIAZANTSEV
Moscow 2002
Caro-Kann Defence B14

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♘f3 ♗b4 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♕c2 ♘c6 9.♗e2 0-0 10. 0-0 ♗e7 11.♖d1 ♗f6.

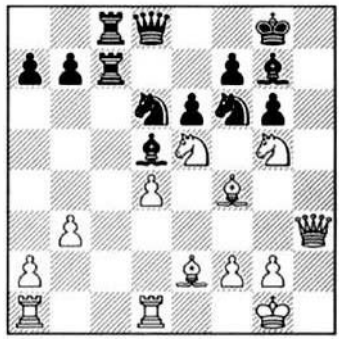


12.♕e4. White begins an attack on the king, forcing the weakening move g7-g6. If 12.♘e4 Black can complete his development: 12...♗d7 (intending ♖c8), for example: 13.♘xf6+ ♕xf6! (not 13...♘xf6? 14.♗g5) 14.♗g5 ♕g6 15.♗d3 ♕h5 16.♕b3 b6 17.♗e4 f6 18.♗h4 ♖ac8 with an equal game (Riazantsev).

12...♘ee7 13.h4 ♗d7 14.♗d3 g6 15.h5 ♗c6 16.♕g4 ♘f5 17.♘e4 ♗g7 18.hxg6 hxg6 19.♕h3 ♖e8 20.♘eg5 ♘f6 21.♘e5 ♖e7 22.♗c4. 22.♗e2? can be met by 22...♘xd4 23.♗c4 and the pin is broken by 23...♘f3+!

22...♗d5. Black vigilantly maintains the blockade – the knight is replaced by the bishop, and now if 23.♗e2?! there follows 23...♕b6!

23.b3 ♖c7 24.♗e2 ♖ac8 25.♗f4 ♘d6.



26.♘c4. This knight retreat signifies an abandonment of the attack, a logical conclusion to which could have been 26.♘xg6!? fxg6 27.♘xe6 ♕e7 (or 27...♗xe6 28.♕xe6+ ♘f7 29.♗xc7 ♖xc7 30.♖ac1 ♖e7 31.♕h3 ♘d6 32.♗d3) 28.♘xc7 ♖xc7 29.♗d3 ♖c3 (29...♗e4? 30.♖c1) 30.♖ac1 ♖xc1 31.♖xc1 with the initiative for White (31...♘h5 32.♕e3, 31...♔f7 32.♗e5). Now, however, Black seizes the initiative.

26...♗xc4! 27.bxc4 ♖d7 28.d5. This activity is essentially forced, since 28.♖ac1 ♘f5 leads to the loss of a pawn, and 28.♗e5 ♘de4! to the exchange of the minor pieces: 29.♘xc4 ♞xc4 30.♕e3 ♘d6 31.♗xg7 ♔xg7, after which White has problems with the defence of his hanging pawns on d4 and c4.

28...exd5 29.cxd5 ♘de4.



30.♖ac1. The alternative was 30.♘xe4♘xe4 31.♗b5 ♖c7 32.♖ab1 ♖c2! with counterplay for Black. 32...♘c3? does not work because of 33.d6 ♖e6 34.♖e1! with dangerous threats for White: 34...♘xb1? 35.♖xc6 ♖c3 36.♖e8+, 34...♘e4 35.d7 ♖c3 36.♖bc1, or 34...♕f6 35.d7.

30...♖xc1 31.♖xc1? An inexplicable blunder of a pawn. 31.♗xc1 ♖xd5 32.♖xd5 ♕xd5 33.♕c8+ ♗f8 34.♗a3 ♘c5 35.♗xc5 ♕xc5 36.♕xc5 ♗xc5 37.♗c4 was correct, regaining the pawn in a somewhat inferior endgame.

31...♘xd5 32.♕h7+ ♔f8, and Black won a pawn, and then also the game.

VALLEJO PONS – KASPAROV

Linares 2005

Queen's Gambit Accepted D21

1.♘f3 d5 2.d4 e6 3.c4 dxc4 4.e4 b5 5.a4 c6 6.axb5 cxb5 7.b3 ♗b7 8.bxc4 ♗xe4 9.cxb5 ♘f6 10.♗e2 ♗e7 11.0-0-0 12.♘c3 ♗b7.



This position with an isolated pawn can be considered dynamically balanced. White's spatial advantage is compensated by Black's firm control of the d5-point. Black's main objective is to eliminate the cramping pawn on b5.

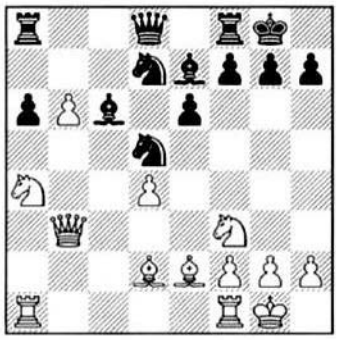
13.♗f4. Kasparov would have parried 13.♘e5 with 13...♕c7! 14.♗f3 ♕xc3 15.♗xb7 ♕xa1 16.♗xa8 ♘bd7, when Black simplifies the position.

13...♗b4! (intending the exchange of the knight) **14.♘a4.** In the event of 14.♕b3 ♗xc3 15.♕xc3 ♘d5 16.♕d2 ♘xf4 17.♕xf4 a6 18.bxa6 ♘xa6 Black gets rid of the b5-pawn while leaving White with the problem of defending his isolated d4-pawn.

14...♘bd7 15.♕b3 ♘d5 16.♗g5 ♗e7. As we know, the exchange of the dark-square bishops is advantageous to Black.

17.♗d2 a6! 18.b6. Understandably, White avoids the exchange of the queenside pawns, but now his b6-pawn will need to be defended.

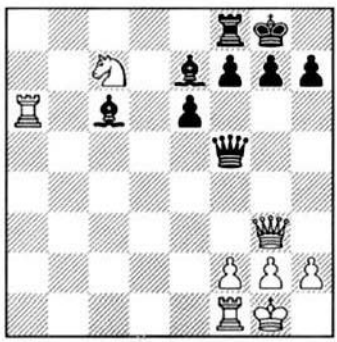
18...♗c6!



19.♘e5?! This move leads to mass exchanges and allows Black to seize the initiative. Stronger was 19.♖fb1!? ♗xa4 20.♖xa4 ♕xb6 21.♕a2 ♕d6 with roughly equal chances.

19...♘xe5 20.dxe5 ♘xb6 21.♘xb6. The alternative was 21.♕xb6 ♕xd2 22.♕xc6 ♕xe2 23.♘b6 ♖ad8=.

21...♕xd2 22.♘xa8 ♕xe2 23.♘c7 ♕xe5 24.♕g3 ♕f5! 25.♖xa6.



25...♗e4. Although nominally he has a slight material deficit, Black has two well-coordinated bishops and the best continuation for him was 25...♕c4! 26.f3 (26.♖c1 ♖d8 27.h3 ♗h4) 26...♕d4+ 27.♔h1 ♗b7 28.♖aa1 ♗d6 29.♘b5 ♕xa1, gaining a material advantage (Kasparov). Possibly, instead of 28.♖aa1 White should decide on 28.♖xe6!? fxe6 29.♘xe6 ♕f6 30.♘xf8 ♗xf8, simplifying the position as much as possible.

26.♖a7 ♗c5?! Stronger was 26...♕c5!? 27.♖aa1 ♗d6 28.♕h4 ♗b7 29.♖fc1 ♕e5 30.♖c1 (30.♖e1 ♕f5) 30...♗xg2 31.♔xg2 ♗xc7 with more than sufficient compensation for the exchange, since now White could have consolidated his forces by 27.♖a4! ♖d8 28.♘b5 (if 28...♗c6 or 28...♝b3 there follows 29.♘d4). But there followed...

27.♖a5? ♗xf2+ 28.♕xf2 ♕xa5 29.♘xe6 ♗xg2! White resigned.

TOPALOV – KRAMNIK

World Championship Match,
7th Game, Elista 2006
Queen's Gambit Accepted D27

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♗d3 dxc4 6.♗xc4 c5 7.0-0 a6 8.♗b3 cxd4 9.exd4 ♘c6 10.♘c3 ♗e7 11.♖e1 0-0 12.a4. This attempt to prevent b7-b5 leads to a weakening of the b4-point, making it easier for Black to control d5.





12...♗d7. 12...b6 is also possible, not fearing 13.d5 exd5 14.♘xd5 ♘xd5 15.♗xd5 .♗b7, but in the event of 13.d5 Black has reserved another post for his bishop: 13...exd5 14.♘xd5 ♘xd5 15.♗xd5 ♗f5, achieving an equal game.

13.♘e5 ♗e8. A Steinitz-style bishop retreat, but with a significant difference – in his game with Zukertort (1886) the f8-rook had moved to d8. But Black's idea in attacking the d4-pawn is to force White to block the e-file for his rook on e1.

14.♗e3 ♖c8. After the exchange 14...♘xc5 15.dxe5 ♕xd1 16.♗xd1 ♘d7 17.♗f3! a5 18.♗d4 White has a spatial advantage.

15.♖c1 ♘b4 16.♕f3. White switches his queen to the kingside.

16...♗c6 17.♕h3. The exchange is rather to Black's advantage, since White is deprived of his attacking knight, and the weakness at c6 is defended.

17...♗d5 18.♘xd5 ♘bxd5.

19.♖cd1! Black has carried out his plan of establishing a blockade at d5, and in search of an active arrangement of his forces White frees his bishop from the defence of the d4-pawn.

19...♖c7. Not so much to seize the c-file, as to defend the f7-pawn.

20.♗g5 ♕c8 21.♕f3. It was not easy to assess the outcome of the exchanging operation 21.♗xf6 ♘xf6 22.♘xf7!? ♖xf7 23.♗xe6 ♕d8 24.♖c1 ♖d7 (24...♖xc1? is bad: 25.♖xc1 ♗f8 26.♗xf7+ ♔xf7 27.♕b3+ ♕d5 28.♖c7+) 25.♕b3 ♝f8, and Black coordinates his pieces.

21...♖d8 22.h4 h6 23.♗c1. 23.♗d2 came into consideration, and if 23...♗b4, aiming for the exchange of bishops, then White can provoke a crisis on the f7- and e6-squares: 24.♝xb4 ♘xb4 25.♘xf7! ♔xf7 26.♗xe6+ ♕xe6 27.♖xe6 ♚xe6 28.g4! However, after 28...g5 29.♕f5+ ♔f7 30.h5 ♘bd5 31.♕g6+ ♔f8 32.♕xh6+ ♖g7 the

position remains unclear, since the white queen finds itself trapped: ♔f8-f7, ♖d8-g8 and ♖g7-h7 is threatened.

23...♗b4 24.♖f1 ♗d6.



25.g3. White sticks to waiting tactics. Of course, the critical decision could have been the attack with 25.g4!?, but here too after 25...♝xe5 26.dxe5 ♘d7 Black has adequate defensive resources, for example: 27.g5 hxg5 28.♗xg5 ♘xe5 29.♕g3 f6 30.♗xf6 ♘f3+! (weaker is 30...♘xf6 31.♖xd8+ ♕xd8 32.♕xe5, when White has the advantage) 31.♕xf3 ♖f7 32.♖xd5 exd5 33.♗xd5 ♖xd5 34.♕xd5 ♕g4+ 35.♕g2 ♕xg2+ 36.♔xg2 ♖xf6, and in the rook endgame Black has real saving chances (Onischuk). The preparatory 27.♕g3 can be met by 27...♘c3! 28.♖de1 ♘e2+ 29.♖xe2 ♖xc1 30.g5 hxg5 31.hxg5 ♘f8, and White's attack comes to a standstill.

25...b6 26.♕e2 ♘e7. Played in Karpov style – Black combines control of the d5-point with a threat to attack the d4-pawn from f5.

27.♖fe1 ♗xe5. Black decides to change the pawn structure, having no doubts about its solidity. However, 27...♘fd5 was also sound.

28.dxe5 (28.♕xe5? ♘c6 would have led to the loss of the d4-pawn) **28...♖xd1 29.♕xd1 ♘fd5 30.♝d2 ♖c5 31.♕g4 ♘f5 32.♕e4 b5 33.h5** (otherwise Black himself can play h6-h5) **33...bxa4 34.♕xa4 ♖b5 35.♖c1 ♕b7.**



Black has managed not only to simplify the position, but also to attack the b2-pawn, whereas White can only pin his hopes on the illusory strength of his bishops.

36.♗c2. If 36.♗xd5 ♕xd5 37.♝c3 White has to reckon with 37...♕f3.

36...♘b6! 37.♕g4 ♖xb2 38.♗e4?! He should have regained the pawn: 38.♗c3 ♖b5 39.♗xf5 exf5 40.♕xf5.

38...♕d7 39.♗e1 ♘d5 40.♗d3 ♘b4 41.♗f1 ♘d3 42.♕d1. After 42.♗xd3 ♕xd3 the prospects of the passed a-pawn would be improved.

42...♘xe5 43.♕xd7 ♘xd7 44.♖c8+ ♔h7 45.♖c7 ♖b1 46.♖xd7 ♖xe1 47.♖xf7 a5. White's counterplay involves exploiting the b1-d3 diagonal.

48.♔g2 ♔g8 49.♖a7 ♖e5 50.g4 ♘d6 51.♗d3 ♔f8 52.♗g6 ♖d5 53.f3 e5 54.♔f2 ♖d2+ 55.♔e1 ♖d5 56.♔e2 ♖b5 57.♖d7 ♖d5 58.♖a7 ♖b5 59.♗d3 ♖d5 60.♗g6. Draw.

To conclude this topic we would like to draw attention to another defensive idea. It is common knowledge that the usual way of parrying an attack along the b1-h7 diagonal by the queen + bishop battery is the move g7-g6. But f7-f5, a rarer way of defending, also occurs. It can be employed in a specific situation, when Black does not have to fear the weakening of the e6-pawn.

KERES – TAL
24th USSR Championship,
Moscow 1957
Queen's Gambit D30

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 c5 4.e3 d5 5.a3 cxd4 6.exd4 ♗e7 7.♘c3 0-0 8.♗f4 ♘c6 9.♖c1 ♘e4 10.♗d3 ♘xc3 11.♖xc3 dxc4 12.♖xc4 ♕a5+ 13.♗d2 ♕d5 14.♕c2.



14...f5! A concrete approach to the position. There is a certain lack of harmony in the arrangement of White's forces: the rook at c4 and the bishop at b2 are badly placed, and Black exploits this. He nips in the bud White's activity on the b1-h7 diagonal and consolidates his queen's central position. The weakening of the e6-pawn is insignificant – there is no way of attacking it.

15.0-0 ♗d7! 16.♖d1?! 16.♗c3 ♖c8 17.♖c3 ♘a5 18.♘e5 was stronger, not conceding the c-file, since 18...♖xc3 19.bxc3 leads to an unclear position.



16...♖ac8. In the event of 16...♗e8 17.♖c3 ♗h5 White attacks the weak c6-pawn – 18.♗c4 ♕e4 19.♕b3. It is risky to play 16...b5 17.♖c3 ♘xd4 18.♘xd4 ♕xd4 19.♗e3, when White has a dangerous initiative for the pawn.

17.♗e3 ♘a5 18.♖xc8. By conceding the c-file, White avoids being saddled with an isolated pawn pair: 18.♖e3 ♖xc3 19.bxc3 ♖c8 (19...♝xa3? 20.♖a1) 20.♘e5 ♗c6 21.f3 b5 (21...♗xa3?! 22.c4!), although after 22.♖b1 ♗f6 23.a4 he has definite counterplay (23...bxa4 24.♗a6 ♖d8 25.♘xc6 ♕xc6 26.♝b5).

18...♖xc8 19.♕e2 ♗d6.



20.♘e5. In the event of 20.♖c1?! ♖xc1 21.♝xc1 ♘b3 22.♗c3 b5! 23.♘e5 ♗xe5 24.dxe5 ♗c6 Black has an appreciable advantage (Tal).

20...♗a4 21.♖e1 ♗xe5 22.dxe5 ♖d8 23.b4?! This leads by force to a difficult endgame. White should have retreated with 23.♗b1, and if 23...♕xe5, then 24.f4 ♕b5 25.♗a2!, keeping the c6- and a7-pawns under fire.

23...♗c6 24.f3 ♕xd3 25.♕xd3 ♖xd3 26.bxa5 ♖xa3 27.♗xa7 ♖xa5 28.♗d4 ♖a2 29.♖b1 ♖d2 30.♗c3 ♖c2 31.♝d4 ♔f7.



32.h4. Black's advantage consists not only in his extra pawn, but also his better bishop, which coordinates excellently with his rook, as is confirmed, for example, by the following variation: 32.h3 f4 33.♖b2 ♖c1+ 34.♔h2 g5 35.♗a7 ♔g6 36.♗b8 ♔f5 37.♗d6 h5 38.♝b8 ♗d5 39.♗d6 g4 40.hxg4 hxg4 41.fxg4 ♔xg4 42.♗b8 b5 43.♗d6 ♖c1 44.♗b8 b4 45.♗d6 b3 46.♖d2 f3 47.♖d4 ♖e4 48.♖xe4+ ♗xe4, and Black wins (analysis by Euwe).

32...♔g6 33.♖b4 h6 34.♖b2. At the cost of the h4-pawn White pins his hopes on the opposite-colour bishops, but in vain. 34.♗e3 was more tenacious.

34...♖xb2 35.♝xb2 ♔h5 36.♝a3 ♔xh4 37.♗f8 ♔g3 38.♗xg7

h5 39.♗h6 ♗xf3! In conclusion an elegant bishop sacrifice follows, after which White can no longer stop the passed pawns.

40.gxf3 ♔xf3 41.♔f1 b5 42.♗d2 h4 43.♗b4 h3 44.♔g1 ♔e2. White resigned.

BRAGA – PORTISCH

Mar del Plata 1982

Sicilian Defence B22

1.e4 c5 2.c3 d5 3.exd5 ♕xd5 4.d4 e6 5.♘f3 ♘f6 6.♗d3 ♗e7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♕e2 cxd4 9.cxd4 ♘c6 10.♖d1 ♘b4 11.♘c3 ♕d8 12.♗c4 b6 13.♘e5 ♗b7 14.a3 ♘bd5.



15.♘e4?! Black has completed his development and he is securely controlling the d5-point. The attempt to build up an attack by switching the rook to the kingside 15.♖d3 is parried by 15...♘xc3! 16.bxc3 ♗d5 17.♗b5 a6! 18.♗a4 (bad is 18.♘c6? ♕c7! 19.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 20.♗a4 ♗c4 with advantage to Black) 18...b5 19.♗c2 ♗e4. The move in the game leads to an exchange of minor pieces, which is advantageous to Black. Therefore 15.♗g5 was more natural.

15...♘xe4 16.♕xe4 ♖c8. Black must prevent the switching of the white rook via d3 to the kingside.

17.♗d3. If 17.♖d3 there follows 17...f6 and in the event of **18.**♖h3 fxe5 19.♕xh7+ ♔f7 20.♕h5+ g6 the king escapes via d7.



17...f5! A radical and concrete solution to the problem of safeguarding the king. In view of the activity of the black pieces, it is difficult for White to exploit the weakness of the e6-pawn.

18.♕e1. If 18.♕e2 the strongest is 18....♗g5!, since 18...♖xc1 19.♖axc1 ♘f4 20.♕c2 ♘xg2 21.♕c7! leads to an unclear game.

18...♔h8 19.♗d2 ♘f6 20.♗b4 ♘d5 21.♗d2 ♗g5! An important defensive procedure – the exchange of the dark-square bishops.

22.♗xg5? 22.♘f3 was better, not allowing the black queen across to the kingside, where it will exert strong pressure on the white king.

22...♕xg5 23.♘f3 ♕h6 24.♖ac1 ♖xc1 25.♖xc1 ♘f4 26.♗f1 ♗xf3 27.gxf3 ♕g5+ 28.♔h1 h6. White has a difficult position in view of the weakness of his kingside and the d4-pawn.

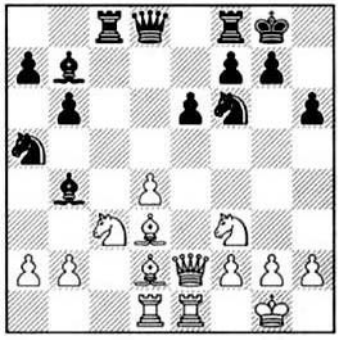
29.♕b4 ♖d8 (29...♖f6? 30.♖c8+ ♔h7 31.♕e7) **30.♕d2 e5! 31.d5 ♖xd5 32.♖c8+ ♔h7 33.♕c2 b5 34.♖f8 ♖d3 35.♕c8 ♕g2+!** White resigned.

4.3. Creation of an isolated pawn pair

A quite popular procedure in the battle against an isolated pawn is the exchange of the knight on c3, leading to the creation of hanging pawns. We encountered it in our study of the Zukertort – Steinitz game, given in the introduction. However, this procedure should be adopted with caution, since hanging pawns on c4 and d4 may become the source of a different type of initiative. The exchange on c3 makes sense if it is possible to blockade the c3-pawn, i.e. prevent c3-c4. In this case a new target for Black's counterplay arises – an isolated pawn pair c3-d4, which may be attacked (in certain situations) by the b- or e-pawn, again transforming the position into one with an isolated pawn, but in an inferior version compared with that planned by the chosen opening system. We will begin with a classic example.

SPASSKY – PETROSIAN
World Championship Match,
3rd Game, Moscow 1966
Caro-Kann Defence B14

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.c4 ♘f6 5.♘c3 e6 6.♘f3 ♗e7 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♗c4 ♘f6 9.0-0 0-0 10.♕e2 ♘c6 11.♗e3 ♘a5 12.♗d3 b6 13.♗g5 ♗b7 14.♖ad1 ♖c8 15.♖fe1 h6 16.♗c1 ♗b4! 17.♗d2.



17...♗xc3! Black creates an isolated pawn pair, since he is able to secure control of d5 and c4.

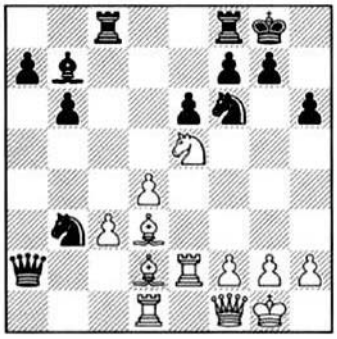
18.bxc3. Not 18.♗xc3? ♕d5!, when the bishop on c3 is playing the role of a pawn.

18...♕d5! 19.♕f1! In order to activate his c3-pawn, White is ready

to sacrifice his a2-pawn. If 19.♗b1 there would have followed 19...♘c4.

19...♕xa2. Here too 19...♘c4 was good, but there appears to be no reason to decline the pawn sacrifice.

20.♘e5 ♘b3 21.♖e2. In the event of 21.♗xh6, if Black is concerned about the attack after 21...gxh6 22.♖e3, he can parry it with the counterattack 21...♖xc3! 22.♖e3 ♖fc8 23.♖g3 ♘h5! 24.♖g5 ♖c1.

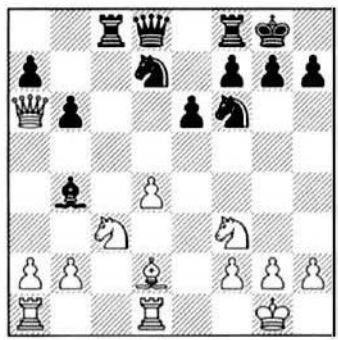


21...♘xd2 (21...♕a3! 22.♗e1 ♘c1! was stronger) **22.♖exd2 ♕d5 23.c4 ♕d6.** Although White has obtained hanging pawns, he does not have full compensation for the sacrificed pawn.

24.♕e2 ♖fd8 25.h3 ♘d7 26.♘g4 h5! (26...♕f4! was also strong) **27.♘e3 g6 28.♖a2 ♖a8 29.♕c2 ♔g7.** Black has retained his extra pawn and the better position.

TAIMANOV – KARPOV
Moscow 1973
Nimzo-Indian Defence E55

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 c5 5.♗d3 0-0 6.♘f3 d5 7.0-0 dxc4 8.♗xc4 cxd4 9.exd4 b6 10.♕e2 ♗b7 11.♖d1 ♘bd7 12.♗d2 ♖c8 13.♗a6 ♗xa6 14.♕xa6.



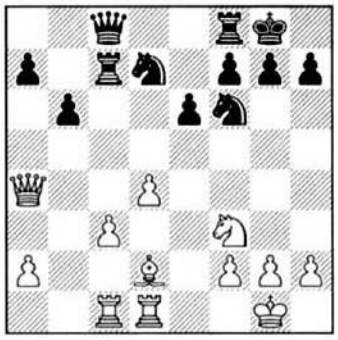
14...♗xc3! Black gives White hanging pawns. Now it is very important for him to keep control of the c4-square, thus blocking the pawns and transforming them into an isolated pawn pair.

15.bxc3 (after 15.♗xc3 the bishop on c3 has no future) **15...♖c7 16.♖ac1.** Preparing c3-c4, which for the moment does not work – 16.c4? ♕c8! and White loses a pawn.

15...♕c8 17.♕a4.

(See diagram)

17...♖c4! The blockade of the isolated pawn pair is worth a pawn: apart from the c4-square, Black also obtains the d5-square for his knight,



from where it will attack the c3-pawn.

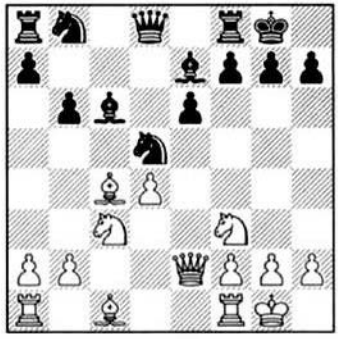
18.♕xa7 ♕c6 19.♕a3 ♖c8 20.h3 h6 21.♖b1. White has to reckon with the pawn advance b6-b5-b4, and after the exchange of his c3-pawn he will again have an isolated d4-pawn, but in a worse version than that resulting from the opening.

21...♖a4 22.♕b3 ♘d5 23.♖dc1 ♖c4 24.♖b2 f6 25.♖e1 ♔f7 26.♕d1 ♘f8 27.♖b3 ♘g6 28.♕b1 ♖a8 29.♖e4 ♖ca4 30.♖b2 ♘f8 31.♕d3 ♖c4 32.♖e1 ♖a3 33.♕b1 ♘g6 34.♖c1? White cracks under the pressure and makes a tactical oversight. He should have kept the b6-pawn under attack by sticking to waiting tactics – 34.♔h2, and only after 34...♖ca4 – 35.♖c1 ♕c4 36.♖cc2.

34...♘xc3 35.♕d3 ♘e2+ 36.♕xe2 ♖xc1+ 37.♗xc1 ♕xc1+ 38.♔h2 ♖xf3! 39.gxf3 ♘h4. White lost on time. The best he could have done was to go into a queen endgame a pawn down: 40.♖b3 ♕g5 41.♕f1 ♕f4+ 42.♔g1 ♘xf3+ 43.♔g2 ♘d2.

M.GUREVICH – YUDASIN
53rd USSR Championship,
Kiev 1986
Queen's Indian Defence E14

1.d4 ♘f6 2.♘f3 e6 3.e3 c5 4.c4 cxd4 5.exd4 b6 6.♗d3 ♗b7 7.0-0 ♗e7 8.♘c3 d5 9.cxd5 ♘xd5 10.♗b5+ ♗c6 11.♗c4 0-0 12.♕e2.



12...♘xc3! An important decision. Black transforms the pawn structure, giving White hanging pawns in the hope of blockading them. Otherwise it is not easy to develop the queenside. For instance, Balashov – Yudasin, Minsk 1985, continued 12....♗b7 13.♖e1 a6 (after 13...♘c6 14.♗xd5! cxd5 15.♗f4 White has a slight but enduring advantage due to the difference in the activity of the bishops) 14.♕e4 ♗f6 15.♗b3, and Black has a problem finding useful moves,

e.g. 15...b5 16.♗f4 ♘xf4 17.♕xb7 ♘d7 18.♖ad1 ♘b6 19.♘e5 with advantage to White.

13.bxc3 ♗d5! Since it is advantageous for Black to exchange the light-square bishops (the weak d5- and c4-squares are exposed), with gain of tempo he vacates the c6-square for the development of his knight, from where it presses on the centre more actively.

14.♗d3 ♘c6! (preventing c3-c4) **15.♗b2** (15.♗e3 is better, with an equal game) **15...♖c8!** With a series of accurate moves Black has solved his opening problems and he now threatens 16...♘a5 with a blockade of the isolated pawn pair.

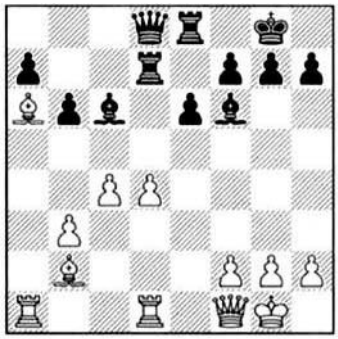
16.♘d2 ♗f6 (forestalling c3-c4).



17.♖fd1. White should nevertheless have decided on 17.c4, which leads almost by force to a position with somewhat the better chances for Black: 17...♘xd4 18.♗xd4 ♗xd4 19.cxd5 ♗xa1 20.♕c4 g6 21.♖xa1 ♕xd5 22.♕xd5 cxd5.

17...♖e8 (intending c6-c5) **18.♕f1 ♘a5 19.♗a6** (if 19.c4, then 19...♗c6 20.♘b3 ♗a4 is unpleasant) **19...♖c7 20.c4.** Black has done his utmost to hinder the advance of the c3-pawn, and White makes use of his last chance to prevent the creation of an isolated pawn pair. But now the d4-pawn is in danger.

20...♗c6 21.♘b3 ♘xb3 22.axb3 ♖d7.



23.d5. Forced. If 23.♕d3 Black attacks with 23...♕a8! 24.♕g3 ♖cd8 25.♕g4 h5!

23...cxd5 24.♗xf6 ♕xf6 25.♗b5 ♗xb5 26.cxb5 d4 27.♖ac1 g6 28.h3 ♕f5 29.♕c4 d3 30.♖d2 ♖c4 31.♕c6 ♖e2 32.♖xe2 dxe2 33.♖e1 ♖e7, and Black achieved a winning position.

MAKARICHEV – MIKHALCHISHIN
46th USSR Championship, Tbilisi 1978
Queen's Gambit D42

1.c4 e6 2.♘f3 ♘f6 3.d4 d5 4.e3 c5 5.♘c3 ♘c6 6.a3 cxd4 7.exd4 ♗e7 8.cxd5 ♘xd5 9.♗d3 0-0 10. 0-0 ♗f6 11.♖e1.



11...♘xc3!? Black creates a form of isolated pawn pair, since his control of the d4-pawn prevents White from playing c3-c4. However, he has to reckon with an attack on his inadequately defended kingside. In the event of 11...♘xd4 12.♘xd4 ♗xd4 13.♗xh7+ ♔xh7 14.♕xd4 ♘xc3! 15.♕xc3 White has a slight but enduring advantage.

12.bxc3 b6 13.♕e2 ♗b7 14.♕e4 g6 15.♗h6 ♖e8 16.♕f4 ♖c8. After 16...♗g7 17.♗xg7 ♔xg7 Black has to reckon with 18.♘g5.

17.♖e3. If 17.♗g5!?, with the idea after 17...♗xg5? 18.♘xg5 ♖c7 of attacking with 19.♕h4 h5 20.g4!, the simplest is 17...♗c7!, parrying the threat of 18.♕h4 by 18...f6 19.♗d2 ♕d7.

17...♗g7! Nothing is given by 17...♘a5 18.♘g5, when 18...♖xc3? fails to 19.♗xg6!

18.♘g5. In the event of 18.♗xg7 ♔xg7 19.♘g5 ♕f6! 20.♕xf6+ ♔xf6 21.♘xh7+ ♔g7 22.♘g5 ♘c7! in return for the pawn Black has strong pressure on the c3-d4 isolated pawn pair (Makarichev).

18...♕f6.



19.♘e4! By allowing the exchange of queens, White neutralises the threats to his isolated pawn pair, which would arise after 19.♕h4 ♗xh6 20.♕xh6 ♕g7 21.♖h3 ♕xh6 22.♖xh6 ♘a5.

19...♕xf4 20.♗xf4 ♖e7 21.♘d6 ♖d8 22.♘xb7 ♖xb7 23.♗e4 ♖c8 24.d5 exd5 25.♗xd5 ♖e7! 26.♖ae1 ♗f6! Black has parried White's slight initiative, and on the 36th move the game ended in a draw.

An important motif in the besieging of an isolated pawn pair may be an attack on the leading pawn at **d4** by c6-c5, which usually again leads to the creation of an isolated pawn for White, but in a worse version than that planned in the opening.

MARIN – GAVRIKOV
Tallinn 1989
Nimzo-Indian Defence E48

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 0-0 5.♗d3 c5 6.♘e2 d5 7.cxd5 cxd4 8.exd4 ♘xd5 9.a3 ♗e7 10.♗c2 ♘c6 11.♕d3 g6 12.h4.



White is planning an assault on the black king's position. It is well known that the best measure against a flank attack is counterplay in the centre. But the immediate 12...e5 13.dxe5 leads to complications favourable for White. For example, the game Knaak – Christiansen, Olympiad, Thessaloniki 1988, continued 13...♘xc3 14.♕xc3 ♗g4 15.f3 ♖c8 16.fxg4 ♘xe5! 17.♕b3 ♗xh4+ 18.g3 ♖xc2 19.♕xc2 ♘d3+ 20.♔f1 ♕d5 21.♘g1! ♖c8 22.♗h6 ♗xg3 23.♖d1 ♕xh1 24.♕xd3, and White parried the attack while retaining a material advantage. Therefore Black first creates a hanging pawn pair.

12...♘xc3! 13.bxc3.



13...e5! Now, in contrast to the above game, 14.dxe5 leads to the exchange of queens. At the same time 14...♗f5 is threatened.

14.♕g3 exd4 15.h5 (White has no choice, other than an attack on the king) **15...♗d6!** (an exchange of pieces eases the defence) **16.♗f4 ♗xf4 17.♘xf4 g5!?** (preventing the opening of the h-file) **18.0-0?!** 18. 0-0-0 was stronger, although here too after 18...♕f6 Black should be able to repel the attack.

18...♔h8 19.h6? White's last chance was 19.♘e2 dxc3 20.♕xc3+ f6 21.♖ad1 ♕e7 22.♘g3, trying to complicate the play (Gavrikov).

19...♕f6 20.♘d5 ♕xh6 21.f4 ♕d6! 22.♘f6? A pointless sacrifice. Objectively stronger was 22.♕xg5 f5 with advantage to Black.

22...♕xf6 23.fxg5 ♕e5 24.♕h4 d3! 25.♖ae1 ♕c5+ 26.♔h1 ♗f5. White resigned.

MOISEENKO – VOLOKITIN

Dagomys 2005

Queen's Gambit D40

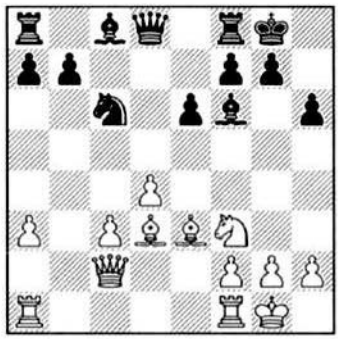
1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 c5 4.e3 cxd4 5.exd4 d5 6.♘c3 ♗b4 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♗d2 0-0 9.♗d3 ♘c6 (the alternative is 9...♘f6) **10.0-0 ♗e7 11.a3 ♗f6 12.♕c2 h6.**



Black has successfully regrouped his forces, and the d4-pawn now needs defending.

13.♗e3. The game Illescas – Dorfman, France 1991, continued 13.♖ad1 ♘xc3 (after 13...♘xd4 14.♘xd4 ♗xd4 15.♘xd5 ♕xd5 16.♗c3 Black is behind in development and White's initiative may become dangerous, for example: 16...e5 17.♗e4 ♕d7 18.♗xd4 cxd4 19.♖d3 ♖e8 20.♖e1) 14.♗xc3 (14.bxc3 c5!) 14...♘e7 15.♕e2 ♗d7 16.♕e4 g6 17.♘e5 ♗a4 18.♖de1 ♝c6 with equal chances. Dorfman also considers the direct attack: 18.d5! ♝xd1 19.dxe6 ♗b3 20.♘xf7 ♖xf7 21.exf7+ ♔xf7 22.♗xf6 ♔xf6 23.♖e1, but after 23...♗d5! 24.♕e5+ ♔f7 25.♕f4+ ♔g7! 26.♕e5+ White has nothing better than to force a draw.

13...♘xe3 14.bxc3.



14...e5! A blow at the leading pawn of the pair.

15.♖ad1 exd4 16.cxd4 ♗g4. White again has an isolated d4-pawn, which needs defending.

17.♗e4 ♖c8 18.♕b1 ♘a5. The game Khairullin – Krivoborodov, Dagomys 2004, continued 18...♕b6 19.h3 ♗xf3?! (19...♕xb1! 20.♖xb1 ♗xf3) 20.♗xf3?! (20.♕xb6! axb6 21.♗xf3) with equal chances, but 19.d5! deserved seriousconsideration, for example: 19...♕xb1 20.♖xb1

♘a5 21.♗xa7 ♖fe8 22.♖fe1 ♘c4 23.h3 ♗xf3 24.gxf3!? (24.♗xf3 ♖xe1+ 25.♖xe1 ♘xa3=) 24...♘d6 25.♗e3 with an extra pawn for White.

19.h3 ♗xf3 20.♗xf3 b6 21.d5 ♕d6 22.♕f5 ♘c4 23.♗c1 ♗b2 24.♗xb2 ♘xb2 25.♖c1. Draw.

Another way of attacking an isolated pawn pair is by undermining its base, the c3-pawn, by b5-b4.

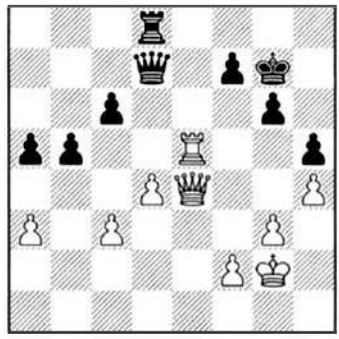
IVANCHUK – BRUZON
Havana 2005
Queen's Gambit D36

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗e7 4.♘f3 ♘f6 5.♗g5 0-0 6.♕c2 ♘bd7 7.cxd5 exd5 8.e3 ♖e8 9.♗d3 ♘f8 10.0-0 c6 11.♖ab1 a5 12.a3 ♗d6 13.♖fe1 ♗g4 14.♘d2 ♗h5 15.♗h4 ♗g6 16.♘f3 ♗xd3 17.♕xd3 ♘8d7 18.e4 dxe4 19.♘xe4 ♗e7 20.♘xf6+ ♗xf6 21.♖xe8+ ♕xe8 22.♖e1 ♕d8 23.♗xf6 ♘xf6 24.g3 g6 25.h4 ♔g7 26.♖e5 h5 27.♕e2 ♘d5 28.♘g5 ♕d7 29.♘e4 b6 30.♘c3.



In this position Black could have attacked the isolated d4-pawn – 30... ♘f6 31.♖c7 (weaker is 31.♕c4 ♖d8 32.♖e1 b5 33.♕c5 ♕xd4 34.♕xc6 ♘g4 35.♕f3 b4 with a dangerous initiative for Black) 31... ♕xd4 32.♕e6 ♖f8 33.♕xc6 ♘g4 34.♕f3 ♕c5, retaining roughly equal chances, but he preferred to attack an isolated pawn pair.

30...♘xc3 31.bxc3 b5 32.♕c4 ♖d8 33.♔g2.

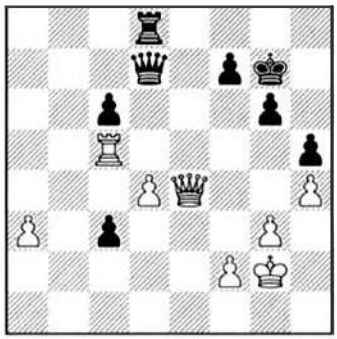


33...b4. One of the effective procedures in attacking an isolated pawn pair. By undermining the c3-pawn Black removes the support of the d4-pawn.

34.♖xa5. Nothing is given by 34.axb4 axb4 35.♖e7 (35.cxb4 ♕xd4 36.♕xd4 ♖xd4 37.b5 ♔f6 38.♖c5 cxb5 39.♖xb5 is too tedious) 35...♕d5! 36.cxb4 ♕xc4+ 37.♖xe4 ♖b8 38.♔f3 ♖xb4 with a simple draw.

34...bxc3 35.♖c5. If 35.♕e5+ Black does not play 35...f6 36.♕e3

c2 37.♖c5 ♕xd4 38.♕e7+, which creates some problems for him, but retreats 35...♔g8, and after 36.♖c5 ♕xd4 37.♕xd4 ♖xd4 38.♖xc3 the resulting position differs from the game only in the position of the king at g8, which does not change its assessment.



35...♕xd4 36.♕xd4+ ♖xd4 37.♖xc3 ♖a4 38.♔f1 c5 39.♔e2 ♔f6 40.♖e3 ♔f5 41.♔d2 f6 (41... c4 is also possible) **42.♖f3+ ♔e5 43.♖e3+ ♔f5 44.♖f3+.** Draw.

4.4. Creation of a central pawn pair

With the white bishop on e3, one of the defensive ideas available to Black is the exchange ♘d5xc3, creating a central pawn pair d4-e3, the leading edge of which can be attacked by e6-e5. But this should have the necessary positional basis and piece support, otherwise it may boomerang.

MIKHALCHISHIN – LALIC
Sarajevo 1985
Queen's Gambit D41

1.d4 ♘f6 2.♘f3 e6 3.c4 c5 4.♘c3 d5 5.cxd5 ♘xd5 6.g3 ♘c6 7.♗g2 ♗e7 8.0-0 ♘f6 9.e3 0-0 10.a3 cxd4 11.exd4 ♕b6 12.♕d3 ♖d8 13.♗e3.



13...♘g4?! A dubious idea. Black is aiming to exchange the bishop, but the opening of the f-file allows White to attack the inadequately defended kingside. 13... ♘d5 was more natural.

14.b4 a6 15.♖ad1 ♘xe3 16.fxe3 ♕a7 17.♔h1 h6. This leads to a weakening of the king's position. 17...♗d7 was sounder, but here too White has attacking chances, for example: 18.♘e4!? ♗e8 (18...h6 19.g4 leads to a position from the game) 19.♘fg5!? h6 20.♘f6+ ♗xf6 21.♕h7+ ♔f8 22.♖xf6 gxf6 (or 22...hxg5 23.♕h8+ ♔e7 24.♕xg7 ♔d7 25.♖xf7+ etc.) 23.♕xh6+

♔e7 24.♘h7 ♔d7 25.♘xf6+ ♔e8 26.d5 ♕b8 (26...♘e5? 27.♖c1+; 26...exd5? 27.♗h3+) 27.♘xe8 ♕e528.d6etc. 18.d5!? ♗e8 19.♕c2 exd5 20.♘xd5 is also possible.

18.♘e4 ♝d7.



19.g4! White attacks a target – the h6-pawn. Doubling rooks on the f-file does not give anything in view of ♗d7-e8.

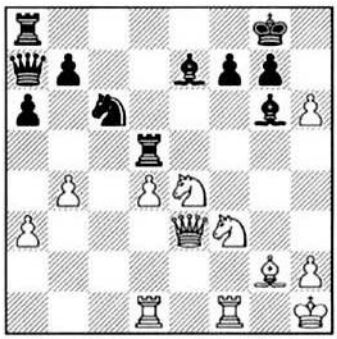
19...e5. Played in accordance with classical recommendations: a counter in the centre is the best reaction to a flank attack. However, it is insufficiently well-supported. If 19...♗e8 there would have followed 20.g5 h5 21.♘g3 g6 22.♘e4, aiming at the weak f6-square.

20.g5 exd4. If 20...♗f5, then 21.d5 is unpleasant.

21.exd4. 21.gxh6 gxh6 22.exd4 is also good, since Black cannot play 21...♗f5? because of 22.♘f6+ ♝xf6 23.♕xf5 ♘e7 (23...dxe3 24.♘g5!) 24.♕e4 dxe3 25.♘e5!

21...♗f5. If 21...hxg5 there follows a mating attack: 22.♘exg5 g6 23.♘xf7! ♔xf7 24.♘g5+ etc.

22.gxh6 ♖d5 (22...g6 23.d5) **23.♕e3 ♗g6.**



24.♘c5! 24.♘c3?! ♖h5 25.hxg7 ♔xg7, allowing the doubling of rooks on the h-file, resembles helpplay.

24...♖ad8 25.hxg7 ♕b8. If 25...♔xg7 there can follow 26.♘d3 with the threat of 27.♘f4, since Black loses a piece after 26...♘xd4 27.♕xe7 ♘xf3 28.♖xf3 ♜xd3 29.♖dxd3 ♖xd3 30.♕f6+ ♔g8 31.♖xd3 ♗xd3 32.♕d8+.

26.♘d3 ♝d6 27.♘h4! ♖h5 28.♘xg6 ♝xh2 (or 28...♖xh2+ 29.♔g1 fxg6 30.♕e6+ ♔h7 31.♝e4) **29.♕f3! ♔xg7 30.♕xh5 fxg6 31.♕xh2 ♖h8 32.♗h3 ♕d8 33.♘f4.** Black resigned.

VYZHMANAVIN – KAIDANOV
Norilsk 1987
Queen's Gambit Accepted D21

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4 3.♘f3 c5 4.e3 cxd4 5.♗xc4 ♕c7 6.♕b3 e6 7.exd4 ♘c6 8.♘c3 a6 9.♕d1 ♞f6 10.0-0 ♗e7 11.♗g5 0-0 12.♕e2.



12...♘g4!? By the threat of diverting the defender of the h-pawn – 13...♘xd4 Black forces the retreat of the bishop to e3.

13.♗e3 b5 14.♗b3 ♗b7. Black plans the exchange on e3, but he does this carelessly. After the preparatory 14...♘a5! 15.♖fc1 ♘xb3 16.axb3 and now 16...♗b7! he would have carried it out in a much better situation. For example: 17.♘d5 ♕d6 18.♘xe7+ ♕xe7 19.♘e5 (after 19.♗f4 ♖ac8 20.♘e5 ♘xe5 21.dxe5 ♕b4 the weakness of the white pawns becomes apparent, the opposite-colour bishops being favourable for Black) 19...♘xe3 20.fxe3 (20.♕xe3 ♕d6) 20...f6 21.♘d3 e5.

15.♖fc1.



15...♘xe3. Black exchanges the bishop, but concedes the initiative to White, who exploits the opposition of rook and queen to occupy the weakened c5-point. After the retreat of the knight – 15...♘f6 Black would have had to reckon with 16.d5.

16.fxe3 ♕b6 17.♘e4 ♘a5?! Black should not have wasted time on the exchange of the bishop. By countering the appearance of the knight at c5 by 17...♖ac8! 18.♘c5 ♘b8!, he would have retained equality.

18.♘c5 ♖fc8 19.♘e5! ♘xb3 20.axb3 ♗xc5. 20...a5, preventing b3-b4, came into consideration. Then nothing is given by 21.♕h5 g6 22.♕h6 ♗xe5 23.♘d7 ♕d8 24.♘xc5 ♕d5, while if White plays as in the game – 21.♘ed7 ♕d6 22.♘xb7 ♕xd7 23.♘c5, then after 23...♕c6 Black gradually prepares e6-e5.

21.♘d7 ♕d6 22.♘xc5 ♗d5 23.b4.



White has firmly established his knight at c5, but Black has his trumps: a strong bishop and the possibility of opening the central files, whereas in the middlegame the weakness of the a6-pawn is not so significant.

23...e5! 24.♖d1 ♖e8 25.♕g4. Kaidanov considers the best to be 25.♕d2 ♕g6 26.dxe5 ♖xe5 27.♘d3 with the threat of ♘f4, but Black parries it by 27...♖xe3! 28.♘f4 ♕b6 29.♕f2 (29.♔h1 ♗b3 30.♖e1 ♖ae8) 29...♗b3 30.♖d3 ♖ae8, retaining his extra pawn.

25...♕h6! 26.e4 ♗c4. Stronger is 26...♕e3+ 27.♔h1 ♗c4 with active counterplay (28...♗e2 is threatened), for example: 28.♖a3 ♕f2 29.♖g3 g6 30.♘d7 ♗c2 31.♕h4 ♕f4. Now, however, White firmly seizes the initiative.

27.♕f3 (27.d5? ♕e3+ 28.♔h1 ♗e2 29.♖e1 ♕xc5!) **27...exd4 28.b3 ♗e6 29.♖xd4 ♕g5.** 29...♖ad8 30.♖xd8 ♖xd8 31.h3 ♗c8 32.♖d1 ♕f6 is more active, although the endgame is advantageous to White.

30.♕g3! ♕f6 31.e5 ♕g6? Black should not have agreed to an obviously inferior endgame. 31...♕e7 32.♘e4 ♕a7 33.♖ed1 ♖ed8 was more logical.

32.♕xg6 hxg6 33.♔f2 ♗c8 34.♖d5! ♖a7 35.♔e3 f6 36.♔d4 ♖ae7 37.♖e1 ♗b7 38.♘xb7 ♖xb7 39.♖d6 ♔f7 40.♔d5! ♖xe5+ 41.♖xe5 fxe5 42.♖xa6, and White won the rook endgame.

When the number of minor pieces is reduced, the creation of a central pawn pair followed by an attack on it with e6-c5 is more justified.

BRAGA – KARPOV
Mar del Plata 1982
Sicilian Defence B22

1.e4 c5 2.c3 d5 3.exd5 ♕xd5 4.d4 e6 5.♘f3 ♘f6 6.♗d3 ♗e7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♕e2 cxd4 9.cxd4 ♘c6 10.♖d1 ♘b4 11.♘c3 ♕d8 12.♗b1 b6 13.♘e5 ♗b7 14.a3 ♘bd5 15.♘e4 ♘e8 16.♕c2 g6 17.♗h6 ♘g7 18.♘c6 ♗xc6 19.♕xc6 ♕c8 20.♕b5 ♖d8 21.♘g3 ♕b7 22.♕e2 ♗h4 23.♗e4 ♕e7 24.♗xg7 ♔xg7 25.♘f1 ♗g5.



The position is roughly equal and, by playing 26.g3 with the idea of h2-h4 and the manoeuvre of his knight to f3, White would have maintained equality. But he preferred to attack the knight.

26.♘e3?! ♘xe3! After this exchange the resulting pawn on e3 is a target for the bishop to attack. It should be noted that the opposite-colour bishops favour Black, who has the more active bishop, supported by the major pieces.

27.fxe3 ♖ac8 28.♗d3 (not 28.♖ac1 in view of 28...♖xc1 29.♖xc1 ♖xd4) **28...♖c7 29.♗b5.**

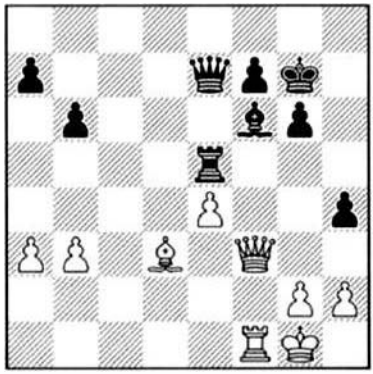


29...e5! This attack is the justification for the exchange on e3.

30.dxe5. White is forced to accept a weak pawn on e3, since 30.d5? ♕c5 leads to the loss of a pawn.

30...♖xd1+ 31.♖xd1 ♖c5 32.e4 ♖xe5 33.♗d3 h5. The advance of the h-pawn enables the pressure on the kingside to be intensified. Black's plan includes creating a second weakness, since the single weakness on e4 is insufficient for him to convert his positional advantage.

34.♕f3 h4 35.♖f1 ♗f6 36.b3.



36...b5! Taking away the c4-square from the light-square bishop. If immediately 36...♖e5?!, then 37.♗c4 and the bishop goes to d5, after which the position is almost equal.

37.♔h1 ♖c5 38.♕e2 ♖e5 39.♕f3 a5 40.a4 bxa4 41.bxa4 ♖c5 42.♗h5 ♖c3 43.♕f4 h3. Black has carried out his plan – a second weakness on h2 has been created.

44.♖f3 hxg2+ 45.♔xg2 ♗e5 46.♕g4 ♖c2+ 47.♖f2 ♖xf2+ 48.♔xf2 ♟xh2 49.♔g2 ♗e5. After winning a pawn Black launches an attack on the king.

50.♗c6 ♕c5 51.♗b5 ♗d4 52.♕f4 ♕c2+ 53.♔h3 ♗f6 54.♔g3 ♕b2 55.♔f3 ♗d4 56.♕g3 ♕d2 57.♔g4 ♕d1+ 58.♕f3 ♕g1+ 59.♕g3 ♕h1 60.♕f3 ♕h2 61.♕d1. White resigned.

PART II

THE ISOLATED D5-PAWN

All the features relating to the isolated d4-pawn for White also extend to the isolated d5-pawn for Black, only on a somewhat reduced scale. Since the advantage of the first move is of importance, a topic such as an attack by Black on the kingside rarely occurs – it is more real to talk about the initiative. Therefore in his choice of strategy with the d5-pawn Black hopes to exploit its dynamic properties to create active piece play, using its control of the c4- and c4-points, as well as its desire to make the d5-d4 breakthrough. As for White's strategy, it is aimed at exploiting the static weakness of the isolated d5-pawn, which is expressed in a striving for the endgame, where its weakness is especially perceptible.

In view of the more restricted opportunities for exploiting the dynamic features of the isolated d5-pawn, modern theory also contains a restricted field of opening variations, where Black goes in for such a pawn. The main openings where positions with an isolated d5-pawn arise are associated with the name of Siegbert Tarrasch, who asserted that the central pawn was good for an attack. In his opinion, 'The purposeful use of space, i.e. the purposeful arrangement of your forces – is the most important thing throughout the game', and he implemented it in opening such as 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 c5 or 1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 ♙5, leading to the creation of an isolated d5-pawn.

Here are a number of typical positions, arising in these popular openings.

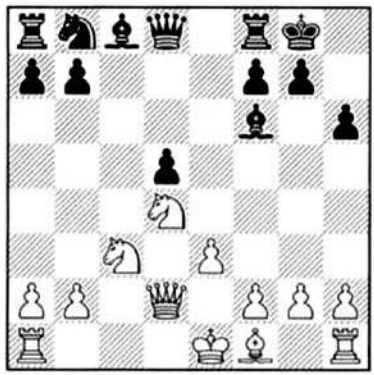
Queen's Gambit, Tarrasch Defence Deferred

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 c5 4.e3 ♘c6 5.♘f3 ♘f6 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♗e2 ♗e7 8.dxc5 ♗xc5.



Queen's Gambit

1.d4 d5 2. 3.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♗g5 ♗c7 5.e3 0-0 6.♘f3 h6 7.♗xf6 ♗xf6 8.♕d2 c5 9.cxd5 cxd4 10.♘xd4 cxd5.



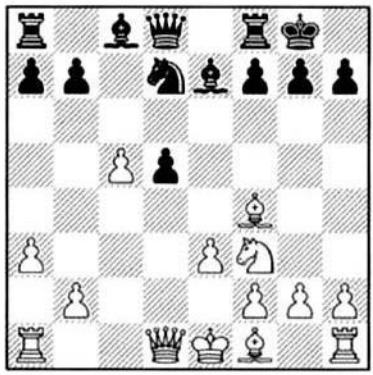
Queen's Gambit, Tarrasch Defence

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 c5 4.cxd5 cxd5 5.g3 ♘f6 6.♗g2 ♗e7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♘c3 ♘c6 9.♗g5 cxd4 10.♘xd4.



Queen's Gambit

1.d4 d5 2. 3.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♘f3 ♗e7 5.♗f4 0-0 6.e3 ♘bd7 7.a3 c5 8.cxd5 ♘xd5 9.♘xd5 exd5 10.dxc5.



Nimzo-Indian Defence

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.♕c2 d5 5.a3 ♗xc3+ 6.♕xc3 ♘c4 7.♕c2 c5 8.dxc5 ♘c6 9.cxd5 exd5.



French Defence, Tarrasch Variation

1.c4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘gf3 ♘c6 6.♗b5 ♗d6 7.dxc5 ♗.xc5.



French Defence, Tarrasch Variation

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘gf3 ♘f6 6.♗b5+ .♗d7 7.♗xd7+ ♘bxd7 8.0-0 .♗c7 9.dxc5.



Chapter 5

Attack on the isolated d5-pawn

From White's point of view the isolated d5-pawn is regarded as a target. Therefore we consider it advisable to continue the study of this topic, which was examined in Part I with regard to the d4-pawn.

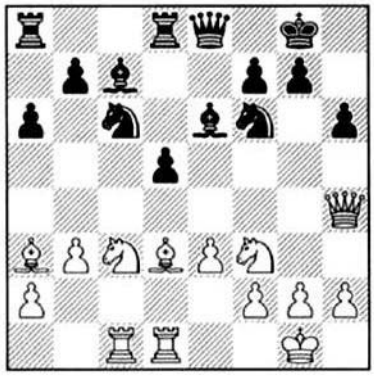
In this chapter we examine plans for carrying out the most expedient arrangement of the forces and the specific positional procedures for an attack by White on the isolated d5-pawn. These are firm control of the d4 blockading square, and exchanges of minor pieces, in particular of Black's dark-square bishop, to weaken his control of the adjacent e5- and c5-squares. Also in White's arsenal is the exchange of his d4-knight on c6 to create an isolated pawn pair, or on e6 to create a central pawn pair.

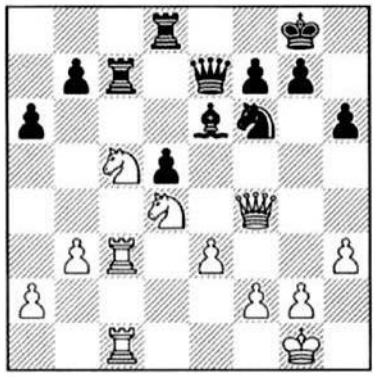
5.1. The strategy of exchanging pieces

Since Black's basic plan is to exploit the dynamic qualities of the isolated d5-pawn, is expressed in a striving for the initiative in the centre and on the kingside, White's basic objective is to exchange the pieces supporting this pawn, which will transform it into a target. In carrying out this strategy, control of the d4 blockading square is important. In order to assess more deeply the consequences of exchanging pieces, we will examine a classical example on the theme of exploiting the weakening of the dark-square periphery around the d5-pawn.

RUBINSTEIN – TEICHMANN
Teplitz-Schönau 1922
Nimzo-Indian Defence E22

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.♕b3 c5 5.dxc5 ♗xc5 6.♘f3 0-0 7.e3 d5 8.cxd5 exd5 9.♗e2 ♗b6 10.0-0 ♗e6 11.♖d1 ♕c7 12.♕a4 ♘c6 13.b3 ♖fd8 14.♗a3 ♕e8 15.♕h4 ♗c7 16.♖ac1 a6 17.♗d3 h6.





18.♘a4! A knight manoeuvre typical for the structure with an isolated pawn, which was introduced by Akiba Rubinstein. Apart from 19.♘c5, Black also has to reckon with 19.♗b2 with the threat of breaking up his kingside pawns. This forces him to exchange the dark-square bishops.

18...♗d6 19.♗xd6 ♖xd6 20.♘c5 ♕e7 21.♘d4! After the exchange of the dark-square bishops White occupies the important dark squares c5 and d4 with his knights, whereas it is difficult for Black to do anything active.

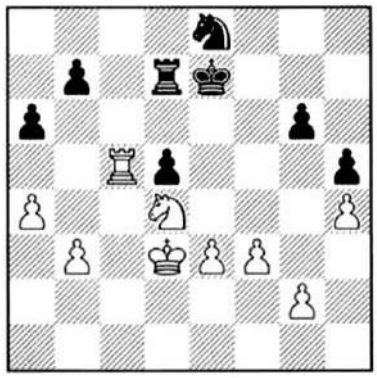
21...♘e5 22.♕f4! It is advantageous for White to exchange minor pieces, with the prospect of reaching an endgame with a knight on d4 against a passive bishop on e6.

22...♘xd3 23.♖xd3 ♖c8 24.♖dc3 ♖dd8 25.♕e5 ♘g4 26.♕f4 ♘f6 27.h3! ♖c7? A mistake, but it was difficult for Black to parry the threat of 28.♘dxe6 fxe6 29.♕e5.

28.♕xc7! ♕xc7 29.♘cxe6 ♕xc3. Black is forced to return the queen, since he loses after 29...♕b6 30.♘xd8 ♕xd8 31.♖c8.

30.♖xc3 fxe6 31.♘xe6 ♖d7 32.f3 ♔f7 33.♘d4 g6 34.♔f2. As a result of the exchanging operation White has won a pawn. The technique for converting it is highly instructive: first White improves the placing of his pieces, and then he exploits his pawn majority on the kingside.

34...♔e7 35.♖c8 ♘e8 36.♔e2 ♔f7 37.♔d3 ♘d6 38.♖c5 ♘e8 39.a4 ♔e7 40.h4 h5.



41.♘e2! The knight is transferred to f4, from where it will be able to attack the d5- and g6-pawns.

41...♘c7 42.♘f4 ♔d6 43.♖c1 ♖g7 44.g4 hxg4 45.fxg4 a5. If 45...g5 there would have followed 46.hxg5 ♖xg5 47.♖xc7! ♔xc7 48.♘e6+ and 49.♘xc7.

46.♖h1 g5 47.hxg5 ♖xg5 48.♖h6+ ♔e5 49.♘g6+ ♔f6 50.♘f8+ ♔f7 51.♖h7+ ♖g7 52.♖xg7+ ♔xg7 53.♘d7 ♘a6 54.♔d4 ♘b4 55.♘c5 b6 56.♘d7 ♘c2+ 57.♔d3 ♘b4+ 58.♔c3 ♔g6 59.♘xb6 ♔g5 60.♔d4 ♘c2+ 61.♔xd5 ♘xe3+ 62.♔c5 ♘xg4 63.♘c4. Black resigned.

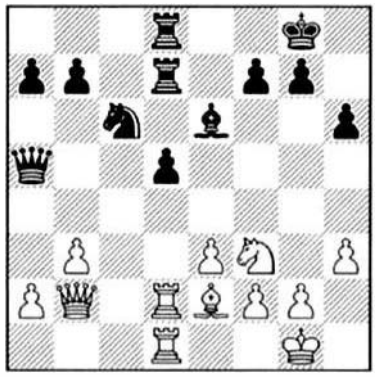
BOTVINNIK – ZAGORYANSKY
Sverdlovsk 1943
English Opening A13

1.♘f3 d5 2.c4 e6 3.b3 ♘f6 4.♗b2 ♗e7 5.e3 0-0 6.♘c3 c5 7.cxd5 ♘xd5. In the given specific situation 7...e□d5 was more flexible, retaining the option of obtaining more dynamic hanging pawns on d5 and c5. It is also useful to retain the knight when transposing into a position with an isolated d5-pawn.

8.♘xd5 exd5 9.d4. A typical procedure, forcing Black to make a choice between an isolated d-pawn and hanging pawns at c5 and d5.

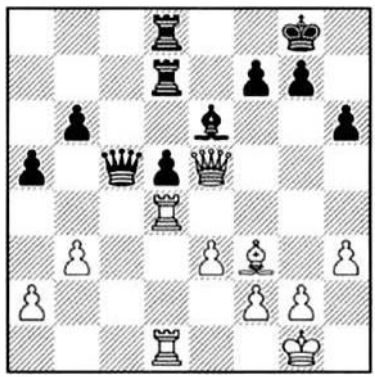
9...cxd4 10.♕xd4! An important moment. From a position of strength White forces the exchange of the dark-square bishops, significantly reducing the dynamic potential of the isolated d5-pawn.

10...♗f6 11.♕d2 ♘c6 12.♗e2 ♗e6 13.0-0 ♗xb2 14.♕xb2 ♕a5 15.♖fd1 ♖ad8 16.♖d2 ♖d7 17.♖ad1 ♖fd8 18.h3 h6.



19.♘e5! After the exchange of knights White gains complete control of the d4-square, his queen's sphere of activity is expanded, and his bishop obtains an excellent post at f3 for an attack on the d5-pawn.

19...♘xe5 20.♕xe5 ♕c5 21.♗f3 (threatening 22.e4) **21...b6 22.♕b2 ♖c8 23.♕e5 ♖cd8 24.♖d4! a5.**



25.g4! White has completely tied the black pieces to the defence of the d5-pawn and, exploiting the fact that the king is inadequately defended, he begins an attack on the kingside, since it will be difficult for Black to defend simultaneously his king and the d5-pawn. A typical positional procedure, by the creation of a second weakness to facilitate the attack on the first one!

25...♕c6 26.g5 hxg5 27.♕xg5 f6 (parrying the threat of ♖h4 and ♕h5) **28.♕g6 ♗f7 29.♕g3 f5?!** This weakening of the king's defences was not directly necessary, although it would not have been easy for Black to parry the attack on the g-file after the switching of the d1-rook to g1.

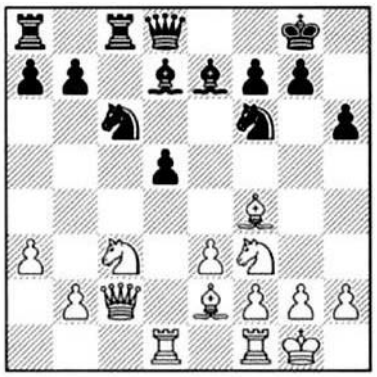
30.♕g5 ♕e6 31.♔h1 ♕e5 32.♖g1 ♖f8 33.♕h6 ♖b8. If 33... g6, then 34.h4 followed by h4-h5-h6 is decisive.

34.♖h4 ♔f8 35.♕h8+ ♗g8 36.♖f4 ♖bb7 37.♖g5 ♖f7 38.♕h5 ♕a1+ 39.♔g2 g6 40.♕xg6 ♗h7 41.♕d6+ ♖fe7 42.♕d8+. Black resigned.

Examples of the mechanism of exchanging minor pieces are to be found in the play of Anatoly Karpov, an expert at attacking the isolated pawn. The following game on the theme of exchanging operations resembles his famous 9th game with Korchnoi from the World Championship Match in Merano 1981 (Part I).

KARPOV – SPASSKY
Montreal 1979
Queen's Gambit D37

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 d5 4.♘c3 ♗e7 5.♗f4 0-0 6.e3 c5 7.dxc5 ♘c6 8.♕c2 ♕a5 9.a3 ♗xc5 10.♖d1 ♗e7 11.♘d2 ♗d7 12..♗e2 ♖fc8 13.0-0 ♕d8 14.cxd5 exd5 15.♘f3 h6.



A superficial impression of this position suggests that it is dynamically balanced, since after 16...♗e6 Black consolidates his forces, although it is not easy for him to exploit the dynamic potential of his isolated d5-pawn. Nevertheless, Black has problems. In this respect the assessment of the position given by Karpov is instructive: 'White's plans include the exchange of at least one pair of knights. In this case it is much easier to keep control of

d4. In addition, the vacated post at f3 can immediately be occupied by the bishop, which will exert strong pressure on the d5-pawn. In principle, this is a typical procedure in this type of position. The only distinguishing feature is that these exchanging operations are usually carried out via the d4-point.'

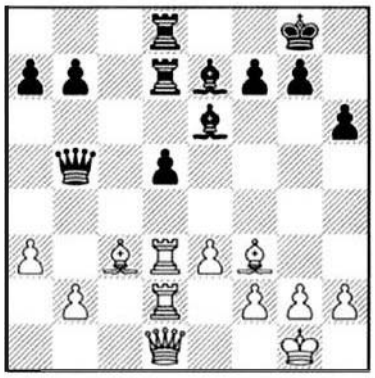
16.♘e5! ♗e6. If 16...♕e8 there could have followed 17.♘xd7! ♕xd7 18.♗f3.

17.♘xc6! ♖xc6 (17...bxc6? 18.♗a6 leads to the loss of the exchange) **18.♗f3 ♕b6 19.♗e5!** Here Karpov makes another valuable comment: 'White's advantage is, of course, considerable, but it is not at all easy to increase it. For the moment he provokes the exchange of the last pair of knights. After all, it is for the long-range bishops and heavy pieces that an isolated pawn is the most convenient target.'

19...♘e4 20.♕e2! The blockading attempt 20.♗d4 leads after 20...♗c5 21.♗xc5 ♖xc5 22.♗xe4 dxe4 to the elimination of the isolated pawn, since 23.♕xe4 ♕xb2 24.♘a4 ♖c5 25.♕f4 ♕b5 is not dangerous for Black (variation by Karpov).

20...♘xc3 21.♗xc3 ♖d8 (21...♗xa3 22.♗xg7!) **22.♖d3! ♖cd6 23.♖fd1 ♖6d7 24.♖1d2.** White carries out a frontal attack on the d5-pawn, arranging his heavy pieces as recommended in such positions by Alekhine – the queen behind the rooks.

24...♕b5 25.♕d1.



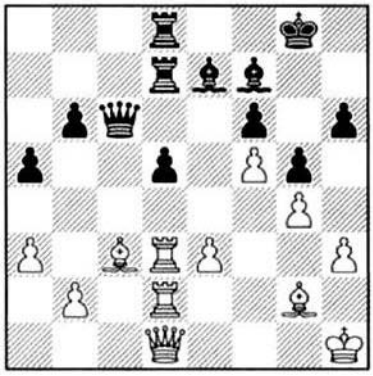
The first part of the plan has been carried out. White has tied Black down to the defence of the d5-pawn and next he wants to prepare an attack on it with c3-c4. However, for the moment this is not possible, since the black pieces are well coordinated. To disrupt their coordination White plans an advance of his kingside pawns, but first he improves the placing of his forces.

25...b6 26.g3 ♗f8 27.♗g2 ♗c7 28.♕h5! (threatening 29.e4) **28...a6 29.h3 ♕c6 30.♔h2 ♕b5 31.f4! f6.** 31...f5 was bad: 32.♕g6 ♗f8 33.♗e5 with the threat of g3-g4.

32.♕d1 ♕c6. Karpov thinks that 32...♖d6 was more tenacious, after which 33.e4 is possible.

33.g4 g5.34...♗d6 35.♔h1 ♗c7 was essential, preventing the advance of the white pawns.

34.♔h1 a5 35.f5 ♗f7.



36.e4! After the defender of the rook on d7 has been removed, White lands this crowning blow, winning a pawn.

36...♔g7 37.cxd5 ♕c7 38.♖c2 b5 39.♖xc7 ♖xc7 40.d6 ♕c4 41.b3. Black resigned.

The technique of besieging the isolated pawn, demonstrated by Karpov, is impressive. As a product of the Soviet chess school, he was undoubtedly helped by his knowledge of the classical heritage. We will now examine a modern example.

RUSTEMOV – V. FILIPPOV
Minsk 1996
Queen's Gambit D45

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.c3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 c6 5.♘f3 ♘bd7 6.♕c2 ♗d6 7.b3 0-0 8.♗e2 c5 9.cxd5 ♘xd5 10.♘xd5 cxd5 11.dxe5 ♘xe5 12.♗b2 ♘xf3+ 13.♗xf3 ♗b4+ 14.♔f1! The exchange of the dark-square bishops, which is usually useful against an isolated d5-pawn, is premature for the moment, since it allows Black to get rid of this pawn: 14.♗c3 ♕f6! 15.♖e1 ♗f5 16.♕d2 ♗xc3 17.♖xc3 ♗e4 18.♗xe4 dxe4. If 14.♔e2, then 14...b6 15.♕d3 a5 is possible, but now if 14...b6 there follows 15.♕d3 a5 16.♕d4!

14...♗c6 15.♕d3 ♗c7.



16.♔e2! The position has stabilised and, by making way for his rook, White prepares a frontal attack on the d5-pawn.

16...♕d7. Black has no real counterplay. The active 16...♗f6 17.♗d4 ♗xd4 18.♕xd4 leads to simplification advantageous to White.

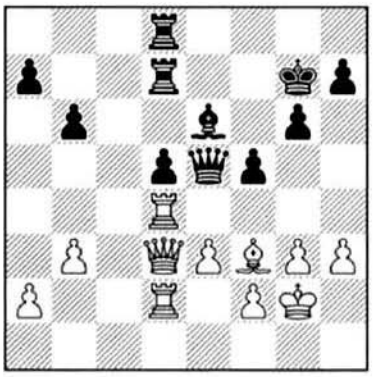
17.♖hd1 ♖fd8 18.♔f1 ♖ac8 19.♔g1. White is in no hurry – having nothing to fear, he has castled artificially.

19...b6 20.♖d2 f6 21.♕c2 ♗b4 22.♖d4 ♗d6 23.♖ad1 ♗c5. This voluntary exchange of the dark-square bishops plays into White's hands. 23...♕f7 came into consideration,

with the idea of 24.♕d2 ♗e5 25.♖d3 ♖d7 (25...♖c5!? 26.♗d4 ♖c7) 26.h3 ♖cd8. Unclear play results from 24.e4 ♖e8 (24...dxe4? 25.♖xd6) 25.♕d3!? (25.exd5 ♗f5 26.♕f1 ♖e2) 25...♗e5 26.exd5 ♗d7 27.♖h4 ♗xb2 28.♕xh7+ ♔f8 29.♕b1 ♗e5 30.♗h5 ♕g8 31.♗xe8 ♖xe8.

24.♖4d2 ♗xb2 25.♖xb2 ♕c7 26.♖bd2 ♕e5 27.♕a6 ♖c7 28.h3 f5. Black excludes one of the potential motifs of a frontal attack – e3-e4.

29.♖d4 ♖cd7 30.♕d3 g6 31.g3 ♔g7 32.♔g2 ♔f6 33.♖d2 ♔g7.



34.b4. Black has defended his d5-pawn and to convert his advantage White needs to create a second weakness in Black's position. Therefore he launches an attack on the queenside.

34...♔f6 35.♕b3 ♔g7 36.♕d1 ♔f6 37.♖2d3 ♔g7 38.♕d2 ♔f6 39.♔h2 ♔g7 40.♗g2 ♔f7 41.a4 ♔f6 42.b5 ♔f7 43.♖c3 ♕b8 44.♕c1 ♕e5 45.♗f3 ♔g7 46.♔g2 ♔f7 47.♗d1! After lengthy manoeuvring White switches his bishop onto the a2-g8 diagonal, from where it puts the black king under an 'X-ray' attack.

47...♕b8 48.♗b3 ♔e7 49.♖c6 ♖d6 50.♖c7+ ♖6d7 51.♖c3 ♔f7 52.♔g1 ♕e5 53.♕d2 ♕b8 54.♖c6 ♖d6 55.♖c3 ♖6d7 56.♔h2 ♕b7 57.♖cd3 ♖d6.



58.f3! White includes the final resource of the frontal attack – e3-e4.

58...♔e7. After 58...♖6d7 59.c4 the pin on the bishop proves decisive.

59.e4 ♕c7 60.♖c3 ♕b7 61.e5 ♖6d7 62.♖c6 ♗g8 63.♕g5+ ♔e8 64.♕f6 ♖f7 65.♖e6+ ♖e7 66.♕h8 ♔f8 67.♖c6 ♖g7 68.♖xd5 ♖xd5 69.♗xd5 ♕d7 70.♖f6+. Black resigned.

When carrying out a plan combining a frontal attack by heavy pieces on the d5-pawn with threats to the king, control of the long a1-h8 diagonal also enables strategic

objectives involving exchanging operations to be implemented. In this case White should normally aim for the exchange of the dark-square bishop controlling the squares adjacent to the d5-pawn, which, above all, enables him to establish control of the d4 blockading point.

PINTER – PODZIELNY
Bad Wörishofen 1986
Queen's Gambit D32

1.♘f3 c5 2.c4 ♘f6 3.♘c3 c6 4.e3 d5 5.d4 a6 6.cxd5 cxd5 7.♗c2 ♘c6 8.0-0 ♗d6 9.dxc5 ♗xc5 10.b3 0-0 11.♗b2 ♖e8 12.♖c1 ♗a7.



13.♖c2! The routine 13.♘a4 ♘e4 leads to unclear play, and so White carries out the plan of a frontal attack along the d-file combined with threats to the king along the a1-h8 diagonal.

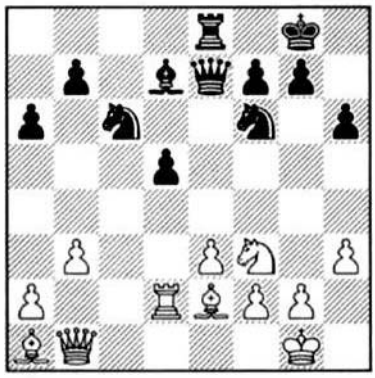
13...♗e6 14.♖d2 ♕c7 15.♕b1! The queen takes control of the important squares e4 and f5, vacating the d1-square for the second rook.

15...♖ad8 16.♖fd1 h6 17.♗a1. White vacates the b2-square for his queen, in order for the queen + bishop battery to set up an 'X-ray' attack on the g7-square (the threat of ♘c3xd5).

17...♗c5 (preventing 18.♕b2 by the threat of 18...♗a3) **18.h3 ♖d7 19.♘a4 ♗b4?** Black persists in trying to counter the threats along the a1-h8 diagonal, which allows White to carry out advantageous piece exchanges. He should have retreated his bishop, without lifting its control of the d4-point – 19....♗a7, when 20.♕b2 can be parried by 20...d4 21.cxd4 ♗d5! 22.♘c5, and if he did not like 22...♗xc5 23.dxc5 ♕xc5 24.♘h4 with the idea of ♘h4-f5-e3, then he could consider 22...♖c7 23.b4 ♘h5 24.♘d3 ♕e4 with active counterplay for the pawn.

20.♘b6! ♗**xd2.** After 20... ♖dd8 21.♗xf6 ♕xf6 22.♘xd5 a pawn is lost.

21.♘xd7 ♗xd7 22.♖xd2.



As a result of his knight manoeuvre White has exchanged it for the dark-square bishop, which has deprived the isolated pawn of any dynamic potential.

22...d4? Black is not satisfied with the passive defence 22...♗e6, but in sacrificing the pawn he did not take into account an intermediate move by White.

23.♘xd4 ♘e4 24.♘xc6 ♗xc6 25.♕b2! (an important interposition!) **25...f5?** Missing an opportunity for counterplay by 25...♕g5! 25.h4 ♕g6.

26.♖d4 ♘g5 27.♗c4+ ♔h8 28.♗d5 f4 29.♗xc6 fxe3 30.♗xe8! e2 31.♖e4! Black resigned. If 31...♘xe4 a familiar technique proves decisive: 32.♕xc2 ♕xe8 33.f3 ♘f6 34.♕xe8+ ♘xe8 35.♗c5! The bishop restricts the knight's mobility and the endgame is hopeless for Black.

IVANCHUK – RIAZANTSEV

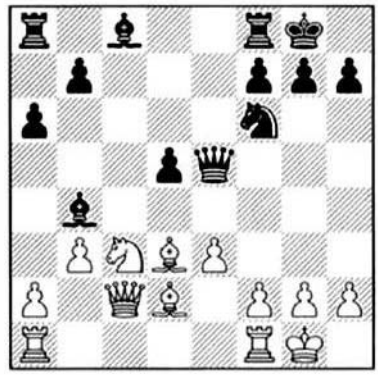
Moscow 2005

Queen's Gambit D45

1.♘f3 d5 2.c4 c6 3.e3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 e6 5.d4 a6 6.b3 ♗b4 7.♗d2 ♘bd7 8.♗d3 0-0 9.0-0 ♕e7 10.♕c2 e5 11.dxe5 ♘xe5 12.♘xe5 ♕xe5 13.cxd5 cxd5.

(See diagram)

14.♘e2! White aims for the exchange of the dark-square bishops, without losing control of d4.

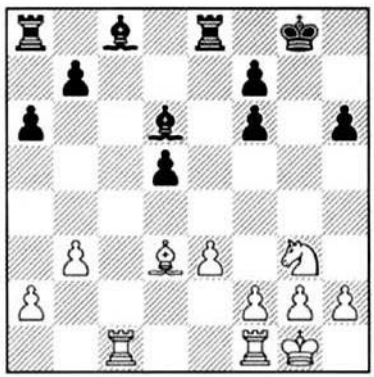


14...♗d6 15.♘g3 ♕e7. 15...♕g5!? looks more active, intending to answer 16.♗c3 with 16...♘g4! 17.♗xh7+ ♔h8 18.♗d3 (18.♗f5? ♘xh2!) 18...♕h4 19.h3 ♘xe3 20.fxe3 ♕xg3 21.♕e2 ♕h2+ 22.♔f2 ♕g3+, forcing a draw by perpetual check.

16.♗c3 h6. The defence of the h7-pawn by 16...♗e5 17.♗xe5 ♕xe5 is tantamount to acknowledging the triumph of White's strategy. After 18.♖ac1 the invasion ♕c7 is threatened.

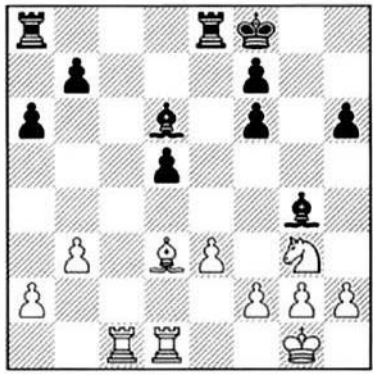
17.♕b2! ♖e8. If Black tries to maintain his pawn structure by retreating his knight – 17...♘e8 he has to reckon with threats along the long diagonal. Forexample: 18.♖ad1 ♗g4 19.♘f5 ♗xf5 20.♗xf5 ♖d8 21.♗d4 ♗a3 22.♕a1 etc. The counterattacking attempt 19...♕g5 also involves a definite risk: 20.f4 ♕h5 21.♘xd6! ♗xd1 (or 21...♘xd6 22.♖d2 f6 23.h3) 22.♘f5 ♗g4 23.♘xg7!

18.♗xf6 ♕xf6 19.♕xf6 gxf6 20.♖ac1.



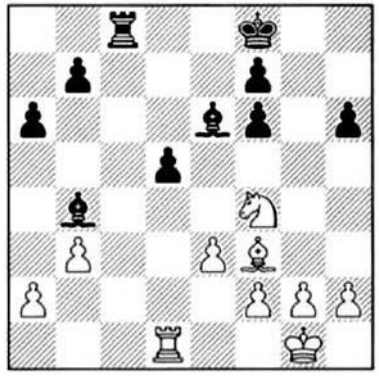
20...♔f8?! The existence of doubled pawns creates problems for Black in endings with various combinations of pieces, requiring him to play with particular accuracy. The d5-pawn could have been defended by 20...♗xg3 21.hxg3 ♗e6 22.♖c7 b5 23.♖fc1 ♖cc8, or by relying on the drawing tendencies of opposite-colour bishops: 20...♗e6 21.♘f5 ♗xf5 22.♗xf5 ♖e5 23.♗g4 (or 23.♖e8+ ♖xc8 24.♗xc8 ♖c7 25.♖d1 ♖c7) 23...♖d8 24.♗f3. However, in both cases White would retain a serious advantage.

21.♖fd1 ♝g4? A loss of time. This move merely assists White's plan of attacking the d5-pawn by playing his bishop to f3 (the exchange of the light-square bishops is unfavourable for Black) and his knight to f4. 21...♗xg3 22.hxg3 ♗e6 23.♖e7 ♖c7 was more logical, although here too White retains practical chances. For example: 24.♖c3 ♖ec8 (24...♖c8 25.♖xc8+ ♗xc8 26.♖c1 ♗e6 27.♔f1) 25.♖dc1 ♖ad8 26.♖c7 d4 27.c4 ♖e8 28.♔f1 b5 29.f4.



22.♗e2 ♗e6 23.♗f3 ♖ac8 24.♘e2 ♗a3? The exchange of a pair of rooks was in Black's interests – 24...♖xc1 25.♖xc1 ♗e5! 26.♖d1 ♖e8. This 'nudging' of White leads to the loss of a pawn.

25.♖c3! ♝b4 26.♖xc8 ♖xc8 27.♘f4. White has carried out his plan. The d5-pawn cannot be defended.



27...♖c2 28.♗xd5 ♝g4 29.f3 ♝e5 30.♖e1 ♗c8 31.♔f1 ♗a3

32.♖e2 ♖c1+ 33.♔f2 b6 34.♗e4 ♗d7 35.♖d2 f5 36.♖xd7 fxe4 37.♖d2 ♗b4 38.♖e2 exf3 39.gxf3 b5? A time-trouble oversight. After 39...♗d6 White would still have had to work hard to convert his extra pawn.

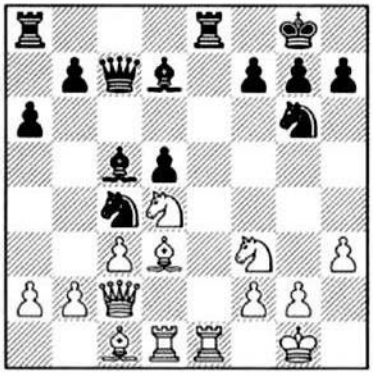
40.♘d3. Black resigned.

MATULOVIC – BALASHOV

Teslic 1979

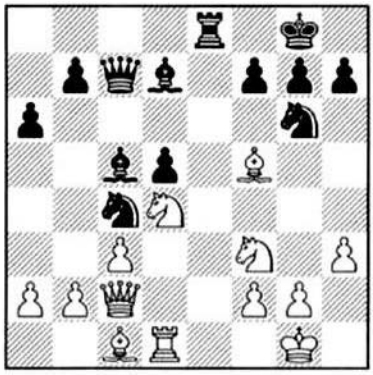
French Defence C09

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.♘gf3 ♘c6 5.exd5 exd5 6.♗b5 ♗d6 7. 0-0 ♘ge7 8.dxc5 ♗xc5 9.♘b3 ♗d6 10.♘bd4 0-0 11.♗e3 ♕c7 12.h3 a6 13.♗d3 ♘g6 14.♖e1 ♖e8 15.c3 ♗d7 16.♕c2 ♘a5 17.♖ad1 ♘c4 18.♗c1 ♗c5.



19.♗f5! The exchange of the light-square bishops is advantageous to White, since the d5-pawn becomes more vulnerable.

19...♖xe1+ 20.♖xe1 ♖e8 21.♖d1! An important moment. White avoids the seemingly advantageous simplification of the position. However, for a frontal attack on the d5-pawn to be effective there have to be at least two heavy pieces.



21...♗xd4. The voluntary exchange of the dark-square bishop may be considered a strategic mistake. 21...♗xf5 22.♘xf5 ♘ce5! was more logical, although after the bishop goes to e3 it is not easy to defend the d5-pawn. For example: 23.♘xe5 ♕xe5 24.♗e3 ♗f8 (of course, 24...♗xe3 25.♘xe3 favours White) 25.a4 ♘f4 26.♘g3 with the threat of ♗xf4, or 22...♕d7 23.b3 ♘ce5 24.♘xe5 ♖xe5 25.♗e3 ♗f8 26.♘g3 followed by ♕d3.

22.♘xd4 ♗xf5 23.♘xf5 ♘f4 24.b3 ♘b6 25.♗e3! The absolute control of the dark squares makes it impossible to defend the d5-pawn: both ♕d2 and g3 are threatened. Black's attempt to complicate the play merely hastens his defeat.

25...♕xc3 26.♕xc3 ♘e2+ 27.♔h2 ♘xc3 28.♖d3 d4 29.♗xd4 ♘cd5 30.♘xg7 ♖e2 31.♘f5 h5 32.♗xb6! ♘xb6 33.♖d6, and White won.

5.2. Exchange of the dark-square bishop in French Defence positions

In the French Defence 1.c4 c6 2.d4 d5 with 3.♘d2 one has to be prepared for play against an isolated d5-pawn, if Black chooses the Tarrasch variation 3...c5. In the resulting positions a significant role is played by Black's dark-square bishop, which supports his initiative on the kingside and in some cases the d5-d4 advance. Therefore, in order to neutralise the dynamic potential of the isolated d5-pawn, White should aim for the exchange of this bishop. We will examine some typical methods.

KARPOV – G.KUZMIN
Interzonal Tournament,
Leningrad 1973
French Defence C09

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘gf3 ♘c6 6.♗b5 ♗d6 7.dxc5 ♗xc5 8.0-0 ♘ge7 9.♘b3 ♗d6 10.♗g5 0-0 11.♗h4 ♕c7.



12.♗g3! A typical way of exchanging the dark-square bishops, which weakens the c5- and e5-squares adjacent to the d5-pawn and strengthens White's control of the d4 blockading point.

12...♗xg3. Black shouldn't have hurried with this exchange; 12...♗g4!? was better.

13.hxg3 ♗g4 14.♖e1 ♖ad8 15.c3 ♕b6 16.♗d3 (threatening 17.♗xh7+ ♔xh7 18.♘g5+) **16... ♘g6 17.♕c2 ♗xf3.** The exchange of this bishop is forced, as otherwise White will gain firm possession of the d4-point.

18.gxf3 ♖d6. Black's counterplay is associated with d5-d4. However, the immediate 18...d4 did not satisfy him because of 19.f4!, after which the knight at g6 is restricted by the f4- and g3-pawns and is unable to exert any serious influence on events. All he can console himself with is 19...dxc3 20.bxc3, after which the manoeuvrability of the second knight is also restricted by

the c3-pawn. But perhaps Black no longer had any other choice? Now White denies him the last chance of activity in the centre.

19.f4 ♖fd8 20.a3! h5 (if 20... d4 there follows 21.c4) **21.♔g2.** White's plan includes playing his knight to f3 and doubling rooks on the e-file.

21...h4 22.♖e2 ♘f8 23.♘d2 ♖h6 24.♘f3 hxg3. The opening of the game favours White, since he holds the initiative, but after 24... h3+ 25.♔h2 the pawn would be cut off from the remaining black forces and would become easy booty.

25.fxg3 ♘d7 26.♖ae1 ♔f8.



27.g4! White launches a decisive offensive on the kingside, exploiting the lack of harmony in the placing of the black pieces.

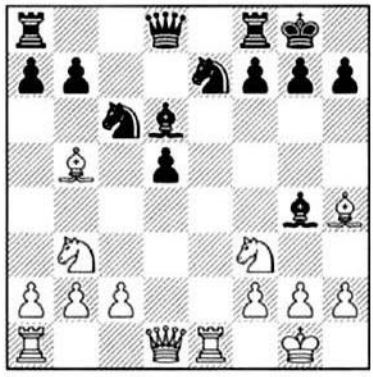
27...♕c7 28.g5 ♖h8 29.♔g3! The king supports the advance of its own pawns!

29...♘c5 30.♗f5 g6 31.b4 ♘c4+. Both 31...gxf5 32.bxc5 ♕d7 33.♖h2 ♔g7 34.♘h4 and 31...♘d7 32.♗xg6 fxg6 33.♕xg6 are bad for Black.

32.♗xc4 dxc4 33.♕xe4 ♔g7 34.b5 ♘a5 35.♕e7! ♕xe7 36.♖xe7 ♖d3 37.♖c7 ♘b3 38.♔g4 ♖f8 39.♖ec7. Black resigned.

BALASHOV – LPUTIAN
52nd USSR Championship,
Riga 1985
French Defence C09

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.♘gf3 ♘c6 5.exd5 exd5 6.♗b5 ♗d6 7.dxc5 ♗xc5 8.0-0 ♘c7 9.♘b3 ♗d6 10.♖e1 0-0 11.♗g5 ♗g4 12.♗h4 h6.

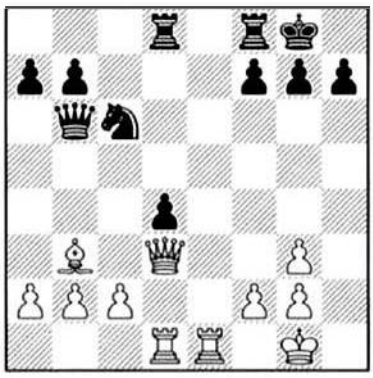


13.♗g3! An exchanging manoeuvre typical of the given position.

13...♗xg3 14.hxg3 ♘f5 15.♕d3 (with the threat of 16.♗xc6 bxc6 17.♘e5) **15...♗xf3 16.♕xf3** (16.gxf3, intending f3-f4, is also interesting) **16...♘fd4 17.♘xd4**

♘xd4 18.♕d3 ♕b6. Black avoids the heavy piece endgame after the exchange of the knight, although this was probably the lesser evil.

19.♗a4 ♖ad8 20.♖ad1 ♘c6 (20...♘e6 came into consideration) **21.♗b3 d4.** Black has not managed to withstand the pressure on the d5-pawn, but after moving to d4 it remains a target. In addition, the bishop at b3 is activated.



22.♖e4! ♖d7 23.c3! ♘a5? After the loss of the pawn, Black's game is doomed. The last chance was 23...♖fd8 24.♖de1 g6, and although White's attack looks dangerous, there are still chances of a defence. For example: 25.♕d2 ♔g7 26.♖h4 g5 (after 26...h5 27.♖xh5! the attack is irresistible) 27.♖he4 ♕c5, 25.♖e8+ ♔h7 26.♕f3 ♖xe8 27.♖xe8 ♔g7 28.♕g4, or 25.♖g4 ♔f8 26.♕f3 ♔g7.

24.♖xd4 ♘xb3 25.♖xd7 ♘c5 26.♖d6 ♕xb2 27.♕c4, and White won.

BOTVINNIK – BOLESLAVSKY
Match-Tournament for the Title of Absolute USSR Champion, Leningrad/Moscow 1941
French Defence C09

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♗b5+ ♘c6 6.♘gf3 ♗d6 7.0-0 ♘ge7 8.dxc5 ♗xc5 9.♘b3 ♗b6.



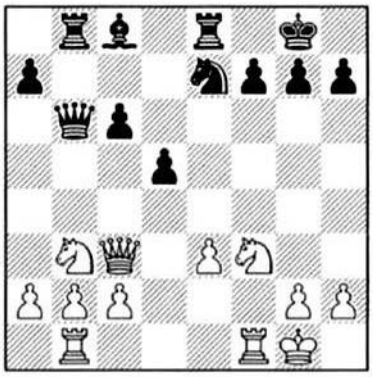
In positions with an isolated d5-pawn, Botvinnik thought it was important for Black to secure control of the d4-point. This is the point of the bishop retreat to b6, from where it not only attacks a blockading piece on d4, but also has the possibility of supporting the d5-d4 advance.

10.♗e3!? Nowadays this move is made with the inclusion of 10.♖e1 0-0 and now 11.♗e3, not spoiling the pawn structure.

10...♗xe3 11.♗xc6+ bxc6. After 11...♘xc6 there would have followed 12.♖e1 and if 12...d4 – 13.♘fxd4. But now Black ends

up with an isolated pawn pair (this topic is covered in detail later).

12.fxe3 0-0 (12...♗g4 was stronger) **13.♕d2 ♕b6 14.♕c3 ♖b8 15.♖ab1 ♖e8.**



16.♖fe1. 'This Nimzowitsch-style move – overprotection of the e3-pawn – throws away a good 50% of White's advantage. The obvious 16.♘c5 ♘f5 17.♖fe1 was the logical continuation.' (Botvinnik)

16...♘g6! Black plays his knight to the better post e5.

17.♘c5 ♗g4 18.♘d4 ♘e5 19.b4 ♖bd8 20.e4. 20.♘de6 ♗xe6 21.♕xe5 came into consideration, consolidating his grip on the dark squares.

20...dxe4 21.♖xe4 a5 22.a3. After 22.♕g3 f6 23.♖xg4 ♘xg4 24.♕xg4 Black could have interposed 24...h5!

22...axb4 23.axb4 f6 24.♖be1 ♔h8. Black should have exploited the latent pin on the white king to switch his bishop to f7 – 24...♗h5!? **25.♔h1 ♗d7.** Even now it was not too late for 25...♗h5!? 26.♘de6 ♗g6! (not 26...♖b8? because of 27.♖xe5 fxe5 28.♕xe5) with a defensible position. Now, however, Black loses a pawn.

26.♘xd7 ♖xd7 27.♕xc6 ♕d8 28.♘f3 ♖c7 29.♘xe5 fxe5 30.♕xe8+ ♕xe8 31.♖xe5 ♕g8 32.♖e8 ♖xc2 33.♖xg8+ ♔xg8 34.♖b1, and White obtained a won rook endgame.

KARPOV – VAGANIAN

Skopje 1976

French Defence C08

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘gf3 a6 6.dxc5 ♗xc5 7.♘b3 ♗b6 8.♗d3 ♘e7 9.0-0 ♘bc6 10.♖e1 ♗g4 11.c3 h6 12.h3 ♗h5.



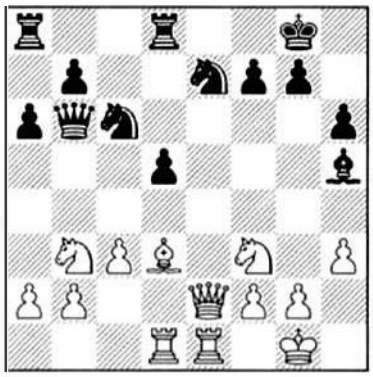
13.♗e3! In the struggle for control of d4 it is important to exchange the dark-square bishop.

13...0-0. The retreat 12...♗c7? leads to serious positional conces-

sions after 13.g4! ♗g6 14.♗xg6 fxg6 15.♘c5.

14.♗xb6 ♕xb6 15.♕e2. The queen makes way for the rook. Black cannot exploit the queen's position by 15...♖e8, since this rook is inadequately defended.

15...♖fd8 16.♖ad1.

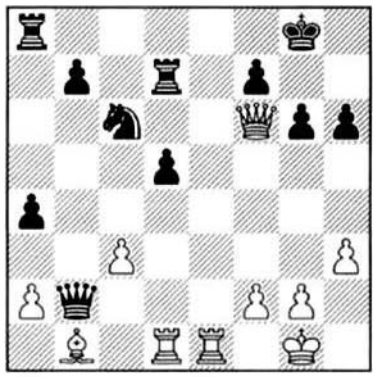


16...a5. A standard way of gaining counterplay on the queenside: Black aims not only to drive away the knight, but also to weaken White's pawns. For example, if 17.♕e3 there follows 17...♕xe3 18.♖xe3 ♗xf3 19.♖xf3 a4 20.♘d4 (20.♘d2 a3 21.b3 d4) 20...♘xd4 21.cxd4 with an equal endgame.

17.♗b1! White intends a regrouping of his pieces with the aim of attacking the king, not forgetting about control of the d4-point.

17...♗xf3. 17...a4 was premature: 18.♘bd4 ♘xd4 19.♖xd4 ♘c6 20.♖h4 ♗xf3 21.♕xf3, and Black's kingside is inadequately defended (21...♕xb2? 22.♕f5 g6 23.♕f6).

18.♕xf3 a4 19.♘d4 ♕xb2 20.♘xc6 ♘xc6 21.♕f5 g6 22.♕f6 ♖d7. An attempt to cover the unprotected king, since if 22...♖e8?! there would have followed 23.♗xg6 fxg6 24.♕xg6+ ♔f8 25.♕xh6+ ♔g8 26.♖e6 with an irresistible attack.



23.♗f5! An intuitive bishop sacrifice, which Black decides not to accept. Indeed, after 23...gxf5 24.♖d3 f4 25.♕xf4 White's attack looks very dangerous, although Karpov suggests the possibility of a defence with 25...f6. Modern computer analysis shows that Black could have held the position after 26.♕xf6 ♖g7.

23...♖e7 24.♖xe7 ♘xe7 25.♗d3 ♘f5. If 25...♔f8 White wins by 26.♖b1 ♕xa2 27.♖xb7 ♖e8 28.♗xg6.

26.♗xf5 gxf5 27.♖e1! ♕xa2 28.♕xh6. 28.♖e3? is a false trail – 28...f4 29.♕xf4 ♕b1+ 30.♔h2 a3! 31.♖g3 ♕g6!, and Black escapes.

28...a3 29.♕g5+ ♔f8 30.♕f6 ♔g8 31.♕xf5 ♕d2 32.♖e7 ♖f8 33.♕g4+ ♔h7 34.♖e5 ♕h6 35.♖h5 ♖a8 36.♕f5+ ♔g7 37.♖xh6 ♔xh6 38.♕f6+ ♔h7 39.♕xf7+ ♔h8 40.♕xb7. Black resigned.

5.3. Piece attack on the isolated pawn

On one occasion, after unsuccessfully attacking an isolated pawn, ♗ent Larsen heatedly exclaimed: 'The blockade of an isolated pawn is old-fashioned; it should be won, not blockaded!' Of course, this is an exaggeration, but in specific situations the strategy of a direct attack has chances of success. Earlier we examined methods of conducting a frontal attack on the d5-pawn with the heavy pieces in Karpov's games with Korchnoi (Meran 1981) and Spassky (Montreal 1979). We will now consider the attack on the isolated d5-pawn with the participation of minor pieces.

BELIAVSKY – INKIOV
Olympiad, Thessaloniki 1988
Nimzo-Indian Defence E42

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.e3 c5 5.♘e2 0-0 6.a3 cxd4 7.axb4 dxc3 8.♘xc3 d5 9.cxd5 exd5 10.♗e2 ♘c6 11.b5 ♘e7 12. 0-0 ♘f5.



In this position the problems of defending the isolated d5-pawn are aggravated by White's pressure on the a-file. The absence of Black's dark-square bishop makes his defence an unpleasant task.

13.♖a4! It is important to take control of the key d4-point.

13...♗e6 14.g4! This flank attack has the aim of weakening Black's defence of the d5-pawn.

14...♘d6 15.f4 ♘de4 16.f5 ♘xc3 17.bxc3 ♗d7 18.♖d4 h5. If 18...h6, then 19.c4! dxc4 20.♗xc4 ♕c7 21.♕b3 with the threat of ♗a3.

19.gxh5 ♘e4 20.♗d3 ♖e8 21.♕g4 ♕b6.

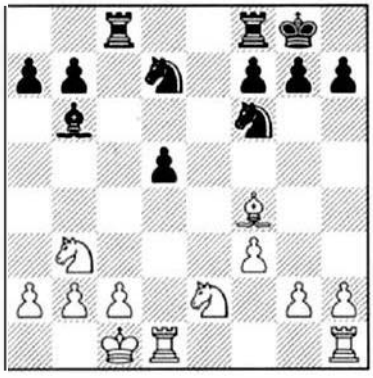


22.c4! A decisive undermining move, leading to the win of the d5-pawn. If 22...♘f6 there follows an attack on the king: 23.♕g2 dxc4 24.h6 ♘h5 25.♗e2.

22...♖ac8 23.♕g2 ♕h6 24.♖xd5 ♘f6 25.c4 ♕xh5 26.♗b2. Black resigned.

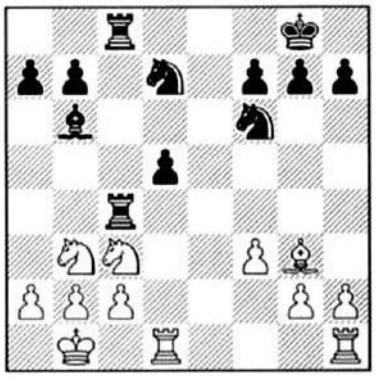
BELIAVSKY – BAREEV
Munich 1994
French Defence C08

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♗b5+ ♗d7 6.♕e2+ ♕e7 7.♗xd7+ ♘xd7 8.dxc5 ♕xe2+ 9.♘xe2 ♗xc5 10.♘b3 ♗b6 11.♗f4 ♘gf6 12.f3 0-0 13.0-0-0 ♖ac8.



A typical position with an isolated pawn has arisen. However, after a routine approach with the blockade of the d4-point – 14.♘bd4 g6 followed by ♖f8-e8 and ♘d7-c5 it is not easy for White to get at the d5-pawn. But it can be attacked immediately.

14.♘c3! ♖c4 15.♗g3 ♖fc8 16.♔b1!



16...d4. This advance is practically forced, but at d4 the pawn is equally weak, which allows White to attack it in combination with threats to the rooks. It should be mentioned that also after the passive 16...♘f8 17.♖he1 ♘e6 (17...a6? 18.♗e5 loses a pawn) 18.♗e5 Black cannot avoid 18...d4, but here too White begins chasing the rooks: 19.♘b5! ♖xc2 20.♘d6 ♖8c6 21.♘f5! ♖6c4 22.♘d2 ♖c5 23.♗d6 ♖xb2+ (things are not changed by 23...♖xd2 24.♘e7+ ♔h8 25.♖xd2 ♗a5 26.♗xc5 ♗xd2 27.♖d1) 24.♔xb2 ♖f5 25.♖e5 ♖xe5 26.♗xe5, and White again wins the d4-pawn.

17.♘b5 ♖xc2 18.♘d6 ♖8c6 19.♘f5! White is again 'in the saddle'! Black is unable to defend against the forks on e7 and d4. Thus if 19...♖6c4 there follows 20.♘d2 ♖c5 21.♘xd4, while the move in the game leads to the loss of the exchange.

19...♘d5 20.♘bxd4 ♖xg2 21.♘xc6 bxc6 22.♖he1 ♘7f6 23.♘h4. Black resigned. The only way to avoid the loss of a second exchange is by 23...♖f2 24.♗xf2 ♗xf2, but after 25.♘f5 ♗xe1 26.♖xe1 ♔f8 27.♖c1 the c6-pawn is lost.

TOPALOV – LEKO
Morelia/Linares 2006
Nimzo-Indian Defence E32

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.♕c2 0-0 5.a3 ♗xc3+ 6.♕xc3 b6 7.♗g5 ♗b7 8.♘f3 d6 9.♘d2 ♘bd7 10.f3 d5 11.cxd5 exd5 12.e3 ♖e8 13.♗e2 ♖c8 14.0-0 ♕e7 15.♗b5 c6 16.♗a4 h6 17.♗xf6 ♘xf6 18.♖fe1 b5 19.♗c2 c5 20.♗f5 ♖c7 21.dxc5 ♖xc5 22.♕d4 a6.



White is firmly blocking the isolated d5-pawn, but it is not easily attacked, since Black has active counterplay on the c- and e-files.

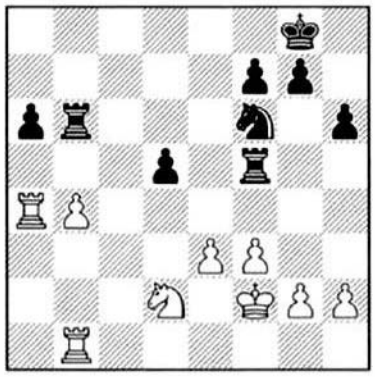
23.a4! White carries out the plan of creating a second weakness: by undermining the b5-pawn, he opens the a-file for his rook.

23...bxa4 24.♖xa4 ♖c6 25.b4 ♕e5. Black is forced to reckon with the existence of a weak pawn at a6 and to ease the defence he exchanges the white queen, which is dominating the position. The exchange of knights would also not have eased his problems: 25...♕c7 26.♗d3 ♘d7 27.♘b3 ♘e5 28.♘c5 ♘xd3 29.♕xd3 ♖b6 30.♕d4.

26.♕xe5 ♖xe5 27.♗d3 ♖b6. Compensating for the pressure on the a6-pawn with an attack on the b4-pawn, but 27...♖e7!? 28.♔f2 ♘d7 with the idea of ♘e5 looks more active.

28.♔f2 ♗c8 29.♖b1 ♗f5. It is useful for Black to exchange his 'bad' bishop.

30.♗xf5 ♖xf5.



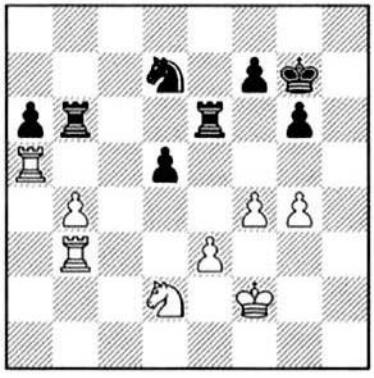
31.♖a5! White not only attacks the d5-pawn, but also pins the rook on f5, which will not be easy to bring into play. 31...♖e5? 32.♘c4 will

not do, while after 31...♖h5 32.h3 ♖h4 33.f4 d4 (33...g5? 34.♘f3 ♖h5 35.g4 ♖xh3 36.♔g2) 34.cxd4 ♖xf4+ 35.♔e3 g5 36.g3 ♖e6+ 37.♔d3 ♖f2 38.♖f1 ♖xf1 39.♘xf1 ♖b6 40.♘e3 ♖xb4 41.♘f5 Black has to reckon with the d-pawn.

31...g6 32.♔e2 h5 (preventing g4) **33.g3 ♔g7 34.h3 ♘d7 35.g4 hxg4 36.hxg4 ♖e5 37.♔f2.** The attempt to win the d5-pawn – 37.f4 ♖ee6 38.♖xd5 ♘f6 39.♖g5 ♘e4 40.♘xe4 ♖xe4 would have led to a rook endgame with the pawns on one wing, where Black's drawing chances are obviously improved.

37...♖c6 38.♖b3 ♖b6. 38...♖c2 39.♔e2 ♘b6 40.♔d3 ♖xd2+ 41.♔xd2 ♘c4+ 42.♔d3 ♘xa5 43.bxa5 d4 44.exd4 ♖xa5 45.♔c4 would have led to a favourable rook endgame for White, since his d-pawn is far more mobile than the a-pawn.

39.f4 ♖ee6.



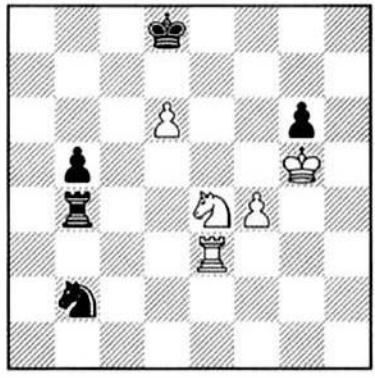
40.g5! Now the d5-pawn is doomed.

40...♖ed6 41.e4! ♖b5 (41...dxe4? 42.♘c4) **42.♖xb5 axb5 43.♖d3 ♘b6 44.♘b1!** White plays his knight to c3, from where it will attack two pawns, but in a critical position Black finds counterplay.

44...♖c6! 45.exd5. The entry of the rook could have been prevented by playing 45.♖c3, but after 45...♖xe3 46.♘xc3 the knight endgame cannot be won 46...dxe4 47.♔e3 f5 48.gxf6+ (48.♔d4 ♔f7 49.♘xb5 ♔c7=) 48...♔xf6 49.♔xe4 g5 50.fxg5+ ♔xg5 51.♘xb5 ♔f6, and Black succeeds in neutralising the b-pawn.

45...♖c4 46.♔f3 ♖xb4 47.♘d2 f6 48.♘e4! The best way of supporting the d-pawn. After 48.gxf6+ ♔xf6 49.♘e4+ ♔f5 50.♘g3+ ♔f6 51.d6 g5 52.fxg5+ ♔xg5 53.d7 ♘xd7 White's resources are exhausted.

48...fxg5 49.♘xg5 ♔f6 50.♔g4 ♘e4 51.♘e4+ ♔e7 52.d6+ ♔d8 53.♔g5 ♘b2 54.♖e3.



54...♖d4?? Black cracks under the prolonged stress, at a moment

when salvation was at hand – 54... ♔d7! 55.♔xg6 ♘c4 56.♖d3 (56.♖f3 ♘xd6 57.♘xd6 ♔xd6=) 56... ♘xd6! 57.♖xd6+ ♔e7 58.♖b6 ♖xc4 59.♖b7+ ♔d6.

55.♘f6! ♖xd6 56.♖e8+ ♔c7 57.♖e2 ♖d1 58.♖xb2, and White won with his extra knight.

5.4. Creation of an isolated pawn pair

Another positional method in the struggle against an isolated d5-pawn is the transformation of one type of advantage into another. One of the most common methods is the exchange of the blockading d4-knight on c6. In this case the d5-pawn is no longer isolated, but if the resulting d5-c6 pawn pair can be blockaded, this leads to the creation of a so-called isolated pawn pair, which is also weak and requires constant defence. Along with the game Zukertort – Steinitz (1886), where this method was employed against a d4-pawn, it is useful to make the acquaintance of a classic game from the heritage of Akiba Rubinstein.

RUBINSTEIN – SALWE
Lodz 1908
Queen's Gambit D33

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 c5 3.c4 e6 4.cxd5 exd5 5.♘c3 ♘f6 6.g3 ♘c6 7.♗g2 cxd4 8.♘xd4 ♕b6.



Black has set up pressure on the d4-point, but he is behind in development, and also the position of the queen at b6 gives White an additional tempo for the occupation of the c5-square.

9.♘xc6! White creates an isolated pawn pair d5-c6, since he succeeds in taking control of the c5-square.

9...bxc6 10.0-0 ♗e7. If 10... ♗e6, then 11.e4! is strong, breaking up the black centre after 11...♘xe4 12.♘xe4 dxc4 13.♗xe4.

11.♘a4 ♕b5 12.♗e3 0-0 13.♖c1 ♗g4 14.f3! ♗e6 15.♗c5 ♖fe8 16.♖f2! White prepares to switch the rook along the second rank to the c-file.

16...♘d7 17.♗xe7 ♖xe7 18.♕d4! (not forgetting about control of c5) **18...♖ee8 19.♗f1 ♖ec8 20.e3! ♕b7 21.♘c5! ♘xc5 22.♖xc5.**



The triumph of White's strategy, begun with the exchange 9.♘xc6 – his pieces are blockading the dark squares.

22...♖c7. It was essential to prevent the complete blockade of the wing by playing 22...a5, since otherwise Black is condemned to perish by suffocation.

23.♖fc2 ♕b6? It was not yet too late for 23...a5, preventing b2-b4.

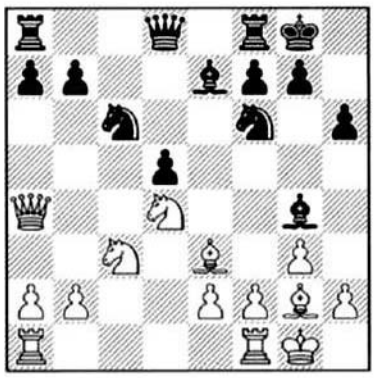
24.b4! a6 25.♖a5. 25.♖xd5 was also possible, but White does not hurry, since Black's queenside is doomed.

25...♖b8 26.a3 ♖a7 27.♖xc6! ♕xc6 28.♕xa7 ♖a8 29.♕c5 ♕b7 30.♔f2 h5 31.♗e2 g6 32.♕d6 ♕c8 33.♖c5 ♕b7 34.h4 a5 35.♖c7 ♕b8 36.b5 a4 37.b6 ♖a5 38.h7. Black resigned.

Boris Spassky also found things difficult when he decided to go in for the creation of an isolated pawn pair in a game with Tigran Petrosian.

PETROSIAN – SPASSKY
World Championship Match,
16th Game, Moscow 1969
Queen's Gambit D34

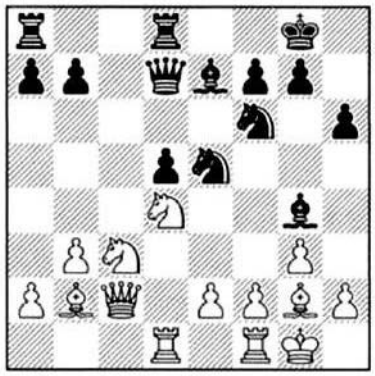
1.c4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘f3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.g3 ♘c6 6.♗g2 ♘f6 7.0-0 ♗e7 8.♘c3 0-0 9.♗g5 cxd4 10.♘xd4 h6 11.♗e3 ♗g4 12.♕a4! White activates his queen and vacates the d1-square for a rook.



The assessment of the position depends on whether the activity of the black pieces compensates for the weakness of the d5-pawn.

12...♘a5 13.♖ad1 ♘c4 14.♗c1 ♕c8! 15.♕c2. It is unfavourable for White to accept the pawn sacrifice: 15.♘xd5 ♘xd5 16.♗xd5 ♘b6 17.♕b3 ♘xd5 18.♕xd5 ♗f6 with strong pressure (Bondarevsky).

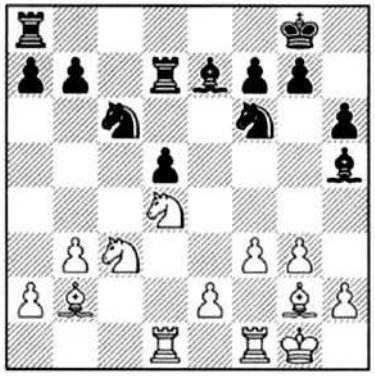
15...♖d8 16.b3 ♘e5 17.♗b2 ♕d7.



18.f3! White is aiming to restrict the activity of the black pieces (if 18...♗e6? there follows 19.f4) or force the transition into an endgame.

18...♗h5 (or 18...♗h3 19.♗xh3 ♕xh3 20.♕f5!) **19.♕f5! ♘c6.** The exchange of queens cannot be avoided (19...♕c7 20.♘cb5 ♕b8 21.♘e6!).

20.♕xd7 ♖xd7.

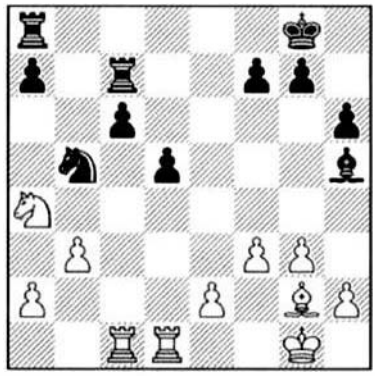


21.♘xc6! bxc6 22.♘a4. After the blockade of the isolated pawn pair, White's advantage is obvious: in the near future Black's light-square bishop will be unable to take part in the defence of the c6-pawn.

22...♘e8. With the idea after f7-f6 of bringing the h5-bishop into play. Bad is 22...c5 23.♗xf6 gxf6 24.g4 ♗g6 25.f4, shutting in the bishop.

23.♖c1! ♖c7 24.♗e5! ♗d6. The exchange of the important dark-square bishop is forced, since 24...♘d6 is bad in view of 25.g4 ♗g6 26.f4! with the threat of 27.♗xd5.

25.♗xd6 ♘xd6 26.♖fd1 ♘b5.



In this position Petrosian could have gained a decisive positional advantage by 27.g4 ♗g6 28.f4, since 28...f6? fails to 29.♖xc6! Black also loses after 28...♗e4 29.♗xe4 dxe4 30.♘c5, besieging the e4-pawn.

27.♔f2?! f6 (bringing the bishop into play) **28.e3 ♗f7 29.♗f1 ♘d6 30.♖c3.** 30.♗a6! ♔f8 31.♖c5 ♔e7 32.♖c1 was stronger.

30...♔f8? Black should have played 30...g5!, depriving the white knight of the f4-square, to which it could have been moved later in the game.

31.♘c5 a5 (31...♔e7 32.♘a6) **32.♖dc1 ♖c7 33.♗h3** (with the threat of 34.♘d7+ followed by 35.♘b6) **33...♖aa7** (33...♗e8 34.♘e6+ ♔f7 35.♘d4) **34.a4?** At the decisive moment Petrosian dallies and throws away the win, to which he was close: after 34.♘d3 ♗e8 35.♘f4 ♔f7 36.♖xc6! ♗xc6 37.♖xc6 ♘b5 38.♗e6+.

34...g5! 35.♖d1 ♔g7 36.♘d3 ♗e837.♘c1 f5 38.♘e2 g4! 39.♗g2 gxf3 40.♗xf3 ♘e4+ 41.♗xe4 fxe4 42.♘d4 ♖f7+ 43.♔g2 ♖f6 44.♖f1 ♖xf1 45.♔xf1 h5 46.♔g2 ♗d7 47.♖c2 ♖a6 48.g4 hxg4 49.♔g3. Draw.

PETROSIAN – BELIAVSKY
41st USSR Championship,
Moscow 1973
English Opening A13

1.c4 c5 2.b3 ♘c6 3.♗b2 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♘f3 d5 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♗e2 a6 8.d4 cxd4 9.♘xd4 ♗b4+ 10.♗c3 ♗d6 11.♘d2 0-0 12.0-0 ♗c7.



It is difficult for White to set up pressure on the d5-pawn, whereas the black pieces have great freedom of movement and, in particular, 13...♕d6 is threatened. Therefore White changes the character of the position.

13.♘xc6! bxc6 14.♕c2! An important factor for the assessment of the position is whether White can control the c5-square or Black will advance c6-c5, obtaining 'hanging pawns', which are undoubtedly better than an isolated pawn pair.

14...♖e8. In the event of 14...♕d6 15.g3 c5 16.♗xf6gxf6 Black's kingside pawns are broken.

15.♗d4! White gains control of the c5-square, after which his advantage is undisputed. The attack on the white king is easily repulsed.

15...♕d6 16.g3 ♗g4?! Passive tactics with 16...♗d7 should have been preferred.

17.♗xg4 ♘xg4 18.♘f3! Black's activity has come to a standstill, but the weakness on c6 is very real.

18...♕h6?!



19.♕f5! Forcing the exchange of queens, since 19...♕h3? fails to 20.♕xf7+ ♔xf7 9.♘g5+.

19...♕e6 20.♕xe6 ♖xe6. The d5-c6 pawn pair is blockaded, and Black's position is strategically lost.

21.♖ac1. Beginning a siege of the weaknesses.

21...f6 22.♖c2 ♘e5 23.♗xe5! In the given position the knight is a more valuable piece than the bishop, since now it is hard for Black to do anything to oppose the manoeuvre of the knight to c5.

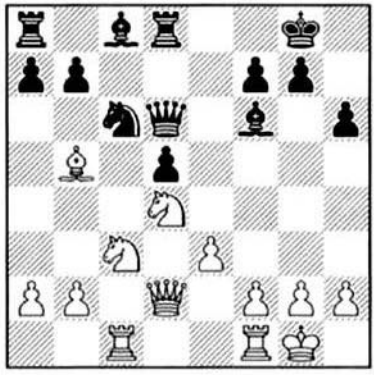
23...♝xe5 24.♖fc1 ♖c8 25.♖c5 (with the threat of 26.♖xd5) **25...♖d6 26.♖1c2 ♔f7 27.♔f1 ♔e6 28.♘e1 d4 29.f4 d3 30.♖d2 ♝b2 31.♖xd3 ♖a8 32.♖xd6+ ♚xd6 33.♘d3 a5 34.♖c4 ♗a3 35.♖a4 ♗c5 36.♘xc5 ♔xc5 37.b4+ ♔c4 38.♖xa5 ♖b8 39.a3 ♔d3 40.♔f2 ♖b7 41.♖c5 ♖a7 42.♖xc6 ♖xa3 43.♔f3.** Black resigned.

AGZAMOV – GELLER

Sochi 1984

Queen's Gambit D55

1.d4 ♘f6 2.♘f3 d5 3.c4 e6 4.♘c3 ♗e7 5.♗g5 0-0 6.e3 h6 7.♗xf6 ♗xf6 8.♕d2 c5 9.cxd5 cxd4 10.♘xd4 exd5 11.♗b5 ♕d6 12.0-0 ♖d8 13.♖ac1 ♘c6.



14.♗xc6! bxc6 15.♘a4! A typical manoeuvre.

15...♗d7 16.♘c5 ♖dc8 17.b4! With the blockade of the c5- and d4-points, White's advantage is obvious.

17...♝e8 18.♖c2 ♖cb8 19.♖fc1 ♗d8 20.♘a6! (preventing 20...a5) **20...♖b6 21.♕e2 ♕g6.** 21...♗d7 22.a4 ♗c8 23.♖xc6 ♝xa6 24.b5 was no better for Black.

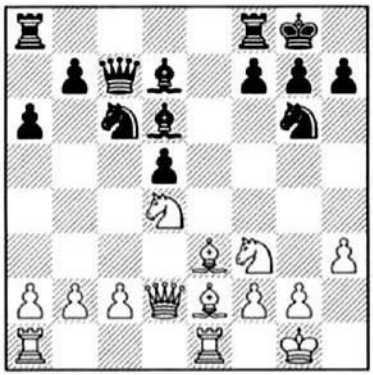
22.a3 ♗d7 23.♕f1 ♗f6 24.♘c5 ♗f5 25.♘xf5 ♕xf5 26.♘b3 ♖d8 27.♘a5 d4 28.♘xc6 d3 29.♖d2 ♖d7 30.♘a5 ♖bd6 31.♘b3. White's position is strategically won.

31...♖d8 32.♘c5 a5 33.♘b7 axb4 34.♘xd6 ♖xd6 35.axb4 ♗e5 36.♖cd1 ♖g6 37.♖xd3 ♔h7 38.f4 ♗c7 39.♕f3 ♖e6 40.g3 ♗b6 41.♔h1. Black resigned.

In conclusion we will draw attention to another way of attacking the d5-c6 pawn pair.

NUNN – VAGANIAN
Baden 1980
French Defence C08

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.♘gf3 a6 5.exd5 exd5 6.♗e2 cxd4 7.0-0 ♗d6 8.♖e1 ♘e7 9.♘b3 0-0 10.♘bxd4 ♘bc6 11.♗e3 ♕c7 12.h3 ♗d7 13.♕d2 ♘g6.



14.♘xc6! bxc6 15.c4! This undermining move prevents the creation of hanging pawns at c5 and d5, and with a subsequent c4-c5 it has the aim of gaining space.

15...a5 16.a3 ♗e6 17.c5! The outcome of the operation begun with 14.♘xc6 – White's dark-square bishop will now dominate on the long diagonal. In the event of 17.cxd5 ♗xd5! the activity of the bishop at d5 compensates for the weakness of the c6-pawn.

17...♗e7 18.b4 ♖fb8 19.♗d4 ♗f5 20.♗f1.



20...f6? This attempt to restrict the dark-square bishop leads to an irreparable weakening of the e6-square. Black should have played 20...♗c4! 21.♘g5 ♗f5, inviting White to reveal his further plans.

21.♗c3! ♗e4?! (21...♗f8 22.♘d4 ♗d7 was more tenacious) **22.♘d4 axb4 23.axb4 ♘e5 24.♖xa8 ♖xa8 25.f3 ♗g6 26.f4 ♘c4 27.♕e2! ♗e4 28.♕g4! ♗f8 29.♖xe4!** Black resigned.

5.5. Creation of a central pawn pair

Apart from the exchange of the blockading d4-knight on c6, in a number of positions the exchange of the knight for the bishop on e6 is also of strategic interest. In the examples given below, the point of such an exchange is not to gain the advantage of the two bishops, but mainly to weaken the light squares on the kingside. The resulting central pawn pair d5-e6 is practically

immobile and in the future it can be put under attack by c2(c3)-c4 or in some cases by f4-f5, which may again lead to the creation of an isolated pawn. However, in contrast to the isolated pawn pair d5-c6, with accurate defence the central pawns d5 and e6 are more dynamic.

KARPOV – KASPAROV
World Championship Match,
4th Game, Moscow 1985
Queen's Gambit D55

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗e7 4.♘f3 ♘f6 5.♗g5 h6 6.♗xf6 ♗xf6 7.e3 0-0 8.♕c2 ♘a6 9.♖d1 c5 10.dxc5 ♕a5 11.cxd5 ♘xc5 12.♕d2 ♖d8 13.♘d4 exd5 14.♗e2 ♕b6 15.0-0 ♘e4 16.♕c2 ♘xc3 17.♕xc3 ♗e6 18.♕c2 ♖ac8 19.♕b1 ♖c7 20.♖d2 ♖dc8.



In this position the blockading strategy 21.♖fd1 does not work because of 21...♗xd4 22.♖xd4 ♖c2 23.♖4d2 ♗f5. Therefore Karpov transforms the position, creating a central pawn pair, which gives Black definite problems.

21.♘xe6! fxe6. The pawn on d5 is reinforced, but the weakness of the light squares in Black's position gives White a slight but stable advantage. It should be mentioned that things are also not easy for Black if he remains with an isolated pawn – 21...♕xe6 22.♖fd1.

22.♗g4 ♖c4 23.h3 ♕c6 24.♕d3 ♔h8. A loss of time. The immediate 24...a5 was simpler, when 25.f4 ♖c5 is not dangerous for Black.

25.♖fd1 a5 26.b3! (preventing a5-a4) **26...♖c3 27.♕e2 ♖f8!** It did not make sense to exchange the active rook: 27...♖c1 28.♖xc1 ♕xc1+ 29.♔h2 ♕c6 30.g3 with a slight but enduring advantage for White.

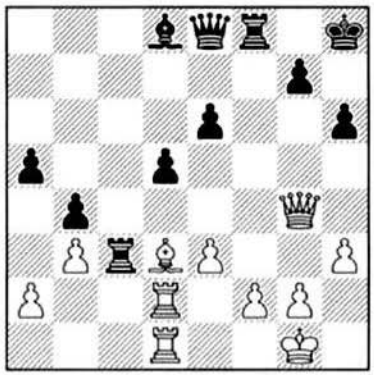


28.♗h5! Switching the bishop to an attacking diagonal.

28...b5. Black aims to reinforce his outpost at c3. 28...♗d8 29.♗g6 ♗c7 30.♗d3 ♕d6 31.g3 ♕c5

32.♕g4 ♕f6 was also not bad, with chances for both sides.

29.♗g6 ♗d8 30.♗d3 b4 31.♕g4 ♕e8.



32.e4! A thematic opening up of the play in this type of position.

32...♗g5. 32...♗b6!?, attacking the f2-pawn, also came into consideration.

33.♖c2 ♖xc2? A positional mistake. It was in Black's interests for the exchange of rooks to take place on c3 with the creation of a passed pawn. Kasparov considers the best to be 33...♕c8! 34.exd5 exd5 35.♕xc8 ♖fxc8 36.♖e2 ♖c1 37.♖xc1 ♕xc1+ 38.♔h2 ♖e8 39.♗g6 ♗f6 with a sound enough position for Black.

34.♗xc2 ♕c6 35.♕e2 ♕c5 36.♖f1 ♕c3 37.exd5 exd5 38.♗b1! White plans to set up the queen + bishop battery on the b1-h7 diagonal.

38...♕d2 39.♕e5 ♖d8? The decisive mistake. 39....♗f6! 40.♕f5 ♔g8 41.♗d3 ♖d8 would have allowed Black to put up a tough defence (Kasparov).

40.♕f5 ♔g8 41.♕e6+ ♔h8 42.♕g6 ♔g8 43.♕e6+ ♔h8 44.♗f5! ♕c3 45.♕g6 ♔g8 46.♗e6+ ♔h8 47.♗f5 ♔g8 48.g3 ♔f8 49.♔g2 ♕f6 50.♕h7 ♕f7 51.h4 ♗d2 52.♖d1. The inclusion of the rook in the attack decides the outcome in White's favour.

52...♗c3 53.♖d3 ♖d6 54.♖f3! ♔e7 55.♕h8! d4 56.♕c8 ♖f6 57.♕c5+ ♔e8 58.♖f4 ♕b7+ 59.♖e4+ ♔f7 60.♕c4+ ♔f8 61.♗h7! ♖f7 62.♕e6 ♕d7 63.♕e5. Black resigned.

SMYSLOV – KASPAROV

Final Candidates Match, 2nd Game, Vilnius 1984

Queen's Gambit D34

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 c5 3.c4 e6 4.cxd5 exd5 5.g3 ♘f6 6.♗g2 ♗e7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♘c3 ♘c6 9.♗g5 cxd4 10.♘xd4 h6 11.♗e3 ♖e8 12.a3 ♗e6 13.♔h1 ♕d7.



14.♘xe6! fxe6 15.f4! White's plan is to play his dark-square bishop to g1 and then open up the position with e2-e4 or f4-f5, exploiting his two bishops.

15...♖ed8! Black prepares to meet the thematic move e2-e4. 15...d4? 16.♘e4 would have irreparably weakened the light squares.

16.♗g1 ♖ac8 17.♕a4 ♔h8 18.♖ad1 ♕e8 19.e4!



19...d4! Black defends resourcefully: 20.♗xd4? fails to 20...b5.

20.♘e2. After 20.e5 dxc3 21.exf6 ♗xf6 22.bxc3 ♕e7! Black has sufficient counterplay.

20...♗c5 21.♕b5! After the rash 21.b4?! d3! 22.♘c1 ♗xg1 23.♔xg1 d2 24.♘b3 ♘g4! 25.b5? (25.♖f3) 25...♕h5 26.h3 ♘e3 Black wins the exchange.

21...♗b6 22.h3. If 22.e5?! White has to reckon with Black's counterplay after 22...♘g4 23.♗f3 ♘e3 24.♗xe3 dxe3 25.♖d6 ♖xd6 26.exd6 ♖d8 27.♖d1 e5! etc. Therefore White prevents this knight thrust.

22...e5.



23.fxe5?! An unfortunate exchange, ruining the fruits of White's strategy. After 23.♗h2! followed by g3-g4 he would have retained the better chances.

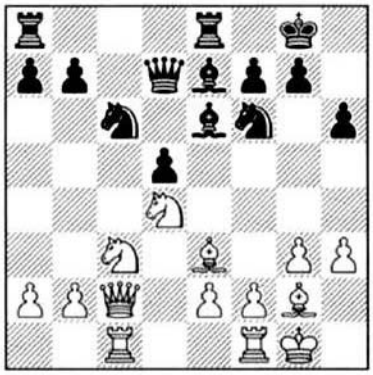
23...♘xe5 24.♕xe8+. Also in the event of 24.♘xd4 ♕xb5 25.♘xb5 ♖xd1 26.♖xd1 ♖c2 Black has sufficient counterplay thanks to the activity of his pieces.

24...♖xe8 25.♘xd4 ♘c4 26.e5! ♖xe5 27.♗xb7. 27.♖c1 ♘e4! 28.♔h2 ♘ed2 29.♖fd1 ♖d8 leads to unclear play.

27...♖c7 28.♖c1! ♘xb2 29.♖xc7 ♗xc7 30.♘c6 ♖e2! 31.♘d4 (31.♘xa7 ♘h5!; 31.♖f2 ♘e4!) **31...♖e5 32.♘f5! ♗b6! 33.♘xh6 ♖a5 34.♗xb6 axb6 35.♘f5 ♖xa3 36.♔h2 ♘c4 37.g4 ♖a7 38.♗h1 ♘e5 39.g5 ♘h5 40.♖e1 ♖a5 41.♘d6.** Draw.

HJARTARSON – ILLESCAS CORDOBA
Linares 1988
Queen's Gambit D34

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.g3 ♘f6 6.♗g2 ♗c7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♘c3 ♘c6 9.♗g5 cxd4 10.♘xd4 h6 11.♗e3 ♖e8 12.♖c1 ♗g4 13.h3 ♗e6 14.♕c2 ♕d7.

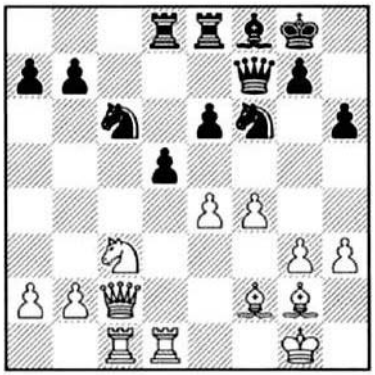


15.♘xe6 fxe6 16.♖fd1. White prepares the plan of f4, ♗f2 followed by e4 or f5 with the aim of opening up the position, when his two bishops will be especially strong.

16...♗f8. Black prepares to meet the e2-e4 attack on his central pawn pair by supporting the e-pawn with his rook. 16...♖ac8 17.f4 ♗d6? (17...♗b4) 18.♗f2 ♕e7 19.e4, and White gained an obvious advantage, Marin – Petursson, Romania 1987.

17.f4 ♕f7! Removing the queen from the 'X-ray' attack of the rook on d1.

18.♗f2 ♖ad8 19.e4.



19...d4! Black prevents the opening up of the position.

20.♘b5 e5! 21.fxe5 d3! Tactics at the service of strategy – 22.♖xd3? ♘b4.

22.♕c3 ♘xe5. After 22...♖xe5 23.♘xa7 ♘xe4 24.♗xe4 ♖xe4 25.♖xd3 Black does not have sufficient compensation for the lost pawn.

23.♗d4 ♕h5 24.♘c7 ♖e7 25.♗xe5 ♖xe5. 25...♕xe5 26.♘d5 ♕xg3! was stronger, when Black has excellent counterplay for the sacrificed exchange.

26.♖xd3 ♗c5+ 27.♔h1 ♖xd3 28.♕xd3 ♘xe4 29.♔h2 ♘f6 30.♕c4+ ♔h7 31.♘d5 ♘xd5 32.♕d3+! ♔h8 33.♖xc5 ♘e7 (33...♘e3 34.♖c8+ ♖e8 35.♕d7 was also insufficient) **34.♖c7 ♕e2 35.♕f3 ♕xf3 36.♗xf3 ♘f5 37.♖xb7** with an extra pawn for White.

5.6. Transition into an endgame

To develop the theme of exchanging when playing against an

isolated pawn, it is useful to include the method of exchanging queens and transposing into a complicated endgame. In this case the isolated d5-pawn loses its dynamic strength and may become a target, while the absence of the queens allows other pieces to exploit the weakness of squares adjacent to it.

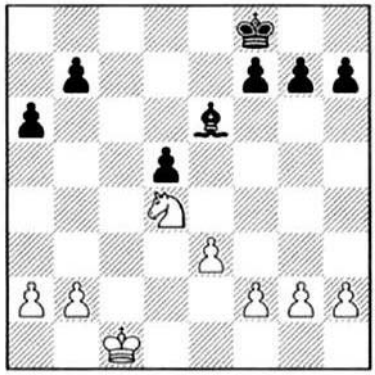
In the study of positions with an isolated pawn, the transition into the endgame is sometimes planned right from the opening.

FLOHR – CAPABLANCA
Moscow 1935
Queen's Gambit D62

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♘f3 ♘bd7 5.♗g5 ♗e7 6.e3 0-0 7.♕c2 c5! The most effective way of countering Rubinstein's set-up with ♕c2 and ♖d1 in the Orthodox Defence. However, it allows White to transpose into an endgame where Black has an isolated d5-pawn.

8.cxd5 ♘xd5 9.♗xe7 ♕xe7 10.♘xd5 exd5 11.♗d3 cxd4 12.♘xd4 ♕b4+ 13.♕d2 ♘c5 14.♗b5 ♕xd2+ 15.♔xd2 a6 16.♗d3 ♗e6 17.♖ac1 ♖fc8 18.♖c2 ♘xd3. Essentially a forced exchange, since 19.♖hc1 followed by b2-b4 was threatened.

19.♔xd3 ♖xc2 20.♔xc2 ♔f8 21.♔d2 ♖c8 22.♖c1 ♖xc1 23.♔xc1.



On the basis of a number of games by Akiba Rubinstein, in the 1930s such an endgame with an isolated d5-pawn and a knight at d4 against a light-square bishop was considered won for White. His advantage comprises not only the superiority of the knight over the bishop, but also the fact that his king can replace the knight on d4, from where it will threaten both wings.

Capablanca had to demonstrate virtuoso defensive technique (at times finding the only moves) in order to save the game.

23...♔e7 24.♔d2 ♔d6 25.♔c3 b6! Black displays a subtle understanding of the endgame: he arranges his pawns on dark squares, preventing the invasion of the king, while the b5-square is controlled by the bishop.

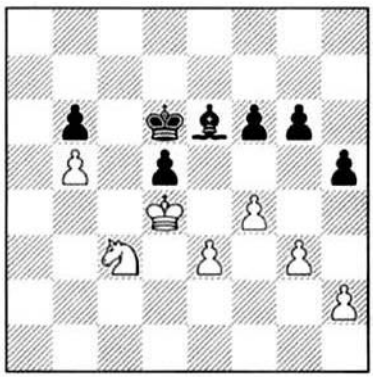
26.f4 ♗d7 27.♘f3 f6! 28.♔d4 a5! 29.♘d2 ♗c8 30.♘b1 ♗e6 31.♘c3 ♔c6 32.a3 h6 33.g3.



33...h5!? Black gives up the f6-g7-h6 pawn triangle in favour of the f6-g6-h5 triangle, denying White the prospect of playing his knight to h4 with the threat of a bind by f4-f5 (after which the knight would be switched to f4 with the threat of an invasion at e6).

34.b4! axb4. Whitewas threatening 35.b5+ ♔d6 36.f5 ♗f7 37.♘e2 with the switching of his knight to f4, and therefore it is important to exchange a pair of pawns, in order to have the possibility of attacking the b5-pawn.

35.axb4 ♔d6 36.b5 g6 (forestalling the threat of 37.f5) **37.♘a4 ♔c7 38.♘c3 ♔d6.**



39.f5! With this pawn sacrifice White breaks up Black's defences.

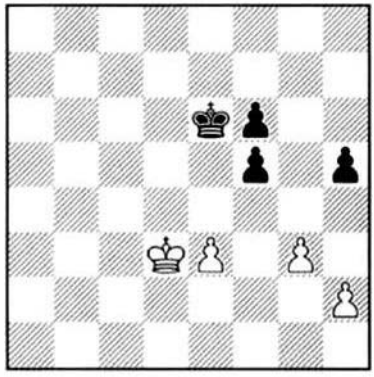
39...gxf5. Bad is 39...♗xf5 40.♘xd5 ♗d7 41.♘xf6 ♗xb5 42.♘d5, and White wins the b6-pawn.

40.♘e2 ♗d7. 40...♗g8! 41.♘f4 ♗f7 42.h3 ♗e8 was more accurate, gaining tempo in anticipation of the pawn endgame.

41.♘f4 ♗e8! Of course, not 41...♗xb5? 42.♘xh5, when White obtains a dangerous passed h-pawn.

42.♘xd5 ♗xb5 43.♘xb6. After 43.♘xf6? ♗e2 it is White who has to fight for a draw.

43...♗c6 44.♘c4+ ♔e6 45.♘b2 ♗b5 46.♘d1 ♗e2 47.♘f2 ♗f1! 48.♘d3 ♗xd3 49.♔xd3.



49...♔e5! The only move. Black would have lost after 49...♔d5 50.♔d2! ♔e5 51.♔c1! ♔e4 52.♔c2 ♔d5 53.♔b3 ♔e5 54.h3 ♔d5 55.♔f4 ♔c6 56.h4 (Grigoriev).

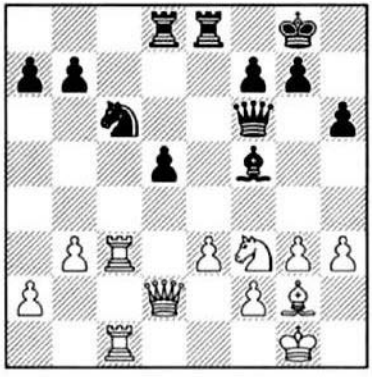
50.♔e2. After 50.♔d2 Black saves himself with the only move

50...h4! 51.gxh4 f4 52.h5 fxe3+ 53.♔xe3 ♔e6 (Capablanca).

50...♔e4! 51.h3 (51.♔f2 h4 52.gxh4 f4) **51...♔d5 52.♔f3 ♔e5.** Draw.

LARSEN – PENROSE
Palma de Mallorca 1969
Nimzovich-Larsen Attack A01

1.b3 c5 2.♗b2 ♘c6 3.c4 e6 4.♘f3 ♘f6 5.g3 ♗e7 6.♗g2 0-0 7.♘c3 d5 8.cxd5 exd5 9.♖c1 ♗e6 10.d4 ♖c8 11.0-0 ♖e8 12.dxc5 ♗xc5 13.♘a4 ♗e7 14.♘c5 ♘d7 15.♘xd7 ♕xd7 16.♕d2 ♕d8 17.♖fd1 ♗f6 18.e3 ♕e7 19.h3 h6 20.♗xf6 ♕xf6 21.♖c3 ♗f5 22.♖dc1 ♖cd8.



23.♘d4! White carries out an exchanging operation, based on the threat of an invasion by his heavy pieces on the queenside.

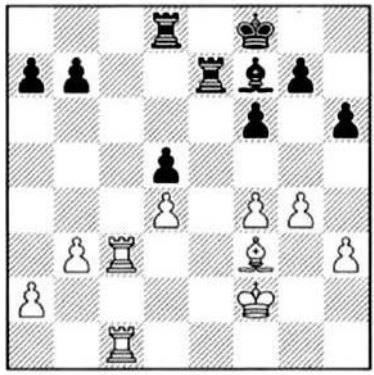
23...♘xd4 24.♕xd4 ♕xd4. The exchange of queens is forced, since after 24...♕e6 25.♔h2 Black has no way of opposing the rook invasion at c7.

25.exd4. The game has gone into an endgame, where White's advantage is determined by his control of the c-file plus the weakness of the d5-pawn.

25...♖e7 26.g4! By seizing space on the kingside, White restricts the range of the bishop.

26...♗e6. Weaker was 26...♗c4?! 27.f3 ♗g6 28.♖c7 ♖cd7 29.♖xd7 ♖xd7 30.♖c8+ ♔h7 31.♔f2 with advantage to White.

27.f4 f6 28.♔f2 ♗f7 29.♗f3 ♔f8.



30.a4! With a pawn attack on the queenside White aims to give Black an additional pawn weakness, which will help him to convert his advantage.

30...♖de8 31.a5 ♖d7 32.b4 ♖ed8 33.♗e2! The bishop is switched to a more active position.

33...♗e8 34.♗d3 ♖e7 35.♖c8 ♖xc8 36.♖xc8 ♔f7 37.b5! White

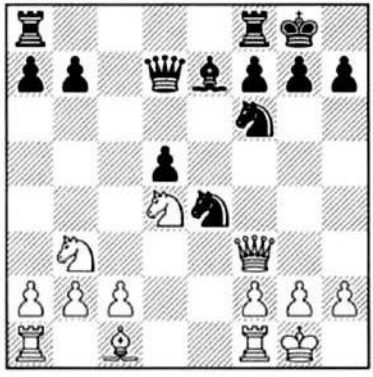
has carried out his plan – 38.♖a8 is threatened.

37...b6 38.axb6 axb6 39.♖b8 ♖c6 40.♗g6+ ♔f8 41.h4. Zugzwang! Black has no useful moves.

41...♖e7 42.h5 ♖e6 43.♔f3 ♖e7 44.g5. Black resigned.

KASPAROV – KHARITONOV
55th USSR Championship,
Moscow 1988
French Defence C08

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.♘gf3 ♘f6 5.exd5 exd5 6.♗b5+ ♗d7 7.♗xd7+ ♘bxd7 8.0-0 ♗e7 9.dxc5 ♘xc5 10.♘d4 ♕d7 11.♕f3 0-0 12.♘2b3 ♘ce4.



13.♕f5. White offers the exchange of queens, planning a piece attack on the isolated d5-pawn.

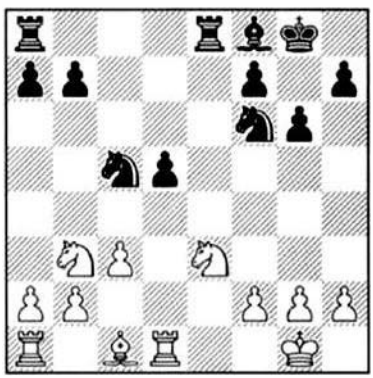
13...♖fc8. In Rublevsky – Bareev, St. Petersburg 1998, Black avoided the exchange by 13...♕d8!? 14.♗f4 g6 15.♕h3 ♖e8 16.♖ad1 ♗d6, but a battle did not ensue – here a draw was agreed.

14.♖e1 ♗f8. In the spirit of the position was 14...♗d8!? with the switching of the bishop to b6, from where it puts pressure on d4.

15.c3 ♕xf5. 15...♘d6! was stronger, transferring the knight to c4.

16.♘xf5 g6 17.♘e3. White begins a combined attack on the d5-pawn, in a situation where the black pieces are insufficiently well coordinated to organise counterplay.

17...♖e8 18.♖d1 ♘c5?! The d5-pawn should have been supported by 18...♖ad8, although even here after 19.♘c2 ♘c5 20.♗g5! ♘ce4 21.♗c3 White has the advantage.



19.g4! A typical idea. By the advance of the wing pawn White exposes the weakness of the d5-pawn, by threatening to drive back its defender.

19...h6 20.h4! In the event of 20.♘xd5 ♘xd5 21.♖xd5 ♖e1+ 22.♔g2 ♘xb3 23.axb3 a5 Black has active counterplay for the pawn.

20...♘xb3?! Black goes along with White's exchanging strategy. He should have aimed for activity: 20...♖c4! 21.g5 (21.f3 ♖e6) 21... ♘h5! 22.♘xd5 ♖xh4 23.gxh4 ♘e6 (Kasparov).

21.axb3 ♗c5. Here 21...♖e4 is parried by 22.♖a4.

22.g5 hxg5 23.hxg5 ♘e4 24.♘g4! White strengthens his position and intends to drive back Black's only active piece – his knight on e4. He does not hurry to capture the pawn, as after 24.♖xd5?! ♖ad8 25.♖xd8 ♖xd8 Black has good compensation.

24...♗b6 25.♔g2 ♔g7 26.♗f4 ♖ad8 27.f3 ♘c5 28.b4! After the impulsive 28.♗e5+ ♖xe5!? 29. ♘xe5 ♘xb3 Black could still have put up some resistance, but now he comes under a total bind.

28...♘b3 29.♖a3 ♖c2+ 30.♔g3 ♖xb2 31.c4! ♖e8 32.c5 ♗d8 33.♖xa7 ♖ee2 34.♖xd5 ♗e7 35.♖xb7. Black resigned.

POLUGAEVSKY – A.ZAITSEV
Vladimir 1969
Queen's Gambit D34

1.c4 e6 2.g3 ♘f6 3.♗g2 d5 4.♘f3 ♗e7 5.0-0 c5 6.cxd5 exd5 7.d4 ♘c6 8.dxc5 ♗xc5 9.♗g5 ♗e7 10.♘c3 0-0 11.♖c1 ♗e6 12.♘d4 ♘xd4 13.♕xd4 h6 14.♗e3 ♕a5 15.♖fd1 ♖fd8.



A routine approach to the position suggests 16.♕d3 followed by ♗d4, retaining a small positional advantage. However, the particular features of the position, in which White's pieces are trained on the queenside, allow him to provoke an advantageous exchange of queens, after which the d5-pawn loses its dynamic strength and becomes a weakness.

16.♕a4! ♕xa4 17.♘xa4 b6 (preventing 18.♘c5) **18.♘c3 ♖d7 19.♘b5!** By playing his knight to the d4 blockading position White denies Black any counterplay.

19...♖ad8 20.b3 ♘e8 21.♘d4 ♗f6 22.h3. White restricts the mobility of Black's light-square bishop.

22...♘d6 23.g4 ♗xd4 24. ♗xd4.



White's advantage is undisputed: Black has no useful moves, whereas White can strengthen his position by advancing his pawns.

24...f5. This attempt to destabilise the position merely widens the scope of the dark-square bishop, which should have been restricted by 24...f6, intending ♗f7.

25.f3 ♘b5 26.e3 (if 26.♗b2, then 26...d4) **26...♔f7.** The lesser evil was 26...♘xd4 27.♖xd4, depriving White of the advantage of the two bishops.

27.♗b2 fxg4. In the event of 27...d4 28.gxf5 ♗xf5 29.e4 ♗e6 30.♗f1 the power of the bishops is felt.

28.fxg4 ♔g8 29.♗e5! A striking manoeuvre, which is worth remembering. The bishop restricts the scope of the knight.

29...♗f7 30.a4 ♖e8 31.♗f4 g5 32.♗h2 ♘a3 33.♖c3?! White had two ways of implementing his strategy: 33.♖d3 with the idea of b3-b4, and 33.e4 d4 34.e5. The delay allows the knight to come into play.

33...b5! 34.♔f2 ♖ed8 35.♖d4 bxa4 36.bxa4. 36.♖xa4!? d4 37.♖xd4 ♖xd4 38.cxd4 ♘b5 39.♖c6 ♘xd4 40.♖xh6 ♘xb3 41.♗e5 was more energetic.

36...♘c4 37.♔e2 ♗e6 38.♗g3 ♖b7?! 39.♖dxc4. Black resigned.

BACROT – BOLOGAN

Poikovsky 2005

Queen's Gambit D37

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 d5 4.♘c3 ♗e7 5.♕c2 0-0 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♗g5 c5 8.dxc5 ♕a5 9.e3 ♘c6 10.♗b5 ♘b4. Black avoids the creation of an isolated pawn pair after 10...a6 11.♗xc6 bxc6 12.0-0 ♕xc5 13.♖ac1.



11.♕a4! White forces the exchange of queens, after which the game goes from the opening into an endgame, where the d5-pawn becomes a weakness.

11...♕xa4 12.♗xa4 ♘d3+ 13.♔e2 ♘xc5 14.♗c2 ♗e6 15.♘d4 ♖ac8 16.♖acl g6. Black takes control of the f5-point, the weakness of which is felt in the event of 16...h6 17.♗h4 g5 18.♗g3 ♘fc4 19.♘xe4 ♘xc4 20.♗c5 ♗d7 21.f3 ♘d6 22.♗xd6 ♗xd6 23.♗f5.

17.♖hdl ♖fd8.



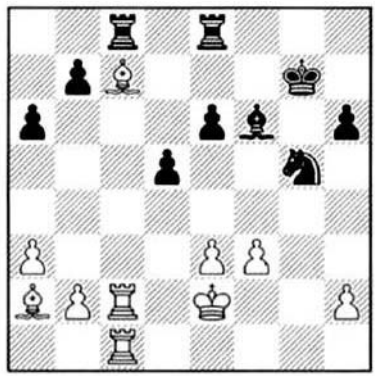
18.♗b1! The d5-pawn is securely blockaded, and White includes his bishop in the attack on it, by switching it to a2.

18...a6 19.a3 ♔g7 20.♗a2 h6 21.♗h4 g5 22.♗g3 ♘ce4 23.♘xe4 ♘xe4 24.♗c7! Nothing significant is promised by the creation of a central pawn pair – 24.♘xc6+ fxc6, since after 25.♗e5+ ♗f6 Black exchanges a pair of bishops, simplifying the position.

24...♖e8 25.♖c2 ♗f6. It was bad to play either 25...♗d6 26.♖dc1 ♔f6 27.f3 ♖xc7 28.♖xc7 ♗xc7 29.♖xc7 ♘d6 30.♘xc6 fxc6 31.♖d7, when Black loses a pawn, or 25...♗c5 26.♘xc6+ fxc6 27.♗e5+ ♔g6 28.♖dc1.

26.♘xe6+. Now, when the dark-square bishop can be retained, it is logical to create a central pawn pair, which can be put under attack.

26...fxe6 27.♖dc1 g4 (f2-f3 was threatened) **28.f3 gxf3+ 29.gxf3 ♘g5.**



30.f4?! White weakens the e4-square, which, however, Black fails to exploit. In the spirit of the position was 30.♗d6 ♖xc2+ 31.♖xc2 ♖d8 32.♗g3 ♘f7 33.b4 ♖d7 and now the undermining move 34.c4!, by which White emphasises the strength of his two bishops. For example: 34...h5 35.cxd5 cxd5 36.♖c7 ♖xc7 37.♗xc7 d4 38.♗d5 or 34...dxc4 35.fxc4 e5 36.♗e6 ♖e7 37.♗d5 ♘g5 38.♖c8, and in both variations White's advantage is obvious.

30...♘f7?! 30...♘e4 suggests itself, but in the variation 31.f5 ♔f7 32.fxe6+ ♔xe6 33.♖d1 Black ap-

parently overlooked the possibility of 33...♖ed8!

31.f5 exf5?! More tenacious was 31...♘d8 32.♗xd8 ♖cxd8 33.♖c7+ ♔f8 (33...♖e7 34.fxe6) 34.fxe6 ♖xe6 35.♖f1 (the immediate 35.♖xb7 is also possible) 35...♔e8 36.♖xb7, when Black at least obtains opposite-colour bishops in return for the pawn.

32.♗xd5 ♗g5 33.♗b6 ♖xc2+ 34.♖xc2 ♘d6 35.♔f3 ♗f6. Things are also difficult after 35...♔g6 36.♗d4! ♘b5 37.♗c5 ♘d6 38.b4 ♖e5.

36.♗c5 ♘e4 37.♗b4 ♘g5+ 38.♔f2 b6? Now Black comes under a mortal rook pin. His last chance was the activation of his forces by 38...♘h3+ 39.♔f1 ♖xe3 40.♗xb7 ♘g5, for example: 41.♖g2 ♖h3 42.♗xa6 ♗c5 43.♗c4, and the pair of outside passed pawns should decide the game (Bologan).

39.♖c7+ ♔g6 40.h4 ♘e6. 40...♘e4+ 41.♔f3 ♗d8 (41...♖e5 42.♗f7+) 42.♖c6+ ♘f6 43.♗c3 also fails to save Black.

41.♖c6 a5 42.♗c3 ♗xh4+ 43.♔f3 ♔f7 44.e4! Black resigned.

Chapter 6

Dynamic potential of the d5-pawn

In the mid-20th century the prevalent opinion was that you could allow yourself an isolated pawn, only if you had a lead in development. This caution was removed by the Petrosian – Spassky 1969 World Championship Match, in which the challenger employed the Tarrasch Defence to the Queen's Gambit with Black in five games and achieved a positive result (–0=4+1). After this match the number of supporters of the isolated pawn in Black's position increased considerably.

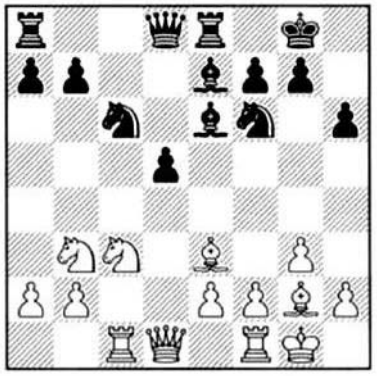
In the examples examined in Chapter 1, Black went along with White by not objecting to reduction in the material. However, the strategy of playing with an isolated pawn envisages not a passive striving for a draw, but above all the exploitation of its dynamic potential to create active piece play and, if possible, the d5-d4 breakthrough.

6.1. Active piece play for Black

The control by the isolated d5-pawn of the central e4- and c4-points allows Black to develop his pieces in active positions, combining threats on the kingside with the possibility of counterplay on the queenside. Pressure on the d4 blockading point is important, tying White down by the threat of the d5-d4 breakthrough.

PETROSIAN – SPASSKY
World Championship Match,
4th Game, Moscow 1969
Queen's Gambit D34

1.c4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘c3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.♘f3 ♘c6 6.g3 ♘f6 7.♗g2 ♗e7 8.0-0 0-0 9.♗g5 cxd4 10.♘xd4 h6 11.♗e3 ♗g4 (in recent times 12...♖c8 was preferred) **12.♘b3 ♗e6 13.♖c1 ♖e8.**



Black has completed his development, and although for the moment the c-file is blocked by the bishops, this is only a temporary phenomenon. For example, if 14.♘c5 there can follow 14...♗xc5 15.♗xc5 ♘e4 with active play for Black.

14.♖e1. A prophylactic move, against the threat of ♕d7 and ♗h3. After 14.♘b5, which was played in the 2nd game of the match, there followed 14...♕d7 15.♘bd4 ♗h3 16.♘xc6 bxc6 17.♕d3 ♗xg2 18.♔xg2 a5! with good play for Black.

14...♕d7 15.♗c5! (the exchange of the dark-square bishops is advantageous to White) **15...♖ac8 16.♗xe7 ♕xe7 17.e3 ♖ed8 18.♕e2.**



18...♗g4! 'There was no point in Black relieving himself of his isolated pawn by 18...d4. You don't play the Tarrasch Defence, in order to be thinking about the weakness of the isolated d5-pawn! Consistent play by Black should be aimed in the first instance at exploiting its strength.' (Bondarevsky)

19.f3 (19.♕f1 ♘e4) **19...♗f5 20.♖cd1 ♘e5 21.♘d4 ♗g6 22.♗h3.**



22...♖c4!? A sharp move; 22...♖b8 would have led to quiet play.

23.g4. If 23.f4 there could have followed 23...♗h5 24.♕f1 ♘c6! 25.g4 ♘xg4 26.♘xd5 ♖xd5 27.♕xc4 ♕h4! 28.♗xg4 ♕xg4+ 29.♔h1 ♖xd4 with a guaranteed perpetual check.

23...♖h4 24.b3 ♘c6 25.♕d2 ♖b6 26.♘ce2?! 26.♘a4 ♖a6 27.♗f1 ♘xd4 28.exd4 was correct.

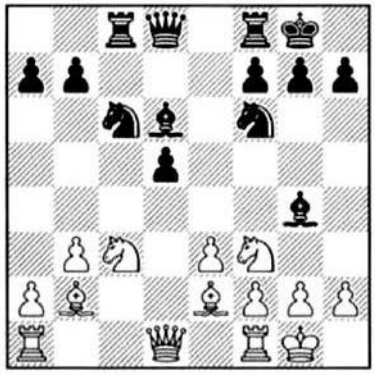
26...♗h7 27.♗g2 ♖e8 28.♘g3 ♘xd4 29.exd4 ♖e6 30.♖xe6 ♕xe6 31.♖c1 ♗g6 32.♗f1? 32.♔f2! would have consolidated the position. Now Black seizes the initiative.

32...♘h7 33.♕f4 ♘f8 34.♖c5 (34.♕e5! was stronger) **34...♗b1! 35.a4 ♘g6 36.♕d2 ♕f6 37.♔f2**

♘f4 38.a5 ♗d3! 39.♘f5 ♕g5! 40.♘e3 ♕h4+ 41.♔g1 ♗xf1. White resigned. After 42.♘xf1 ♖e2 he has no defence.

KARPOV – CHANDLER
Bath 1983
Queen's Gambit D32

1.c4 e6 2.♘c3 d5 3.d4 c5 4.e3 ♘f6 5.♘f3 ♘c6 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♗b5 ♗d6 8.dxc5 ♗xc5 9.0-0 0-0 10.b3 ♗g4 11.♗b2 ♖c8 12.♗c2 ♗d6.



A typical manoeuvre in this structure. Black switches his bishop to the b8-h2 diagonal, planning an attack on the kingside.

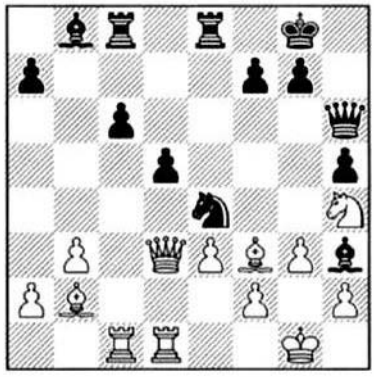
13.♘b5. White's strategy is aimed at firm control of the d4-point. After the exchange of the light-square bishops: 13.♖c1 ♗b8 14.h3 ♗h5 15.♘h4 ♕d6 16.g3 ♗xc2 17.♘xc2 ♖fd8 18.♘d4 ♘e5 Black does not experience any problems, Zviagintsev – Lutz, Essen 2002.

13...♗b8 14.♖c1 ♖e8 15.♕d3. If 15.♘bd4 there also follows 15...♘e4. For example, the game Sunye Neto – Kasparov, Graz 1981, continued 16.h3 ♗xf3 17.♘xf3 ♕d6 18.♕d3 ♘g5 19.♖fd1 ♖cd8 20.♔f1 ♘e4 with excellent play for Black.

15....♘e4 16.♘bd4 ♕d6 17.g3 h5. A sharp move. 17...♕f6 with the threat of 18...♗xf3 was in the spirit of the position.

18.♘xc6. This relieves Black of the problem of his isolated pawn. The immediate 18.♘h4!? was stronger.

18...bxc6 19.♘h4 ♗h3 20.♖fd1 ♕h6 21.♗f3.



21...g5! Black goes onto the offensive.

22.♘g2 h4 23.♕e2 ♗f5 24.♗d4 hxg3 25.fxg3 ♖e6. 25...♗d6 26.♖f1 c5 was also possible, but Black is carried away by his attack on the king.

26.♖f1 ♕h3 27.♘e1 g4.



28.♗g2? White should have reconciled himself to 28.♗xe4 ♗xe4 28.♕f2 f5 and an inferior position, since now Black could have concluded the game with a spectacular queen sacrifice – 28...♕xh2+!! 29.♔xh2 ♘xg3 30.♕a6 ♘e2+ with a mating attack. But Black committed an irreparable mistake, disrupting the logical course of the game.

28...♘xg3?? 29.hxg3 ♕xg3 30.♖xf5 ♕h4 31.♗xd5 ♖h6 32.♕g2 ♖c7 33.♘f3 ♕h3 34.♖g5+ ♔f8 35.♗g7+ ♔e8 36.♗xh6. Black resigned.

NEUKIRCH – UHLMANN

East German Championship, Potsdam 1974

French Defence C09

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♗b5+ ♘c6 6.♘gf3 ♗d6 7.0-0 cxd4 8.♘b3 ♘ge7 9.♘bxd4 0-0 10.♗g5 ♕c7 11.h3.



11...f6! Wolfgang Uhlmann is one of the most devoted supporters of the French Defence – against 1.e4 he has invariably replied 1...e6. Naturally, he is also a great expert on this type of position. Therefore this not altogether typical weakening of the e6-square should be regarded as a strictly concrete measure. In view of White's pawn being at h3, he cannot exchange the dark-square bishops by ♗h4-g3-d6. At the same time, the weakness of the e6-square is insignificant, and Black gains the opportunity to centralise his knight at c5, from where it controls c4.

12.♗e3 ♘e5 13.b3 (preventing ♘e5-c4) **13...a6 14.♗e2 ♗d7 15.♕d2 b5 16.♖ad1 ♔h8 17.♘e1.** With the idea of driving away the knight by 18.f4.

17...♘5g6! Black neutralises White's intentions, threatening if 18.f4 to play 18...f5 followed by the transfer of a knight to e4 (♘e7-g8-f6-e4).

18.♘d3 f5! The white pieces are huddled together on the central files and are hindering one another, which allows Black to launch an offensive.

19.♗g5 f4 20.♝xe7 ♗.xe7 21.♗g4 ♗f6 22.♗.xd7 ♗xd4 23.♗g4 ♗c3 24.♕e2 f3! 25.♕e3 ♖ae8 26.♕c5 ♕xc5 27.♘xc5 fxg2 28.♔xg2 h5 29.♗d7 ♘f4+ 30.♔g1 ♖e7. White resigned.

SCHMID – PORTISCH

Olympiad, Nice 1974

French Defence C09

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.♘gf3 ♘c6 5.exd5 exd5 6.♗b5 ♗d6 7.dxc5 ♗xc5 8.0-0 ♘ge7 9.♘b3 ♗d6 10.♗g5 0-0 11.♗h4 ♗g4 12.♗e2 ♖e8 13.♖e1 ♕b6 14.♘fd4 ♗.xe2 15.♖xe2.



15...♝e5! Exploiting the power of his dark-square bishop, Black provokes a crisis on the d4 blockading point.

16.♘xc6. A forced exchange, since 16.♖d2 ♘xd4 17.♘xd4 ♗.xd4 18.♖xd4 ♘f5 19.♖f4 ♘xh4 20.♖xh4 ♕xb2 leads to the loss of a pawn. If 16.c3 there follows 16... ♗.xd4.

16...♘xc6 17.c3 a5! The advance of the a-pawn is an important device in the attack on the queenside. If 18.♕xd5? there follows 18...a4 19.♘c5 ♕b5 with the threat of ♖a8-a5.

18.♖b1 a4 19.♘d2 ♕b5! 20.♗g3 ♗f6 (avoiding the exchange of the important bishop) **21.♖xe8+ ♖xe8 22.♕f1 ♕e5! 23.♖e1.**



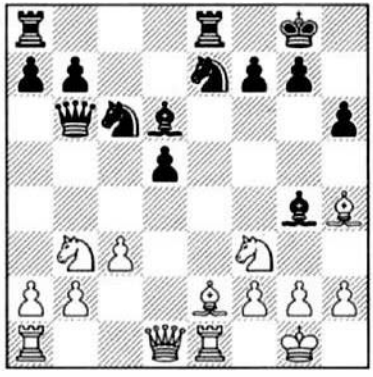
23...♖d8! Black avoids exchanges, since his pieces are much the more active. The rook may be able to aid the d5-d4 breakthrough.

24.a3 h6 25.♕d3 ♕b6 26.♕c2 ♕b5 27.♝c7 ♖c8 28.♗f4 ♘d4! 29.♕d1 ♘e6 30.♕g4 h5 31.♕f5 ♖e8 32.♘f3 ♕xb2 and Black converted his advantage into a win.

For many years Rafael Vaganian has been famed as an expert on the French Defence, and his games are especially worthy of study.

PSAKHIS – VAGANIAN
Moscow 1981
French Defence C09

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘gf3 ♘c6 6.♗b5 ♗d6 7.dxc5 ♗xc5 8.0-0 ♘ge7 9.♘b3 ♗d6 10.♖e1 0-0 11.♗g5 ♗g4 12.♗e2 ♖e8 13.c3 h6 14.♗h4 ♕b6.



By activating his queen, Black not only takes control of the important d4 blockading point, but if 15.♗g3 he has prepared 15...♗xg3 18.hxg3 ♘f5 with the threat of ♘xg3.

15.♗xe7. White exchanges his bishop in the hope of further simplification after 15...♘xe7 16.♘fd4. More logical was the immediate 15.♘fd4 ♗xe2 (15...♗d7 16.♗g3 ♗xg3 17.hxg3 ♘g6, intending ♘ge5, is also possible) 16.♖xe2 ♘g6 17.♗g3 ♘xd4 18.♘xd4 ♖e4 with an equal game, A.Rodriguez – Vaganian, Biel Interzonal 1985.

15...♖xe7! 16.♕xd5 ♖ae8 17.♕d2 a5! Black has gained a serious initiative for the sacrificed pawn.

18.h3 (if 18.♘bd4?!, then 18... ♗c5! is unpleasant) **18...♗g3!**



A picturesque position – the culmination of Black's attack! The capture on f2 is threatened, and 19.♗d1? does not defend against this: 19...♖xe1+ 20.♘xe1 ♗xf2+!

19.♘bd4 ♗xf3 20.♗f1! The only move; if 20.♗xf3?, then 20... ♘xd4 21.cxd4 ♕xb2!.

20...♗xf2+. Black relieves the situation, now leaving White with the problem of an isolated pawn. But, apparently, better chances were offered by 20...♖xe1 21.♖xe1 ♖xe1 22.♕xe1 ♘xd4 23.♕e8+ ♔h7

24.♗d3+ f5 25.cxd4 ♗xf2+ 26.♔f1 ♗xd4 27.gxf3 ♕c5.

21.♔xf2 ♘xd4 22.cxd4 ♗d5 23.♖xe7 ♖xe7 24.b3 ♖e4 25.♖d1 ♕f6+ 26.♔g1 b6 27.♗c4. With difficulty White has managed to maintain the balance.

27...♕d6 28.♕d3 g6 29.a4 ♔g7 30.♗xd5 ♕xd5 31.♕c4 ♕d6 32.♕c3 ♕d5 33.♕c4 ♕d6. Draw.

A.SOKOLOV – VAGANIAN
Candidates Tournament,
Montpellier 1985
French Defence C09

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘gf3 ♘c6 6.♗b5 ♗d6 7.0-0 cxd4 8.♘b3 ♘e7 9.♘bxd4 0-0 10.c3 ♗g4 11.♕a4 ♗h5 12.♖e1 ♕c7 13.♗f1.



White has gained control of d4, but the active placing of Black's pieces enables him to develop energetic counterplay, based on the d5-pawn's control of the important central squares e4 and c4.

13...a6! Defending against 14.♘b5. It was risky to play 13... ♘xd4?! 14.♘xd4 ♗xh2+ 15.♔h1, when Black has to reckon with the threat of ♘d4-b5 (15...♗d6? 16.♘b5 ♕d7 17.♕h4! ♗g6 18.♘xd6).

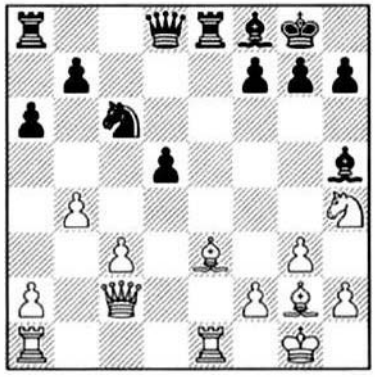
14.g3 ♘a5. The knight is switched to a more active position at c4.

15.♘h4 ♘c4 16.♕c2. A pair of minor pieces should have been exchanged – 16.♘f5 ♘xf5 17.♘xf5.

16...♖fe8 17.♗g5 ♘c6 (attacking the key blockading square d4) **18.♘df5 ♗f8 19.♘e3 ♕a5!** With the idea after 20.♗g2 of carrying out the d5-d4 breakthrough – 20... ♘xe3 21.♗xe3 d4 22.cxd4 ♘xd4!

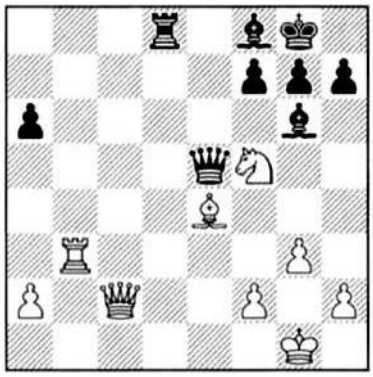
20.b4?! ♘xe3 21.♗xe3 ♕d8. It is hard for White to fight for the d4-point, since the bishop at h5 prevents his rook from going to d1, and at the same time the knight at h4 is out of play.

22.♗g2.



22...d4! The opening of the position leads to a real advantage thanks to the two active bishops.

23.♗xd4 (23.♗xc6 d3!) **23...♘xd4 24.cxd4 ♕xd4 25.♗xb7 ♗xb4 26.♘f5 ♕f6 27.♖xe8+ ♖xe8 28.♖b1 ♗f8 29.♝e4 ♗g6 30.♗d3 ♖d8 31.♗e4 ♕e5 32.♖b3.**

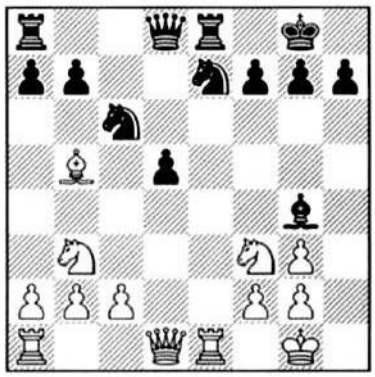


32...h5?! This outwardly active move allows White to consolidate his position. Black could have fought for an advantage with 32...♖e8 33.♗d3 ♗c5.

33.♖e3! ♕a1+ 34.♔g2 ♖d1 35.♕e2 ♖g1+ 36.♔h3 ♝c5 37.♘e7+ ♗xe7 38.♗xg6 fxg6 39.♖xe7 ♔h7 40.♖e6 ♕d4 41.♕e4 ♕xe4 42.♖xe4. Draw.

A.SOKOLOV – VAGANIAN
Candidates Match, 6th Game, Minsk 1986
French Defence C09

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘gf3 ♘c6 6.♗b5 ♗d6 7.dxc5 ♗xc5 8.0-0 ♘e7 9.♘b3 ♗d6 10.♖e1 0-0 11.♗g5 ♗g4 12.♗h4 ♖e8 13.♗g3 ♗xg3 14.hxg3.



14...♕b6! With gain of tempo Black brings his queen to an active position, from where it controls the important d4-point.

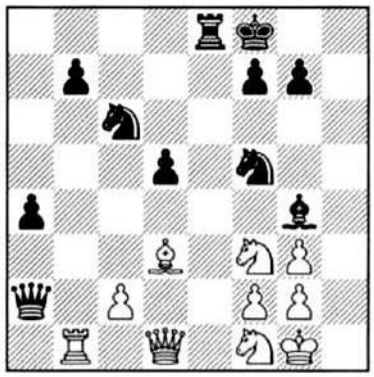
15.♗d3 a5! The march of this pawn, threatening to break up White's pawns on the queenside, is one of the important resources for Black in this type of position. He ignores the threat of 16.♗xh7+, hoping to gain several tempi for his queenside play.

16.♗xh7+?! (16.a4 was more circumspect) **16...♔f8!** (with the threats of g7-g6 and a5-a4) **17.♗d3.** 17.♕c1? was worse in view of 17...♝xf3 18.gxf3 a4 19.♘d2 g6!, when the bishop is trapped, since nothing is given by 20.♘c4 ♕d4.

17...a4 18.♘bd2 ♘f5! Threatening to capture on g3, whereas 18...♕xb2?! would hand the initiative to

White: 19.♖b1 ♕xa2 20.♕c1 and the queen is in a dangerous position.

19.♖xe8+ ♖xe8 20.♘f1 ♕xb2 21.♖b1 ♕xa2.



22.♕c1. If 22.♖xb7 there would have followed 22...d4!, not fearing 23.♗b5 ♕d5 24.♗xa4 ♘e5! 25.♗xe8, and now not 25...♘xf3+? 26.gxf3 ♗xf3 27.♖b8 or 25...♗xf3? 26.♖b8, which favours White, but the simple 25...♕xb7.

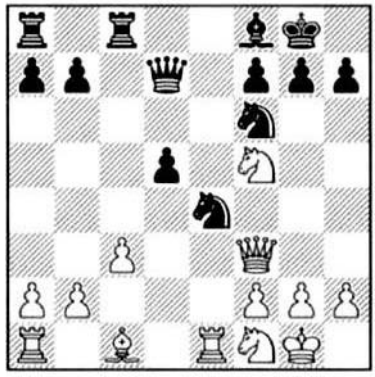
22...d4 23.♘3h2 ♘h6 24.♘xg4 ♘xg4 25.♖a1 ♕d5 26.♖xa4 b5! 27.♖a6 ♘ge5 28.♕a3+ b4 29.♕a4 ♘xd3 30.cxd3. Both 30.♕xc6 ♕xc6 31.♖xc6 ♘c1 32.♖c4 ♖e1 33.f3 d3 34.cxd3 b3 35.♖b4 ♖e2 and 30.♖xc6 ♘e1! 31.f3 d3 32.♕xb4+ ♔g8 33.♖d6 ♕a2 were also advantageous to Black (Vaganian).

30...♖e6 31.♖b6 g6 32.♖b5 ♕d6 33.f4 ♖e1! 34.♖b6 ♖c1, and Black gained an overwhelming advantage.

NAUMANN – VAGANIAN
Bundesliga 2005
French Defence C08

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘gf3 ♘f6 6.♗b5+ ♗d7 7.♗xd7+ ♘bxd7 8.0-0 ♗e7 9.dxc5 ♘xc5 10.♘d4 ♕d7 11.♕f3 0-0 12.♘f5 ♖fc8. In Azarov – Dolmatov, Greece 2003, Black followed a plan recommended by Kasparov: 12...♗d8 13.♘b3 ♘ce4 14.♗c3 ♖c8 15.c3 ♖e8 16.♗d4 a5, and obtained good play.

13.♖e1 ♗f8 14.♘f1 ♘ce4 15.c3.



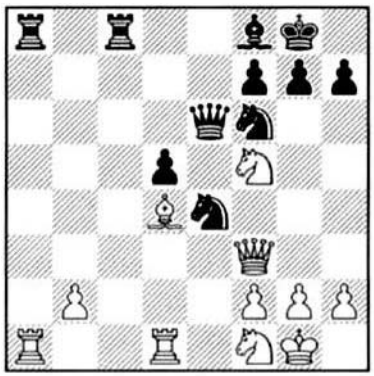
15...b5. Black carries out the plan of an attack on the queenside, based on the centralisation of his pieces: the d5-pawn supports the knight on e4, and the bishop at f8 supports the pawn offensive.

16.a3. The alternative was 16.♗e3 b4 17.cxb4 ♗xb4 18.♖cc1 g6 19.♘d4 ♗d6.

16...a5 17.♗e3 b4 18.axb4 axb4

19.cxb4 ♗xb4 20.♖ed1 ♗18. 20...♖xa1 also came into consideration: 21.♖xa1 g6 22.♘d4 (22.♘h6+ ♔g7 23.♖d1 ♗c5!) 22...♘g4 23.♖d1 ♗d6 24.h3 ♘xe3 25.♘xe3 ♕b7 with counterplay.

21.♗d4 ♕e6.



22.♘1e3. Stronger was 22.♖xa8 ♖xa8 23.♘1e3 g6 24.♘g3 ♖d8 (24...♗g7? 25.♘xd5!) 25.♘e2 ♗g7 26.♘f4 ♕e8 27.b4, and White's chances are preferable.

22...♘d2! Black forces the exchange of the important dark-square bishop, after which it will be easier for its surviving opposite number to control d4.

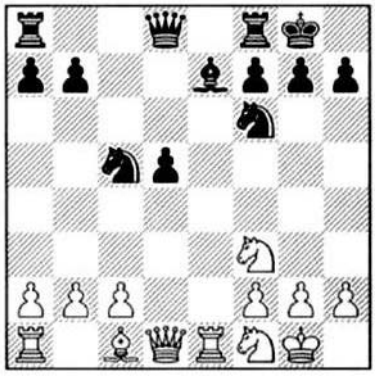
23.♕f4 ♖xa1 24.♖xa1 ♘b3 25.♖d1 ♘xd4 26.♘xd4 ♕b6 27.b3 ♖e8 28.♘ec2 g6 29.h3 ♘e4 30.♕f3 ♗g7. The same strategy of pressure on the centre.

31.♘e2 ♕b5 32.♘cd4 ♕c5 33.♕d3 ♖c8 34.♕e3 ♕b4 35.♕d3 ♘c3 36.♘xc3 ♖xc3 37.♕b5 ♕xb5. Draw.

Of the modern elite grandmasters, a great expert on positions with an isolated pawn is Vasily Ivanchuk, who successfully plays them with both colours. His strategy of counterplay with a d5-pawn is based on active pressure on the central squares.

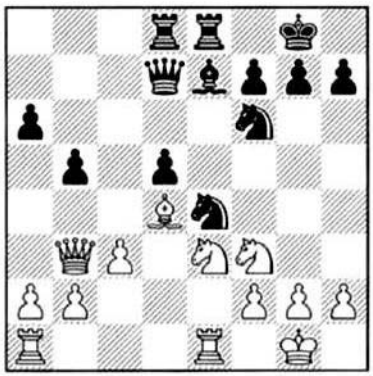
DELGADO – IVANCHUK
Havana 2005
French Defence C08

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.♘gf3 ♘f6 5.exd5 exd5 6.♗b5+ ♗d7 7.♗xd7+ ♘bxd7 8.0-0 ♗e7 9.dxc5 ♘xc5 10.♖e1 0-0 11.♘f1.



11...a5. Since White's plan of blockading the d4-square usually includes the move c2-c3, Black prepares an attack on this pawn. However, this more often occurs with the move order 11...♖e8 12.♗c3 a5. The plan of controlling the c4-point after a7-a6 and b7-b5 also occurs, creating for White the motif of attacking

the b-pawn by a2-a4. For example, the game Rublevsky – Bareev, Moscow 2005, continued: 12...b5 13.c3 ♕d7 14.♗d4 ♖ad8 15.♘c3 ♘cc4 16.♕b3 a6.



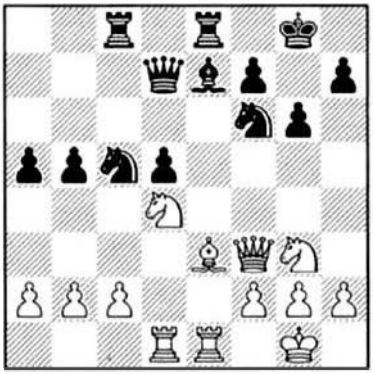
17.♘e5!? ♕b7?! 18.♘d3 ♕c6 19.a4! ♘d2 (19....♗d6 20.axb5 axb5 21.f3 also favours White) 20.♕c2 ♘c4 21.axb5 axb5 22.♘f5 ♗f8 23.b3 ♘b6 24.♘e5 with an obvious advantage to White.

Black's defensive mistakes were associated with inadequate control of the squares adjacent to the d5-pawn. 17...♕c7 (instead of 17...♕b7?!) was more active, and now if 18.a4 ♗c5 19.♘f3 ♗xd4, when 20.♘xd4 is bad because of 20...♘xf2! White would have had to restrict himself to 18.♘d3 ♗d6.

12.♗c3 b5 13.♘d4 ♕d7 14.♕f3 g6 15.♖ad1 ♖fe8 16.♘g3 ♖ac8.

(See diagram)

Black has developed his pieces in active positions, from where they



control the squares adjacent to the d5-pawn. A dynamically balanced position has arisen.

17.a3. Or 17.c3 b4 18.cxb4 axb4 with an equal game.

17...b4 18.axb5 axb5 19.♗g5 ♘ce4! Black's play is still based on control of the central squares.

20.♗xf6. If 20.♗c3 there can follow 20...♘g4, since 21.♘xe4 dxe4 22.♕xe4 ♗d6 23.♕f3 ♗xh2+ is unfavourable for White.

20...♘xf6 21.h3 ♗d8. The bishop is switched to b6 in order to control the d4-point.

22.♖xe8+ ♕xe8 23.♘f1 ♕e5 24.♕b3 ♗b6 25.♕xb4 ♗xd4 26.♕xd4 ♕xd4 27.♖xd4 ♖xc2 28.♘e3 ♖xb2 29.♘xd5. Draw.

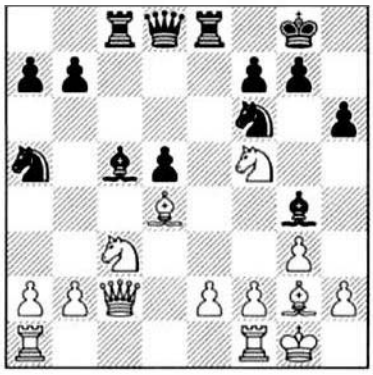
S. SAVCHENKO – IVANCHUK

Cruise Odessa-Istanbul 2006

Queen's Gambit D34

1.♘f3 d5 2.d4 c5 3.c4 e6 4.cxd5 exd5 5.g3 ♘f6 6.♗g2 ♗e7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♘c3 ♘c6 9.♗g5 cxd4

10.♘xd4 h6 11.♗e3 ♖e8 12.♕b3 ♘a5 13.♕c2 ♗g4 14.♘f5 ♖c8 15.♗d4 ♗c5.



16.e3?! This move weakens the light squares, which allows Black to develop an energetic initiative. The classical continuation is 16.♗xc5 ♖xc5. For example, the 9th game of the Karpov – Kasparov world championship match, Moscow 1984/85, continued: 17.♘e3 ♗e6 (White is better after 17...d4?! 18.♖ad1 ♘c6 19.♘xg4 ♘xg4 20.e3, when it is not easy for Black to escape from the pin) 18.♖ad1 ♕c8 19.♕a4 ♖d8 20.♖d3 a6 21.♖fd1 ♘c4 22.♘xc4 ♖xc4 23.♕a5 ♖c5 24.♕b6 ♖d7 25.♖d4 ♕c7 26.♕xc7 ♖dxc7, and Black was able to repel the frontal attack on the isolated d5-pawn. It should be mentioned that the pawn is defended by the rook from c5, where it is more actively placed than behind the pawn. We will also encounter this defensive procedure in subsequent examples.

16...♘e4! Regarding 16...♗xf5 17.♕xf5 ♗xd4 18.exd4, it is appropriate to repeat Bondarevsky's assertion: 'You don't play the Tarrasch Defence in order to worry about the isolated d5-pawn'.

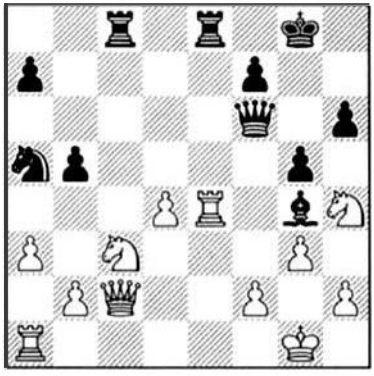
17.♘h4. 17.♗xe4!? dxe4 18.♖ad1 ♗xd1 19.♖xd1 came into consideration, with definite compensation for the exchange.

17...♗xd4 18.exd4 b5 19.a3 ♕f6. 19...♘c6 was also in the spirit of the position.

20.♖fe1 g5!? Vasily Ivanchuk is true to himself – the main thing is the initiative! 20...♕xd4 21.h3 ♗h5 22.♗xe4 dxe4 23.♖xe4 ♖xe4 24.♕xe4 ♕xe4 25.♘xe4 would have led to a roughly equal endgame.

21.♗xe4. A forced exchange, since 21.h3? gxh4 22.hxg4 hxg4 is bad for White.

21...dxe4 22.♖xe4.



A critical point of the game. White has parried the immedi-

ate threats, and Black should have retreated his bishop – 22...♗e6 23.♘g2 ♖ed8, when in view of the threat of ♗f5 he retains sufficient compensation for the sacrificed pawn. But the game went **22...♗h3? 23.♘d5! ♕d6 24.♘f5!**, and White seized the initiative.

VAN WELY – IVANCHUK
Monaco 2006
Slav Defence D15

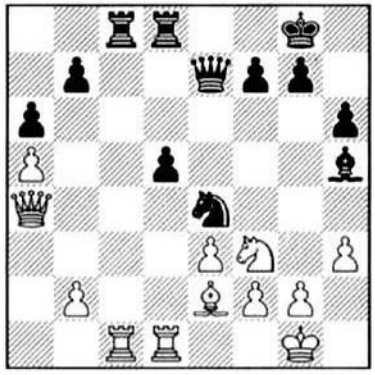
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘f3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 a6 5.a4 e6 6.♗g5 ♘bd7 7.♕c2 h6 8.♗h4 ♗e7 9.e3 0-0 10.a5 c5 11.dxc5 ♘xc5 12.cxd5 ♘xd5 13.♘xd5 exd5 14.♗xe7 ♕xe7 15.♗e2.



White has achieved the exchange of the dark-square bishops and a blockade of the queenside weaknesses. But he has delayed castling, which Black energetically exploits.

15...♗g4 16.0-0 ♖ac8 17.♖fd1 ♖fd8 18.h3 ♘e4 19.♕a4. If 19.♕b3 there can follow 19...♗e6 with the idea of 20.♖ac1 ♖xc1 21.♖xc1 d4.

19...♗h5 20.♖ac1. A routine move. 20.♖dc1 is more accurate, when if 20...♘g3 there is the retreat 21...♝d1.



20...♘g3! Black seizes the initiative.

21.♗d3. Of course, 21.♖xc8 ♘xe2+ 22.♔f1 ♖xc8 23.♔xe2 ♖c4 was safer, although this position cannot be considered an achievement for White.

21...♖xc1 22.♖xc1 ♗xf3 23.gxf3 d4 24.♕c4 dxe3?! Black's powerful initiative would have been worthily crowned by the knight retreat 24...♘h5! Now, however, White succeeds in consolidating his forces.

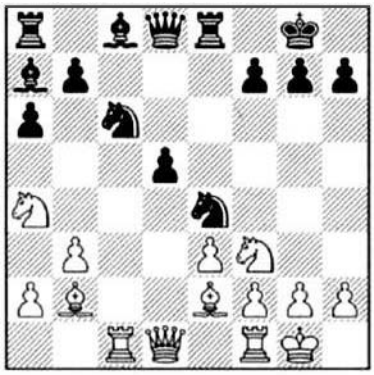
25.fxg3 ♕d6 26.♗f1 ♕xg3+ 27.♔h1 ♕xf3+ 28.♗g2 ♖d1+ 29.♖xd1 ♕xd1+ 30.♔h2 e2 31.♕c8+ ♔h7 32.♕f5+ ♔g8 33.♕c8+ ♔h7 34.♕f5+. Draw.

GERSHON – IZORIA

Athens 2005

Queen's Gambit D32

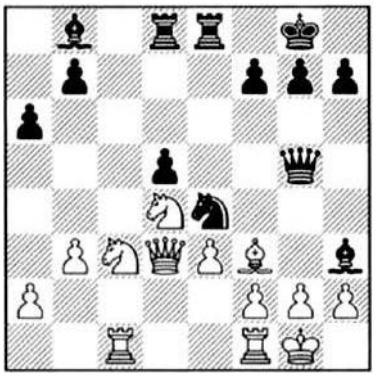
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 a6 4.e3 ♘f6 5.♘f3 c5 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♗e2 ♗d6 8.0-0 0-0 9.dxc5 ♗xc5 10.b3 ♘c6 11.♗b2 ♗a7 12.♖c1 ♖e8 13.♘a4 ♘e4.



14.♗d4. Black has developed his pieces in active positions, and White already has problems in choosing an effective plan. The exchange of the dark-square bishop seems dubious, but apparently White did not like Black's activity after 14.♘d4 ♕d6 15.♗f3 ♘c5.

14...♘xd4 15.♘xd4 ♕g5 16.♕d3. The threat of ♗h3 could have been prevented by 16.♗f3 ♗d7 17.♘c3 (not 17.♖c7? because of 17...♗xa4 18.bxa4 ♘xf2!) 17...♖ac8 18.♕d3 ♕e5 19.♖fd1 ♗b8 20.g3, although here after 20...♗a7 Black also has an excellent game.

16...♝h3 17.♗f3 ♖ad8 18.♘c3 ♗b8.



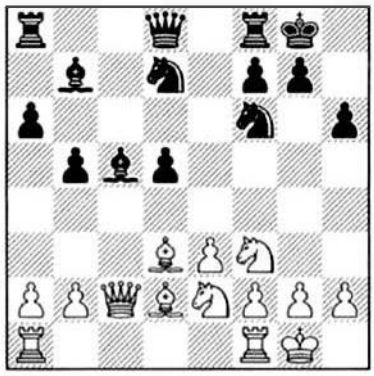
19.♘de2?! White underestimates Black's threats. 19.♘ce2!? was more circumspect, intending to answer 19...h5 with 20.♘f4. The acceptance of the pawn sacrifice 19.♘xe4 dxe4 20.♗xe4 ♕e5 21.♗xh7+ (21.♘f3 ♕h5! is dangerous) 21...♔h8 22.f4 ♕xe3+ 23.♕xe3 ♖xe3 24.♗f5 ♗xf5 25.♘xf5 ♖e2 would have led to a better endgame for Black.

19...h5! 20.♘g3. If 20.♖fd1 Black increases his initiative: 20...♗f5 (20...h4 21.♘xd5) 21.♕d4 ♗e5 22.♕b6 ♘xc3 23.♘xc3 d4.

20...h4 21.gxh3 hxg4 22.hxg3 ♘xg3! 23.fxg3 ♕xg3+ 24.♝g2 ♖xc3 25.♕d4 ♕h2+ 26.♔f2 ♖de8 (with a threat of mate) **27.♕xe3 ♖xe3 28.♔xe3 ♕xg2 29.♔d3 ♕xh3+ 30.♔c2 ♗e5 31.♘e2 ♕e3 32.♖fe1 g6 33.♖cd1 ♕e4+ 34.♔c1 d4 35.♘g1 ♝f4+ 36.♔b2 ♝e3 37.♘e2 ♗f2.** White resigned.

L'AMI – SARGISSIAN
Wijk aan Zee 2007, Tournament B
Queen's Gambit D38

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 d5 4.♘c3 ♗b4 5.♗g5 ♘bd7 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♕c2 c5 8.dxc5 h6 9.♗d2 ♗xc5 10.e3 0-0 11.♗d3 a6 12.0-0 b5 13.♘e2 ♗b7.



This position can be considered dynamically balanced. Here 14.b4!? ♗d6 (weaker is 14...♗b6 15.♗c3 ♘c4 16.♗d4) 15.♘ed4 ♘c4 should have been considered, when although White firmly controls the d4-point, Black is established at c4. But White underestimated Black's counterplay along the a7-g1 diagonal, based on the coordination of his dark-square bishop, knight and rook.

14.♘g3 ♖c8 15.♕b1 ♖e8 16.♖c1 ♘c4 17.♗e1? Even here it was not too late for 17.b4 ♗b6 18.♖xc8 ♕xc8 19.♕b2 ♘df6 20.♖c1 ♕d7, simplifying the position, although in less favourable circumstances.

17...♘xg3 18.hxg3.



18...♖xe3! 19.b4 ♖xf3 20.bxc5 ♖f6 21.a4 ♘xc5 22.axb5 axb5 23.♗h7+. 23.♗xb5? d4 was clearly weaker.

23...♔h8 24.♗f5 ♘e6. 24...♖cc6 25.♕xb5 ♖xf5 26.♖xc5 ♖xc5 27.♕xc5 would have led to the same material balance as in the game.

25.♖xc8 ♕xc8 26.♗xe6 ♖xe6. White would have had more difficult problems to solve after 26...fxe6! 27.♕xb5 e5 28.♖a7 ♖f7.

27.♕xb5 d4. The outcome is that Black has won a pawn, although in trying to convert it he has to reckon with the drawing tendencies of opposite-colour bishops.

28.♗d2 ♗c6 29.♕b4 ♕d7 30.♖e1 ♖f6. After the rook exchange 30...♖xc1+ 31.♗xc1 ♕d5 32.f3 d3 33.♗d2 the passed pawn is blockaded.

31.f3 ♔h7 32.♖e7 ♕d8 33.♖e5 d3 34.g4 ♖d6 35.♕f4 f6 36.♖e3 ♕d7 37.♖e1 ♗b7. If 37...♖d4 there can follow 38.♖c7! ♕xc7 39.♕xd4 ♕c2 40.♕c3.

38.♖c1 ♗d5 39.♗b4 ♖b6? Black did not want to exchange rooks – 39...♖c6 (after 39...♖a6 40.♖c7 he has to reckon with the activation of the white rook), but the move in the game leads to the loss of a pawn.

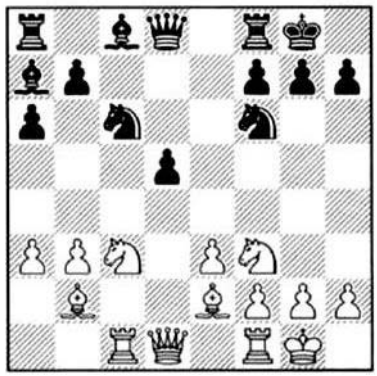
40.♕d4 ♖b7 41.♕xd3+. Draw.

6.2. The d5-d4 breakthrough

It is well known that the dynamic potential of an isolated pawn lies in its 'lust to expand'. But for Black, who has a tempo less for making the d5-d4 breakthrough, it requires more effort to unblock the d4-square. When playing d5-d4 one must assess the consequences of opening the position. We will begin with an 'anti-example'.

RESHEVSKY – GHITESCU
Olympiad, Tel Aviv 1964
Queen's Gambit D32

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘c3 c5 4.e3 ♘c6 5.♘f3 ♘f6 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♗e2 ♗e7 8.dxc5 ♗xc5 9.0-0 0-0 10.b3 a6 11.♗b2 ♗a7 12.♖c1.



12...d4? Black is behind in development, and it is obvious that opening the position will not be to his advantage. 12...♗e6 was correct.

13.exd4 ♘xd4 14.♘xd4 ♕xd4. Black shouldn't have exchanged the queens. After 14...♗xd4 15.♗f3 ♖b8 16.♘a4 ♝xb2 17.♘xb2 ♗c6 18.♘d3 ♕b6 it would be easier for him to defend. Now, however, it is far more difficult for him to resist White's pressure on the queenside.

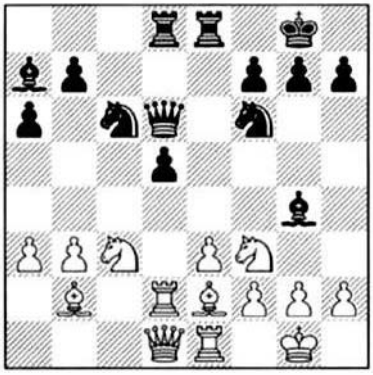
15.♕xd4 ♗xd4 16.♖fd1 ♗a7 17.h3! An important move, restricting the opponent's pieces. 17.♗f3 can be met by 17...♗g4 18.♝xb7 ♗xd1 19.♗xa8 ♗xb3, equalising the position.

17...♝f5 18.♗f3 ♖ab8 19.g4! With the march of his g-pawn White drives the black pieces from the centre.

19...♗g6 20.g5 ♘h5 21.♘d5 ♖fe8 22.♖c7 ♚h8 23.♘e7 ♘f4 24.♘xg6+ hxg6 25.♖xf7 ♘xh3+ 26.♔g2 ♘xf2 27.♖dd7. Black resigned.

WIRTHENSOHN – TAL
Olympiad, Luzern 1982
Queen's Gambit D32

1.c4 ♘f6 2.♘c3 c5 3.♘f3 e6 4.e3 d5 5.cxd5 exd5 6.d4 ♘c6 7.♗e2 ♗e7 8.dxc5 ♗xc5 9.0-0 0-0 10.b3 a6 11.♗b2 ♕d6 12.♖c1 ♗a7 13.♖e1 ♖e8 14.a3 ♗g4 15.♖c2 ♖ad8 16.♖d2.



The black pieces are developed in active positions, whereas the white pieces are poorly coordinated. The time has come for decisive action.

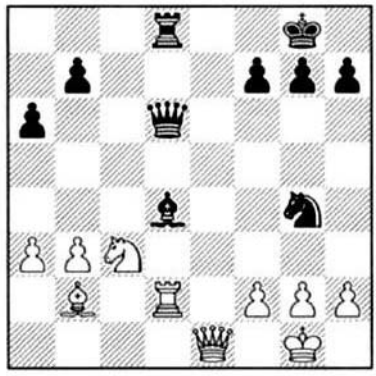
16...d4! As a result of the opening of the position, the activity of the black pieces increases significantly.

17.♘xd4. The d4-pawn cannot be ignored – 17.♘b1 ♗xf3 18.♗xf3 dxe3 19.♖xe3 (19.fxe3 ♖xe3!) 19...♖xe3 20.♖xd6 ♖xd6 21.♕c1 ♖xb3 is obviously favourable for Black. Apparently the lesser evil was 17.exd4 ♗xf3 18.♗xf3 ♖xe1+ 19.♕xe1 ♘xd4 20.♔h1 ♖e8, but here too Black's initiative is very dangerous.

17...♘xd4 18.exd4. If 18.♗xg4, then 18...♘f3+! or 18...♘xg4 19.♕xg4 ♘f3+ is decisive.

18...♗xd4 (with the threat of 19....♗xf2) **19.♗xg4 ♖xe1+.** 19...♘xg4 was more accurate: 20.g3 ♕h6 21.♖xe8+ ♖xe8 22.h4 ♘xf2 23.♖xf2 ♕c3 24.♘c4 ♗xb2 25.♕d7 ♖f8 with a winning position.

20.♕xe1 ♘xg4.



21.♘e4? This loses quickly. 21.g3 ♕h6 22.♕e7 ♖f8 23.♘e4 ♗xb2 24.♖d8 g6 25.h3 was more tenacious, although even here after 25....♗xa3! Black transposes into a won endgame.

21...♕xh2+ 22.♔f1 ♕h1+ 23.♔e2 ♕xg2 24.♔d1 ♕f3+ 25.♕e2 ♕h1+ 26.♕e1 ♕f3+ 27.♕e2 ♕xb3+ 28.♔e1 ♘e5 29.♘g5 ♗c3. White resigned.

TAL – AGZAMOV
Sochi 1984
Queen's Gambit D32

1.c4 c5 2.♘f3 ♘f6 3.♘c3 e6 4.e3 ♘c6 5.d4 d5 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♗e2 cxd4 8.♘xd4 ♗d6 9.0-0 0-0 10.♘f3 a6 11.b3 ♖e8 12.♗b2 ♗c7 13.♕d3 ♕d6 14.♖fd1? 14.g3!? was essential.



White has underestimated the threats posed by the queen + bishop battery, and this allows Black to open the position to his advantage.

14...d4! 15.exd4 ♗g4. This forces a weakening of the king's position and creates the possibility in certain variations of exploiting the pin on the knight at f3. This standard attacking mechanism, based on the breakthrough of the d-pawn, is examined in Part I (Chapter 2) in the game Petrosian – Balashov, Moscow 1974 (p.??).

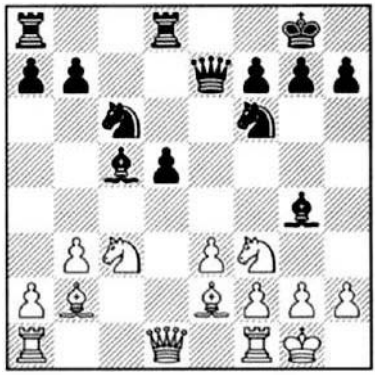
16.g3. It is also not possible to defend after 16.♔f1 ♘b4! 17.♕d2 ♗xf3 18.♗xf3 ♕xh2 19.g3 ♘g4! 20.♘c4 f5.

16...♘b4! An important interposition. Now if 17.♕d2?! the thematic pinning mechanism goes into operation: 17...♖xc2! 18.♕xc2 ♖c8, and White loses material.

17.♗a3 ♘xd3 18.♗xd6 ♗xd6 19.♖xd3 ♗b4! 20.♗f1 ♗f5 21.♘d1 ♗xd3 22.♗xd3 ♘d5, and Black converted his exchange advantage.

FISH – LAUTIER
Saint Vincent 2005
Nimzo-Indian Defence E56

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 c6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.♘f3 d5 5.e3 0-0 6.♗d3 c5 7.0-0 ♘c6 8.cxd5 exd5 9.dxc5 ♗g4 10.♗e2 ♕e7 11.b3 ♗xc5 12.♗b2 ♖fd8.



13.♘d4. White blocks the d5-pawn, since if 13.♖c1 or 13.♖c1 there follows 13...d4, but it would have been better to do this after 13.♘a4 ♗d6 and now 14.♘d4.

13...♗xd4! 14.♗xg4?! White persists in the retention of Black's isolated pawn and as a result he comes under a strong initiative, whereas after 14.exd4 Black's position is merely slightly preferable.

14...♗e5 15.♗h3. If 15.♗f3 there would have followed 15...d4! 16.cxd4 ♖xd4 17.♕c2 ♖ad8 with a spatial advantage for Black.

15...♘e4 16.♖c1? 16.♕c1 was essential, since now Black makes a breakthrough in the centre, exploiting the opposition of rook and queen.



16...d4! 17.exd4. White should have reconciled himself to 17.♘xe4 dxe4 18.♕c2 ♗xb2 19.♕xb2 ♕xe4, when Black has the advantage.

17...♖xd4 18.♘d5 (18.♕e1 ♘d2) **18...♗xh2+ 19.♔h1.** Also after 19.♔xh2 ♕d6+ 20.♔g1 ♖xd1 21.♖fxd1 ♕h6 22.♗f5 ♕h4 White does not have compensation for the queen.

19...♘xf2+ 20.♖xf2 ♖xd1+ 21.♖xd1 ♕h4 22.♖e2 ♗g3 23.♖d3 ♕g5 24.♖e4 h5 25.♖ee3 ♗e5 26.♗a3 ♔h8 27.♖f3 ♘d4 28.♖xf7 ♕g6. White resigned.

BAREEV – IVANCHUK

Havana 2006

Nimzo-Indian Defence E37

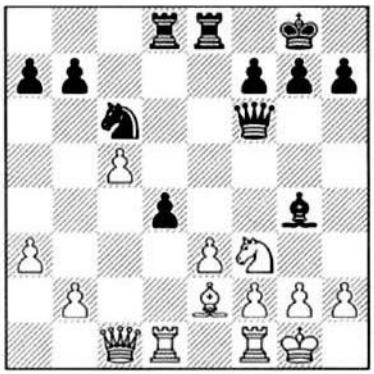
1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗b4 4.♕c2 d5 5.a3 ♗xc3+ 6.♕xc3 ♘e4 7.♕c2 c5 8.dxc5 ♘c6 9.cxd5 exd5 10.♘f3 ♕f6 11.e3 ♗g4 12.♗e2 0-0 13.0-0 ♖fe8 14.♗d2.



14...d4! The d5-d4 breakthrough disrupts the harmony in the placing of the white pieces.

15.♖ad1. The dynamic strength of the breakthrough by the d-pawn is especially effective after 15.♖ae1? – 15...d3! 16.♗xd3 (16.♕xd3 ♗xf3 17.♗xf3 ♖ad8) 16...♗xf3 17.gxf3 ♕xf3 with an attack for Black (Ivanchuk).

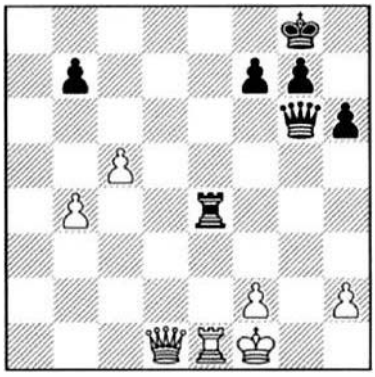
15...♘xd2 (15...♖ad8 16.♗c1!) **16.♕xd2 ♖ad8 17.♕c1.**



17...d3?! As was shown by Ivanchuk, this breakthrough should have been prepared by the useful move 17...h5 18.h3 (if 18.♖fe1, then 18...d3! is now effective since, compared with the game, after the exchange of pieces Black could have included his rook in the attack) 18...d3 19.♖xd3 ♖xd3 20.hxg4 hxg4 21.♗xd3 gxf3 22.g3 ♕h6 23.♖e1 ♖e6 24.♕c4 ♕h3 25.♗f1 ♕h5 26.♖d1 ♖h6 etc.

18.♖xd3 ♖xd3 19.♗xd3 ♗xf3 20.gxf3 ♘e5 21.♗e4 ♘xf3+ 22.♗xf3 ♕xf3 23.♕d1 ♕f5 24.b4. 24.♕d6 h5 25.♖d1 ♖e6 26.♕d8+ ♔h7 27.♕d3 ♖g6+ 28.♔f1 ♕xc5 29.♕d5! ♖g5 30.♕xc5 ♖xc5 31.♖d7 leads to an equal endgame (Ivanchuk).

24...h6 25.♖e1 a5 26.e4 ♕g6+ 27.♗f1 axb4 28.axb4 ♖xe4.



29.♕b1? After the simple 29.♖xe4 ♕xe4 30.♕d8+ ♔h7 31.♕d7! White would not have been in any danger (31...♕xb4 32.♕f5+). But now his king comes under attack.

29...♕a6+ 30.♔g2 ♖g4+ 31.♔h3 ♖g6 32.♕f5? To defend the king, the rook should have been brought up – 32.♖e8+ ♔h7 33.♖e3!, for example: 33...♕f6 34.♕c2 ♕d4 35.♖g3 ♕xb4 36.♖xg6 fxg6 37.e6 bxc6 38.♕xc6, hoping for a draw in the queen endgame.

32...♕c6 33.♖e4. White also fails to save the game with 33.♖e3 ♖g5 34.♕e4 ♕d7+ 35.♔h4 ♕d1 36.♕f3 ♕d4+ 37.♖e4 (37.♕e4 ♕f6) 37...♕d8 38.♔h3 ♕d7+ 39.♔h4 ♖g1 (Ivanchuk).

33...♖g5 34.♕f3 ♕d7+ 35.♔h4 ♖g1 36.♕e3 ♕f5 37.♖e8+ ♔h7 38.♕e4 g5+. White resigned.

A motif for the d5-d4 breakthrough is often provided by the fact that the white king is still in the centre. Here is a typical example.

YUSUPOV – TIMMAN
Tilburg 1987
Queen's Indian Defence E12

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 b6 4.a3 ♗b7 5.♘c3 d5 6.cxd5 ♘xd5 7.♕c2 c5 8.dxc5 ♗xc5 9.♗g5 ♕c8 10.♖c1 h6 11.♗d2 ♘c6 12.♘xd5 exd5 13.c3 0-0 14.♗b5 ♘c7 15.b4 ♗d6 16.♕xc8 ♖fxc8 17.♔e2.



White is threatening with ♗c3 or ♘d4 to establish a blockade on d4, retaining a stable advantage.

17...d4! A pawn sacrifice, enabling Black to activate his light-square bishop.

18.exd4 a6! It is essential to drive the bishop away from the weakened c6-square, which becomes apparent in the line 18...♘d5?! 19.♘e5! f6 20.♗c6.

19.♖xc8+ ♖xc8 20.♗d3 ♘d5. The activity of the black pieces fully compensates for the sacrificed pawn.

21.♖c1 ♖xc1 22.♗xc1 ♘f4+ 23.♗xf4 ♗xf4 24.a4 ♗d6 25.b5 axb5 26.♟xb5 ♗xf3+. It is useful to repeat an old joke: 'the advantage of the two bishops is often expressed in the favourable exchange of one of them'. Black liquidates into a theoretically drawn position with opposite-colour bishops.

27.♔xf3 ♔f8 28.♔e4 ♗a3 29.♔d5 ♗b2 30.♟c4 ♔e7 31.f3 ♗c3, and Black held the endgame.

KORCHNOI – BELIAVSKY
Leon 1994
Queen's Gambit D45

1.c4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e3 ♘f6 4.♘c3 e6 5.♘f3 ♘bd7 6.♕c2 ♗d6 7.b3 0-0 8.♗b2 e5 9.cxd5 cxd5 10.dxe5 ♘xe5 11.♗e2 ♘xf3+ 12.♗xf3.



12...d4! The motive for the pawn sacrifice is White's delay in castling.

13.exd4? Viktor Korchnoi likes to accept sacrificed pawns, but in

the given situation it was correct not to take the pawn, but to sacrifice one – 13.♘e4 ♘xe4 14.♗xe4 dxe4 15.0-0exf2+ 16.♕xf2, obtainingactive play. Now his king is prevented from castling.

13...♖e8+ 14.♔f1. A blitz game Seirawan – Speelman (1992) went 14.♘c2 ♗b4+ 15.♔f1 (no better is 15.♗c3 ♗f5! 16.♕d2 ♗xc3 17.♕xc3 ♖e8 18.♕b4 ♗d3 with an unpleasant pin) 15...♗e6 16.♘f4 ♖c8 with active play for the pawn. In the event of 14.♗e2 ♗g4 15.f3 ♗h5 16.0-0 ♕c7 17.h3 ♗g6 18.♗d3 ♘h5 Black has an unpleasant initiative on the kingside (Korchnoi).

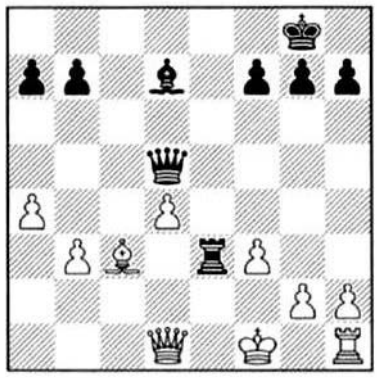
14...♕a5 15.♕d1 ♗b4 16.♖c1 ♗d7. 16...♗e6!? also came into consideration.

17.a3. A difficult decision, but how can 17...♖ac8 be prevented? Of course, not possible was 17.♗xb7? ♗xc3 18.♗xc3 ♕b5+ with the loss of a piece.

17...♗xc3 18.♖xc3. In the event of 18.♗xc3 ♕xa3 19.♗xb7 ♖ab8 20.♖a1 ♕e7 21.♗f3 ♘e4 22.♗xe4 ♕xe4 White may also have problems on the h1-a8 diagonal.

18...♘d5 19.♗xd5. Not 19.♖c5? because of 19...♗b5+ 20.♔g1 ♖e1+, mating on the first rank.

19...♕xd5 20.a4 ♖ae8 21.f3 ♖xe3 22.♗xc3 ♖e3.



23.♗a1. White loses after 23.♕d2? ♖xf3+ 24.gf ♕xf3+ 25.♔g1 ♗c6. But in order to release his rook, he has to part with his queenside pawns.

23...♖xb3 24.♔f2 ♗xa4 25.♖e1 f6. After opening an escape square for his king, Black threatens to win the queen by 26...♖b2+.

26.♕e1 ♗e6 27.♕f4 h5 28.h4 ♖a3 29.♔g3 ♖a2 30.♗c3 ♕f7 31.♕f5. This loses immediately, but if the king moves 31.♔h2 the invasion of the queen is decisive: 31...♕g6 32.♗d2 ♕d3 33.♗b4 ♗xf3 with crushing threats.

31...♕c7+. White resigned.

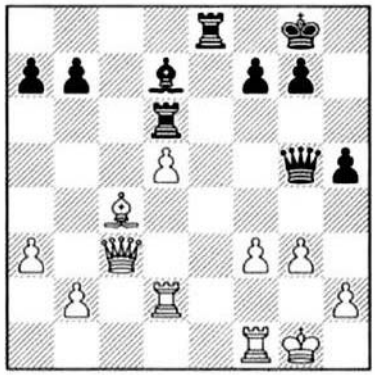
KOROTYLEV – KHAIRULLIN

Moscow 2007

Queen's Gambit D37

1.d4 ♘f6 2.e4 e6 3.♘f3 d5 4.♘e3 ♗e7 5.♗f4 0-0 6.e3 ♘bd7 7.a3 c5 8.cxd5 ♘xd5 9.♘xd5 exd5 10.dxe5 ♘xe5 11.♗e5 ♗f6 12.♗e2 ♗xe5 13.♘xe5 ♘e6 14.♘f3 ♕f6 15.♕d2 ♖d8.





16.♖d1. The attempt to take control of the d4-point with the king still in the centre creates the motive for the d5-d4 breakthrough. After 16.0-0 Black could also have played 16...d4, but in this case White would have gained a spatial advantage by 17.♖ad1 dxe3 18.♕xc3 ♗d7 19.♘e5.

16...d4!? 17.♘xd4. White accepts the pawn sacrifice. 17.0-0 dxe3 would have led to a position from the above variation.

17...♘xd4 18.exd4 ♗d7 19.♕d3 (19.0-0? ♝a4) **19...♗c6 20.0-0 ♖d6 21.♖d2.** In the event of 21.♗f3 ♝xf3 22.♕xf3 ♕xf3 23.gxf3 ♖ad8 24.♖fe1 ♔f8 25.♖e4 g6 in view of the threat of f7-f5 the d4-pawn cannot be held.

21...♕g5 22.g3. If 22.f3 there can follow 22...♖e8 23.♖f2 (23.♕c3 ♖e3) 23...♖ed8 24.♕c3 ♕f4, regaining the pawn with the better position.

22...♕d5 23.f3 ♖e8 24.♕c3 h5 25.♗c4 ♕g5 26.d5 ♗d7.

27.♕d4. 27.f4 ♕h6 (27...♕d8 28.♕d4) 28.♕d4 looks more critical.

27...h4 28.g4 h3 29.♗e2 f5. Draw. White did not want to risk 30.f4 ♕d8!? (30...♕h4 is weaker: 31.♕f2 ♕xf2+ 32.♔xf2 fxg4 33.♖c1 with the better endgame for White) with active play for Black: 31.♕xa7 fxg4 or 31.g5 ♖e4 31.♕c5 ♖g6 (32.g5? ♖xg5+).

6.3. Spatial expansion by the d5-d4 advance

In positions where White has not established pawn control of the d4 blockading square, the dynamic potential of the isolated d5-pawn is often used to gain space in the centre of the board. However, it should be borne in mind that it may also become a target on d4.

We will begin with a classic example.

LASKER – TARRASCH
St. Petersburg 1914
Queen's Gambit D30

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 c5 3.c4 e6 4.cxd5 cxd5 5.g3 ♘c6 6.♗g2 ♘f6 7.0-0 ♗e7 8.dxc5 ♗xc5 9.♘bd2.

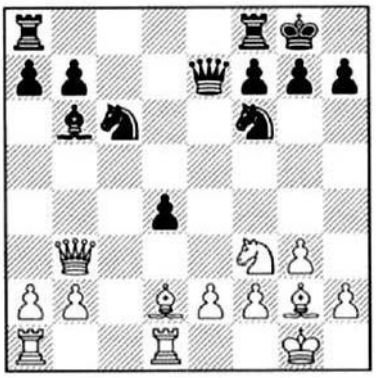


Black faces a choice – whether to agree to the blockade of the d5-pawn after 9...0-0 10.♘b3 ♗b6 11.♘bd4 ♘e4 or decide on a spatial expansion, as occurred in the game.

9...d4. Regarding this advance, Capablanca made a valuable comment in his notes to the following game.

10.♘b3 ♗b6 11.♕d3! Emphasising the problems with the defence of this pawn. As a target for attack, it is important to blockade it! 11.e3 dxc3 12.♗xe3 0-0 would relieve Black of the problem.

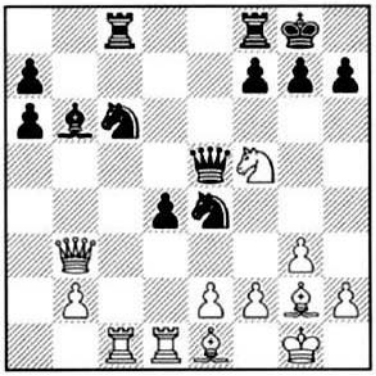
11...♗e6 12.♖d1 ♗xb3 13.♕xb3 ♕e7 14.♗d2 0-0.



15.a4! This pawn raid has the aim of destabilising the placing of the black pieces on the queenside.

15...♘e4 16.♗e1 ♖ad8. This natural move merely strengthens the effect of the a-pawn's advance, but in the event of 16...♖fe8!? 17.a5 ♗c5 18.a6 ♖ab8 19.♕c2 bxa6 20.♘h4! Black would have encountered the same problems as in the game.

17.a5 ♗c5 18.a6 bxa6 19.♖ac1 (exploiting the overloading of the queen in defending the minor pieces) **19...♖c8 20.♘b4 ♗b6 21.♘f5 ♕c5.**



22.♗xe4. White wins the exchange, but 22.♕f3!, exposing the undefended state of the black knights, was even stronger: 22...♘c5 23.b4 ♘d7 24.♕f4! or 22...♘f6 23.♕f4!

22...♕xe4 23.♘d6 ♕xe2 24.♘xc8 ♖xc8 25.♕d5 ♕c6 26.♕f3 h6 27.♗d2 ♘e5 28.♖xc8+ ♕xc8 29.♕c4 ♘d7. 29...♘g4 was no better: 30.♖c1 ♕d7 31.♕c6 ♕xc6 32.♖xc6 d3 33.♔g2! f5 (33...♗xf2? 34.♖c8+ ♔h7 35.♔f3) 34.♖d6.

30.♖c1 ♕f8 31.♗xh6 ♘c5 32.♕g4 f5 33.♕g6 ♕f7 34.♕xf7+ ♔xf7 35.♗g5 ♘d3 (35...♘e4 36.h4 d3 was more tenacious) **36.♖b1 ♔e6 37.b3 ♔d5 38.f3 a5 39.h4 ♘c5 40.h5 d3 41.♔f1 a4 42.bxa4 ♘xa4 43.♗f6 ♔e6 44.♗xg7 ♔f7 45.♗e5 ♘c5 46.♖d1.** Black resigned.

CAPABLANCA – RUBINSTEIN

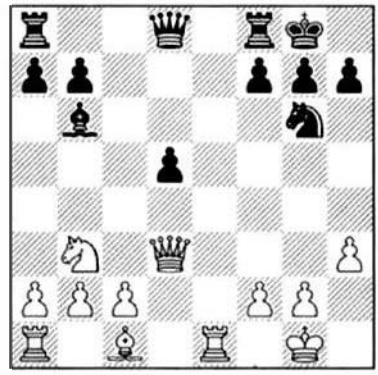
Berlin 1928

French Defence C09

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 c5 3.dc e6 4.c4 ♗xc5 5.exd5 exd5 6.♗b5+ ♘c6 7.0-0 ♘gc7 8.♘bd2 0-0 9.♘b3 ♗b6 10.♖e1 ♝g4 11.♗d3 ♘g6 12.h3 ♗xf3 13.♕xf3 ♘ce5 14.♕f5 ♘xd3 15.♕xd3.

(See diagram)

It is obvious that, with a small number of minor pieces on the board, the isolated d5-pawn is weak, and if White should succeed in exchanging the bishops after ♗e3, its weakness will increase. Black could have prevented this exchange by 15...♕f6!, exploiting the fact that the f2-pawn is inadequately defended. After the best reply 16.♗e3 ♕xb2 17.♕xd5 ♝xe3 18.♖xe3 the position would have been completely equal. But Rubinstein takes a different decision.



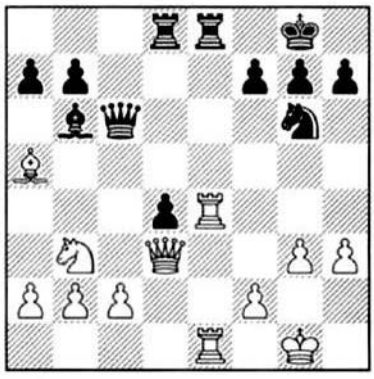
15...d4. This is how Capablanca comments on this pawn advance: 'From the point of view of the safety of the pawn this is a natural enough move, but it is strategically wrong unless there is more than an even chance of advancing it still further. In its present position the pawn blocks the line of action of the strongly posted bishop at b6. There is one advantage in having it at d4, namely that the white c-pawn cannot advance. But again that is an advantage provided that Black is able either to defend the pawn at d4 or to attack White's c-pawn.'

16.♗d2 ♕f6 17.♖e4. The course of the game shows that Black's attempt to gain space has not solved the problem of the isolated pawn – at d4 it remains a target for White to attack.

17...♖ad8. 17...♖fd8 was more logical, intending by the knight manoeuvre ♘g6-f8-e6 to support the d4-pawn. The second rook could have been developed at c8.

18.♖ac1 ♕c6. The assessment of the position depends on whether Black is able to gain counterplay. If he does not succeed in this, the static weakness of the d4-pawn will give White a positional advantage. For the moment Black prevents 19.♗a5, on which there follows 19...f5! 20.♖e6 ♘f4.

19.g3 (preventing ♘f4) **19...♖fe8 20.♗a5!** It is important to exchange the defender of the d4-pawn, after which it is doomed. The direct win of the d4-pawn by 20.♖xc8+ ♖xc8 21.♖xe8+ ♕xe8 22.♘xd4? ♘c5 would have led to the loss of a piece.



20...♖xe4. 20...♗xa5! was stronger: 21.♘xa5 ♖xe4 22.♕xe4 (22.♖xe4 ♕d5 23.♘b3 ♘e5 24.♕e2 ♖e8 favours Black) 22...♕b6 23.♘b3 a5 with good counterplay for Black.

21.♕xe4 ♘f8. 21...♕xe4 22.♖xe4 ♝xa5 23.♘xa5 f5 was better, although even here White would have retained a slight advantage after 24.♖c2, since it is not easy to defend the d4-pawn.

22.♕xc6 bxc6 23.♖e7 ♖d5?! Black misses a chance to activate his rook, which makes it difficult to defend the queenside pawns. After 23...d3 24.cxd3 ♖xd3 25.♗xb6 (25.♗b4 ♖xg3+) 25...axb6 26.♖b7 ♖d1+ 27.♔g2 ♘d7! it would have been much easier to defend.

24.♗xb6 axb6 25.♖b7 ♘d7 26.♖c7 ♖d6 27.♖c8+ ♘f8 28.♘d2 c5. If 28...b5, then 29.♘b3 followed by ♘a5.

29.♘c4 ♖e6 30.♖b8 ♖e1+ 31.♔g2 g5 32.a4 ♖a1 33.♘xb6 ♔g7 34.♖c8 ♘e6 35.♘d7 ♖xa4 36.♘xc5 ♖b4 37.♘d3 ♖b5 38.♔f3 h6 39.b4 h5 40.g4 hxg4+ 41.hxg4 f6 42.♖c4 ♔f7 43.♘c5 ♘d8 44.♘b3. Black lost on time.

HÜBNER – IVKOV
Germany 1975
Queen's Gambit D41

1.c4 ♘f6 2.♘c3 c5 3.♘f3 e6 4.g3 ♘c6 5.♗g2 d5 6.cxd5 ♘xd5

7.0-0 ♗e7 8.♘xd5 exd5 9.d4 0-0 10.dxc5 ♗xc5 11.b3 ♗f5 12.♗b2 ♗e4 13.♖c1 ♕c7 14.♕d2.



The black pieces are very active and the position can be assessed as dynamically balanced. A logical continuation could have been 14...♗b6 15.♖fd1 ♖fe8. But Black decided to expand his spatial control, overlooking an opportunity for White to exchange the queens.

14...d4? 15.♕g5! White liquidates into an endgame, in which the d4-pawn loses any chance of advancing further and becomes a target.

15...♕xg5 16.♘xg5 ♗xg2 17.♔xg2 ♗e7? With the support of the bishop from f6, the pawn becomes more vulnerable. Therefore 17....♗b6 18.♖fd1 ♖fe8 19.♔f1 ♖ad8 was more logical, when if 20.♘f3 there can follow 20...d3 21.exd3 ♘b4 22.d4 ♘xa2.

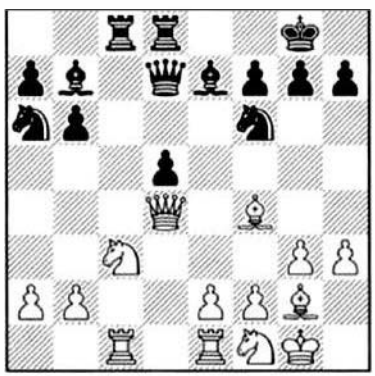
18.♘f3 ♗f6 19.♖fd1 d3?! 19... ♖fd8 was more tenacious, although after 20.♖d2 and ♖cd1 the d4-pawn cannot be saved.

20.♗xf6 dxc2 21.♖d7 gxf6 22.♖xb7 ♖ac8 23.♖c1 ♖fe8 24.♘g1 ♘d4 25.♖d7 ♖ed8 26.♖xd8+ ♖xd8 27.♘f3 a5 28.♘xd4 ♖xd4 29.♖xc2, and White easily won the rook endgame.

Let us now turn to some positive examples.

LJUBOJEVIC – KARPOV
Moscow 1977
Queen's Indian Defence E17

1.♘f3 ♘f6 2.g3 b6 3.♗g2 ♗b7 4.0-0 e6 5.c4 ♗e7 6.♘c3 0-0 7.♖e1 d5 8.cxd5 exd5 9.d4 c5 10.♗f4 ♘a6 11.♘d2 ♕d7 12.♘f1 ♖fd8 13.h3 ♖ac8 14.♖c1 cd 15.♕xd4.



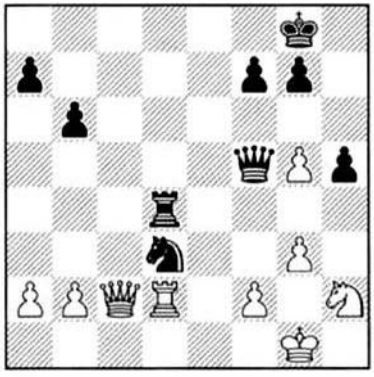
The black pieces are excellently mobilised, whereas it is obvious that the queen on d4 is a poor blockader.

15...♖c4! 16.♕d1 d4. Black expands his spatial control, fixing the

pawn on e2. However, this move allows a simplification of the position, and Karpov thinks that it would have been more effective after the preparatory 16...♘h5!? 17.♗e5 – 17...d4! 18.♗xb7 ♕xb7 19.♘b5 ♖c5 20.♖xc5 bxc5 21.♕a4 f6, and Black has a greater advantage compared with the game.

17.♗xb7 ♕xb7 18.♘c4! ♖xc1 19.♘xf6+ ♗xf6 20.♕xc1 ♕d5 21.♕b1 ♘c5 22.♘h2 h5 23.h4 d3?! A premature exchange of the pawn which is cramping White. Black should have secured the post for his knight at c5 by 23...a5, which would have retained a serious advantage.

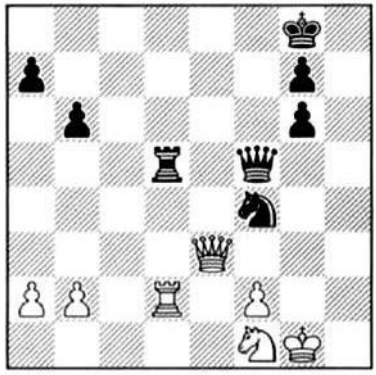
24.cxd3 ♘xd3 25.♖d1 ♕b5 26.♗g5 ♗xg5 27.hxg5 ♕f5 28.♖d2 ♖d4 29.♕c2.



29...h4! Black opens up the king's defences.

30.gxh4 ♕h3 31.♕c6 (parrying the threat of 31...♘e1) **31...♖xh4 32.♕g2 ♕f5.** It was also possible to play for a win in the endgame: 32...♘f4 33.♕g3 ♘e6 34.♖d3 ♕xg3 35.♖xg3 ♖c4 (Karpov).

33.♕g3 ♖d4 34.g6 fxg6 35.♕e3 ♖d5 36.♘f1 ♘f4.



37.♕xf4? This involves an oversight. White should have exchanged rooks – 37.♖xd5 ♘xd5, when it is not easy for Black to convert his extra doubled pawn.

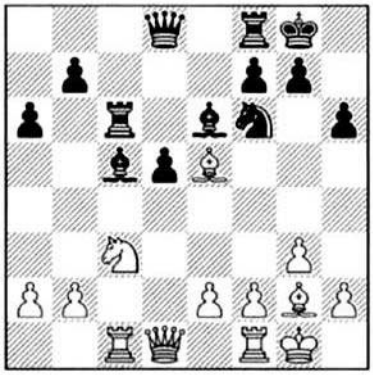
37...♕xf4 38.♖xd5 ♕g4+! Ljubojevic was hoping for 38...♕c4 39.♖c8+ ♔f7 40.b3, when White succeeds in defending his a2-pawn.

39.♘g3 ♕e4 40.♖d8+ ♔h7 41.b3 ♕c2 42.♔g2 g5 43.♖d6 ♕xa2, and Black soon won.

ANDERSSON – MUREY
Interzonal Tournament,
Moscow 1982
Queen's Gambit D33

1.♘f3 d5 2.d4 c5 3.c4 e6 4.cxd5 exd5 5.g3 ♘c6 6.♗g2 ♘f6 7.0-0 ♗e6 8.♘c3 h6 9.♗f4 ♖c8 10.♖c1

a6 11.dxc5 ♗xc5 12.♘e5 0-0 13.♘xc6 ♖xc6 14.♗e5.



14...♘g4! Black is ready to exchange his dark-square bishop for the sake of advancing his central pawn.

15.♗d4. If 15.♗f4 there can follow 15...g5 16.♗d2 ♕d7 with active play.

15...♗xd4 16.♕xd4 ♖c4! 17.♕a7. The queen retreat 17.♕d2 d4 18.♘e4 ♖xc1 19.♖xc1 ♗xa2 leads to the loss of a pawn.

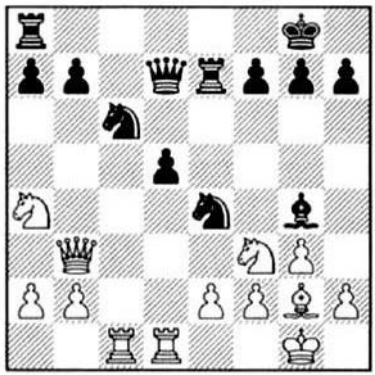
17...d4 18.♘e4 d3! 19.exd3 ♖xc1 20.♖xc1 ♕xd3. The d5-pawn has successfully completed its raid, and after the logical continuation 21.♕xb7 ♗d5 22.♕d7 ♗xe4 23.♕xg4 ♗xg2 24.♔xg2 ♕d5+ and ♕xa2 the position would have become extremely simplified.

21.h3?! ♘e5 22.♘c3 b5 (22...♕d2!? was more energetic) **23.♖d1 ♕c2 24.♕d4 ♕xb2 25.♖d2.** 25.♖b1 ♕c2 26.♗e4 ♗f5! was also advantageous to Black. If 25.♕xe5 there follows 25...b4.

25...♕c1+ 26.♖d1 ♕c2 27.♗e4 ♗f5 28.♗xc2 ♘f3+ 29.♔f1 ♘xd4 30.♗xf5! ♘xf5 31.♘d5! ♖a8. Black has won a pawn, in return for which White merely has some activity.

HULAK – MARJANOVIC
Yugoslavia 1984
Queen's Gambit D34

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.♘f3 ♘c6 6.g3 ♘f6 7.♗g2 ♗e7 8.0-0 0-0 9.dxc5 ♗xc5 10.♘a4 ♗e7 11.♗e3 ♖e8 12.♖c1 ♗g4 13.♕h3 ♕d7 14.♗c5 ♘e4 15.♗xe7 ♖xe7 16.♖fd1.



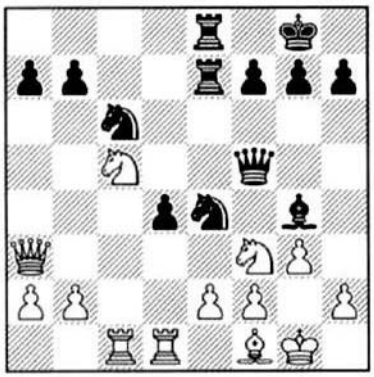
Black has deployed his pieces actively, whereas a serious defect of White's position is the knight at a4, which is shut out of the game.

16...d4! By the advance of this pawn Black gains a spatial advantage.

17.♕a3. It is not possible to exploit the opposition of queen and

rook by 17.c3. By sacrificing a pawn – 17...♕f5 18.cxd4 ♖ae8! – Black develops a dangerous initiative: 19.♖d3 (19.♘c5? ♘g5) 19...b5 20.♖xc6 bxa4 21.♕c2 (21.♕a3?! ♘xf2; 21.♕d1? ♘g5) 21...♘xf2 (if 21...♘g5, then 22.♘e5 is possible) 22.♔xf2 ♖e2+ 23.♕xc2 ♖xe2+ 24.♔xe2 ♕e4+ 25.♗f2 ♕xc6, and Black has won the queen for a rook and minor piece.

17...♖ae8 18.♗f1 ♕f5 19.♘c5.



19...♘xf2! 20.♔xf2 ♖e3 21.♖d3. 21.♘d3? allows a mating attack: 21...♖xe2+! 22.♗xe2 ♖xe2+ 23.♔xc2 ♕xf3+ 24.♔d2 ♕e2#.

21...b6. After the preparatory 21...♗xf3 22.exf3 and now 22...b6 (22...♕xf3+ 23.♔g1 ♘e5 24.♖b3) Black's attack could have reached its logical conclusion. After any move of the white knight 23...♘e5! is very strong.

22.♘b7 ♗xf3 23.♘d6 (if 23.exf3, then 23...♘e5! is unpleasant) **23...♕h5 24.♔g1 ♖xe2 25.h4 ♗d5?** With this bishop retreat Black significantly reduces the intensity of the attack, which could have been continued after 25...♘e5! 26.♗xe2 ♗xc2.

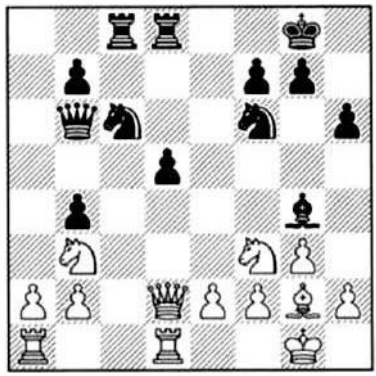
26.♘xe8 ♖xe8 27.♕d6 ♕f5 28.♕f4. White has managed to consolidate his forces and hold the position. On the 67th move the game ended in a draw.

KHARLOV – IVANCHUK

Moscow 2005

Queen's Pawn Game D02

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 c5 3.c3 a5 4.dxc5 ♘f6 5.c4 e6 6.cxd5 ♗xc5 7.♕c2 ♗b4+ 8.♗d2 exd5 9.♗xb4 axb4 10.♘bd2 ♘c6 11.♘b3 ♗g4 12.g3 ♖c8 13.♕d1 0-0 14.♗g2 ♕b6 15.0-0 ♖fd8 16.♕d2 h6 17.♖fd1.

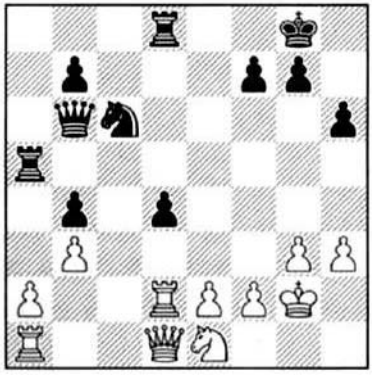


17...♘e4! White has not managed to control the d4 blockading square and Black has gained a spatial advantage. But before expanding it by d5-d4, he drives back the

queen. After the immediate 17...d4 White has 18.♕f4.

18.♕e1 d4! 19.♘c1 (19.♖ac1 ♖a8 20.♖a1 is pointless) **19...♘c5 20.♘d3 ♘xd3 21.♖xd3 ♖a8.** 21... ♗f5!? 22.♖d2 ♖a8 also came into consideration.

22.♖d2 ♖a5 23.♕d1 ♗e6 24.b3 ♗f5 25.h3 ♗e4 26.♘e1 (26.♖c1 ♖c5) **26...♗xg2 27.♔xg2.**



27...♖c5. 27...♕c5 is also possible, intending 28.♖c1 ♕d5+ 29.♘f3 ♖da8, but 30.♖cc2 holds the position.

28.♘f3 ♖c3 29.♕b1! ♕a5?! White has managed to stabilise the position and, so that the d4-pawn should not become a target, Black should have simplified with 29... d3 30.♖xd3 (weaker is 30.exd3 ♘d4 31.♘xd4 ♕xd4) 30...♖dxd3 31.exd3 ♕d8 32.♕e1 ♖xd3, gaining control of the d-file.

30.♕e4. After this centralisation of the queen the d4-pawn loses its dynamic potential and becomes weak.

30...♖xb3. If 30...♕c5 31.♖ad1 ♖c1 32.♖xc1 ♕xc1 Black has to reckon with 33.e3 dxe3 34.♖xd8+ ♘xd8 35.♕xe3 (after 35.♕c8+ ♔h7 36.♕xd8 ♕c2! 37.♕d5 ♕xf2+ 38.♔h1 e2 all the same the knight has to be given up) 35...♕xe3 36.fxe3, when White stands better in the knight endgame.

31.♖ad1 ♖a3 32.♘xd4 ♕d5 33.♕xd5 ♖xd5 34.♘b3, and White obtained the better endgame.

Chapter 7

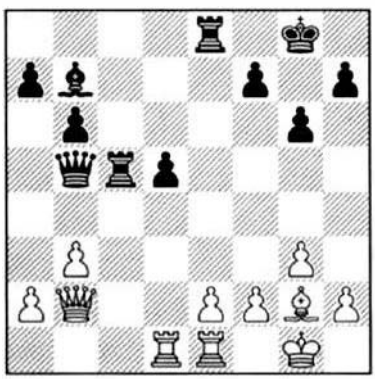
The isolated pawn with a small number of pieces

In the preceding chapters the theme of the isolated pawn was mainly considered as a consequence of opening strategy. However, its appearance is often the consequence of the middlegame. In this case, maintaining a secure blockade of the isolated pawn (most often the d5-pawn), giving the position a stable character, usually involves the exchange of several pieces. The result of this is a marked lowering of the dynamic strength of this pawn, forcing Black to switch to passive defence, which, however, is by no means easy to overcome. In this chapter we will examine methods of handling positions with an isolated d5-pawn where there is a limited amount of material, but the queens are still on the board.

It should be kept in mind that, with the queens on the board, the position has the character of a middlegame. In certain positions, by coordinating his queen with the other pieces, White can develop an attack on the king.

FISCHER – FILIP
Interzonal Tournament,
Palma de Mallorca 1970
English Opening A14

1.b3 d5 2.♗b2 ♘f6 3.♘f3 e6 4.g3 ♗e7 5.♗g2 0-0 6.0-0 c5 7.c4 ♘c6 8.cxd5 ♘xd5 9.♘c3 ♗f6 10.♕c1 b6 11.♘xd5 exd5 12.d4 ♗a6 13.♖e1 ♘xd4 14.♗xd4 cxd4 15.♕a3 ♗b7 16.♖ad1 ♗e7 17.♕a4 ♕e8 18.♕xd4 ♖c8 19.♕f4 ♗f6 20.♘d4 ♗e5 21.♕e3 g6 22.♘b5 ♕xb5 23.♕xe5 ♖fe8 24.♕b2 ♖c5.



A particular feature of the position is the weakening of the a1-h8 diagonal, which is controlled by the

white queen in the absence of any counterplay for Black.

25.h4! White creates threats on the kingside. The usual reaction to this pawn advance is h7-h5, but this weakens the kingside still further. White carries out a frontal attack on the d5-pawn by tripling his heavy pieces on the d-file with the threat of e2-e4, and then the attempt to erect a barrier by f7-f5 will catastrophically weaken the kingside.

25...♖ec8 26.♖d2 ♖c3. Black tries to block the weakened diagonal.

27.♖ed1 ♕c5 (with the threat of 28...♖xg3) **28.b4 ♕e7 29.e3 h5.** Black resigns himself to the loss of his d5-pawn, but hopes to exploit the weakening of the a8-h1 diagonal.

30.a3 ♔h7 31.♗xd5 ♗xd5 32. ♖xd5 ♕e4.



33.♖d8! The two kings are in equally dangerous positions, but White gets his attack in first, since the rook at c3 is tied down by the mate threat on h8.

33...♕f3 34.♔h2 ♖8c4 35. ♖1d7! g5 36.♖f8 ♔g6 37.♖g8+ ♔h7 38.♖xg5 ♖c8 39.♖dd5 ♔h6 40.♖df5. Black resigned.

KHENKIN – RUSTEMOV

Sochi 2005

Queen's Gambit D37

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘c3 ♗e7 4.♘f3 ♘f6 5.♗f4 0-0 6.e3 ♘bd7 7.a3 c5 8.cxd5 ♘xd5 9.♘xd5 exd5 10.dxc5 ♘xc5 11.♗e5 ♗f6 12.♗e2 ♗xe5 13.♘xe5 ♕d6 14.♘f3 ♗g4 15.♘d4 ♗xe2 16.♕xe2 ♖ac8 17. 0-0 a6 18.♖fd1.



White has a stable advantage thanks to his secure blockade of the d5-pawn.

18...g6. This unprovoked weakening of the castled position creates motifs for an attack on the king. Black should have stuck to central strategy: 18...♖fe8 19.♘f5 ♕e5 20.♕g4 g6 21.♘d4 ♘e4 22.h4 ♖c4.

19.h4! White begins an attack on the kingside.

19...♖c7?! 19...h5 was necessary, not fearing 20.g4?! in view of 20...♕e7! 21.gxh5 ♕xh4. If 20.♖ac1 there can follow 20...♘e4 21.♘f3 (21.♕f3 ♕e5 22.♕h3 ♖c7!) 21...♕d7 22.♕d3 ♖xc1 23.♖xc1 ♖c8 24.♖d1 ♕c6, and the d5-pawn is indirectly defended in view of the threats on the first rank.

20.♖ac1 ♖fc8. Here in the event of 20...h5 21.g4 ♕e7 22.gxh5 ♕xh4 23.b4 it transpires that the rook on c7 is badly placed, and White gains the advantage.

21.h5 ♕e5. 21...♘e4 22.♖xc7 ♖xc7 23.♘c2 (23.h6 ♕f8) 23...♘f6 24.♘b4 ♖d7 25.♕f3 ♕e5 26.♖d4 ♖c7 is also possible, exploiting the fact that the back rank is inadequately defended.



22.♕g4 ♔g7. In the event of 22...♘e6?! 23.♖xc7 ♖xc7 24.♘xe6 ♕xe6 25.♕f4 ♖d7 (25...♖c4 26.♕b8+) 26.♕d4 White carries out a frontal attack on the d5-pawn. 26.h6 f6 27.♕d4 is also possible.

23.♕h4.



23...♔f8. The threat of h5-h6 has become a reality, and Black must play with great care to resist the attack on his king. 23...♘e6 24.h6+! ♔f8 25.♖xc7 ♖xc7 26.♘xe6+ fxe6 27.♕d8+ ♔f7 was more accurate, not fearing 28.e4!? (28.♖f1 ♖e7 29.♖c1 ♕h5) 28...dxe4 29.♖d7+ ♖xd7 30.♕xd7+ ♔f6 31.♕xh7 ♕d6 with the threat of perpetual check by ♕d6-d1-h5 (Rustemov).

24.h6! f6? A further weakening of the king's defences, which allows White to develop an attack. 24...♘e6 was correct, leading to a position from the previous note.

25.♘f3 ♕e6. 25...♕xb2 was also insufficient: 26.♖b1 ♕c3 (or 26...g5 27.♖xb2 gxh4 28.♖xd5) 27.♖xd5 b5 28.♖bd1.

26.♕f4 ♕e7. No better is 26...♕f7 27.♕b4 ♕e6 28.♘d4 ♕d6

29.♘e2 b6 30.♘f4, winning the d5-pawn.

27.♖xd5. White has won a pawn and with it the game.

GHEORGHIU – A.PETROSIAN
Bagneux 1982
Queen's Gambit D58

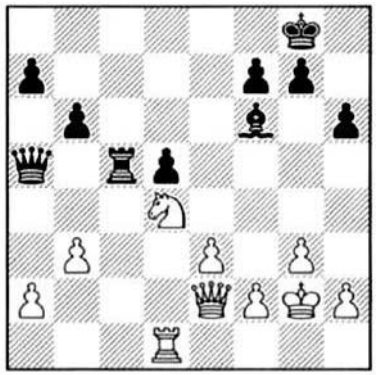
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.♘c3 ♗e7 4.♘f3 ♘f6 5.♗g5 h6 6.♗h4 0-0 7.e3 b6 8.♗d3 ♗b7 9.0-0 ♘bd7 10.♕e2 c5 11.♖fd1 cxd4 12.♘xd4 ♘e5 13.♗xf6 ♗xf6 14.cxd5 ♘xd3 15.♕xd3 ♗xd5 16.♕e2 ♖c8 17.♘db5 ♖c5 18.♘xd5 exd5 19.♖d2 ♕d7 20.♘d4 ♖fc8.



Despite White's stable positional advantage and his solid blockade of the isolated pawn, it is not easy to approach it – Black has good counterplay on the c-file.

21.♖ad1 ♕a4'?! An inaccuracy, which allows White to drive the queen to a passive position. 21...♖c1 was better, and now if 22.b3 there can follow 22...♗xd4 23.♖xd4 ♖8c2. In the event of 22.♘b3 ♖xd1+ 23.♕xd1 the move 23...♕a4 is far more effective, for example: 24.a3 ♕c4 25.h3 (25.♘d4 ♕c1 26.h3 ♗xd4) 25...a5 26.♘d4 ♖c5 27.b3 ♕c1 28.b4 ♕xd1+ 29.♖xd1 axb4 30.axb4 ♖c4.

22.b3 ♕a5 23.g3 ♖c1 24.♔g2 ♖xd1 25.♖xd1 ♖c5.



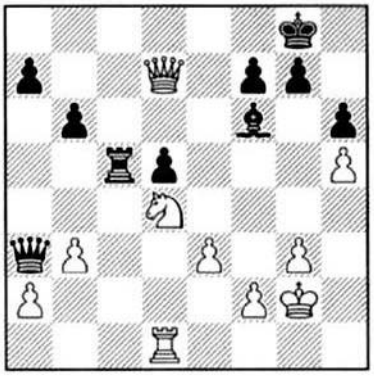
26.h4! White exploits the passive placing of the black pieces to seize space on the kingside.

26...♕b4. It is hard to offer Black any good advice. 26...♗xd4 27.♖xd4 ♕c3 28.♕f3 ♕c2 29.b4 and 26...b5 27.♘f5 with the threat of ♕g4 were both inadequate.

27.h5 ♖c7 28.♕f3 ♖c5. If 28...♕c5, then 29.♖d2! with the threat of ♖c2 is possible.

29.♕f5. After tying the black pieces to the defence of the d5-pawn, White prepares an attack on the king.

29...♕a3 30.♕d7! White attacks the f7-pawn – 30...♕xa2 31.♕e8+ ♔h7 32.♕xf7.



30...♔f8 31.♘b5. Including the knight in the attack. The 'queen + knight' duo does not leave the black king any saving hopes.

31...♕b4 32.♘d6 ♔g8 33.♕xf7+ ♔h7 34.♖xd5 ♖c2? A time-trouble blunder, but equally after 34...♖xd5 35.♕xd5 the game cannot be saved.

35.♕g6+ ♔h8 36.♕xc2. Black resigned.

DREEV – GODENA
European Championship,
Warsaw 2005
Queen's Gambit D46

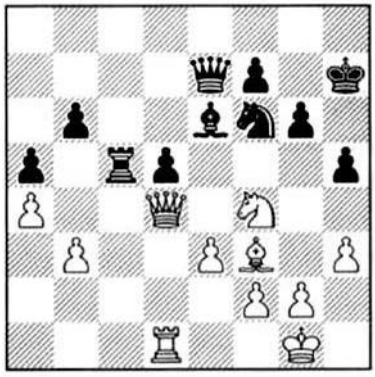
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.e3 e6 5.♘f3 a6 6.b3 ♗b4 7.♗d2 ♘bd7 8.♗d3 0-0 9.0-0 ♗d6 10.♖c1 e5 11.cxd5 cxd5 12.dxe5 ♘xe5 13.♘xe5 ♗xe5 14.♘e2 ♘g4 15.h3 ♘f6 16.♗c3 ♕e7 17.♕c2 ♗xc3 18.♕xc3 ♗d7 19.♘d4 ♖fc8 20.♕a5 ♕d6 21.♗e2 g6 22.♗f3 h5 23.♕d2 ♕a3 24.♖c3 ♖xc3 25.♕xc3 ♖c8 26.♕a1 a5 27.♖d1 ♕e7.



28.♘e2! The weakening of the a1-h8 diagonal, which is controlled by the white queen, restricts Black's forces. White begins an attack on the d5-pawn.

28...♖c5 29.♘f4 ♗c6 30.♕e5 ♘d7 31.♕d4 ♘f6 32.a4 b6 33.♕e5 ♘d7 34.♕b2 ♘f6 35.♕d4 ♔h7. In the event of 35...♔g7? 36.♕e5 ♖c7 Black has to reckon with the threats of 37.♗xh5 and 37.♘xe6+ fxe6 38.g4.

36.♘d3 ♖c6 37.♘e5 ♖c5 38.♘d3 ♖c6 39.♘f4 ♖c5.

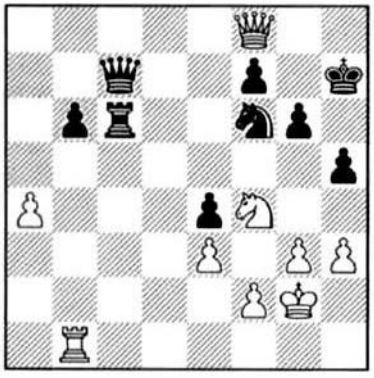


40.g3. This solid move, the last before the time control, al-

lows Black to activate his bishop. The immediate 40.b4 was better: 40...axb4 (there are also problems after 40...♖c4 41.♕xb6 axb6 42.a5 ♕c7 43.♖b1) 41.♕xb4, creating a second weak pawn on b6, which complicates Black's defence. For example: 41...♕c7 42.♕d4 ♕e7 43.♕b2 ♖c4 44.♖d4 ♕d8 45.e4.

40...♗f5 41.b4 axb4 42.♕xb4 ♕c7 43.♕d4 ♕e7 44.♕b4 ♕c7 45.♔g2 ♗e4. 45...♕c6 46.♘e2 ♗e4 also came into consideration.

46.♗xe4 dxe4 47.♖b1 ♖c6 48.♕f8.



48...g5? After putting up a difficult defence, Godena loses his sense of danger (he should have maintained a defensive pose – 48...♕d7 49.♖d1 ♕e8) and weakens his king's defences. He could have been immediately punished for this by 49.♖b5!, when the mate threat 50.♖xg5 can only be parried by 49...♖c5, after which there follows 50.♖xb6.

49.♘e2?! ♕d7. Intending to parry 50.♖b5 with 50...♘d5.

50.♘d4 ♖c8 51.♕a3 ♘d5 52.♖b5 h4? Unwarranted activity, allowing White to fix the weak f5-point. Black should have stuck to waiting tactics: 52...♖d8 53.a5 bxa5 54.♕xa5 ♔g6.

53.g4 ♘f4+? With the naïve hope after the knight exchange of returning with the rook to c2. But equally after 53...♖d8 or 53...♖a8 Black is unable to withstand the combined attack of the white pieces. For example: 53...♖a8 54.♕b3 ♖a5 55.♕c4 ♖xb5 56.axb5 ♔g8 57.♘f5 ♕e5 (57...♕d6 58.♕d4 f6 59.♕a1 ♕d7 60.♕a8) 58.♕c8 ♕f6 59.♕d7 ♕e6 60.♕d8 f6 61.♕f8.

54.exf4 ♕xd4 55.♕e7! ♕c4 56.♖xg5 ♖c5 57.f5 ♖c6 58.♕f8. Black resigned.

MOROZEVICH – GELFAND

Fügen 2006

Petroff Defence C42

1.e4 e5 2.♘f3 ♘f6 3.♘xe5 d6 4.♘f3 ♘xe4 5.d4 d5 6.♗d3 ♘c6 7.0-0 ♗e7 8.c3 0-0 9.♖e1 ♗f5 10.♗f4 ♖e8 11.♕b3 ♘a5 12.♕c2 ♗d6 13.♗xd6 ♕xd6 14.♘a3 ♕f4 15.♘e5 ♘c6 16.♘b5 ♘xe5 17.dxe5 ♖xe5 18.♘xc7 ♖d8 19.♘b5 ♗g6 20.♘d4 ♘c5 21.♗xg6 hxg6 22.g3 ♕f6 23.♖xe5 ♕xe5.



White is firmly blockading the isolated d5-pawn. Black's chances lie in exploiting the e-file and the e4-point.

24.♖d1 ♖e8 25.♖d2 ♕f6 26.♔g2 ♖e5. In the event of 26...♕a6 27.a3 ♖e1 White liquidates into a favourable knight endgame – 28.♖e2 ♖xe2 29.♕xe2 ♕xe2 30.♘xe2.

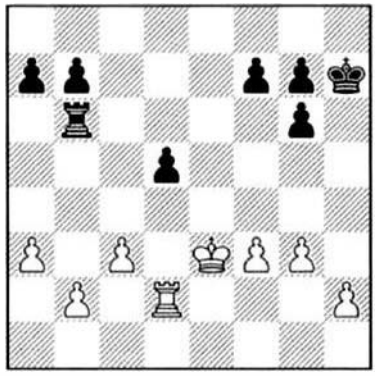
27.♘f3 ♘e4 28.♖e2 ♖f5. Black is aiming for active play, by attacking the targets on the f-file, but in so doing he loses control of the e-file. However, also after 28...♖e7 29.♕d1 ♕d6 30.♘d4 a6 31.♕e1 he is forced to concede it.

29.♕d3 ♔h7 30.♕e3 ♕a6. If 30...a6 Black has to reckon with 31.c4 ♘d6 32.h4!? with the threat of ♘g5+.

31.♘d4 ♖f6 32.f3 ♘c5 33.a3 ♘e6 34.♖d2 ♘xd4?! This exchange should have been prepared by 34...♕b6, since in the event of 35.♕c5 ♘xd4 36.♕xd4 ♕xd4 37.♖xd4 ♖b6! 38.♖d2 g5 39.♔f2 ♔g6 play transposes into a more favourable rook endgame than the one occurred in the game.

35.♕xd4 ♖e6 36.♔f2! An excellent move! The king prevents the invasion of the rook, which was possible after 36.♕xd5 ♖e2+ 37.♔h3 ♖xd2 38.♕xd2, when in the queen endgame Black gains counterplay: 38...♕f1+ 39.♔g4 ♕c4+ 40.f4 f5+ 41.♔h3 (41.♔f3 ♕c4+ 42.♔f2 ♕h1=) 41...♕f1+ 42.♕g2 ♕d3 (Morozevich, Kuzmin).

36...♕b6 (36...♖d6? 37.c4) **37.♕xb6 ♖xb6 38.♔e3.**



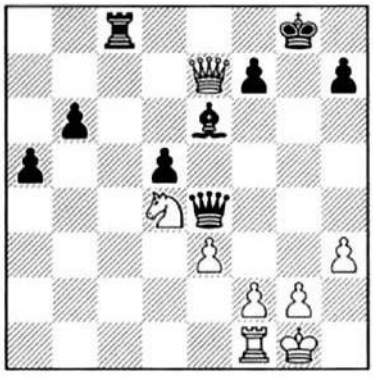
38...♖d6. Black is forced to concede the e-file. In the event of 38...g5 the king performs an outflanking manoeuvre: 39.♔d4 ♖f6 40.♖f2 g4 (40...♖f5 41.g4 ♖f4+ 42.♔xd5) 41.f4 ♖f5 42.♖e2 ♖h5 43.♔c5 ♔g6 44.♔d6, penetrating into the heart of the black position (Morozevich, Kuzmin).

39.♔d4 b6 40.♖e2 g5 41.b4 f6 42.♖e7 a6 43.♖a7 b5 44.♔c5 ♖e6

45.♔xd5 ♖e3 46.♔d4. Black resigned.

MOROZEVICH – ARONIAN
Morelia/Linares 2007
Queen's Gambit D38

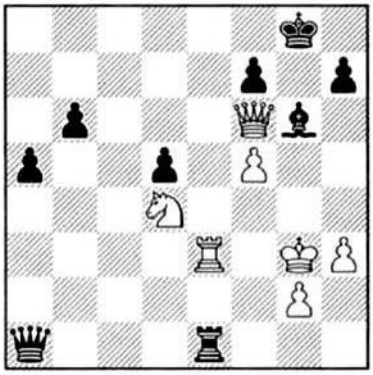
1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 d5 4.♘c3 ♗b4 5.cxd5 exd5 6.♗g5 ♘bd7 7.e3 c5 8.♗e2 ♕a5 9.0-0 0-0 10.♘d2 ♗xc3 11.bxc3 ♕xc3 12.♖c1 ♕a3 13.dxc5 ♕xa2 14.♗f4 ♖e8 15.♘f3 ♘e4 16.♗b5 a6 17.♗a4 ♘exc5 18.♖xc5 ♘xc5 19.♗xe8 ♗e6 20.♗e5 ♖xe8 21.♗xg7 ♔xg7 22.♕d4+ ♔g8 23.♕xc5 ♕c4 24. ♕d6 ♖c8 25.h3 ♕c7 26.♕b4 a5 27. ♕h4 ♕c2 28.♘d4 ♕e4 29.♕e7 b6.



30.♔h2! The main defect of Black's position is the weakness of the dark squares, especially in the vicinity of his king, against which White prepares an attack.

30...♗f5 31.♕f6 ♗g6 32.f4! ♕xe3 33.♖f3 ♕c1 34.♖g3. The immediate 34.f5 is also good.

34...♕a1 35.f5 ♖c1 36.♖e3 ♖h1+ 37.♔g3 ♖e1.



38.♖f3. There was a forced mate by 38.♕d8+ ♔g7 39.f6+ ♔h6 40.♔h4! ♕xd4+ 41.g4 and ♕f8#.

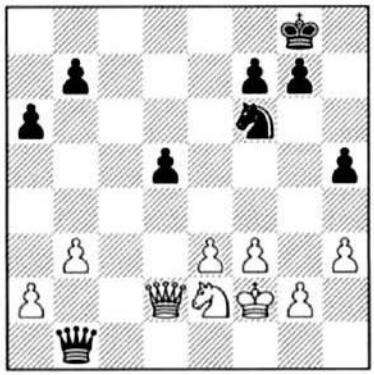
38...♖f1 39.fxg6? Here too the above manoeuvre would have led to mate: 39.♕d8+ ♔g7 40.f6+ ♔h6 41.♔h4! But now, after the exchange of rooks, the outside passed pawns counterbalance the knight, which is forced to defend its king.

39...♖xf3+ 40.♕xf3 ♕e1+ 41. ♔f4 hxg6 42.♕xd5 ♕f2+ 43.♘f3. Draw.

BU XIANGZHI – BRUZON
World Team Championship,
Beer Sheva 2005
Queen's Gambit D37

1.♘f3 d5 2.c4 e6 3.d4 ♘f6 4.♘c3 ♗e7 5.♗f4 c5 6.dxc5 ♘a6 7.cxd5 ♘xd5 8.♘xd5 exd5 9.e3 ♘xc5 10.♗b5+ ♗d7 11.♗xd7+

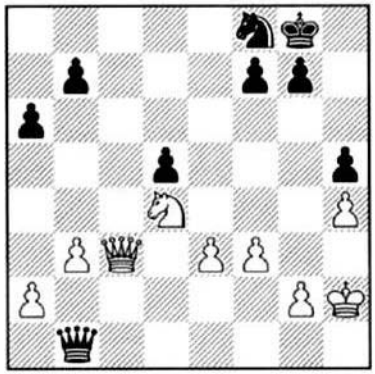
♕xd7 12.0-0 0-0 13.♕e2 ♖ac8 14.♗e5 a6 15.♗d4 ♘e4 16.♘e5 ♕f5 17.♖ac1 ♖xc1 18.♖xc1 ♖c8 19.♖xc8+ ♕xc8 20.♘d3 ♗f6 21.♗xf6 ♘xf6 22.♕d2 h6 23.f3 ♕c4 24.b3 ♕c7 25.♘f4 ♕e5 26.h3 ♕a1+ 27.♔f2 ♕b1 28.♘e2 h5.



29.h4! White blocks the h5-pawn, which may become a potential weakness, since its defence by g7-g6 will irreparably weaken the dark squares. The threatened penetration of the white knight to f5 forces Black to concede the c-file.

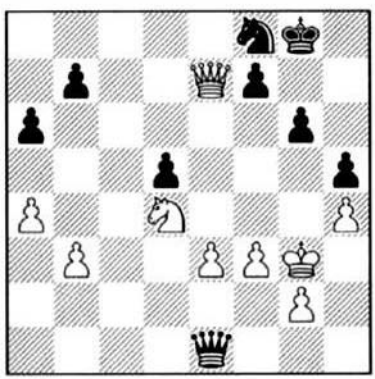
29...♕h1 30.♔g3 ♕b1 31.♘d4 ♘d7. After the return of the queen to Black's rear by the elaborate manoeuvre 31...♕e4!? White also takes control of the c-file – 32.♕c1 ♕e5+ (32...♕g6+ 33.♔f2) 33.♔f2 ♕b8 (33...♕h2? 34.♕e8+ ♔h7 35.♕f5+ ♔g8 36.♕g5) 34.♕c2, but in this case he gains control of the f5-point.

32.♕c3 ♘f8 33.♔h2.



33...g6? This weakening of the long diagonal, with the white queen already standing on it, is contrary to the spirit of the position and it allows White to launch an attack on the king. However, it was not easy for Black to prevent the queen's threatened invasion on c5. If 33...b6 there would have followed 34.e4! dxe4 35.♘f5. But he could have tried to parry the threat to the d5-pawn by counterplay against the h4-pawn – 33...♕g6!? 34.♕c5 ♕f6 35.g3 ♕e5 and if 36.e4 there is 36...♘e6.

34.a4 ♕a2 35.♔g3 ♕a3 36.♕c7 ♕a1 37.♕e7! ♕e1+.



38.♔f4! The king goes into the attack against its opposite number!

38...♕d2? 'Cooperative' play! But Black also loses after 38...b6 39.g3 with the idea of ♕c7-d8xd5.

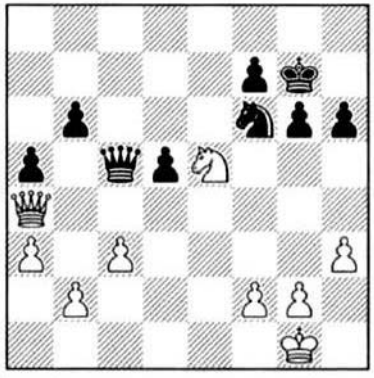
39.♔g5! ♕xg2+ 40.♔h6 ♕b2 41.f4. Black resigned.

IVANCHUK – KORCHNOI

Lvov 2000

French Defence C08

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♘gf3 a6 6.♗e2 ♘c6 7.0-0 cxd4 8.♖e1 ♗e7 9.♘b3 ♘f6 10.♘fxd4 0-0 11.♗f4 ♗d6 12.♗xd6 ♕xd6 13.c3 ♖e8 14.♕c2 ♗g4 15.♗xg4 ♘xg4 16.♘f3 ♘ce5 17.♘bd4 ♘xf3+ 18.♘xf3 ♕c5 19.h3 ♘f6 20.♕b3 b6 21.♖ad1 ♖e4 22.♘d2 ♖xe1+ 23.♖xe1 a5 24.a3 h6 25.♘f3 ♖e8 26.♖xe8+ ♘xe8 27.♘e5 ♘f6 28.♕a4 ♔h7 29.♘c6 g6 30.♘e5 ♔g7.



In this position Black failed to cope with the rotation of the white pieces around the d5-pawn.

31.♕f4. From f4 the queen indirectly attacks the f7-pawn, creating the threat of advancing the g-pawn.

31...g5. By removing his control of f5, Black creates a new weakness in his position. The reason for this outwardly anti-positional move is that other candidate moves have their drawbacks. If 31...h5? there follows 32.g4. 31...b5? will not do because of 32.♕xf6+!, nor 31...♕d6? because of 32.♘xg6! After 31...♕e7 32.♕d4 Black cannot endure the pin on the long diagonal and he is forced to return with 32...♕c5, after which he has to reckon with the consequences of the knight endgame: 33.♕xc5!? bxc5 34.b4 cxb4 35.cxb4 axb4 36.axb4, where the b-pawn advances to b6, diverting the knight.

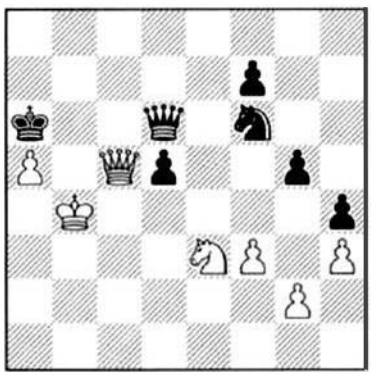
32.♕d2 ♘e4 33.♕e2 ♕d6 34.♘g4 ♕e6 35.♕d3 h5 36.♕d4+ ♔g8 37.♘e3 ♘f6 38.f3 ♔f8 39.♔f2 ♔e8.



40.b4! This shows the result of the weakening of the f5-point. White

creates an outside passed pawn. Black cannot prevent this: his queen is unable to control all the invasion squares.

40...axb4 41.cxb4 ♔d7 42.a4 ♔c8 43.♔e2 h4 44.♔d2 ♔b7 45.♔d3 ♔a8 46.♔c3 ♕c6+ 47.♔b3 ♕e6 48.♔b2 ♔b7 49.♔a3 ♕d6 50.♔b3 ♕e6 51.a5 bxa5 52.bxa5 ♔a6 53.♔b4 ♕d6+ 54.♕c5.



54...♕b8+?! Black cracks under the prolonged pressure on the d5-pawn and suddenly aims for unwarranted activity. It was safer to control the b6- and f5-squares with the queen, by playing 54...♕e6. If 55.♘c2, then 55...♔b7 is possible, and in the event of 56.♘d4 activity with 56...♕c1+ is now appropriate.

55.♔c3 ♕b1? A blunder, leading to defeat. The defence could have been held by 55...♕c5+! 56.♔c2 ♘d7!? (56...♕e6?! is inadequate in view of 57.♔d2 ♘d7 58.♕c8+ ♔xa5 59.♕d8+ ♔b4 60.♕g5 d4 61.♘c2+ ♔c4 62.♕xh4 with advantage to White) 57.♕c6+ ♔xa5 58.♕xd5+ ♕xd5 59.♘xd5 ♔b5 60.♔d3 ♔c5 61.♔e4 ♔d6 62.♔d4 f5, and Black is alright.

56.♘c2. Black resigned.

Chapter 8

The isolated pawn in the endgame

When the queens are exchanged, the dynamic possibilities of the isolated pawn are greatly reduced, and it may become a target. Therefore a decision by the side with the isolated pawn to exchange the queens should be carefully weighed up and taken only if counterplay is guaranteed. Often this problem has to be solved as early as the opening stage. In Chapter 5, using the example of the game Flohr – Capablanca (Moscow 1935), we have already touched on the topic of White's opening strategy employing the strategic procedure of exchanging queens and going into an endgame. In modern play this procedure occurs most often in the Tarrasch Variation of the French Defence, where Black does not object to exchange queens, counting on gaining sufficient counterplay in a complicated endgame. For studying the defensive technique in this type of position, it is useful in the first instance to turn to the games of Mikhail Botvinnik.

ILYIN-ZHENEVSKY – BOTVINNIK
Leningrad 1932
French Defence C08

1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♗b5+ ♗d7 6.♕e2+ ♕e7 7.♗xd7+ ♘xd7 8.dxc5 ♘xc5 9.♕xe7+ ♗xe7. This variation occurs rarely nowadays, since Black maintains equality without difficulty.

10.♘e2. White aims to blockade the d5-pawn.



10...♘e6! Black forcefully hinders White's plan and is the first to take control of d4.

11.♘f3 ♗f6! It can be said that this is the key move of Black's counterplay. Already then Botvinnik considered control of the blockading point d4 to be an important element in the defence.

12.♗e3 ♘e7. The second knight is also included in the fight for the d4 blockading point.

13.0-0-0 0-0 14.♖he1 ♖fd8 15.♘fd4 ♘c6 16.f4?! A needless weakening of the position.



16...♖e8! Black rejects winning of a pawn by 16...♘cxd4?! 17.♘xd4 ♗xd4 18.♗xd4 ♘xf4, which after 19.♖c7 b6 20.♖f1 ♘c6 21.♖fxf7 ♘xd4 22.♖xg7+ would have led to a draw by perpetual check (variation by Botvinnik) and threatens to win a piece after exchanges on d4.

17.♘xe6 ♖xe6. This is stronger than 17...fxe6.

18.♗f2 ♖c8 19.a3. Of course, 19.♖xd5? is not possible because of 19...♘b4 20.♖c5 ♖ce8.

19...♘a5. Threatening 20...♘c4 and therefore White cannot play 20.♖xd5? ♘c4 21.c3 ♖ce8 22.♖c5 ♘d6!

20.c3.



20...♘c4?! By subtle manoeuvring Black has weakened White's position, and after 20...♖ce8! 21.♘g3 ♖xe1 22.♖xe1 ♖xe1+ 23.♗xe1 ♗h4! and 24...♗xg3, with a knight against bishop and weak light squares in the opponent's position, he would have gained a favourable endgame (Botvinnik). Now, however, White succeeds in simplifying the position in a more favourable situation.

21.♘d4 ♖e4. If 21...♖ce8 there follows 22.♘c2, attacking the d5- and a7-pawns.

22.♖xe4 dxe4 23.♘c2! a5 24.♘e3 ♘xe3 25.♗xe3 b5 26.♗d4 ♗e7 27.f5, and White now stands better, since the e4-pawn is obviously weak. However, with accurate play Black succeeded in holding the position.

27...b4 28.axb4 axb4 29.♖e1 bxc3 30.bxc3 ♖e8 31.♔c2 ♗d6

32.h3 ♗g3! (restricting the rook) **33.♖e2 f6 34.♖e3 ♗f2 35.♖e2 ♗g3 36.♖e3 ♗f2 37.♖c2 ♗g3 38.♔d1 ♔f7 39.♖e3 ♗f2 40.♖e2 ♗xd4 41.cxd4 g6 42.g4 gxf5 43.gxf5 e3 44.♔c2 ♖e4 45.♔d3 ♖f4 46.♖xe3 ♖xf5.** Draw.

FLOHR – BOTVINNIK

8th match game, Leningrad 1933

French Defence C08

1.d4 e6 2.e4 d5 3.♘d2 c5 4.exd5 exd5 5.♗b5+ ♗d7 6.♕e2+ ♕e7 7.♕xe7+ ♗xe7 8.♗xd7+ ♘xd7 9.dxc5 ♘xc5 10.♘b3. Of course, Flohr knew the previous game, where **10.♘c2** was played, but he decided to offer the exchange of knights.



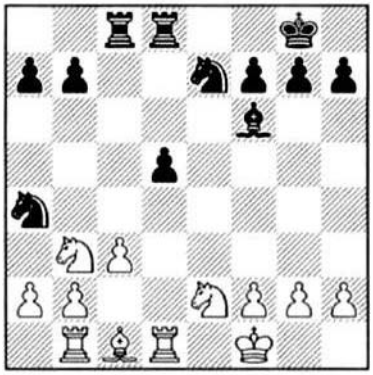
10...♘a4! Naturally, Black avoids the exchange and with a subtle manoeuvre he prevents the development of the bishop. He subsequently plans to transfer this knight to c4.

11.♘e2 ♗f6! As in the previous game, this is a key move in the control of the d4 blockading point.

12.c3. Botvinnik recommends 12.♘bd4, in order to free the bishop.

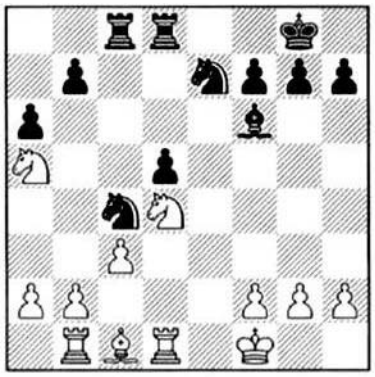
12...♘e7 13.0-0 0-0 14.♖d1 ♖fd8 15.♖b1. Otherwise it is difficult to develop the bishop.

15...♖ac8 16.♔f1.



16...a6! The knight at a4 has carried out its duties and it must be switched to the more active square c4, but after the direct 16...♘b6?! White plays his bishop to d4 – 17.♗c3! ♘c4 18.♗d4, exchanging the important dark-square bishop. Therefore Black makes a useful waiting move, intending to meet 17.♗c3 with 17...♘f5.

17.♘ed4 ♘b6 18.♘a5 ♘c4. Forcing the retreat or the exchange of the knight, since 19.♘xb7? ♖d7 leads to the loss of a piece.

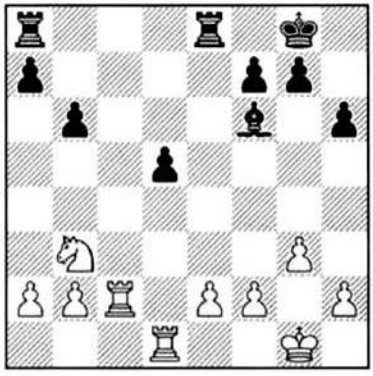


19.♘xc4 dxc4. The isolated pawn theme is exhausted.

20.♗e3 ♘d5 21.♘f3. Draw. 21...♘xe3 22.fxe3 is unfavourable for Black, since White obtains the d4-point (Botvinnik).

And now a modern example of play in an endgame, where with the help of the bishop on f6 Black succeeds in controlling the d4-point.

ARONIAN – BELIAVSKY
Warsaw 2005

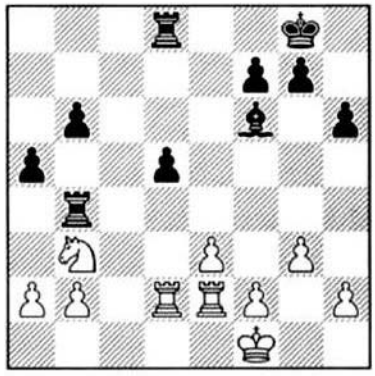


In this position White is not able to establish his knight on the d4 blockading square, in view of the activity of the black pieces.

23...♖ac8! 24.♖cd2. In the event of 24.♖xc8 ♖xc8 25.♖d2 (if 25.♖xd5 both 25...♖c2 and 25...♗xb2 are good) 25...a5! White cannot prevent the exchange of his knight – 26.e3 a4 27.♘d4 ♗xd4, transposing into an easily tenable rook endgame: 28.♖xd4 ♖c2 29.♖b4 a3 30.bxa3 ♖xa2 31.♖xb6 ♖xa3, which Black is not in danger of losing even without his d5-pawn (which he is by no means obliged to give up).

24...♖c4! A subtle rook manoeuvre with the aim of demobilising the knight.

25.c3 ♖b4! 26.♖e2 ♖d8 27.♔f1 a5 28.♖dd2. 28.♘d4 ♗xd4 29.♖xd4 ♖xd4 30.cxd4 ♔f8 31.♖e5 leads to a drawn rook endgame.



28...d4! A worthy conclusion to Black's active play.

29.♘xd4 ♗xd4 30.exd4 ♖dxd4 31.♖xd4 ♖xd4. The conflict is exhausted.

32.♖e8+ ♔h7 33.♔c2 ♖b4 34. b3 a4 35.♖c3 axb3 36.axb3 ♖b5 37.♖c3 g5 38.h3 h5 39.♔d3 ♖f5 40.♔e3 ♖b5 41.♔d4. Draw.

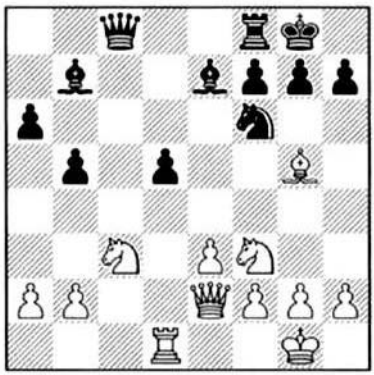
These examples clearly illustrate how important it is, in this type of complicated endgame, to retain the minor pieces, which can cover the weakness of the squares adjacent to the isolated pawn. With regard to the d5-pawn, this relates mainly to the dark-square bishop, the exchange of which makes it harder for Black to defend the dark-square periphery. We saw this in the middlegame positions examined in Chapter 1. The same problems are also typical of the endgame. Here is a classic example from the heritage of Capablanca.

CAPABLANCA – TEICHMANN
Berlin 1913
Queen's Gambit D63

1.d4 d5 2.♘f3 ♘f6 3.c4 e6 4. ♗g5 ♝e7 5.♘e3 ♘bd7 6.e3 0-0 7.♖c1 b6 8.cxd5 exd5 9.♗b5 ♗b7 10.0-0 a6 11.♗a4 ♖c8 12.♕e2 c5 13.dxc5 ♘xc5 14.♖fd1 ♘xa4 15.♘xa4 b5 16.♖xc8 ♕xc8 17.♘c3.

(See diagram)

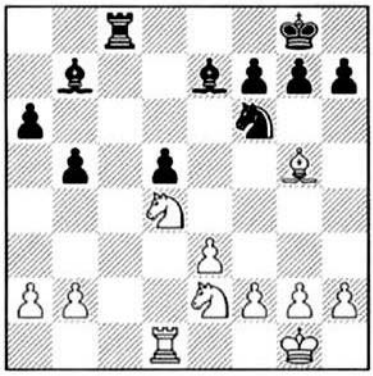
The d5-pawn needs defending, and Black offered the exchange of queens – **17...♕c4**, counting on the notorious advantage of the two



bishops. But, as Capablanca demonstrates, this plan is faulty, since the bishop on b7 is passive, and Black cannot bring it into play other than at the cost of the d-pawn. Black should have avoided exchanges, and therefore 17...♖d8 was more logical, with the possible continuation 18.a3 h6 19.♗f4 ♘e4, intending ♗f6.

18.♘d4 ♕xe2 19.♘cxe2! ♖c8. Black forestalls White's intention to occupy the e-file, and as a result he comes under a mortal pin. However, it was not easy for him to disentangle himself: 19...h6 20.♘f5 ♗d8 21.♗h4 (21.♗f4 .♗e8 22.♘ed4 followed by ♖d1-c1 is also good) 21....♗c8 22.♘cd4 ♗xf5 23.♘xf5 g6 24.♘d4! (weaker is 24.♘xh6+?! ♔g7 25.♗xf6+ ♗.xf6 with active play for the pawn) and then ♖d1-c1. The exchange of rooks also does not solve Black's problems: 19... g6 20.♖c1 ♖e8 21.♖xc8+ ♗.xc8 22.♘e6 ♔f8 23.♘cd4 ♗.b7 (23... ♗d7 24.♗xf6 ♗.xf6 25.♘b4 leads

to the loss of a pawn) 24.♘xe7 ♔xc7 25.f3 with a clearly better endgame for White.



20.♘f5! White exploits the pin on the knight to exchange Black's dark-square bishop.

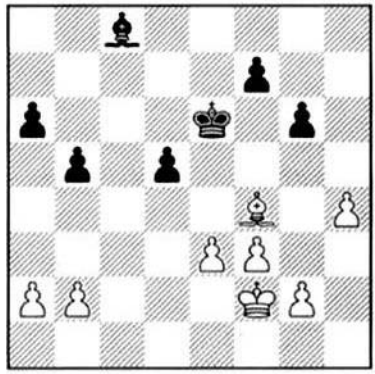
20...♔f8. In the event of 20...♗d8 White wins the d5-pawn – 21.♘d6 ♖c7 22.♘xb7 ♖xb7 23.♗xf6 ♗xf6 24.♖xd5 ♖c7 25.♖d2.

21.♘xe7 ♔xe7 22.♘d4 g6 (parrying the threat of 23.♘f5) **23.f3!** Emphasising Black's helplessness – to escape from the pin, he is forced to give up a pawn.

23...h6 24.♗xh6 ♘d7 25.h4 ♘c5 26.♗f4 ♘e6 27.♘xe6 ♔xe6 28.♖d2 ♖h8? A loss of time, since White ignores the threat to his h4-pawn. 28...b4 was better, with the idea after a6-a5 of activating the bishop. White would have continued g2-g4 and h4-h5, creating a passed pawn.

29.♖c2! Forcing the exchange of rooks, after which, despite the presence of opposite-colour bishops, White achieves a won endgame.

29...♖c8 30.♖xc8 ♗xc8 31.♔f2.



31...d4. A forced pawn sacrifice, since after the transference of the white king to d4 Black is unable to avert the threat of it penetrating to c5 or e5.

32.exd4 ♔d5 33.♔e3 ♗e6 34.♔d3 ♔c6 35.a3 ♗c4+ 36.♔e3 ♗e6 37.♗h6 ♔d5 38.♗g7. Black resigned.

In modern practice, improved defensive technique means that far more effort is demanded of the attacking side, and often a direct attack aimed at winning the isolated pawn proves insufficient. To convert the advantage it is normally necessary to create an additional weakness in the opponent's position, and it is this that determines the attacking side's strategy.

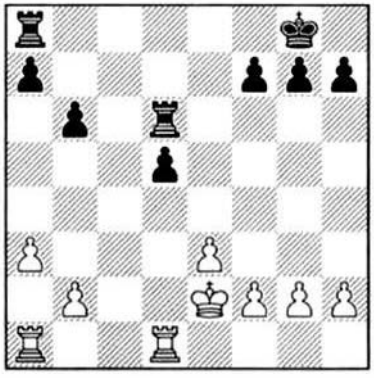
We will examine some typical examples of the play in complicated endgames, in which rooks are present.

8.1. Play with four rooks on the board

It can be considered that the main strategy in complicated endgames with rooks present is the coordination of them with the minor pieces. Therefore the defender must be careful about exchanges that weaken the periphery. The absence of his dark-square bishop may tell when there is a frontal attack on the isolated pawn. The attacker may alternate threats to the pawn with the invasion of the rooks on the files adjacent to the pawn, which may lead to the transformation of the position into a more favourable endgame.

We will begin with an ending without any minor pieces.

BAREEV – FARAGO
Rome 1990



In view of the threat of a frontal attack by the white rooks, the black rooks are tied to the defence of the d5-pawn and are unable to make use of the c-file, since the 8th rank is inadequately defended.

19...♖ad8 (19...♖c8 20.♖ac1) **20.♖ac1 ♔f8 21.♖c7 ♖6d7 22.♖dc1.** It is important for White to consolidate his grip on the c-file, since the weakness of the d5-pawn alone is insufficient for a win, and he needs to create a second weakness on the queenside.

22...♔e7.



23.♔d3 ♖xc7 24.♖xc7+ ♖d7 25.♖c8. The exchange of one pair of rooks favours White, since it reduces Black's possibilities of counterplay to the minimum.

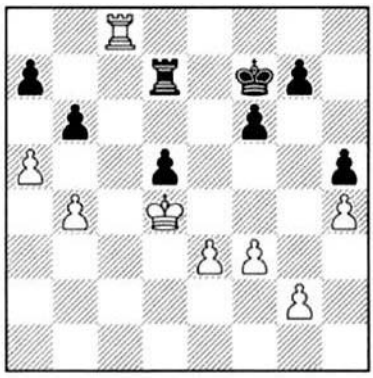
25...h5?! An inaccuracy. 25...a5 was stronger, when White could reply 26.g4!, preventing h7-h5.

26.b4! White carries out the plan of creating a second weakness on the queenside.

26...♔e6 27.♔d4 f6 28.h4. Preventing 28...h4 followed by g7-g5.

28...♔f5 29.f3 ♔g6. If 29...g5, then 30.hxg5 fxg5 31.♖f8+ ♔g6 32.♖e8 followed by ♖c5, winning the d5-pawn.

30.a4 ♔f7 31.a5.



31...♔e6. After 31...bxa5 32. bxa5 ♔c6 White would have surrounded and won the d5-pawn – 33. ♖c6+ ♔c7 34.♔c5 ♔f7 35.♖d6.

32.a6. Fixing the weakness on a7.

32...♔d6 33.b5 ♔e6 34.g3 g6 35.♖e8+ ♔d6 36.♖f8 ♔e6 37.♖c8 ♔d6 38.♖c6+ ♔e7 39.g4 ♔f7 40.gxh5 gxh5 41.♖c8. Now that Black has acquired three weak pawns on a7, d5 and h5, his position is hopeless.

41...♔e6 42.♖e8+ ♔d6 43.♖h8 ♖c7 44.♖d8+ ♔e6 45.♖xd5 f5 46.e4 fxe4 47.fxe4 ♖h7 48.♖d8 ♖c7 49.♖e8+ ♔f6 50.e5+ ♔f7 51.♖h8 ♖c5 52.♖xh5 ♔e6 53.♖h6+ ♔e7 54.♔e4 ♖xb5 55.♔f5. Black resigned.

Having familiarised ourselves with the problems of defending an isolated pawn in a double rook endgame, let us turn to more complicated positions with minor pieces on the board. We will begin with a typical example of a frontal attack.

RIBLI – PINTER
Baile Herculane 1982



White's advantage is obvious: the black rooks are tied to the defence of the d5-pawn, and the bishop is stronger than the knight. However, the standard idea of a frontal attack with the preparation of e3-e4 does not work here.

For the conversion of the advantage, the one weakness at d5 is insufficient: another target must be created.

27.g4! This pawn offensive on the kingside, supported by the bishop, should lead to the creation of a second weakness.

27...♔f7 28.♔c2 ♔c6 29.f4 f5?! The opening of the position favours White, who has a long-range bishop. 30...g6 was more cautious.

30.gxf5+ ♔xf5 31.♔f3 ♔e6 32.h4 ♖f8 33.♔g4 g6? Black ignores the threat of e3-e4, which could have been parried by 33... ♘b8.



34.e4! h5+. 34...♖fd8 leads to a lost position after 35.exd5+ ♖xd5 36.♖xd5 ♖xd5 37.♖xd5 ♔xd5 38.f5.

35.♔g5 d4 36.♗xd4 ♘d8 37.♗g7 ♘f7+ 38.♔xg6 ♘h8+ 39.♔h6 ♘f7+ 40.♔xh5. Black resigned.

One of the modern defensive ideas is to protect the d5-pawn with the rook from c5. Here the rook is more actively placed than in the rear, since it not only defends the pawn, but also participates in play on the c-file. Nevertheless, the defender has to be on the alert.

IVANCHUK – ARONIAN
Morelia/Linares 2007
Queen's Gambit D38

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.♘f3 d5 4.♘c3 ♗b4 5.♗g5 ♘bd7 6.cxd5 cxd5 7.♕c2 c5 8.a3 ♗xc3+ 9.♕xc3 h6 10.♗xf6 ♕xf6 11.e3 0-0 12.♗e2 h6 13.0-0 ♗b7 14.♖fc1 ♖ac8 15.dxc5 ♕xc3 16.♖xc3 ♖xc5.



17.♖cc1! Showing a deep understanding of the position. White takes measures to retain the rooks, since for a successful frontal attack on the isolated pawn he needs both of them.

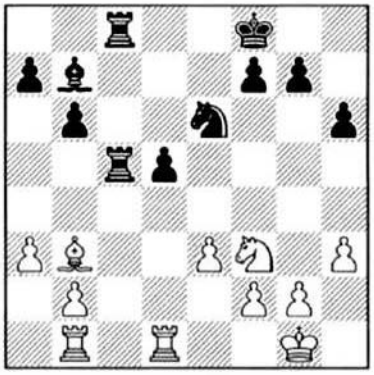
17...♖fc8?! To ease the defence Black should have exchanged rooks – 17...♖xc1+ 18.♖xc1 ♖c8 19.♖xc8+ ♗xc8, reaching a minor piece endgame of the type examined below in Averbakh – Matanovic.

18.♖d1! ♖c2 19.♗b5! ♘f8 20.♖ab1. In an unusual way White has retained both his rooks.

20...♖2c7. A prophylactic retreat in the event of ♘f3-d4. After

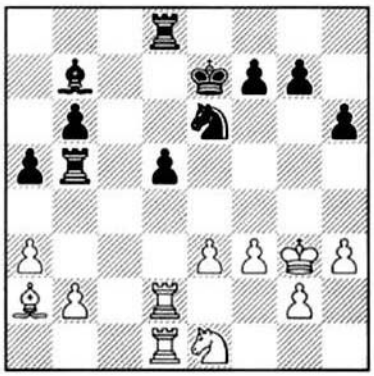
20...♘e6 21.♗d7 ♖f8! (21...♖d8? 22.♗xe6 fxe6 23.♘d4) 22.♖dc1 in order to hold the c-file Black has to make positional concessions: 22...♖c4 23.b4 followed by ♘f3-e5.

21.♗a4 ♘e6 22.♗b3 ♚f8 23.h3 ♖c5. This side protection of the isolated pawn against a frontal attack is one of the safe methods of defence.



24.♔h2! By moving his king away, White avoids the exchange of rooks on the back rank.

24...♚e7 25.♖d2 ♖b5 26.♗a2 ♖bc5 27.♘e1 a5 28.♖bd1 ♖d8 29.♔g3 ♖b5 30.f3.

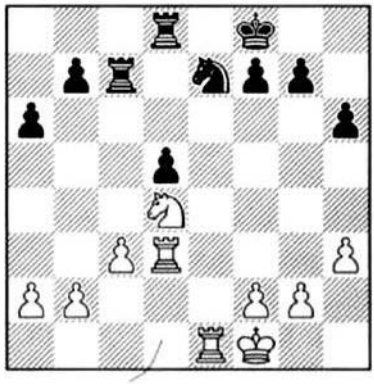


30...♖c8? A mistake, leading to the loss of a pawn. Black should have played 30...♖c5 with a defensible position.

31.♘d3! (threatening to trap the rook) **31...d4.** A forced pawn sacrifice. It was possible to defend against the threat of 32.b4 by 31...a4, but after 32.♘b4 ♘c7 33.e4! dxc4 34.♖d7+ ♚e8 35.♖xf7 ♖g5+ 36.♚f2 exf3 37.gxf3 the invasion of the second rook is decisive.

32.♗xe6 ♔xe6 33.♘f4+ ♔e7 34.♖xd4 ♖c7 35.♖1d2 ♖bc5 36.e4 ♖c4 37.♖d6 ♖4c6 38.e5 ♖c2 39.♖xc2 ♖xc2 40.♖xb6, and with two extra pawns White won easily.

AKOPIAN – SADVAKASOV
Moscow 2007



26.♖ed1. Apart from the frontal attack, the plan of playing the king to d3 and exploiting the e-file deserved serious consideration – 26.♖f3!? ♔g8 27.♔c2 ♘c6 28.♔d3 with the possible variations:

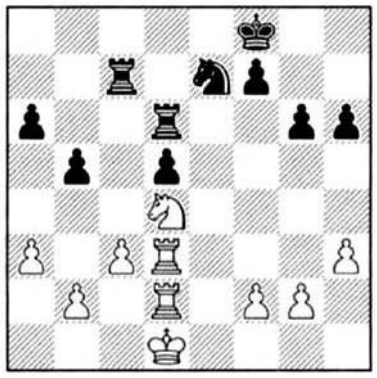
1) 28...♘xd4 29.♔xd4 ♖c4+ 30.♔d3 ♖e4 (after 30...♔f8 31.b3! White drives back the rook followed by ♔d3-d4) 31.♖fe3 (31.♖xe4 dxe4+ 32.♔xe4 ♖d2=) 31...f6 32.♖1e2, and White forces the exchange of a pair of rooks with the subsequent advance ♔d3-d4 and f2-f4-f5;

2) 28...f6!? 29.♖fe3 (in the event of 29.♘xc6 bxc6 Black can obtain counterplay on the b-file: 30.♖fe3 ♔f7 31.♖e6 a5 32.b3 c5 33.♖a6 c4+ 34.♔d4 cxb3 35.axb3 ♖b8 36.♖b1 ♖b5 or 30.♖f4 c5 31.♖e6 c4+ 32.♔d4 ♖b7) 29...♘xd4 30.♔xd4 ♖c4+ 31.♔d3 b5 32.♖e6 ♖f4 (after 32...♔f7 33.♖xa6 d4 34.♔c2 dxe3 35.bxe3 b4 36.♖a7+ ♔g6 37.♖e3 or 32...d4 33.♖e8+ ♖xe8 34.♖xe8+ ♔f7 35.♖e4 Black has no compensation for the lost pawn) 33.♖xa6 ♖xf2 34.♖e2 ♖xe2 35.♔xe2 d4 36.♔d3 dxe3+ 37.♔xe3 with advantage to White. In the rook endgame, apart from the weakness of the b5-pawn, Black has to reckon with the creation of an outside passed pawn.

26...♖d6 27.♖1d2 ♖cd7 28.♘b3 b6 29.♘d4 b5 30.♘b3 ♖c7 31.a3 ♖b6 32.♖e2 g6 33.♔e1. The flank attack on the d5-pawn – 33.♘d4 ♖d6 34.♖c5 – is parried by 34...f6 35.♖e6 ♖cd7 36.♖xd6 ♖xd6 37.g4 (37.♘b3 ♘c6) 37...♔f7.

33...♖d6 34.♖ed2 ♖c8 35.♔d1 ♖c7. Black sticks to waiting tactics, retaining both rooks. This leaves him hopes of gaining counterplay, which is more difficult after the exchange of a pair of rooks – 35...♖e6 36.♘d4 ♖c5 37.♖c2 ♖xc2 38.♔xc2.

36.♘d4.



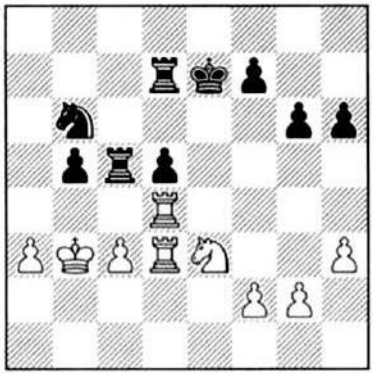
36...♘c8! Black takes the opportunity to activate his knight – from b6 it will not only defend the d5-pawn, but also have an influence on the queenside.

37.♘c2 ♘b6 38.♘e3 ♖cd7 39.b3. Without the preparation of c3-c4 the frontal attack on the d5-pawn is pointless. But this move weakens the c3-pawn.

39...♖c7 40.♔c2 ♖dc6 41.♔b2 ♖c5! The flank defence of an isolated pawn by a rook is often more effective than from the rear, since the rook is more actively placed.

42.♘c2 a5! Black defends splendidly. He intends by a5-a4 to deform White's pawn structure, which will remove c3-c4 from the agenda.

43.♘e3 ♖d7 44.♖d4 a4 45.♖2d3 axb3 46.♔xb3 ♔e7.

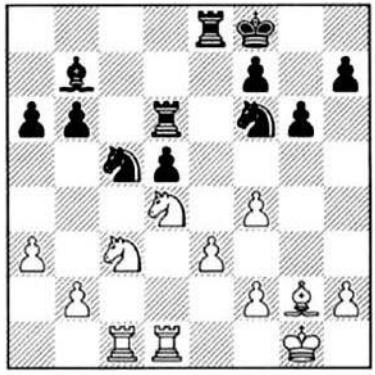


47.♖f4. As a result of the flank counterattack the two sides now have the same number of pawn weaknesses. After 47.♔b4 there follows 47...♔d6, while if 47.♘g4 Black can sacrifice a pawn – 47...♖a7!? (weaker is 47...h5?! 48.♖e3+ ♔f8 49.♘f6 ♖d8 50.g4, establishing the knight at f6) 48.♘xh6 ♔d6, with play against the weak queenside pawns: 49.♖f3 ♖ec7 50.♘g4 (50...f5 was threatened) 50...♘c4.

47...♔e6 48.♘c2 ♔e5 49.♖b4 ♖a7 50.♘d4 ♖a5 51.♖e3+ ♔d6 52.♖e2 ♘c4 53.♖a2 ♘e5 54.♔c2 ♘c6 55.♘xc6 ♖xc6. Black has successfully defended, and after the transition into a double rook ending the game soon ended in a draw.

We will consider some examples of flank strategy with the use of rooks to attack the rear periphery.

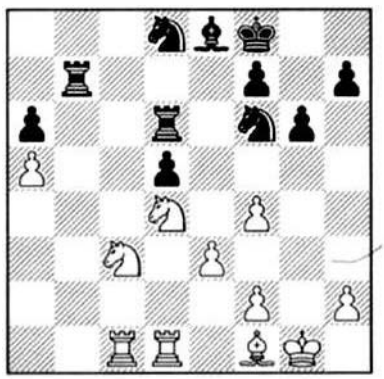
GELFAND – KARPOV
Vienna 1996



In contrast to standard positions with an isolated d5-pawn, a small advantage is conferred by White's doubled f4-pawn, which is controlling the centre. But to convert his advantage he must create a second weakness in Black's position, and with this aim he begins a pawn offensive on the queenside.

21.b4 ♘e6. The active 21...♘ce4 is not good because of 22.♘a4 with the threat of f2-f3.

22.♘ce2 ♖e7 23.a4 ♘d8 24.a5 ♗c6 25.♘c3 ♗e8 26.♗f1 bxa5 27.bxa5 ♖b7.



28.♖a1! A Petrosian-style move. The removal of this rook from its active position has the specific preventive aim of defending the a5-pawn, in order to begin a piece attack on the weak a6- and d5-pawns.

28...♖c7?! An aimless move, which merely invites the knight to go to b4, for where it is aiming. Black should have brought up his forces towards the centre – 28...♔e7 or 28...♘e6, whereas the obvious 28...♘e4 would have run into 29.♘db5! ♗xb5 30.♘xe4.

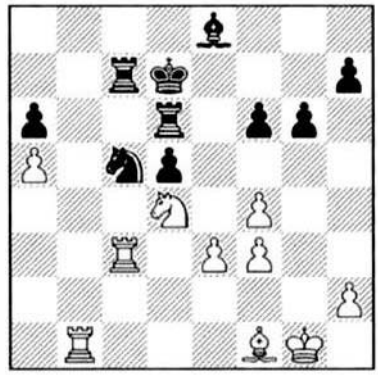
29. ♘a2 ♖b7 30.f3 ♘e6 31.♖db1. Now, after the seizure of the b-file, the game is decided, and the subsequent lengthy struggle is merely explained by Karpov's fine defensive technique.

31...♖e7 32.♘b4 ♘c5. After the passive defence of the a6-pawn – 32...♘xd4 33.exd4 ♖a7 White liquidates into a technically won endgame: 34.♘xa6 ♖axa6 35.♗xa6 ♖xa6 36.♖b6 ♖xb6 37.axb6 ♗c6 38.♖c1 (Gelfand).

33.♖c1 ♖b7 34.♖ab1 ♘fd7 35.♘bc6 ♖c7 36.♘e5 ♔e7 37.♖c3 f6 38.♘xd7 ♔xd7.

(See diagram)

39.♖b8! The attempt to transform the positional advantage into a material one by the pin 39.♖bc1 ♘e6 40.♘xe6 ♖xc3 41.♘f8+ ♔c7 42.♘xg6+ hxg6 43.♖xc3 allows Black to become active with 43...d4.

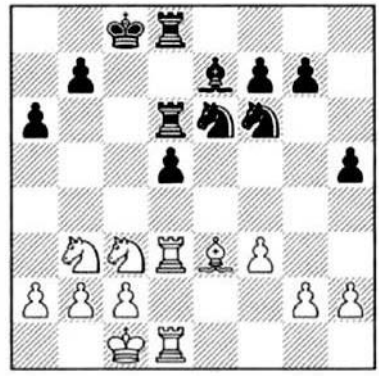


39...♘c6 40.♖xc7+ ♘xc7 41.♔f2 ♔c7 42.f5 g5 43.♔e1. The king heads for d4.

43...♗b5. Black pins his last hopes on the rook endgame.

44.♗xb5 ♘xb5 45.♘xb5 axb5 46.♖xb5 ♖c6 47.♖xd5 ♖c3 48.♔d2 ♖a3 49.♔c2 ♖xe3 50.♔h2 ♖e2+ 51.♔b3 ♖xh2 52.a6 ♖h1 53.♔b4 ♖a1 54.♖a5 ♖b1+ 55.♔c5 ♖b8 56.a7 ♖a8 57.♔c6, and White won.

NAIDITSCH – BUNZMANN
Bad Wiessee 1999



White has an enduing positional advantage in view of the weakening

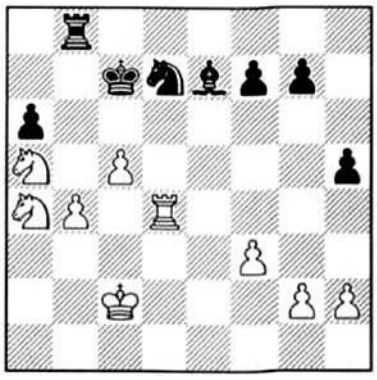
of Black's queenside pawns, and, as a consequence, of the dark squares, which makes it more difficult for him to defend the isolated d5-pawn.

20.a4! White is threatening to win the d5-pawn after setting up a bind with 21.a5 and invading with his bishop on b6. Therefore Black is forced to go in for a further weakening of his pawn structure.

20...b6 21.a5! bxa5. Avoiding the exchange by 21...b5 leads to the loss of a pawn after 22.♗b6 ♖8d7 23.♘c5 ♘xc5 24.♗xc5 ♖c6 25.♗xe7 ♖exc7 26.♘xd5.

22.♘a4 ♔d7 23.♘xa5 ♖b8 24.c4. White goes in for a forcing variation, provoking d5-d4, but 24.♘c3 was simpler: 24...♘c7 (or 24...d4 25.♘c4! ♘d5 26.♗xd4 ♘xc3 27.♗xc3) 25.♗f4 ♖c6 26.♘xd5 ♘fxd5 27.♖xd5+ ♘xd5 28.♗xb8 with an extra pawn.

24...d4 (24...♖c8 25.♔b1) **25. c5 ♖d5 26.♗xd4 ♖xd4 27.♖xd4+ ♘xd4 28.♖xd4+ ♔c7 29.♔c2 ♘d7 30.b4.**



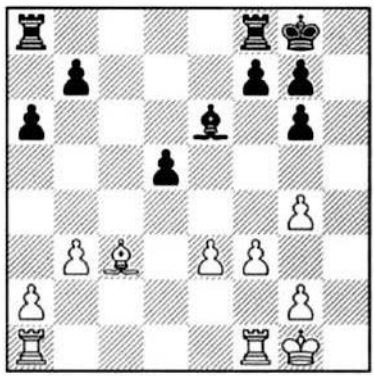
White is a pawn up with a winning position.

30...♗f6 31.♖e4 ♖b5? This leads to further loss of material. 31...♘e5 32.♘b6 ♖d8 33.♘bc4 ♘xc4 34.♘xc4 ♖d5 was more tenacious.

32.♘c3 ♗xc3 33.♔xc3 ♘xc5. Otherwise the invasion of the rook is decisive.

34.♖c4 ♔b6 35.♖xc5 ♖xc5+ 36.bxc5+ ♔xc5 37.♘b3+ ♔d5 38.♔d3 g5 39.♘d2 g4 40.f4 ♔c5 41.♘e4+ ♔b4 42.♔c2 b4 43.♘d6 ♔c5 44.♘xf7 g3 45.bxg3 bxg3 46.♘b6 ♔d4 47.♘f5+. Black resigned.

DREEV – RIAZANTSEV
Sochi 2005



Contrary to popular opinion, with other pieces on the board, opposite-colour bishops by no means guarantee a draw. Moreover, the side with the more active bishop has a definite advantage. In the given

position White's dark-square bishop is influencing events on both wings, and the black king will be tied to the defence of its pawns.

23.g5! White fixes the kingside pawns.

23...♖ac8 24.♗d4. It stands to reason that play on the c-file – 24.♖ac1 ♖c6 25.♗d4 ♖fc8 gets White nowhere.

24...f6?! This natural desire to escape from the pressure of the g5-pawn creates a problem with the f6-pawn. Black's best chance was to activate his rooks as much as possible. Riazantsev gives the following variation: 24...♖c2 25.♔h2 ♖fc8 26.♔g3 ♖d2 27.♖h1 ♖cc2 28.♖h2 ♖xa2 29.♖ah1 ♔f8 30.♖h8+ ♔e7 31.♖b8 ♖xg2+ 32.♔f4 ♖a2 33.♖xb7+ ♔d6 34.♖b6+ ♔d7! and, in view of the threat of a mating attack after 35... ♖g4+, White is forced to open the position with 35.e4, which increases the mobility of the black rooks. Here are some possible variations: 35...♖d2 (35...♖g4+ 36.♔e3 ♖gg2 37.♖c1 ♖e2+ 38.♔f4 ♖g4+!? 39.fxg4 ♖xe4+ 40.♔f3 ♖xd4 41.♖xa6 ♗xg4+ 42.♔e3 ♖e4+ 43.♔d2 ♗e6 is also possible, with sufficient compensation for the exchange) 36.♗xg7 dxe4 37.fxe4 ♖d3 38.♗f6 ♖g4+ 39.♔e5 ♖xb3 40.♖xa6 ♖b5+ 41.♔d4 ♖xe4+!, forcing a draw.

25.gxf6 gxf6 26.♔f2 ♚g7?! Black should first have included 26...♖c2+ 27.♔g3 and now 27...♔g7, denying White a possibility which occurred in the game.

27.g4! ♖h8 28.♔g3 g5 29.♖h1 ♖xh1 30.♖xh1. The black king is tied to the defence of the f6-pawn, and at the same time White can attack with his f-pawn.

30...♚g6 31.f4 f5! Afterthe passive 31...♗g8 32.f5+ ♔g7 33.♖h5 ♚f7 White prepares the creation of a second weakness on the queenside: 34.a4 ♖c6 35.a5 ♖c1 36.♖h6 ♖c6 37.b4 ♔g7 38.♖g6+ ♔f7 39.♔f2! ♗h7 40.♖h6 ♗g8 41.♔e2 ♔g7 42.♖g6+ ♔f7 43.♔d2 ♗h7 44.♖h6 ♗g8 45.♖h1 ♖c4 46.♖b1 followed by b4-b5.

32.♖h5! gxf4+ 33.exf4 fxg4 34.♖g5+ ♚h6. If 34...♔f7, then 35.f5 ♗d7 36.♖g7+ ♔e8 37.f6 is decisive.



35.♖e5?! A loss of time. The immediate 35.♔h4! was stronger: 35...♗f7 36.♖f5 ♖c7 37.♖f6+ ♔h7 38.♖d6! ♖e7 39.♔xg4 ♔g8 (or 39...♖e2 40.♖d7 ♔g6 41.f5+

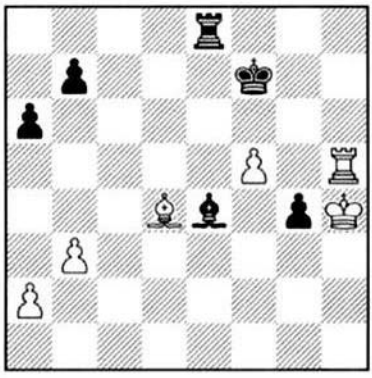
♔h6 42.♖d6+ ♔h7 43.♔g5 with the invasion of the king) 40.♔g5 ♔f8 41.♔f6 with a complete bind.

35...♖e8 36.♔h4 ♗f7?! Black misses a chance to activate his pieces: 36...g3! 37.♔xg3 ♗f7, which would enable him to hold the position. For example: 38.♖f5 ♗e6 39.♖f6+ ♔h5 40.f5 ♗g8 41.♖b6 ♔g5 42.f6 ♖e4= (Riazantsev).

37.♖f5 ♗g6. There is not much choice. 37....♗g8 38.♖f6+ ♔h7 39.♔xg4 ♖e6 leads to a lost bishop ending after 40.♔g5 (40.♖f8 ♖e4) 40...♖xf6 41.♔xf6 ♔h6 42.f5 ♗h7 43.♔e6 ♗g8+ 44.♔e7 ♔g5 45.♔f8, while the active 37...♖e4 38.♖xf7 ♖xd4 39.♔xg4 ♖d2 40.♖xb7 ♖xa2 41.♔f5 leads to a difficult rook ending.

38.♖xd5 ♗e4. More tenacious was38...g3 39.♔xg3 ♗e440.♖d6+ etc.

39.♖h5+ ♔g6 40.f5+! ♔f7.



In this position White could have won by an attack on the king: **41.♖h7+ ♔f8 42.♔g5! ♔g8** (42...g3 43.♔f6) **43.♖g7+ ♔f8 44.f6 ♖c8 45.b4 g3 46.♗c5+ ♖xc5+** 47.bxc5 g2 48.♔f4 with a simple win (Riazantsev). But there followed **41.♔xg4? ♗b1! 42.♔g5 ♖d8!** and Black held the position: **43.♖h7+ ♔e8 44.♖h8+ ♔d7 45.♖h2 ♔e8! 46.♗e5 ♖d1 47.♖h8+ ♔d7 48.♖h7+ ♔e8! 49.♖xb7 ♖g1+ 50.♔f6 ♖f1 51.♗c3 ♖xf5+! 52.♔e6 ♖b5 53.♖e7+ ♔d8 54.♖d7+ ♔c8 55.♖d2 ♖c5 56.♗e5 ♖c6+ 57.♔e7 ♗f5 58.♖d8+ ♔b7 59.♗d6 ♖c8.** Draw.

I.SOKOLOV – TREGUBOV
Reykjavik 2006



White has a slight advantage thanks to his more active bishop, which is able to support his pawn offensive on the kingside.

28.♖c3. White prepares to exchange rooks on a defended square. After 28.b3 ♖xc1 29.♖xc1 ♗xa3 30.♖a1 ♗c531.♖xa7 ♗xd432.exd4

which is bound to decide the game.

28.♖xe1 ♔f8 29.g5! After the pushing back of the knight, the d5-pawn becomes more vulnerable.

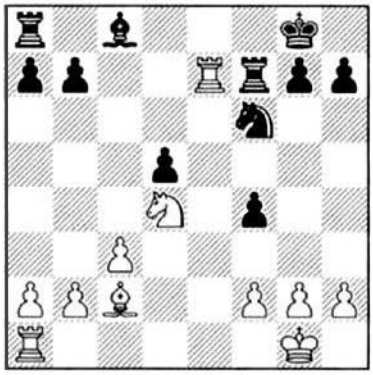
29...hxg5. After 29...♘h5 30.gxh6 gxh6 31.♗f5 ♗xf5 32.♘xf5 the h6-pawn is lost.

30.hxg5 ♘e8 31.♔e3 ♘c7 32.♔f4 ♘e6+. No better was 32...♖e8 33.♖h1 ♘e6+ (33...♔g8 34.♗h7+ ♔f8 35.♗f5) 34.♔e5 ♔g8 (34...♘xg5+? 35.♔d6 ♗h3 36.f4 loses a piece) 35.♘xe6 ♗xe6 36.♔d4 with the threat of advancing the f-pawn.

33.♘xe6+ ♗xe6 34.♖h1 ♔e7 35.♖h7 ♖g8 36.♔e5 d4. A forced pawn sacrifice. After the passive defence 36...g6 37.f4 ♔d7 White carries out a pawn breakthrough on the kingside. For example: 38.f5 gxf5 39.♗xf5 ♗xf5 40.♖xf7+ ♔e8 41.♖xf5 with a won rook endgame. Also good is 38...♗b5+ ♔c7 39.a3 ♖f8 40.♖g7 ♖h8 41.f5! ♗xf5 42.♖xf7+ ♔b8 43.♔xd5, threatening an attack on the king.

37.a3 g6 38.♔xd4 ♖d8+ 39.♔e3 ♔d6 40.♖h4 ♖e8 41.♖d4+ ♔c5 42.b4+ axb4 43.axb4+ ♔c6 44.♔f4 ♗a2 45.c4, and White converted his extra pawn.

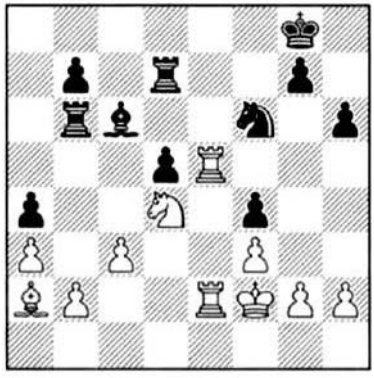
KAIDANOV – BRADFORD
USA Championship 2007



20.♖e5! It is important to retain the rook, in order to control the e-file and attack the isolated d5-pawn.

20...♗d7 21.♗b3 ♗c6 22.♖ae1 a5 23.a3 h6 24.f3 a4 25.♗a2. The bishop has performed its role on the a2-g8 diagonal, and now was the time to switch it to the weakened g6-square after 25.♗c2!

25...♖a6 26.♖1e2 ♖b6 27.♖f5 ♖f8 28.♖fe5 ♖d8 (28...♖f7 29.♖c6) **29.♔f2 ♖d7.**



30.♗b1. White has discovered the Achilles' heel of Black's position – the g6-point.

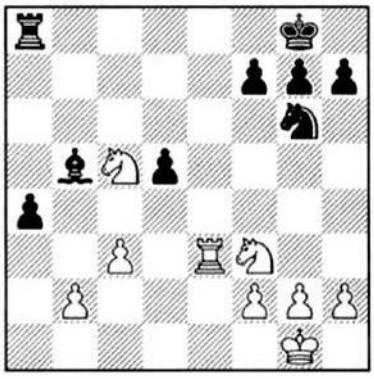
30...♜d8 31.♖e7 ♗b5 32.♘xb5 ♖xb5 33.♗g6 ♔h8 34.♔e1 ♖b6 35.h4 h5 36.♖7e6 ♖b5. 36...♖xc6 37.♖xc6 d4 38.cxd4 ♖xd4 39.♖b6 ♖d7 40.♖b4 also fails to save Black.

37.♗d3 ♖c5 38.♖e7 b5 39.♖b7 d4 40.♖xb5 ♖cc8 41.c4. Black resigned.

8.2. Play with one pair of rooks

In positions where there is one pair of rooks remaining, an increasingly important role is played by the king, which may take an active part in the attack on weaknesses. When conducting the strategy of an attack on the isolated pawn, still important is the motif of creating an additional weakness and transposing into a favourable rook or minor piece ending.

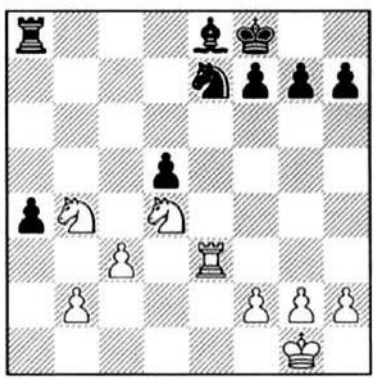
HORT – VELIMIROVIC
Budapest 1973



The weak d5 and a4 pawns in Black's position give White a slight advantage. But if Black should succeed in exchanging the a4-pawn for the pawn on b2, the weaknesses at d5 and c3 may cancel each other out.

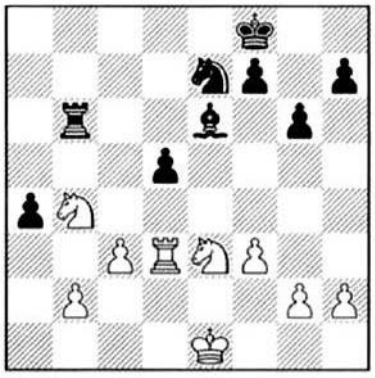
24.♘d4 ♗e8 25.♘a6! White manoeuvres skilfully with his knights, preventing a4-a3 and keeping the d5-pawn under fire. For example, in the event of 25...♖xa6 26.♖xc8+ ♘f8 it is not easy for Black to escape from the pin: 27.♘f5 f6 28.♘e7+ ♔f7 29.♘xd5 ♔xe8 30.♘c7+ ♔d7 31.♘xa6 ♔d6 32.♘b4 with an extra pawn for White.

25...♔f8 26.♘b4 ♘e7?! Missing the opportunity to play 26...a3 27.bxa3 ♖xa3 28.♘dc2 (28.g3 ♖a5) 28...♖a5, when Black's chances of a draw increase.



27.♘dc2! Now the a4-pawn is securely blockaded, and White can embark on a siege of the d5-pawn.

27...♖b8 28.♖d3 ♗d7 29.♘c3 ♗c6 30.f3 g6 31.♔f2 ♖b6 32.♔c1.



32...♘c6?! An unnecessary knight exchange, leading to an ending with a stable structure, where the remaining knight is clearly stronger than the bishop. 32...g5 33.♔d2 f5 came into consideration.

33.♘xc6 ♖xc6 34.♔d2 ♖c5 35.♘c2 ♗f5? In order to prevent the knight from reaching the d4 blockading point, Black is ready to go into a rook endgame, in which White finds a winning manoeuvre. Black should have held his ground with 35...♖b5 36.♔c1 ♔e7 37.♘d4 ♖b6.

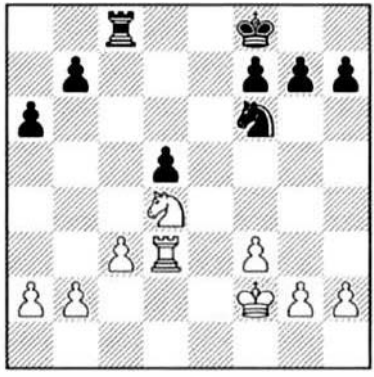
36.♖d4 ♗xc2 37.♔xc2 ♖a5 38.♔b1! The threat of the king manoeuvre to a3 forces Black to part with one of his weak pawns – d5 or a4.

38...a3 39.b4 a2+ 40.♔a1 ♖a3 41.♖xd5 ♖xc3 42.♔xa2! With the king cut off, the b-pawn is bound to decide the game.

42...♖c2+ 43.♔b3 ♖xg2 44.b5 ♔e7. Or 44...♖g1 45.♖c5 f6 46.♖c2 with the threat of b5-b6.

45.b6 ♖g1 46.♔c2! ♖g2+ 47.♔c3 ♖g1 48.♔c2 ♖g2+ 49.♔c3 ♖g1 50.♖b5 ♖c1+ 51.♔d4 ♖d1+ 52.♔c5 ♖c1+ 53.♔d5 ♖d1+ 54.♔c6 ♖c1+ 55.♖c5 ♖xc5+ 56.♔xc5 ♔d7 57.♔d5 f5 58.h4. Black resigned.

PARMA – PUC
Ljubljana 1969



White's advantage consists in the possibility of organising an attack on the d5-pawn, and also the more active role of his king, which, in contrast to its opposite number, is ready to arrive at the centre of events.

26.g4! White seizes space on the kingside and prepares to switch his knight to e3 for an attack on the d5-pawn.

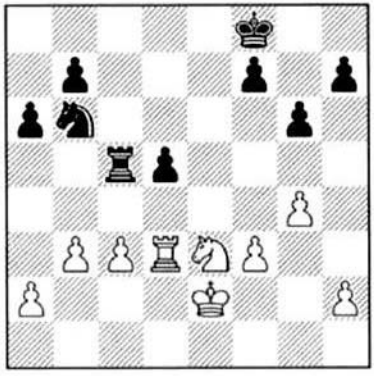
26...♘d7. If 26...g6 there would follow 27.♘e2 with the threat of 28.g5, which can only be parried by

g6-g5, leading to a weakening of the f5-point.

27.♘f5 ♘b6 28.b3. Nothing is given by 28.♘d6?! on account of 28...♖c6! (28...♖c7? 29.♖c3) 29.♘xb7 ♘a4 30.♖xd5 ♖b6, and Black regains the sacrificed pawns.

28...g6 29.♘e3 ♖c5. If 29...♖d8? there follows 30.c4 d4 31.♘e2, winning a pawn.

30.♔e2. For the attack on the d5-pawn the knight must be evicted from b6, and this cannot be done without the support of the king.



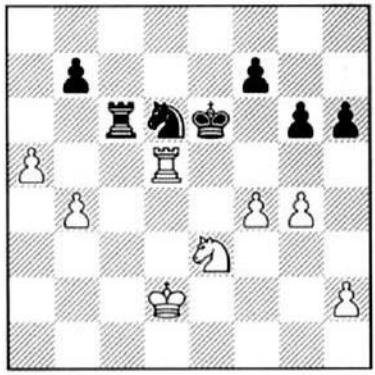
30...h6?! Realising that it is too late to support the d5-pawn with the king (30...♔e7 31.a4 ♔e6 32.b4 ♖c8 33.a5, and White wins the pawn), Black prepares to bring it into play via f6. Strange logic – it would have been better to spend a tempo on 30...a5!?

31.♔d2 ♔g7? The black king is still unable to come to the rescue of the d5-pawn – 31...♔e7 32.b4 (32.a4 is also good) 32...♖c8 (if 32...♖b5? all the same there follows 33.a4! ♘xa4 34.♘xd5+, also winning the exchange) 33.♘xd5+ ♘xd5 34.♖xd5, and in the rook endgame White has an extra pawn on the queenside with the king cut off. But here too it was not yet too late for 31...a5, not fearing 32.b4 ♖b5!?

32.♖d4! An important blockading move, which supports the pawn offensive on the queenside. In the event of 32.b4 ♖b5!? 33.♖d4 a5 34.a3 a4 35.♔d3 ♔f6 the king succeeds in defending the d5-pawn, and then after ♘b6-d7 the rook is also released from captivity.

32...a5 33.a4 ♔f6 34.b4 axb4 35.cxb4 ♖c6 36.a5 ♘c8. Even worse is 36...♔e5? 37.♔d3, when the tactics do not work: 37...♖c3+? 38.♔xc3 ♘a4+ 39.♔b3 ♔xd4 40.♘d1.

37.♖xd5 ♔e6 38.f4 ♘d6 39.♖e5+ ♔d7 40.♖d5 ♔e6.



41.f5+! Before breaking through on the queenside, it is use-

ful also to advance a pawn on the kingside.

41...gxf5 42.gxf5+ ♔e7 43.b5 ♖c8 44.a6 bxa6. 44...♖a8 45.axb7 ♖b8 was more tenacious.

45.bxa6 ♔d7 46.♖a5 ♔c6 47.♔d3 ♔b6 48.♖a4 ♘b5 49.a7! ♖d8+. 49...♘xa7? is not possible because of 50.♘c4+ ♔b7 51.♘d6+.

50.♘d5+! ♔b7 (50...♖xd5+ 51.♔e4) **51.a8♕+ ♖xa8 52.♖b4 ♖a5** (52...♔c6 53.♖xb5!) **53.♘c3 ♔c6 54.♖xb5 ♖xb5 55.♘xb5 ♔xb5 56.♔d4.** This is where the foresight in playing 41.f5+ is seen.

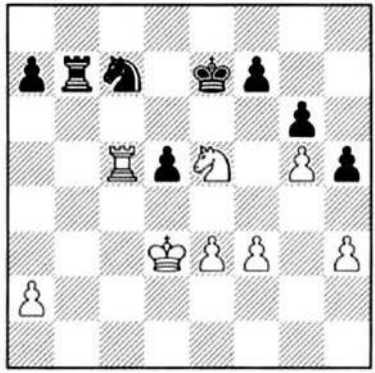
56...♔c6 57.♔e5 ♔d7 58.♔f6 ♔e8 59.♔g7 ♔e7 60.f6+ ♔e6 61.h3. Black resigned.

NIKOLIC – PORTISCH
Ter Apel 1994



24.♖c2! An important move – the a2- and f2-pawns are possible targets for Black's counterplay and therefore they must be defended.

24...♘e4 25.♘e5 ♖b7 26.♔f1 ♔f8 27.♔e2 ♔e7 28.g4 ♘f6 29.h3 g6 30.f3 h5 31.g5 ♘e8 32.♗d3 ♘c7 33.♖c5.



33...d4. An essentially forced pawn sacrifice, since Black is in a kind of zugzwang: the d5-pawn is weak and 33...♔d6? is not possible because of 34.♖c6+ ♔e7 (34...♔xe5?? 35.f4+ ♔f5 36.♖f6#) 35.♖f6. After 33...♘a6 34.♖a5 ♘b4+ 35.♔c3 ♔d6 36.f4 when a zugzwang position again arises – the f7-pawn is weak. Also dubious is 33...f6 34.gxf6+ ♔xf6 35.♘c6 ♖b2, and now, if there is nothing better, 36.♘e7 ♔xe7 37.♖xc7+ ♔e6 38.♖xa7 winning a pawn.

34.exd4 ♘e6 35.♖a5 ♘xg5 36.♘xg6+ ♔f6 37.♘f4 h4 38.♘h5+ ♔g6 39.♘f4+ ♔f6 40.♖a6+ ♔f5 41.♘g2 ♘xh3 42.♖a5+ ♔e6 43.♔e3 ♔d6 44.♘xh4 ♖e7+ 45.♔d2 ♔c6 46.♘f5 ♖d7 47.♔e3 ♔b6 48.♖e5 ♘g5 49.a4,

and White gradually converted his extra pawn.

MAMEDYAROV – KVEINYS
Reykjavik 2006

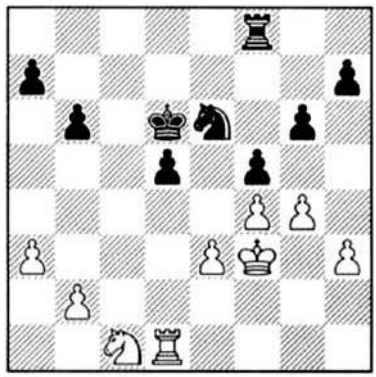


White's advantage is minimal. He cannot extract anything real from the blockade of the d4-point and the c-file – 21.♔d3 ♔d6 22.♘d4 ♘c5+ 23.♔e2 g6 etc. Therefore his chances lie in creating a new weakness on the kingside.

21.f4 f5!? The blockade of the attacking pawn allows White to create a new target – the f5-pawn. It would also not have been easy to breach Black's position after the passive 21...♔d6 22.g4 ♖e8, although he can also go in for counter-activity – 22...a5 with the idea of 23.♖d1 a4 24.♘d4 ♘xd4+ 25.♖xd4 ♔c5, reaching a tenable rook endgame.

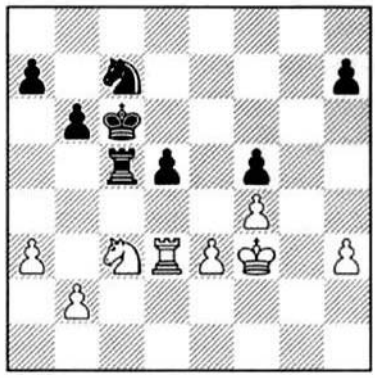
22.h3 b6 23.g4 ♖f8 24.♖d1 g6 25.♔f3. 25.♖xd5 fxg4 26.hxg4 ♖xf4 favours Black.

25...♔d6 26.♘c1.



26...♖c8. Serious consideration should have been given to the exchange 26...fxg4+!? 27.hxg4, when Black sets up counterplay: 27...♘g5+ 28.♔e2 ♘e4 29.♘d3 a5 30.♖c1 g5! For example: 31.b4 axb4 32.axb4 ♖a8 33.♖c2 gxf4 (33...♖a3 is also good) 34.exf4 d4! 35.♔f3 ♔d5, and the black pieces become very active – ♖a3 is threatened.

27.♘a2 ♖c5 28.♘c3 ♔c6 29.♖d3 ♘c7 30.gxf5 gxf5.



31.h4. White plans to invade with his rook along the g-file with

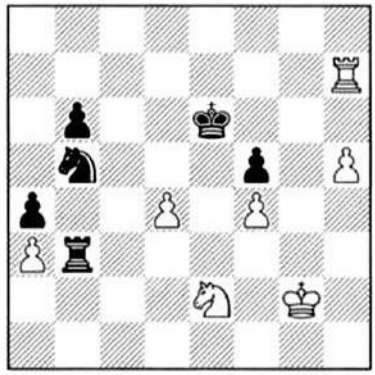
an attack on the h7-pawn, which in the end proved successful, and first he advances his h-pawn. However, as the course of the game shows, Black gains counterplay on the opposite wing. The invasion of the king looks more logical: 31.♔g3 ♔d6 (31...♘b5? 32.♘xb5 ♖xb5 is not possible on account of 33.b4 a5 34.♖d4, when the black rook is immobilised) 32.b4 (weaker is 32.♔h4 ♔e6 33.♔g5 ♘e8 34.♔h6 ♘f6 35.♘e2 ♘e4 36.♘d4+ ♔f6) 32...♖c6 33.♔h4 ♔e6 34.♔g5 a5 35.bxa5 bxa5 36.h4 (36.♔h6 ♔f7+ 37.♔g5 ♖f6 38.♘xd5 is also possible, winning the d5-pawn, but not 37.♔xh7?? ♘e6 and the king finds itself in a mating net) 36...♖c5 37.♘e2 (37.♔h6 ♔f7 38.h5 ♖e6+ 39.♔g5 ♖f6 is less effective) with the decisive threat of 38.♘d4+. For example: 37...♘b5 (or 37...♘e8 38.♘d4+ ♔f7 39.♘b3 ♖c6 40.♔xf5) 38.a4! ♖c2 39.axb5 ♖xc2 40.♖a3 ♖g2+ 41.♔h5 ♖g3 42.b6 and the b-pawn decides the game – 42...d4 (or 42...♔d6 43.b7 ♔c7 44.♖xa5 ♖xe3 45.♖xd5 ♔xb7 46.♖d7+ ♔c6 47.♖xh7) 43.♖xa5 d3 44.b7 d2 45.♖e5+ ♔d7 46.♖d5+ ♔c7 47.♖xd2 etc.

31...a5 32.h5 ♘b5 33.♘e2 a4 34.♖d2. Defending against the invasion of the rook, which was possible after 34.♖d1. In the event of 34.b3 axb3 35.a4 ♘d6 36.♘d4+ ♔c7 37.♘xb3 ♖c4 (37...♖c2? 38.♖xd5 ♖h2 39.♘d4 ♖xh5 40.♘b5+ ♘xb5 41.axb5 leads to a lost rook endgame) 38.♖xd5 ♖xa4 39.♘d4 ♖a5 Black retains the balance.

34...♔d7 35.♖d1 ♔e6 36.♖g1 ♖c2 37.♖g7 d4. Black makes space for his king, enabling him to use his rook more actively. But the simple 37...♖xb2 38.♖xh7 ♘xa3 39.♘d4+ ♔f6 40.♖h6+ ♔f7 41.♖h7+ ♔f8 was also possible, defending successfully.

38.exd4. After 38.♖xh7 d3 it is White who has to fight for a draw.

38...♖xb2 39.♖xh7 ♖b3+ 40.♔g2.

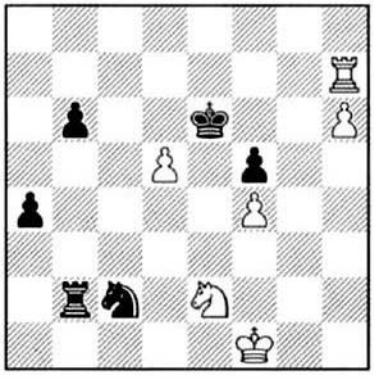


40...♖b2. Black intends to capture the a3-pawn with his knight, but the coordination of his pieces would also have been adequately consolidated after 40...♖e3!? 41.♘g3 ♖xa3. For example: 42.♖b7 (42.♖h6+ ♔f7 43.♘xf5 ♖b3 44.♖xb6 is parried by 44...♘xd4) 42...♘xd4 43.h6 ♖e3 44.♖xb6+ ♔f7 45.♖b4 ♖c2+ 46.♔h3 ♘f3 47.♘xf5 ♔g6

48.♘e7+ ♔xh6 49.♖xa4 ♔g7, reducing the pawn material to the minimum.

41.♔f1 ♘xa3 42.h6 ♘c2. The alternative 42...♘c4 43.d5+ (nothing is given by 43.♖c7 ♘d2+ 44.♔g1 ♘f3+ 45.♔f1 ♘h2+ 46.♔e1 ♘f3+) 43...♔f6! (43...♔xd5?! 44.♖d7+ ♔c6 45.h7 ♖b1+ 46.♔g2 ♘e3+ 47.♔f3 ♖h1 48.♖d8 leads to the loss of the knight) 44.♔f2 ♘d6 causes Black great problems. For example, the variation 45.♖c7 ♘e4+ 46.♔e3 ♖b3+ 47.♔d4 ♖b4+ 48.♔d3 ♖b1 49.♘c3! (49.♘c1 ♖b2 50.h7 ♖h2=) 49...a3 50.h7 ♖h1 51.♘xe4+ fxe4+ 52.♔xe4 a2 53.♖a7 ♖xh7 54.♖xa2 leaves White with chances in the rook endgame.

43.d5+!? A useful move, which unexpectedly proves effective. In the event of 43.♖g7 ♖b1+ 44.♔g2 ♘e3+ 45.♔f3 ♘d5 46.♘g3 ♖b3+ Black neutralises the h-pawn.



43...♔d6? This loses. 43...♔f6! would have held the position.

44.♖g7 ♖b1+ 45.♔g2. 45.♔f2 a3 46.♖a7! would also have won.

45...♘e3+ 46.♔h2 ♘f1+ 47.♔h3 ♖b2. 47...♖e1 48.♖g6+ ♔xd5 49.♘c3+ ♔c4 50.h7 ♘e3 51.♔h2 ♘f1+ 52.♔h1 ♘g3+ 53.♔g2 would also not have saved the game.

48.♖g2 ♘e3 49.♖g6+. Black resigned.

CHLOUPEK – STOHL
Prague 1992



In this position with an isolated d4-pawn the advantage is with Black – his blockading knight is obviously stronger than the bishop. To convert this advantage it is important for him to coordinate the actions of his knight and rook.

30...♖b8! Black prepares a pawn offensive on the queenside. He does not occupy the open c-file with his rook, since after the exchange of rooks it is not easy to win the minor piece ending.

31.♖c1 ♔f8 32.♔f1 ♔e8 33.♔e2 ♔d7 34.♔d3. White decides against preventing Black's pawn offensive on the kingside, since after 34.h4 h5 his pawns are on squares of the same colour as his bishop, and after ♖b8-g8 Black could prepare g7-g5, trying to obtain a passed pawn or create a weakness at h4.



34...g5! The advance of the black pawns has the aim of fixing White's pawns on dark squares.

35.♖3 h5 36.♖c2 g4! 37.♖2 f5 38.♗c1.



38...h5! And now, in turn, weaknesses are created on the queenside.

39.fxg4. If 39.h3 there follows 39...h4! 40.fxg4 hxg3 41.♖3 f4.

39...hxg4 40.♗f4. White should not have conceded the c-file – 40.♖c2.

40...♖c8 41.♗d2. If 41.♖c2 there would have followed 41...♘xf4+ 42.gxf4 ♖h8 with the invasion of the rook – 43...♖h3+.

41...a4 42.bxa4 bxa4 43.♗b4 ♖c1 44.♖b2.



44...♘f6! The knight has fulfilled its blockading function on d5 and it now switches to e4.

45.♗c5 ♘e4 46.♖b7+? 46.♗b4 ♔c6 47.♗a5 was more tenacious. After the exchange of rooks – 47.♖c2+? ♖xc2 48.♔xc2 ♘g5 49.♔d3 ♘f3 (but not 49...♔d5 50.♔e3 ♘f3? 51.h4!) White loses his h2-pawn.

46...♔c6 47.♖b6+ ♔c7 48.♖xe6? This loses a piece, although it was possible to restrict the loss to

a pawn – 48.♔e3 e5! 49.♖a6 ♖c3+ 50.♔e2 exd4 51.♗xd4 ♖xa3, which, however, would not have prolonged the resistance for long. Also bad was 48.♖b2 ♖c3+ 49.♔c2 ♔c6 and 50...♔d5 – White has no defence.

48...♖xc5 49.dxc5 ♘xc5+ 50.♔d4 ♘xe6+ 51.♔e5 ♔d7 52.♔xf5 ♘d4+ 53.♔xg4 ♘b5 54.♔f4 ♘xa3 55.♔e4 ♘c4 56.♔d3 a3. White resigned.

8.3. Minor piece endings

The most typical minor piece endings with an isolated d5-pawn are characterised by the presence of a blockading knight on d4. In them a sharply enhanced role is played by the king, which turns into an active fighting piece. Therefore it is important to centralise the king as quickly as possible, so that it may join the attack on the isolated pawn, coordinating its actions with the knight. When playing such endings, it is also important to create additional targets, which largely depends on the pawn structure. In this connection it is appropriate to remind you of Capablanca's advice regarding the general rules for arranging the pawns in such endings: 'If you have a bishop, then, irrespective of whether or not the opponent has a bishop, you should keep your pawns on squares of the opposite colour to your bishop.'

FLOHR – PIRC
Podebrady 1936



A typical position for the structure with an isolated d5-pawn. Despite the obvious virtues of White's position, it is not easy for him to convert his positional advantage – with accurate defence Black can hold the position.

27.♔c2. In simple endings it is important to centralise the king as quickly as possible.

27...♘e4 28.f3 ♘c5 29.♔c3.



29...♔d6?! Black misses a chance to take play into a simpler endgame – 29...♘xb3! 30.♔xb3 with drawing chances, by setting up a defence with 30...b6!, as demonstrated in the game Flohr – Capablanca (Moscow 1935), which was examined in section 5.6.

30.♗c2! g6? 30...h6 was necessary, arranging the pawns on squares of the opposite colour their own bishop.

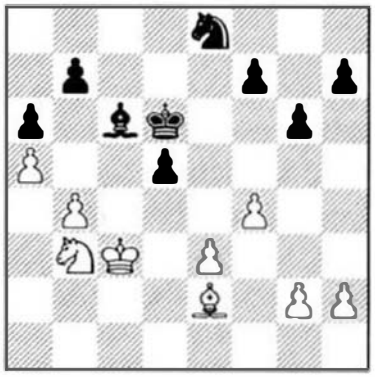
31.a4. 31.b4 was more accurate (Flohr).

31...♗d7. The correct way of defending was 31...a5 or 31...b6, preventing White from setting up a bind on the queenside.

32.a5 ♘e6 33.b4 ♘c7. After the knight exchange 33...♘xd4 34.♔xd4 the bishop endgame is clearly in White's favour, in view of the weakness of the d5- and b7-pawns.

34.♗d3 ♗e8. Black waits passively, whereas he should have tried to erect a barrier against a possible attack by White on the kingside – 34...h6 with the idea of g6-g5.

35.f4 ♗d7 36.♗e2 ♘e8 37.♘b3 ♗c6. The passive conduct of the endgame may slowly but surely lead to defeat. It was essential to prevent White's next move, by playing 37...h5.

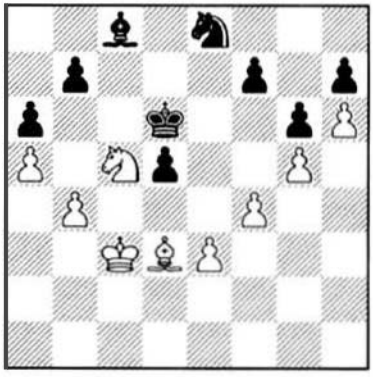


38.g4! White carries out the plan of fixing the kingside pawns.

38...♘f6 39.♘c5 ♘e8. In the event of 39...♘e4+ 40.♘xc4 dxe4 41.g5 followed by 42.♔d4 Black would have lost a pawn, but at least he should have avoided the creation of a weakness at h7 by playing 39...h6.

40.g5. Now Black has as many as three weak pawns at d5, b7 and h7 – more than sufficient for the conversion of White's advantage.

40...♘c7 41.♗d3 ♘e8 42.♘b3 ♗d7 43.♘d4 ♘c7 44.♗e2 ♗c8 45.h4 ♗d7 46.h5 ♘e8 47.h6 ♔e7 48.♗f3 ♗e6 49.♘b3 ♘c7 50.♘c5 ♗c8 51.♗e2 ♔d6 52.♗d3 ♘e8.

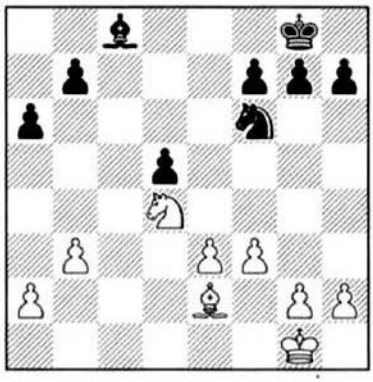


53.e4! The exchange of the d5-pawn enables White to expand the space he controls, after which his king invades the black position.

53...dxe4 54.♗xe4 ♘c7. If 54... ♔c7, then 55.♔d4 ♘d6 56.♔e5 is decisive.

55.♘xb7+ ♗xb7 56.♗xb7 ♘e6 57.♗xa6 ♘xf4 58.♗c4. Black resigned.

AVERBAKH – MATANOVIC
Belgrade 1961



White has a slight advantage, but by correct play Black should be able to defend. White's plan is to centralise his king and fix the black pawns on light squares.

25.♔f2 ♔f8 26.♔e1 (26.♔g3 g5!) **26...♔e7 27.♔d2 ♔d6.** 27... a5 was weaker: 28.♔c3 ♔d6 29.b4 b6 30.bxa5 bxa5 31.♘b3.

28.b4. White aims to fix Black's queenside pawns on light squares.

28...♘e8?! As Yuri Averbakh showed, the knight should have been switched to e7, where it defends the kingside, and the bishop established at d7, from where it prevents the advance of the a-pawn.

29.♗d3.



29...g6?! In such positions the defending side should place his pawns on squares of the opposite colour to his bishop. The correct decision was 29...h6.

30.♔c3 ♘c7 31.a4 b6? Black creates a weakness at a6. 31...♗d7 was better.

32.a5 bxa5 33.bxa5 ♔c5 34.♘b3+ ♔d6 35.♔b4 ♘e6 36.g3.



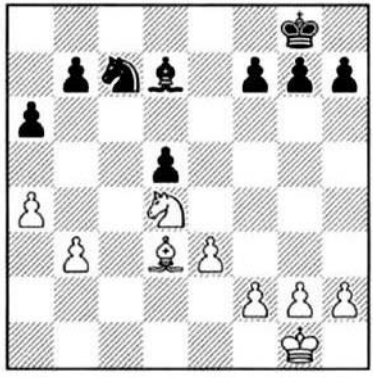
36...♘d8?! The idea of exchanging knights is incorrect, since the bishop endgame is lost. Black should have restricted himself to 36...h6.

37.♘d4 ♘c6+ 38.♘xc6 ♔xc6 39.f4! White needs to create a second weakness on the kingside.

39...f5. If 39...h6, then 40.e4! dxe4 41.♗xc4+ ♔d6 42.♔c4 ♗g4 43.♔d4 ♗c2 44.♗c2 ♗g4 45.♗d3 ♗c8 46.h4 ♗b7 47.g4! ♗c8 24.g5 hxg5 25.hxg5 ♗b7 26.♗c4 and wins.

40.h4 ♔d6 41.h5! (with the threat of h5-h6) **41...gxh5 42.♔c3!** Black resigned. If 42...♔c5 White drives back the king by employing the 'triangulation' mechanism: 43.♗f1! ♗b7 44.♗c2 ♗c8 45.♗d3 ♔□6 46.♔d4 ♔d6, after which for further gain of space he again employs triangulation.

POLUGAEVSKY – MECKING
Mar del Plata 1971



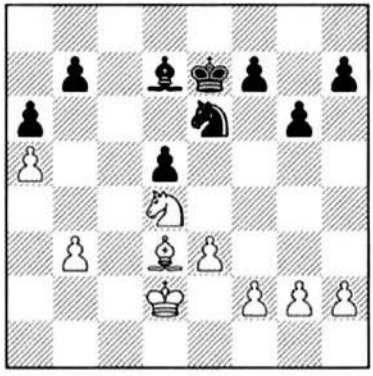
In this endgame the pawn structure is identical to that in the Flohr – Pire game. Of course, for Lev Polugaevsky, who had made a deep study of the classical heritage, it was easy to play this ending.

28.a5! It is important to fix Black's queenside pawns, giving him a second weakness – the b7-pawn.

28...♔f8. After the more active 28...♘e6 29.♘e2 (29.♘xc6 fxc6=) 29...♘c5 30.♗c2 ♔f8 31.♘f4 Black would still have had defensive problems.

29.♔f1 ♔e7 30.♔e2 g6. In a similar position Capablanca arranged his kingside pawns on dark squares and defended the d5-pawn with his bishop, but Mecking is intending to go into a bishop endgame.

31.♔d2 ♘e6.



32.♘xe6. A concrete decision: Polugaevsky goes in for the temporary liquidation of the isolated pawn, hoping to win the bishop endgame, but Black has a defensive resource discovered by Timman.

An alternative was 32.♔c3 ♘c5 33.♗c2, but after 33...♘e4+ 34.♗xe4 dxe4 35.♘e2 f5 36.♔d4 ♔d6 it is not apparent how to loosen Black's position. However, Timman's suggestion 33.♗e2!? comes into consideration, not fearing 33...♘e4+ 34.♔b4♘xf2 35.♔c5♘c4+ 36.♔b6 ♘d6 37.♔c7 g5 (or 37...f5 38.♗f3 ♗c6 39.♘e2) 38.♗f3 ♗c6 39.g4 with the idea of 40.♘f5+, and White retains definitive chances.

32...fxe6. The bishop endgame after 32....♗xe6? 33.♔c3 is lost for Black.

33.f4 e5! With the exchange of this pawn Black reverts to a structure with an isolated d5-pawn. But this cannot be avoided, since otherwise White plays his king to d4 and breaks through with f4-f5, winning the d5-pawn.

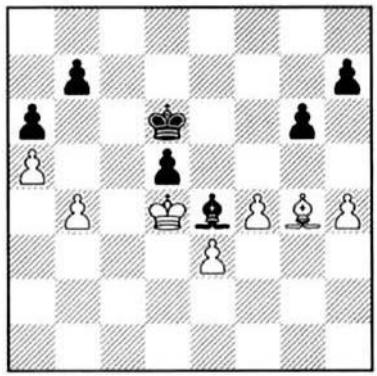
34.g3.



34...♔d6? After this natural reply (which is what Polugaevsky was hoping for) the bishop endgame is lost for Black. The only saving chance consisted in 34....♗b5! But when short of time it is not everyone who would decide to go into a pawn endgame – 35.♗xb5 axb5, without calculating the variations 36.fxe5 ♔e6 37.♔d3 ♔xe5 38.b4 g5 39.g4 h6 40.h3 ♔e6 and 36.♔c3 ♔e6 37.b4 ♔f6 38.g4 h5, where Black succeeds in maintaining the opposition. The variation pointed out by Timman is also not easy to calculate: 35.♗c2 ♔d6 36.♔c3 ♗e2 37.♗b1 ♗f1 38.♔b4 d4! 39.exd4 exd4 40.♗e4 ♔c7 41.♔c5 d3 42.♔d4 d2 43.♗f3 b6 44.axb6+ ♔xb6 45.♔c3 ♔c5 46.♔xd2 ♔d4, where White is unable to convert his extra pawn.

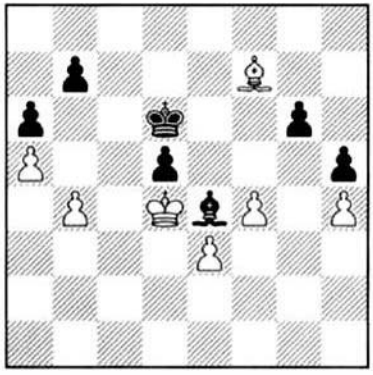
35.♔c3 ♗e6. Here 35....♗b5 36.♗xb5 axb5 37.♔b4 d4 no longer works because of 38.fxe5+! ♔xe5 39.exd4+ ♔xd4 40.♔xb5 and White wins.

36.♔b4 exf4 37.gxf4 ♗g4 38.♔c3 ♗f3 39.♔d4 ♗g2 40.h4 ♗f3 41.b4 ♗h1 42.♗e2 ♗g2 43.♗g4 ♗e4.



44.♗c8! A subtle manoeuvre, which has the aim of weakening the g6-pawn.

44...♔c7 45.♗e6 ♔d6 46.♗g8 h6 47.♗f7 h5 48.♗e8 ♗c2 49.♗f7 ♗e4.



50.f5! The decisive breakthrough, placing Black in zugzwang.

50...♗xf5. In the event of 50...gxf5 51.♗xh5 ♔e6 52.♗e2 ♔f6 White decides matters with 53.♗xa6! bxa6 54.b5! when one of the pawns will queen.

51.♗xd5 ♗c8 52.e4 ♔e7 53.♔e5 g5 54.hxg5 h4 55.g6 h3 56.g7 h2 57.g8♕ h1♕ 58.♕f7+ ♔d8 59.♕f8+. Black resigned.

In the preceding examples we looked at endings where both sides had a stable pawn structure, which White could transform at his discretion. We will now examine an example with a poor pawn structure for Black.

KARPOV – HORT
Budapest 1973



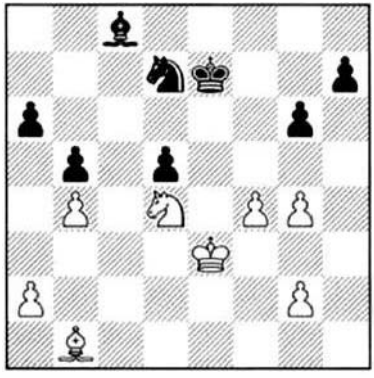
Apart from the weakness of the d5-pawn, Black's a6- and b5-pawns are on squares of the colour of his bishop and are potential weaknesses.

32.b4! White fixes Black's queenside pawns on squares of the colour of his bishop.

32...g6. If 32...h6, then 33.♗g6 is unpleasant.

33.g4! White also strives to fix the kingside pawns, creating a new weakness on h7.

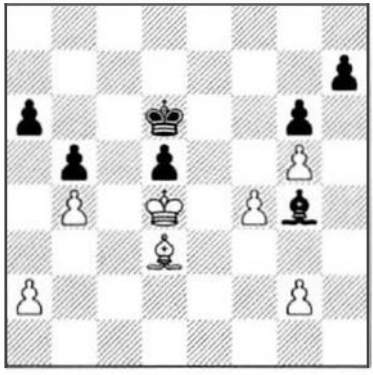
33...♘d7 34.f4.



34...♘f8?! Too passive, but also after 34...♘b6 35.♘c6+ ♔d6 36.♘e5 ♘c4+ 37.♔d4 White increases his advantage, threatening to create a passed f-pawn. For example: 37...♔e7 38.g5! (38.♔xd5? ♘e3+) 38...♔d6 39.♘f7+ ♘e7 40.♘h6 ♘d6 41.g4 etc. The immediate 34...♔d6 35.g5! ♘b6 is more accurate, but here too White can obtain a similar position: 36.♘f3 ♘c4+ 37.♔d4 and then 38.♘e5.

35.g5! ♔d6 36.♔f3 ♘e6? Going into a bishop ending, in which all the pawns are on squares of the same colour as the bishop, leads to a rapid defeat. Black should have returned with his knight to d7.

37.♘xe6 ♗xe6 38.♔e3 ♗g4 39.♗d3 ♝e6 40.♔d4 ♗g4.



41.♗c2! A triangulation manoeuvre to seize control of the h3-c8 diagonal, from where the weak a6-pawn becomes accessible.

41...♗e6 42.♗b3 ♗f7 43.♗d1 ♗e6 44.♗f3 ♗f7 45.♗g4. Black resigned. There is no reasonable defence against the threat of 46.♗c8.

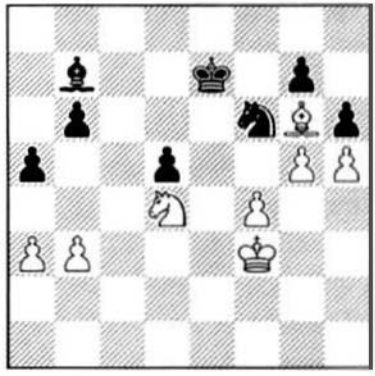
RAUSIS – FARAGO
Germany 1996



In this position the conversion of the pawn majority on the kingside proves decisive.

30.♗f5! ♝a6 31.f4 ♘g8 32.h5 ♘f6 33.♔f3 ♝b7 34.♗g6 ♔e7. Black also loses after 34...♝e8 35.g5 ♗g4+ 36.♔g3 ♝xh5 37.gxf6 ♗xg6 38.fxg7 ♝f7 39.♘f5+.

35.g5.



35...♘e4. Black is unable to oppose the potential passed pawn.

Things are not changed by 35... hxg5 36.fxg5 ♘e4 37.♗xe4 dxe4+ 38.♔c3 ♔f8 39.♘f5 ♗d5 40.h6 gxh6 41.gxh6 ♗g8 42.♔xe4 etc.

36.♗xe4! This exchange leads to the win of a pawn.

36...dxe4+ 37.♔e3 ♗d5 38.b4 axb4 39.axb4 ♗f7. 39...♔f7 40.♘f5 hxg5 41.fxg5 ♗b3 (41...♔f8 42.h6) 42.♔xe4 ♗d1 43.♘g3 leads to the same structure as in the game.

40.♘f5+ ♔f8 41.♘g3 ♗b3 42.♔xe4 ♔f7 43.♔e5 hxg5 44.fxg5 ♗c2 45.g6+ ♔f8 46.♔f4 ♗b1 47.♔g5 ♗d3 48.♘f5 ♔g8 49.♘d4 ♗e4 50.♔f5. The immediate 50.h6 gxh6+ 51.♔xh6 ♔f8 52.♘f5 is also possible, followed by playing the king to h8.

50...♗f1 51.♔g5 ♗c4 52.h6 gxh6+ 53.♔xh6 ♗a2 54.♔g5 ♔f8 55.♔f6 ♔e8 56.g7 ♗g8 57.♘f5 ♗h7 58.♘h6 ♔d7 59.♔e5. Black resigned.

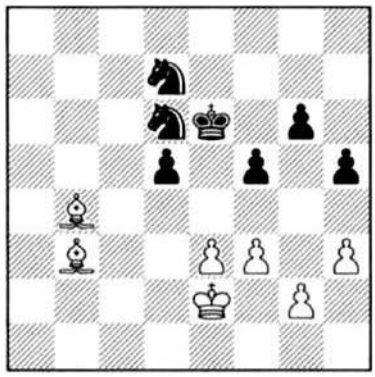
PANNO – DONNER
Palma de Mallorca 1971



White's advantage lies not only in the advantage of the two bishops over a pair of knights which have no strong points, but also in the possibility of active manoeuvres with the threat of transforming the position to his advantage by exchanging one of the bishops.

28.♗b5 ♘e4 29.f3 ♘ec5 30.♔f2 ♘e6 31.♗c3 ♘c7 32.♗a4 ♔e6 33.♗b4 ♘e8. Black's defence is rather more flexible after 33... ♘a6 34.♗c3 ♘c7.

34.♔c2 ♘d6 35.♗b3 f5. Parrying the threat of □3-□4.

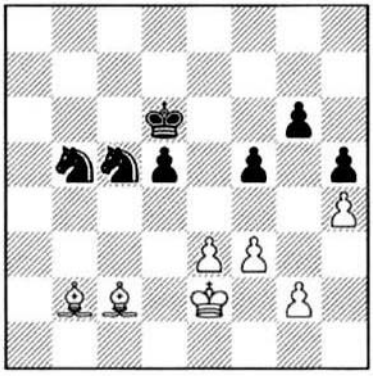


36.h4! It is important to fix the pawns, after which there is a potential threat of exchanging the dark-square bishop at the appropriate moment, with play against Black's pawns on the light squares.

36...♘e5 37.♗c5 ♘d7. After 37...♘dc4 38.♗a4 ♘d6 39.♗xd6! ♔xd6 40.♗e8 ♔c7 41.f4! ♘f7 42.♗xf7 White would have won in the pawn endgame.

38.♗d4 ♘b5? 38...♘f6 was better, agreeing to give up the d5-pawn.

39.♗b2 ♘c5 40.♗c2 ♔d6? Black underestimates the threat of opening up the kingside. 40...♘d7 was essential, retaining possibilities of a defence after both 41.g4 hxg4 42.fxg4 fxg4 43.♗xg6 ♘e5 44.♗h7 ♘d6, and 41.♗a4 ♘c7 42.♔f2 (or 42..♗d4 ♔d6 43.♔f2 ♘e5 44.♔g3 ♘e6) 42...♘b6 43.♗c2 ♘c4. Now, however, White exploits the potential of his light-square bishop.



41.g4! White discloses Black's pawn weaknesses.

41...hxg4?! At any event, 41...♔e6 42.gxh5 gxh5 was more tenacious, and although the weaknesses at h5 and f5 are not easy to hold, there would still have been some possibilities of counterplay (43.♔f2 f4!? 44.exf4 d4). Now, however, the breakthrough of the h-pawn proves decisive.

42.fxg4 ♔e6 43.h5 ♘c7 44. hxg6. Black resigned.

8.4. Endings with one pair of minor pieces

Endings with a minimum number of minor pieces and an isolated pawn (most often this is a d5-pawn) are usually of a technical nature. The most common forms of this ending are bishop v. bishop and knight v. bishop. When talking about bishop endings, what is implied is a conflict of light-square bishops, in which the black bishop is restricted to the passive defence of the d5-pawn. The technique of converting such an advantage was demonstrated fully enough in the previous section. Therefore here we will dwell in more detail on the endgame where the black bishop has to fight against a knight, deployed on the d4 blockading square.

In Chapter 5 [p.140] we looked at the ending of the Flohr – Capablanca game (Moscow 1935), in which Capablanca displayed virtuoso defensive technique against manoeuvres of the knight and king. In order to see how difficult it is to defend in such endings, we will examine an endgame played two years later. Vyacheslav Rauzer was undoubtedly familiar with the great Cuban's defensive methods, but he was unable to save the game.

BELAVENETS – RAUZER
Moscow 1937



In this position White has grounds for playing for a win thanks to the superiority of his knight, which is controlling the important dark squares. We know that the conversion of such a positional advantage is possible only if an additional target is created in Black's position, apart from the d5-pawn.

25.♔f1. In minor piece endings the king must play an active role.

25...♔f8 26.f3. 26.♔e2? is premature because of 26...d4!

26...♔e7 27.♔e2 ♔e6 28.♔d3 ♔e5 29.f4+. The creation of a new weakness is most realistic on the kingside, where the black pawns are badly placed from the positional point of view. Therefore White begins a pawn offensive here.

29...♔e6 30.♔d4.



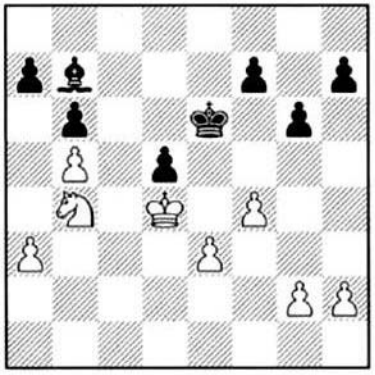
30...♔d6?! From a comparison of this position with that in the Flohr – Capablanca game it can be concluded that 30...a5 would be a useful move, relieving Black of a weak pawn on a7. The weakening of the light squares is not dangerous, since they are controlled by the bishop.

31.b4! ♔e6?! Black is too careless. 31...a6 was now essential, preventing the creation of a weak a7-pawn.

32.b5. Before starting manoeuvres with his knight, White must safeguard himself against the invasion of the black bishop. If Black should succeed in forcing g2-g3 after playing his bishop to f1, he will acquire chances involving the march of his king to h3 (Belavenets).

32...♗b7 33.♘a2 ♔d6. Here too 33...a6 was possible, getting rid of the weak a7-pawn.

34.♘b4 ♔e6?! Black still remains passive, whereas it was now essential to play 34...f6, aiming to hinder the creation of a weak pawn on the kingside.

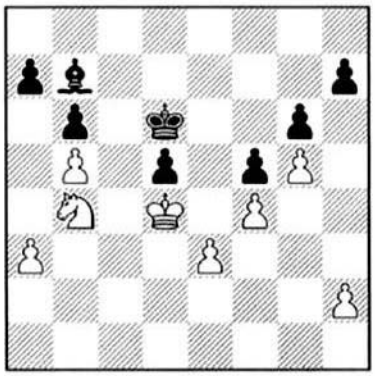


35.g4! Threatening not only g4-g5, fixing the f7- and h7-pawns, but above all 36.♘c6, which did not work immediately, since in the pawn endgame after 35.♘c6? ♗xc6 36.bxc6 ♔d6 37.c7 ♔xc7 38.♔xd5 f5! White is unable to win.

35...f5. Black is forced to block the f-pawn. In the event of 35...h6 36.♘c6 ♗xc6 37.bxc6 ♔d6 38.c7 ♔xc7 39.♔xd5 the pawn endgame is lost in view of the strong position of the white king. For example: 39...♔d7 40.e4 ♔c7 41.e5 ♔d7 42.f5 gxf5 43.gxf5 ♔c7 44.e6 f6 45.h3 h5 46.h4 a6 47.a4 a5 48.♔c4 ♔c6 49.e7 ♔d7 50.♔b5 and wins (Belavenets).

36.g5. White fixes the weakness of the h7-pawn. His further plan consists in advancing h2-h4-h5-h6, after which the knight sacrifices at f5 or h6 will be threatened, while after the exchange on h5 the knight will go to f6, attacking the h7-pawn.

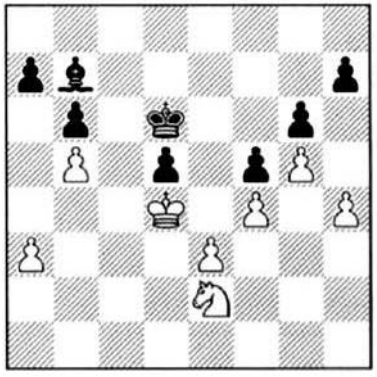
36...♔d6.



37.h3! Subtle conduct of the endgame! White gains a tempo for the switching of his knight to g3. In the event of 37.h4 ♔e6 38.♘a2 ♔d6 39.♘e3 ♔e6 40.♘e2 ♗c8 41.♘g3 ♗d7 42.a4 ♗e8 Black is able to prevent h4-h5 (Belavenets).

37...♔e6 38.♘a2 ♔d6 39.♘c3 ♔e6 40.h4. Here is this tempo! Black is forced to take up the opposition with his king.

40...♔d6 41.♘c2.



41...♗c8? Black submissively goes along with White. As Be-

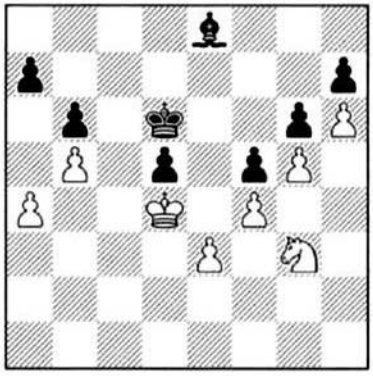
lavenets showed, the last saving chance was 41...a6 (but not 41...a5, since the knight goes to a4, threatening the b6-pawn) 42.♘c3 (42.a4 a5) 42...axb5 43.♘xb5+ ♔c6! 44.♘c3 ♔d6 45.♘a4 ♔c6 46.♔e5 ♔b5 47.♘b2 ♔c5 48.♔f6 d4 49.exd4+ ♔xd4 50.♔g7 ♔e4 51.♔xh7 ♔xf4 52.♔xg6 ♔g4 53.h5 f4 54.h6 ♗e4+ 55.♔f6 ♔h5!, and it is not apparent how White can win.

42.♘g3 ♗d7. 42...a6 is now too late in view of 43.bxa6 ♗xa6 44.h5 ♔e6 45.h6 with the threat of ♘h5.

43.a4. If 43...♗c8 there follows 44.h5 gxh5 45.♘xf5+ ♔e6 46.♘g7+, winning the d5-pawn.

43...♔e6 44.h5 ♗e8. Black loses after 44...gxh5 45.♘xh5 ♗c8 46.♔c3! (zugzwang!) 46...♔f7 47.♔d3 ♔e7 48.♘f6, when he loses a pawn (Belavenets).

45.h6 ♔d6.



White has carried out his plan, and Black, with three(!) weak pawns at d5, a7 and h7, has no defence.

46.♘e2. Here the game was adjourned and White was awarded a win. Here is the main variation given by Belavenets: 46...♗d7 47.♘c3 ♗e6 48.♘a2 ♗f7 (48...♗c8 49.♘b4 ♗b7 50.♘d3 ♗c8 51.♘e5 and there is no defence against 52.♘xg6) 49.♘b4 ♗e6 50.♘c6 a5 51.bxa6! ♔xc6 52.a7 ♔b7 53.♔e5 ♗d7 54.♔f6 ♗xa4 55.♔g7 b5 56.♔xh7 b4 57.♔xg6 b3 58.h7 ♗e8+ 59.♔f6 b2 60.h8♕ b1♕ 61.a8♕+ ♔xa8 62.♕xe8+, and the queen endgame is easily won for White.

Despite all the problems caused by the isolated pawn, we would like to end this section on an optimistic note and give an example where the dynamic potential of this pawn was revealed deep in the endgame.

V.KOVACEVIC – VELIKOV

Olympiad, Luzern 1982



In this position Black cannot exploit the weakness of the iso-

lated d4-pawn, since the d5-square is inaccessible to his king, but he could have maintained the balance by 40...♘e8 (with the idea of taking control of the d5-square after ♔e7-d6 and ♘e8-c7) 41.♔e5 ♘c7 42.♗c4 ♘e8, sticking to waiting tactics. But there followed...

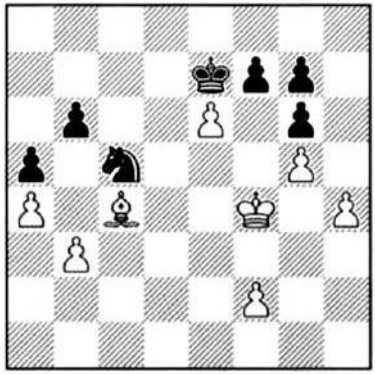
40...♔f6?! 41.g5+ ♔e7 42.d5! and White opened up the position, which enabled him to activate his king and expand the scope of his bishop.



42...♘b7. Things have become much more difficult for Black. In the event of 42...exd5 43.♔e5 White obtains a great spatial advantage, ensuring the superiority of the bishop over the knight, and real winning chances. Kovacevic gives the following variation: 43...d4! 44.♔xd4 ♔e6 45.f3! (weaker is 45.♗c4+?! ♘xc4 46.♔xc4 ♔d6 47.f4 ♔c6, when the breakthrough 48.f5 does not work because of the simple 48...♔d6! 49.fxg6 fxg6 50.♔b5 ♔c7, and Black maintains the opposition; 46.bxc4 ♔d6 47.f4 ♔c6 48.♔e5 ♔c5 49.f5 ♔xc4 50.f6 gxf6+ 51.♔xf6 b5 also leads to a draw) 45...♘f5+ 46.♗xf5+ ♔xf5 47.♔d5 ♔f4 48.♔c6 ♔xf3 49.♔xb6 f5! 50.gxf6 gxf6 51.♔xa5 f5 52.b4 f4 53.b5 ♔g4 54.b6 f3 55.b7 f2 56.b8♕ f1♕ 57.♕b4+! with good winning chances in the queen endgame.

43.dxe6 ♘c5. In the event of 43...♔xe6?! 44.♗c4+ ♔e7 45.♔e5 the spatial advantage also proves decisive: 45...♘d6 46.♔d5 ♔d7 47.♗d3! ♘c8 48.♗b5+ ♔c7 49.f4 ♘d6 (49...♘e7+ 50.♔e5 ♘f5 51.h5) 50.♗d3 ♔d7 51.♗f1 ♔c7 52.♔e5 ♔d7 53.♗h3+ ♔c6 54.f5, and White breaks through on the kingside.

44.♗c4.



44...f6? The decisive mistake. The exchange of pawns allows White to make a breakthrough with his h5-pawn. Saving chances were offered

by 44...fxe6! 45.♔e5 ♔d7 (if 45...♘d7+ White uses the triangulation method to reach the same position as in the preceding variation: 46.♔e4! ♘c5+ 47.♔d4 ♔d6 48.f3!) 46.♔d4 ♔d6 47.f3! ♔e7 48.♔c3 ♔d6 49.♗c2 (with the threat of transferring the bishop to c2) 49...e5 (after 49...♔c5? 50.♔c4 ♔f4 51.♗d1 ♔e3 52.♗e2 White transfers his bishop to b5 and wins the queenside pawns) 50.♔c4 (50.♗c4 can be met by 50...♘e6!, and in the pawn endgame after 51.♗xe6 ♔xe6 52.♔c4 ♔d6 53.♔b5 ♔c7 Black maintains the opposition) 50...♘e6!, and Black succeeds in exchanging his g6-pawn for the h4-pawn – 51.♗d3 ♘f4 52.♗e4 ♘g2 53.♗xg6 ♘xh4 54.♗c4 ♘g2 55.♔b5 ♔c7, and in holding the position.

45.gxf6+ gxf6. If 45...♔xf6, then 46.e7! ♔xe7 47.♔g5 is decisive.



46.♔g4! White prepares the advance of his f-pawn.

46...♘e4. If 46...♘xe6 White transposes into a won pawn endgame: 47.♗xe6 ♔xe6 48.f4! followed by f4-f5.

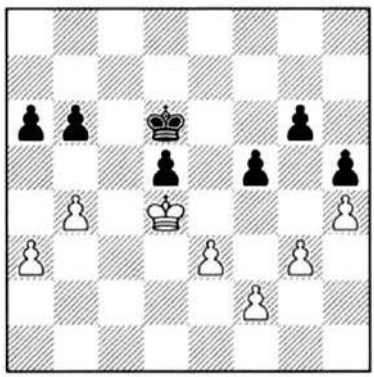
47.f3 ♘d2 48.f4 ♘e4. Black also loses after 48...♘xc4 49.bxc4 ♔xe6 50.f5+ ♔f7 51.♔f4 ♔g7 52.fxg6 ♔xg6 53.♔g4 (Kovacevic).

49.f5. Black resigned.

8.5. Pawn endings

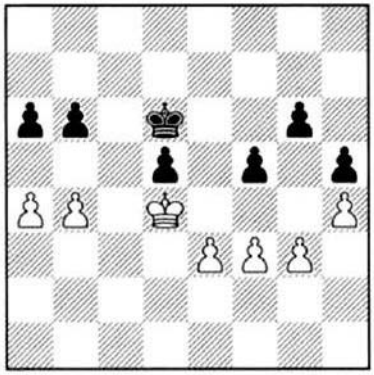
In pawn endings with an isolated pawn, the possibility of weakening the opponent's position in the battle for the opposition acquires decisive importance. We will examine two examples.

EHLVEST – RAUSIS
Zonal Tournament, Riga 1995



32.a4 ♔e6 33.f3. The start of a battle for the opposition, after which the white king will penetrate to e5 or c5.

33...♔d6.

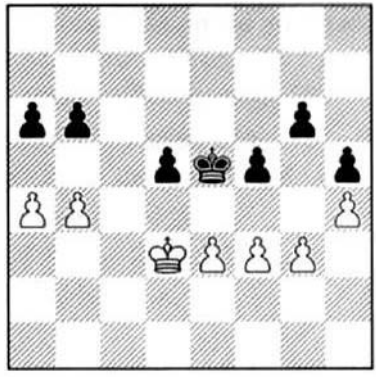


The critical factor for the solution of this position is the advance 34.a5! bxa5 35.bxa5, and after 35...♔c6 36.♔e5 ♔c5 White gains the lateral opposition of the kings by 37.f4! A possible continuation is 37...♔c4 (also after 37...♔b5 38.♔f6 ♔xa5 39.♔xg6 play reduces to a queen endgame with an extra pawn for White) 38.♔e6! ♔b5 39.♔f6 and in the resulting queen endgame White has real winning chances. Here are the main variations:

1) 39...♔c4 40.♔xg6 ♔d3 41.♔xf5 ♔xe3 42.♔g6 d4 43.f5 d3 44.f6 d2 45.f7 d1♕ 46.f8♕ ♕g4+ (after 46...♕a4 47.♕f4+! ♕xf4 48.gxf4 ♔xf4 49.♔xh5 White wins the pawn endgame) 47.♔h6 (with the threat of ♕f4+) 47...♔e2 (47...♕xg3? loses after 48.♕a3+ ♔f4 49.♕xg3+ ♔xg3 50.♔xh5) 48.♕f4, and White wins the h5-pawn, after which the game is decided by the pair of connected passed pawns;

2) 39...♔xa5 40.♔xg6 ♔b5 41.♔xf5 a5 42.♔g6, and after the advance of the a- and f-pawns a queen endgame with practical winning chances is reached.

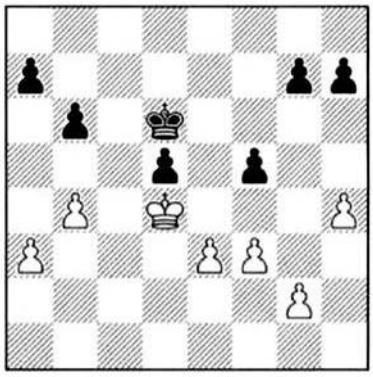
34.♔c3 ♔e5 35.♔d3. Here it was already essential to play 35.a5!, since now by 35...a5! Black could have restricted White's possibilities: after 36.bxa5 bxa5 37.♔c3 ♔e6 38.♔d4 ♔d6 39.f4 ♔c6 40.♔e5 ♔c5 41.♔f6 ♔c4! **42.♔xg6** ♔d3 43.♔xf5 ♔xe3 44.♔g6 d4 with the appearance of the queens the a4-pawn comes under attack. This remark also applies to the next two moves of the game.



35...♔c6 36.♔c3 (36.a5!) **36...♔e5** (36...a5!) **37.♔d3** (37.a5!) **37...♔e6** (37...a5!) **38.♔d4 ♔d6 39.a5 bxa5 40.bxa5 ♔c6 41.♔e5 ♔b5?** This loses quickly. More tenacious was 41...♔e5 42.f4 (if 42.♔f6? Black is saved by 42...♔e4! 43.♔xg6 ♔d3 44.♔xh5 ♔xe3) 42...♔c4 43.♔e6, reaching a position analysed in the note to Black's 33rd move.

42.♔xd5 ♔xa5 43.♔c5. Black resigned.

YURTAEV – TEMIRBAEV
Olympiad, Elista 1998



In contrast to the previous example, here the b6-point is securely defended and White is unable to penetrate to c5.

34...h5! First of all Black eliminates the threat of a pawn offensive on the kingside, not forgetting subsequently to carefully maintain the opposition of the kings.

35.a4 ♔e6 36.a5 ♔d6 37.a6 ♔e6 38.e4. White tries to exploit the slightly better position of this king, but this proves insufficient.

38...dxe4 39.fxe4 fxe4 40.♔xe4 g6 41.♔f4 ♔f6 42.g3 b5 43.g4 hxg4 44.♔xg4 ♔e6 45.♔f4 ♔f6 46.♔e4 ♔e6 47.♔d4 ♔d6 48.♔e4 ♔e6 49.♔f4 ♔f6 50.♔g4 ♔e6. Draw.

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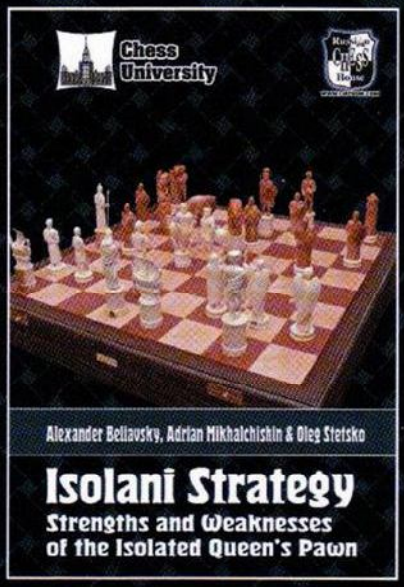
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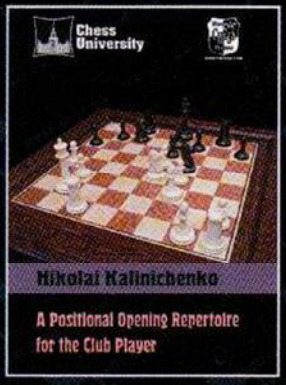
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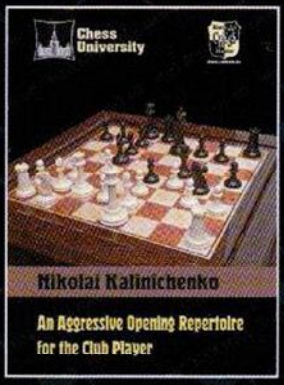


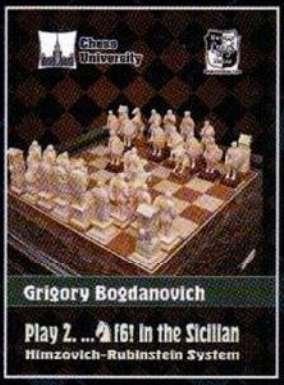
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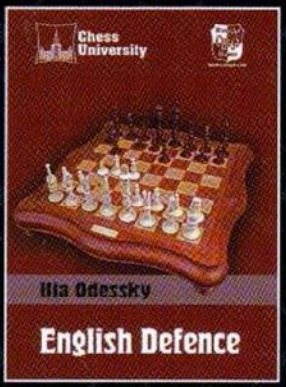
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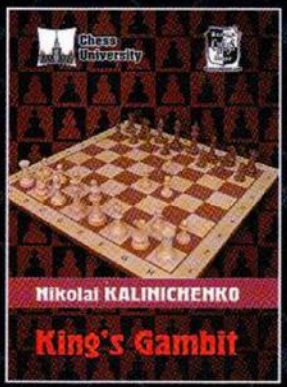
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